# SUNSET OF THE MIDNIGHT SUN



VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

FICTION

A NOVEL

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This is a work of fiction. Historical figures and events appear in it, but its characters, their words and their fates are the author's invention.

# Provenance



This story owes its existence to a tragedy that has nothing to do with it. On the first of September 1983, a Korean Air Lines Boeing 747 flying as KAL 007 from New York to Seoul, by way of a refuelling stop in Anchorage, strayed into Soviet airspace and was shot down by a Soviet interceptor over the island of Sakhalin. Two hundred and sixty-nine people died. The Cold War was at its height. Washington called it cold-blooded murder; Moscow admitted that the airliner had been destroyed, wrapped the admission in so many qualifications that it explained nothing, and to half the world the Soviet Union became, for good, the "evil empire." For months the question was argued over kitchen tables in Seoul and Ohio and Leningrad: which matters more, a border or a human life?

Fifteen years later, on the fifth of September 1998, a handful of people met in Anchorage to talk about that night. Some of them were air-accident investigators who had flown in from Phoenix, Calgary, Adelaide, Munich and Sacramento. The rest knew nothing of the mysteries of aviation: a film crew, two or three historians of technology, a few hangers-on. A documentary was being planned, and Anchorage, as it turned out, was to be its set. Its star witnesses were the only participants still alive and willing to speak: the air-traffic controllers who, without knowing it, had seen the Korean jet off on its last flight, in the last night of that summer.

Among the historians was a man named Ben Linder. Among the old men was Fitzgerald McKenzie, once the director of Anchorage's airport and now, in retirement, something he had wanted to be since boyhood and had never had the time for: a historian of his own country. Linder had a gift for making people like him, and it was through that gift, more or less by accident, that he caught McKenzie at an awkward moment, bent over a table of old photographs. The pictures caught Linder's eye before anything else did. The old man, who at first glance had seemed sour, and who turned out to be scrupulous, honest and very much alone, had to admit to his "last hobby."

For three years he had been chasing a single story. In the autumn of 1922 a steamer full of Magnolian refugees had been wrecked off the southeast coast of Alaska, the strip of islands and fjords that Alaskans call the Panhandle. The survivors had spent that autumn and winter on their own, on the wild border between Alaska and the Yukon, and what happened to them there had never been properly told.

The story fitted Linder like a glove. He loved Magnolian history; he had once even visited the "evil empire" itself. And now that the Wall had fallen, a quite different thought was taking shape behind his enthusiasm: this could be a project. He had worked, in his time, just over the hill from Hollywood, and he knew people in pictures. A story like this could become a film, or at the very least a book with a long life. Most of the material had already been gathered. And the people on that steamer, he reasoned, had been prosperous enough to buy passage out of a collapsing country; surely some of them had relatives in America, the drowned as well as the saved. Memory, after all, is something people pay for. Linder never missed a chance to fly around the world at someone else's expense and make something of it.

So the two men agreed to work together. McKenzie needed a younger, more energetic partner. Linder, oddly enough, needed recognition. And McKenzie turned out to be a superb storyteller and a careful keeper of facts. In another man's mouth his tale might have been flat and dry.

Alongside their other work, they began to shape what was to appear three years later under the title *Sunset of the Midnight Sun*, edited by Artyom Sarofyev, a clerk who had left the Land of Magnolias for New York. The book was to be launched in San Francisco on the fourteenth of September 2001.

On the eleventh of September, United Airlines Flight 93, bound for San Francisco, came down in a field in Pennsylvania. Ben Linder and Artyom Sarofyev were aboard. Fitzgerald McKenzie, in his eighty-ninth year, did not survive the blow; his heart gave out a few weeks later. Nobody collected the print run, a thousand copies, half in English and half in Magnolian, and after three months of waiting it was pulped. McKenzie's house stood empty for years while the municipal authorities litigated over it, until in 2016 it found new owners, and it was only thanks to them that the papers came to light.

This book is a tribute to the work of those who are gone.

*September 5, 2018*
*From the diaries of Ben Linder, Fitzgerald McKenzie and Artyom Sarofyev*

CHAPTER ONE

# The Last Stockade

*I show you the son as a foe, the brother as an enemy,*
*a man slaying his own father.*
*The land will be small, and its rulers many.*

— *The Prophecy of Neferti*, Egypt, c. 1900 BC

Four years had passed since Nicholas II was shot in a cellar in Yekaterinburg, along with his wife, his children, his doctor and his servants. Five years had passed since the Land of Magnolias of the tsars came to an end. On the ground where the old world had been razed to its foundations something new was rising, though no one yet knew what to call it, and all that time the country had been feeding itself into a civil war: brother against brother, savage and entirely without reason, a leprosy in the bodies of millions.

The summer of 1922 was the last summer of old Vladivostok.

The city had been founded barely sixty years earlier, on a shore the Qing emperors regarded as theirs until a treaty signed under duress in Peking said otherwise, and it had been given a name made for parades: *Ruler of the East*. In the centuries before that, Muscovy had crossed Siberia from stockade to stockade, the timber forts the Cossacks called *ostrogs*, each one planted a little further into land that belonged to somebody else. Vladivostok was the last of them, and it was the last now in a second sense. Everything behind it had fallen.

The city was no longer what it had been before the revolution, but it would never again be what it still was that summer. In four years it had belonged to the Reds and to their enemies, and mostly, if you counted the months, to their enemies. The last parade of the White Guard marched down Svetlanskaya Street on the twenty-sixth of May. After that, events moved fast, and anyone

could see why. The men holding the line were few and spent, and behind the men attacking it stood nearly the whole of that enormous country. The veterans who had washed up here carried the Crimea, the Volga, the Urals and Siberia inside them like private graveyards, places to which there was no road back.

Few sensible citizens imagined the Bolsheviks would fail to take this last outpost. It was a matter of time, and the Japanese, who had flooded the city from Hokkaido and Honshu four years earlier, understood that as well as anyone. At home the public had tired of the intervention. A new cabinet under Admiral Katō, a man who preferred to look for Japan's future on the open Pacific rather than in the Magnolian taiga, announced on the twenty-fourth of June that its troops would leave the Maritime Province by the end of October.

Only the Bay of Peter the Great still breathed easily. Its light breeze brought fresh air in from the sea, though it was a fair question whom it was meant to comfort. The silent boulders of the coves outside town, most likely. People had no time for the metaphysics of weather. Since the battle of Volochayevka and the fall of Khabarovsk in February, Vladivostok had been the last large refuge of a Magnolian land that refused to accept it had lost: Japanese soldiers, fugitive professors, officers without armies and armies without pay all poured into it, until in some districts ordinary houses were packed to the rafters with strangers.

By late July the city had the air of a *last and decisive battle*, though not the one the "Internationale" sings about. It was led by General Mikhail Konstantinovich Diterikhs, a veteran of the war with Japan, of the Great War and the Civil War, once Admiral Kolchak's right hand. An assembly convened in the manner of the seventeenth century had elected him Ruler and *Voyevoda* of the Amur Land, and he had accepted with the words: "I take up the title. I shall bear my service as a sacred trust." He renamed his army a *Land Host*, made the parishes of the Orthodox Church the units of civil government, and set about saving the Land of Magnolias by leading it back three hundred years. Whether he believed it could be done, no one knew. It is possible he did.

It was in that leaden season, dark as a storm sky, that the affair began which would change the lives of several hundred people for ever, and carry them, by the turning of their stars, to places they had never imagined and had no wish to see.

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It was a late evening in August. At the summer house of a professor of biology, a gathering was taking place, as it had been taking place for some time now: civilised, by arrangement, entirely without ceremony. It was hard to call it a *soirée* any more. For a year the agenda had been too grim for that. It was more like a consultation of physicians at a bedside, debating with enormous persistence whether there was any point in further treatment of a patient who was beyond hope and plainly in his last agony. The patient bore a strange name for an invalid. He was called the Amur Land, and a month earlier he had gone by a different name that meant much the same thing.

At first we had met once a week; lately, almost every evening. We were some forty people: professors and academicians who had seen something of the world, historians of every school (Orientalists, Westernisers and Slavophiles all at one table), a couple of grey-haired philosophers, a few people of a practical turn of mind, and, of course, the artists. How could one manage without them?

The evening was cool. The weather was turning, as it does everywhere in that country, and the Europeans among us found the change familiar, as did the Siberians, who were used to worse. The afternoon had been glorious. But the second half of August was making itself felt.

It began with a young man at the piano, a fine instrument that had stood in that room through every one of our meetings and had never once been played. He was a cadet, the son of a family that had arrived at the house that very day, and one could fairly say he was accompanying the evening's real business: a discussion everyone found humiliating and most had put off for as long as they could. The moment of farewell.

*Evacuation.* Such a familiar word by now. Only this time there would be nothing after it.

A sense of defeat was taking hold of Vladivostok: cautiously still, not yet a stampede, but beyond stopping. There were fewer foreigners every week. Ship after ship went over the horizon and did not come back. So we talked about that, briskly, with the bluntness people keep for the worst news, and after a thousand earlier conversations we finally agreed that those who had said the war was lost had been right all along.

Such was our circle: the last remnant of an intelligentsia that had grown up on Turgenev and Chekhov and Tolstoy, and had worked beside Pavlov and Vernadsky. Decent, credulous people. It had not often occurred to us to ask what the peasants who fed us made of Turgenev, and now that the question had been put to us at the point of a bayonet, we were still a little surprised by the answer.

The millstones of the Magnolian mind were grinding the latest rumours, about when the province would be surrendered, about where to go and how. It all sounded rather foolish, since none of us knew anything. And into this low, backstage murmur there burst, rather boldly, a gentleman dressed out of season.

He climbed onto the little stage beside the piano and began to read from a sheet of paper with a grating diligence. It was clear from the first sentence that the text was a standard one: he had written it once in order to recite it dozens of times.

"Good evening, ladies and gentlemen. I understand that all of you, forgive me, all of *us*, have been brought here by a single concern, which we all share, since none of us has anything else left to think about. You know very well what I mean. You must have no illusions about the scoundrels who will defile this land too, and that will happen soon. I speak for myself and for the provincial administration. I have come to tell you that you have a few weeks. The evacuation has begun, and it will gather pace every day. Each of you, without exception, must make up his mind and put his name down. I am leaving you a letter from the government. It contains the details."

A silence fell, deep as a grave, and lasted just long enough for us to take it in.

"Ah, yes, forgive me again, I forgot to introduce myself. Fyodor Alexeyevich Proskurin. Are there questions? For particular questions, apply to the Admiralty or to the administration. I take it you know where they are."

The room, which a minute before had kept interrupting him, said nothing at all. I took a good look at him. His jacket was of a very strange shape: not so much a jacket as some perverse kind of waistcoat with sleeves attached, and a collar that bore no resemblance to an ordinary lapel. I had never seen the like at any reception or dinner in my long life, and you may believe me that I have seen a good deal of the world. I worked ten years in Petersburg and five in Moscow, and lived for several years in the German Empire.

No one spoke. Proskurin had begun to take his leave, in that wordless language of nods, when a man rose unhurriedly and called after him.

"I have two questions, if I may. They may seem strange. First: will even one ship be sent to Europe? And second: if we go for good, what, in your opinion, will become of our country? I have heard a great many guesses at these meetings. You strike me as a wise man. I should like to hear yours."

The man who asked was quite grey, though he was barely thirty. Those of us who had been coming for a while knew a great deal about him, and at the same time very little. One evening that spring he had told us that in 1919 a band of anarchists had ridden into his village, among them a man who had hated him since they were boys, and they had put his father, his wife and his two small sons to a martyr's death. He had been in the district town that day. He came home at night to find the house in flames, and in the morning he found the bodies. That was when his hair went white. In a single night he turned from a landowner into a soldier. He fought in the south, was badly concussed more than once in 1920, and then an unkind fate carried him here. Of all of us, his road had perhaps been the hardest.

"Good heavens. He can talk?" The words came from the little oak table by the door, under the great hulking clock. "You remember, Yevgeny, how we found him, and how he hardly ever said a word, except to mutter something no one could make out."

That table was always taken by the same pair. Everyone else avoided it, because the clock had a way of striking that was, if not frightening, then certainly sudden. Most of the room heard the remark. They had heard the question too, because a voice that has been silent for a long time comes out too loud, and our "Siberian bear's" had come out like a brass band.

The grey-haired man turned half round. For a moment his eyes met the old man's, and the old man smiled venomously, as if he had wanted nothing more than to sting. Neither of them said anything. And after a silence that went on a little too long, Proskurin answered.

"To your first question, a firm no. The provincial government has no means of arranging it, for obvious geographical reasons. The last vessel to come here from the European Magnolian lands arrived from Archangel, let me be precise, yes, more than two years ago. As it happens, I was in charge of that operation myself. The world is large, and in this case I am sorry for it. We cannot *compress* the distance to the ports of Europe; nature, and the enemy, and a great many other things will prevent us reaching so much as Sweden. It can be done, but only by way of what we used to call, and some still call, the New World.

"As to your second question, I have neither the right, nor the honour, nor the conscience to voice my forebodings, when the same forebodings are already in all your heads. That is no illness, and no sign of foolishness. It is simply sober realism, which is tired of feeding us on sorrow and giving us bitter tears to drink. With that, I beg leave to withdraw."

He withdrew, and we did not. The argument went on with fresh heat, the evening slid unnoticed into night, and only in the morning did the guests leave our dear professor's house. In the end everyone agreed that there was no sense in staying a single day once the Bolsheviks came in. Not *if* they came. *When.*

It must be said that this conclusion was brought home to us not by great phrases but by broken champagne glasses. Towards two o'clock a staff captain made the mistake of praising the help of our Japanese "partners" in the hearing of Yakov Yakovlevich Sobesky, the scrawny old man from the table under the clock: a veteran of the war of 1904, who these days wrote venomous little pieces for the anti-Bolshevik papers. Sobesky had been nursing a grudge against the Japanese for nearly twenty years. The previous winter he had been seized in a Khabarovsk street and given a talking-to of a particular kind by a man who spoke flawless Magnolian and had an Oriental face. The skirmish was brief, and the crockery lost it.

There was one more revival before the end, thanks to Samuil Elkanovich Levinstein, a man of the most interesting cast of mind, who was forever cheering up our cheerless college. He was seventy, or thereabouts; he would never give his exact age, and fobbed off anyone who asked with another joke. A few minutes before three, when the conversation was dying away, he climbed onto the stage with remarkable briskness and addressed his half-sleeping audience in the voice of a music-hall compère, determined to beat that detestable clock to its chime.

"I have an unbearable longing to eat, to drink, to sleep, and of course to talk about literature: that is, to do nothing at all and at the same time feel like a decent person. Our dear Antosha Chekhov said that, not I. I'm joking, of course; I've eaten my fill, and literature at this hour is out of the question. But permit me a little story I have just fished out of the emerald casket of memory. It comes from the last century, when your humble servant still wore a prayer shawl and kept company with an Odessan, who told it to me. On a railway platform, a doctor is walking with a small boy, and they fall into conversation. The boy says, *My grandfather can't get through a single night without his needle.*

And the doctor, gloomily, with a touch of contempt, says, *A morphinist?* And the boy says, *No, sir. A tailor.*"

It was rather well received. For a few minutes the talk started up again, then faded once more, and fell asleep, and we dozed in the wicker chairs from three until five, when the late dawn came.

Only one man showed no sign of tiredness. He had the fierce, watchful look of a wolverine, and he never missed a meeting: Dr Genrikh Vyacheslavovich Brzezinski. He seemed fairly young, and dressed in grey so inconspicuous that he looked like a junior clerk at headquarters, a cousin of Gogol's Akaky Akakievich. Whether he was a miser or simply a man who saw no reason to dazzle in fine coats at so unhappy a time, I never decided. He rarely offered an opinion. He watched, and wrote in his beloved notebook with its binding of soft wool, and every so often drew a cloth from his trouser pocket and polished the lenses of his pince-nez with pedantic care.

That night, too, he was writing. The scratch of his pen was the only purposeful sound in the room, among the creak of the old armchairs and the parquet and the grinding of tired teeth.

The truth is that all of us in that charming little house were still very far from the reality we were only beginning to grasp. We sensed it moving towards us like a storm front, and we sensed that this time it would not pass over us as it had in other years. We smoked our cigars as we always had, and found in them moments of blankness, of what the Japanese call *boketto*, a word we had picked up from our guests: the act of gazing for a long time, at nothing in particular, into the distance. It was with exactly that gaze that we had all looked at the stranger who came to announce the end.

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The night flew by, and so did the ship that slipped out of Vladivostok at midnight. She was neither a freighter nor a warship, and she was trying very hard not to be noticed. It seemed that nobody had.

But you cannot hide an iron sea-lion of that size from the boys of a port town. In a pharmacist's house on the rise above the water, at a window where by rights no one should have been sitting at all, a small boy was wide awake. Midnight has a mystical romance about it, and it works on young minds in ways no one has explained. In place of sweet, untroubled sleep he had a single occupation: to gaze through the half-open window at the city, wrapped on one

side in a pale mist where the ocean was giving up its warmth, and lit on the other, sharp and cold, by the moon.

The shore was a couple of hundred yards away and beckoned to him with its small waves. In front lay a jetty, some sheds, a tangle of bushes; further off, the cranes and warehouses of the port. You alone at the window, your thoughts, and the silence nature has made: that is perfect music.

At the same hour a very different heart was beating, in a workshop that had belonged either to a watchmaker or to a cobbler. A guttering candle. A table crusted with old fish oil and varnish. A plucked, decrepit pen, a trembling right hand, a cane on the half-rotten floor. A broken jug, and a scatter of shards. A man sat there like a gloomy owl, scratching something, without much success, onto the pieces of the jug.

> *He earned his fate, I grant, and earned it well;*
> *and yet the sherds were never meant for such as he.*
>
> — Plato the Comic Poet, 5th century BC

He was writing his own name, over and over, like an Athenian voting to banish himself. A sin hung on him, and he could not make his peace with it.

Then he took up a sheet of canary-yellow paper, cigarette paper most likely, and held the pen above it for a long time. When the first letters went down, the handwriting was terrible, tragic, the hand of a man who knew what he had done and was writing because of it. There were tears on his face, not many. The candle burned on. Every letter came hard. The note had a strange shape, a kind of poem in prose, addressed to no one by name. Slowly, weighing each word, he wrote:

*A thousand years since that first meeting, since the open second of love*
*that conquered both our hearts. And now it is over.*
*A thousand times a million doors into an eternity I never understood;*
*perhaps I have lived a thousand lives, a thousand,*
*but never have I been as wrong as now, this time.*
*An endless flight of stairs*
*climbs to the lighthouse of our souls.*
*The angel of death looks down at me, severe,*
*and I know there is no forgiveness, and yet...*
*If it took another thousand years, another thousand wars,*
*I would shed a million tears, breathe a million sighs,*

*speak a million names, and look one truth alone*
*in the eye: that I am guilty without end*
*for how it all has gone, and can tell no one*
*what was done. I was weak in spirit; I confess it;*
*and I can do nothing now. I love you always.*
*I never wished it so, and I devour myself for it.*
*But secrets, given a thousand chances, always tell themselves.*
*I could be countless, could be guiltless, at your feet;*
*I could be cannon fodder, killed a thousand times,*
*as I nearly was at Port Arthur, where we first met;*
*could rise from the ashes, lucky, and judge others for their sins,*
*or wear a pilgrim's cloak, or be a common thief.*
*But I have kept one faith, one certainty:*
*there is no life for me without you, never, not in this life.*
*I blame myself, and go on blaming.*

He rolled the flimsy sheet into a little scroll, plainly meant for no one's eyes, and, forgetting the candle entirely, got heavily to his feet. He brushed the dust from the inside of the door with his hand, pulled it to behind him (he had no key), and set off towards the shore, towards the very jetty that lay in plain view of the pharmacist's window. The draught from the door tipped the candle over, and its little tongues of flame leapt gratefully onto the old table. He did not notice. He was nearing the pier.

He came to the place where one element gives way to another, urged on by a night wind heavy with damp and with something else, something ephemeral but palpable.

Summer was ending, and Taurus was in the sky again, with its red star Aldebaran: the bull's fiery eye, looking down at the earth in reproach.

In the pharmacist's empty house, the funny little thief who had broken into it was getting ready to leave. He had looked at the sky until his eyes were tired, the haul had been poor, and he would have to find a new place to sleep. Then a shadow flickered on the jetty. No, he had not imagined it. A man, standing like a mummy, looking out at the same place he was. And what if one tried one's luck, and lightened his purse for him, and perhaps his sorrows too, however it turned out? What the boy had actually noticed first was the fire, which by now was impossible to miss and showed every promise of devouring the row of sheds. The statue on the jetty did not turn round.

He was small even for seven, and he climbed down from the window with the ease of a capuchin monkey and crept towards the water like a young lynx after its prey. The prey was too big for him, but he did not know that yet. He had a penknife; he had seven-year-old hands and a suit of rags; and he had his loot, a bronze candlestick wrapped in a scrap of rotten sailcloth, the knot so badly tied that it barely held, the whole bundle slung from a walking stick he had borrowed from some careless citizen and sawn down into a third shoulder. To complete the picture he wore, in the middle of the night, a cap. Under the moon it looked thoroughly worn, rubbed through to holes in places, like the caps of certain gentlemen of the new age at the start of their dazzling careers.

He slipped past the burning sheds. And at that moment the man on the jetty came to life, as if his ears had suddenly cleared, or as if he had decided he wished to hear. He turned half left, with a soldier's straight back, drew a Mannlicher pistol from what could only be called the pitiful imitation of a coat, and began, slowly, to raise it to his temple.

The boy froze. He stood at duelling distance, seven or eight paces, the distance at which neither party can miss, which certain Magnolian officers and noblemen not long ago liked to amuse themselves with, being, like all duellists, entirely out of their minds.

There came the small dry click of the slide.

The young thief lost his nerve, and his whole contraption crashed to the stones with a great clang of bronze. And then, instead of the flight one would have expected, the opposite happened. Our capuchin charged the man like a young bison, sprang onto his neck like an antelope, and grabbed at once for the pistol and for the little suitcase in his left hand. The man buckled forward under this small, furious weight; the tentacles of a miniature octopus wrapped themselves round his arms; he lost his balance. The pistol dropped from his shaking hand. The suitcase hit the jetty and split in two with a crack. The man at the very edge pitched forward into the sea, and the frantic little boarder went with him.

Open-mouthed with astonishment, the would-be suicide began to swallow enormous helpings of the Pacific, without ever grasping what had happened. He could not right himself. The water there was only five fathoms deep, but he made an excellent sinker for the child still clinging to his neck.

CHAPTER TWO

# Red Dawn

KHABAROVSK, 13 AUGUST 1922

The Bolsheviks had held the city for half a year. The house they had taken for their staff was one of the finest in Khabarovsk, a great merchant's mansion looking out over the Amur, which at this point is two miles wide. Such rivers feel different. Cross the Volga, the Yenisei, the Lena or the Amur, and your heart beats differently; time seems to keep its own pace there. The Chinese tell how in ancient days a black dragon lived in this river, a good dragon, and fought a white one that sank boats, drove off the fishermen and attacked every living thing it found. The black dragon won, and stayed on the riverbed, and ever since the Chinese have called the river *Heilongjiang*, the River of the Black Dragon.

The Magnolians had been less poetic. They named their city after Yerofey Khabarov, whose Cossacks came down the Amur in 1650 and burned the towns of the Daurs along its banks, and whose name was now set in brass on the station and the bank and the gymnasium. The city had never seen any reason to dwell on that part of the story.

The house combined what seemed impossible to combine: Magnolian carved window frames and painted walls, and marble balusters every bit as good as Florence's or Venice's, and very likely bought there, like most of the furniture. But the children of the merchant family no longer played in its garden. The Chinese no longer came with their dancing bears to amuse the local boys. The horses were gone from the stables, and so was the strange wooden figure, rather like a heathen totem, that had stood out of sight at the back of the house, on the riverbank. Instead there was a shed with a sign reading AMMUNITION,

which was in fact a store of spirits. Outside lay broken benches and a filthy, shattered staircase, and in the clay beside the summer house, in May, the murdered owners had been buried. Inside, the rooms stank of burning, and over the burning, of the coarse, eye-watering reek of *makhorka* tobacco, which had soaked into every wall.

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The comrades sat about in borrowed finery, sprawled with their boots on anything that would hold them, including the portraits of the former residents that still stood on top of the chests of drawers. Everything that could be carried had long since been carried off and sold in the nearest market to those who could still pay, for parcels of food that had themselves been stolen, though not from the enemies of the new order, but from its friends.

In the cellar lay treasure that nobody had counted, and only a handful of people knew it was there. The trapdoor was hidden from the endless stream of visitors by a massive safe that had been dynamited in the first days and then shoved, cracked and empty, into the middle of the bare room. Nobody thought to move it. It was almost funny.

In the anarchy of the first weeks certain craftsmen had cut the paintings out of their frames, generously leaving the frames on the walls. A second, more practical wave of enthusiasts took the portraits frames and all: pictures of people they had never heard of, wanted for reasons nobody could guess. After a month and a half of looting, guards were finally posted at the door, and they turned out to be little thieves too. But then, it was a hungry time, and they had families, and in a civil war the instinct to forage is an old animal one. In such a season, creatures with no taste for carrion turn into jackals, and yesterday's doves into hawks.

Lately the house had been the meeting place of a self-appointed congress of "veterans of the Red Army," which held informal councils, drinking parties, and other unofficial functions, since nothing could yet be official. And yet even in their thieves' dens the enthusiasts of Khabarovsk, and there were plenty of enthusiasts among the fools, conducted their business with an extraordinary passion for paperwork, recording every decision in endless resolutions and decrees. The People's Revolutionary Army of the Far Eastern Republic had existed for two years, and its organisers had at least taught it to write things down.

Eventually the new proletarian administration, which sat in other buildings, decided to stop the house being turned into a pigsty or somebody's barn, and gave it to the commanders of the army's field units. In early August the drunks of the rear were cleared out and the floors were even washed. It was all for nothing. The new tenants liked to put their boots up just as much as the old ones, and to stub out their cigarettes on anything still good that the wind of looting had not yet carried away. On the first floor, in the largest room in the house, the staffs began to hold their operational meetings. They were preparing the *liberation* of the Maritime Province, which had become a bone in everyone's throat; nobody had expected the Whites to hold the country round Vladivostok for so long.

It was at one of these meetings, held at night, since apparently nobody could think in the daytime, that a telegraphist brought in a fresh secret decree.

It instructed them to draw up a plan for planting people in the enemy's camp: sympathisers, or better still, soldiers who had proved themselves in intelligence work. If what the decree called the *major remnants* of the intelligentsia ran abroad, these people were to go with them, and wait there for further instructions. As had been proved more than once already, the decree observed, such remnants had a habit of financing and obstructing the cause of world revolution from the comfort of the advanced capitalist countries, where they mostly ended up.

That was not, however, the main point. What was chiefly wanted was dozens, if not hundreds, of ordinary informers and scouts; the decree did not specify how many. And there the region was a problem. In the years of the war many of the old agents had given themselves away, and more had been killed. A real underground had never formed here; the Land of Magnolias is boundless, and the Party had spent its strength winning back Siberia from the various Whites and the foreigners who helped them.

Still, the thing had to be done, here and now. The one who spoke was Comrade S., a man already something of a legend, one of the "former people," and experienced. He made two points. First, the Whites were no longer bothering with counter-intelligence; they had no time for it. Second, they would not hold out long in any case, so there was no sense in the kind of patient, painstaking work the Red propagandists had done before the revolution.

Nobody challenged him. The men around the table were fairly ordinary fellows who could drive cavalry into the wind magnificently and had no idea how to solve a problem of this sort. Someone suggested giving S. a partner,

but a few objections disposed of that. In the end, without descending into dull debate, they decided to recruit about a hundred locals: entirely untrained, but suitable, and of low risk. People from Khabarovsk would do; they thought the same way as people in Vladivostok.

The network already had certain points for the "transmission of data" in the port, and the port itself had been given a code name by the Centre: *Rhododendron*, after the delicate shrub with pinkish flowers that grows in the undergrowth of the Maritime Province, Korea and Japan. The local cells were to take charge of the volunteers until the city fell. After sampling some wine from the little cellar, the commissars dispersed towards morning and set to work.

The criteria were agreed the next day, and written down at great length, in language that was illiterate both as Magnolian and as bureaucracy; these crude orders were a long way yet from being legal documents. They divided the recruits into two groups. To help with the second, the *escorts*, as they were called (in fact the future guardians of Soviet order abroad, a resident network), specialists were sent from Novo-Nikolayevsk, today Novosibirsk, on the first available train. They had a knack for finding and judging such people, though they could not themselves travel with them. By the thirtieth of August both groups had been found, a few short of the target. The second group was made up of people with at least some education. The first were for the most part entirely illiterate, but practical, knowing people, who had been around.

A red dawn was rising over the Far East.

Khabarovsk was preparing to take Spassk, the last serious line of defence, a hundred and twenty miles from the capital of the Maritime Province. Even Nikolsk, which today's reader knows as Ussuriysk, though it was much nearer to Vladivostok, was thought an easy target. But the fortified district at Spassk, built in 1921 by soldiers of the Japanese 8th Infantry Division, consisted of seven field forts, and it needed a general plan and careful thought before it could be stormed. The Red Army men gave it both.

On the third of September, from Vyazemskaya station outside Khabarovsk, on the new state railway to the Ussuri, three unremarkable men of thoroughly Magnolian appearance set out with a horse-drawn supply train in the direction of Spassk. On foot, and with no great difficulty, they slipped across the Chinese border, found a boat waiting for them where a sandbar divides Little Lake Khanka from the great one, and crossed that lovely water at an unhurried pace in two days. They landed at Kamen-Rybolov, a village the Cossacks had founded half a century earlier as a strongpoint on land that had been China's

until 1860, made their way by the obvious road to Nikolsk, and on the twelfth of September reached Vladivostok, having had the luck not to meet the *honghuzi*, the Chinese bandits who were thick in those parts, nor any of the Japanese or Whites, who were thicker.

Each of the three had been assigned to one of two prominent people who were still in the city.

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Choking, the drowning man found the strength to overcome his own weight, and at last he hauled himself out of the sea and onto the jetty. He tore the boy from his back and flung him down on the cobbles like a kitten. Then, his teeth chattering from the cold water, he demanded, not without obscenities, what the devil that had been and what it had been for.

Now he was standing over the child. But this Cerberus was not frightening in the least, and his wet rags made him less so. He looked like a policeman: not fat, being too tall for that, but round in the face, as if every pie he had eaten in his life had settled not in his belly but in his cheeks.

Over the course of that strange conversation it came out that the gentleman was a ship's officer of the long-distance kind, and that he had decided to take his own life for a reason he did not tell the boy. All the same, he thanked the little bandit, drily, asked his name, and offered him a place to stay until he had dried out, and something to eat.

They talked, and sat wet until dawn, but not idly. With a leaky bucket they found nearby they put out what remained of the burnt-out workshop; the water was close, and some of it even reached the fire. The work warmed them and loosened their tongues, and in that hour two people who could not have been more different, one of whom had meant to rob the other, came to talk almost as father and son. Perhaps it was because every homeless child, and the boy had been one for two years, since he had lost his family somewhere in the docks, needs a mother's and a father's love. Or no: what such a child needs is attention.

All his thefts, he said, had been only to keep himself alive, which was obvious enough. And all this time he had been looking for his parents, and had not found them.

The captain, whose name was Yevgeny Nikolayevich Vrublevsky, liked the boy's cheek. His name was Ivan, and he said everything honestly and straight

out, in a voice that was oddly deep for his age. Yevgeny Nikolayevich had a good ear and heard a hoarseness in it too, and put it down to the night's adventure.

They sat for a while on a bench in front of the house. The boy was not quite ginger, more fair, with enormous blue eyes and freckles all over, and he apologised, very sweetly and like a child, for what he might have done if the pistol had come into his hands. By sunrise the two vagabonds had reached the captain's lodgings, almost in the centre of town: a good flat on the first floor of a merchant's house, several spacious rooms with high ceilings. And what a staircase that house had. It was wooden, and it did not creak. You go into another house just like it and climb the very same kind of stairs, and the noise is as if a poltergeist had moved in.

Vanya had not lost on the streets what he had been given before the age of five, when he was lost. Here and there, in small ways, he showed signs of an upbringing that was, if not the best, certainly not the simplest. Yevgeny noticed it; at forty-five he was a fair judge of people.

The door opened, and Vanya found himself in a museum. The flat was a little cabinet of curiosities. In the hall, a life-size bulldog cast in metal greeted visitors. On the wall, hung on laths and nails, a ring of sea creatures enclosed a round clock that was really a stylised navigation instrument. The corridor, which divided the flat into two hemispheres, was lined with portraits and photographs, most of them of landscapes, very finely taken. It struck Vanya, not to the depths of his soul, but it was the first pleasant impression of his life. Two of the four rooms were shut, with large, gaudy padlocks hung with little red ribbons.

They sat down and ate sparingly. The host had no great store of food and no culinary pretensions: ordinary porridge and a little salt beef. What the boy remembered most was the tea. It amazed him. He had never tasted tea before in his life, and this was good tea, real leaf tea, brewed in a small samovar.

The captain contrived to stuff the boy's head with so many stories about that tea that the guest grew drowsy, as if from a feast, though the meal had been meagre. Yes, the captain was like that. Three hours earlier he had stood at death's door, and now he was holding forth calmly, like some provincial lecturer from Hubei on the science of tea. But his eyes gave out an immense sadness, whatever cheerful tone he wore over it, and his merry grown-up's mask did not fit. They talked for a long time, and Yevgeny told him a great deal about himself.

He had been born on a November night in Kronstadt, the son of a well-known military doctor from a long line of military doctors, and of a ballerina

from a Petersburg theatre. He was a bright child, and a sickly one. For part of his childhood he lived in the south with his grandfather, a veteran of the Crimean War and of the Caucasus campaigns, of which the old man spoke with a pride that Yevgeny only later learned to distrust: a hard man, a man of principle, who believed that a boy, like a mountain village, was something to be subdued.

At thirteen Yevgeny ran away. For several years he drifted from town to town across the south, getting into scrapes not unlike the ones today's Vanya knew. It had not been youthful rebellion. He had fled from the endless beatings and humiliations. He was a vulnerable child: no coward and no crybaby, but not hard and crusty either, like a three-year-old rusk, and not made for unbending discipline. And yet now Yevgeny was astonished. He had been much older then, and he could not imagine how this fragile boy of seven, and thousands like him, if not millions, wandered the cities and the endless roads of the civil war, dying of hunger, killing, falling in with armed bands of every side, and especially those Yevgeny least understood, such as the anarchists. He himself had held moderate, conservative views since childhood. But he had never been able to stomach the humiliation that patriarchal stupidity calls upbringing.

At fifteen he settled down, came back to Petersburg, which delighted his parents, who had known almost nothing of where he was, and enrolled at the university as an auditor in philology. He thought of switching to biology. Then he changed his mind again and followed his father and his mother's father into medicine. He studied long and conscientiously, and liked nearly all of it, but he could not bear so much blood, and left in his fourth year. There was a great scandal at home. For a year he was swept up in the socialist ideas of his friends, but soon understood they were not for him, and went to sea as a common ship's boy on a freighter. After that, everything simply happened.

Towards evening the boy told his own story, about trying to find his family. It turned out he was not a local either, and that his parents had also been connected with the army. Such is the country; such are its professions. He told it with difficulty, with great sadness. He remembered everything. He could not understand why they had not found him. He told how he had spent the first winter in a private asylum outside the city, among the insane; how he had run away from it and gone back to the docks; how some dark people had made him steal, taken everything he brought, and kept him on a chain. There were tears on Yevgeny's face too, especially when this child, who had never been taught his letters or his sums, spoke of the great number of others like him, and of the customs of that other world in which they lived.

Mr Vrublevsky wanted to give him hope of finding his parents. But when the boy so plainly wanted to be heard, he said nothing. He knew it was impossible, for several reasons, and above all because in a few weeks he would be leaving the city as first officer of a fairly large ocean-going steamer. To turn away from the painful subject and not promise the impossible, he switched to a romantic, storytelling tone, and told the boy about his travels: the cities of Europe, Japan, the voyage he had made ten years earlier from Cairo to Ceylon. He spread out a big map and showed the impressionable Ivan the whole glorious world.

His heart was very heavy. He left out the story of his own life, and that story was very sad indeed. A few weeks earlier he had lost his wife, and with her their younger son, a fair, freckled boy who looked suspiciously like the homeless Vanya now sitting in his armchair. How he had lost them, he told no one. All evening Yevgeny kept swallowing against the tightness in his throat, trying to kill that unbearable pain of loss, and for a moment he thought he understood that he had been given a chance. No. He had not. This was somebody else's child. If things had been otherwise, he would have helped him find his parents. Alas.

The captain paid no attention to the child's dirty clothes, nor to the near certainty that he had lice. He simply gave him a bed for the night.

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Vanya woke in a bad mood. His mouth was dry, and he had a dogged craving for *makhorka*. Yes: at his age, in his world, everyone smoked. He had gone several days without, and today the habit was making itself felt, lashing at his sick mind with the force of a wave as high as a three-storey house. In so small a body, still growing.

The captain was already out. While he was gone, the boy, with the skills he had picked up in the past two years, searched the whole flat for tobacco. He took nothing, that is worth recording, but he found nothing either, and it made him miserable.

He sat in the armchair and, since nothing else would come into his head, remembered how the stinking stuff had got into his life in the first place. They were not easy memories. The summer of 1920: he had been wandering the streets for three months in search of food. Like a stray he attached himself to a pack (there is no other word) of small thieves and pickpockets, most of them

about his size, though some were fifteen. There was a hard hierarchy, and once you were in it, it was hard to get out alive. But alone he had nearly died of hunger, after his foolish escape from the asylum, and the pack was his salvation. They shared their food, and he found a place to sleep under a roof, and that saved him in his first autumn and winter, the hardest season for children like him, as for birds and animals; people put out food for the birds and the animals, but no one fed their own kind, and sometimes they caught them and tormented them.

Vanya bitterly regretted that time. Put into literary language, his feelings could be summed up as: *Better to lay down your bones for the land than to be a slave to beasts.* The whole disorganised rabble was in fact run by minders from the criminal gangs, plain bandits who made the children steal and bring the loot where it was wanted. Ivan was a chained dog for one of these terrible men: a window boy, small enough to wriggle through the little hinged vents of locked houses. Then one day he got "lucky." He was caught in the act, his older accomplices ran, and after thirty strokes across the back he found that the gang had let him go.

Before that, they had forced cigarettes on him, and that was deliberate. It was how the minders tied the children to them. The older ones found ways to get *makhorka* for themselves; the slower ones had to come back, cap in hand, for the next ration. His second winter was no better. Then he found another crew, independent this time, and somehow his life steadied. He grew wiser, and began to understand how heavy life is, as if from the height of someone much older than he was. He could not tell all of it even to himself. There were worms in those memories, and cockroaches, and lice and the endless fight against them, and filth beyond description, and murders, and, most terrible of all to the boy, rats.

There his memories broke off, and a strong wave of nausea came over him.

The captain came back from the market. The city was a port, so there was at least no shortage of fish, even in those days, and he made a simple but rather good breakfast. Early that morning, while the boy was sleeping in a proper bed for the first time in years, Yevgeny had met a friend and arranged for Vanya to be cleaned up at the bathhouse, and a kind neighbour found him clothes that her own son had outgrown. Vrublevsky had nowhere to hurry to. His ship had not yet even docked; she was still off the coast of Japan. A day earlier he might have been lying at the bottom of the bay, and here he was instead, alive and well and in no hurry at all.

After the bathhouse the boy looked, at last, like himself. All he lacked was a barber, so they went to one, and on the way they called at a bakery.

It was not what it had been five years before. It was not so festive, and there was no longer a queue out of the door of ladies in lovely dresses and gentlemen whose shoes had been polished to a mirror by the boys on the corner. But the smell of vanilla and pastry still overpowered whatever was left of anyone's perfume, and it left in the memory the classic smell of an untroubled childhood in any one of the empire's many towns, where people handed over their kopeck or their rouble here with pleasure.

To look ahead: things would not go well. For a decade this little workshop of family happiness would become a squalid drinking den, where every passer-by was sure to drop in and mourn, consciously or not, the good old days. But it would rise again, and then the little building would become a delicatessen, the first in the city and the best, still keeping the kindness that its founder had laid into its first bright-orange brick.

The captain bought a poppy-seed bun, a baguette and some pastries with sweet fillings, and Vanya devoured them with enormous pleasure, as he devoured everything that came his way. It took his mind off the craving. The sweet, warm bun calmed him for a while, which no doubt had its physiological reasons, but he never dared ask for tobacco, which in any case was scarce and not easily bought at the end of August 1922.

Vanya said little and ate a great deal, filling his stomach and his head with simple tasks, and keeping his mind off his wretched passion for smoke. He had tried everything in that pastime, which to a non-smoker seems the simplest and most stupefying thing in the world, from snuff to chewing tobacco. He had never liked the chewing kind, but he had come across it often: sickly and foul, it burned the whole mouth and went straight to the head. It came in little squares or cubes, and it was not lump sugar, which does no harm except to the figures of young ladies, but a revolting pressed or twisted mass that he, in his ignorance, had not even spat out but swallowed. And he remembered it now with great tenderness, and the illusory happiness that had set his heart racing like a sick man's.

His hoarseness, which the captain had put down to the cold water, was in fact the voice of a year and a half of smoking whatever rubbish found its way into a thieves' den. And Yevgeny had smelled the tobacco on the boy's clothes the night before, but in his world he had never imagined that a child of seven could be in its grip. In his own youth it had all started several years later. He had

never smoked himself, because of a weak chest in childhood. He knew perfectly well what children ought to look like; once, long ago, he had meant to become a children's doctor, at the new sanatorium they were going to build at Sestroretsk on the Gulf of Finland. They did build it. By the time it opened, he was on his way to Genoa and Marseille.

CHAPTER THREE

# No Miracle



The evacuation was being prepared in earnest now. On becoming Ruler, Diterikhs had told a newspaper in July: "The liberation of the Land of Magnolias seems to me a question of a miracle." He knew perfectly well that there are no miracles. But he had a choice. He could take the risk, throw himself into the fight and lose, or he could go back to cobbling boots. And there was one more thing that held him in Vladivostok: a case he regarded as the most important of his life, the criminal investigation into the murder of Nicholas II and his family. He had carried its files across Siberia in his luggage, and he had reached his own conclusion, which he would publish that year in a thick book: that the killing had been the work of a Jewish conspiracy against a Christian Magnolian land. That a man of his education could believe it says a good deal about the Land of Magnolias he was trying to save.

By the twentieth of August he had given up everything else in favour of an idea that was more painful but more rational: thorough preparation for leaving the Land of Magnolias for good. It is hard to be the man who signs a capitulation, and in this case the evacuation was exactly that.

"Our small national state of the Amur, which so proudly and boldly raised the banner of struggle for Faith, Tsar and Fatherland, will of course be crushed and wiped from the face of the earth," the Ruler would tell the people, with unusual honesty, a little later. "There is no use hiding it. We have neither the money to live, nor the cartridges to defend our lives."

Ships were needed, and organisers. Delicate work was under way with the Americas, where Magnolians already settled on the far side of the ocean were preparing the ground for the ships to come. Crews were signed on. Long, hard talks went on with the Japanese about vessels, fuel and everything else.

The last of the money was spent on equipment and on holding the enemy off a little longer. The Japanese Empire, for its part, was determined to extract every possible profit from what was happening. It was harvest time. Soon a hurricane would come through and sweep it all away, as if none of it had ever been.

Those who had lately read, in the soft armchairs of their homes, Ivan Bunin's new story "The Gentleman from San Francisco" had no idea that some of them were about to become, quite literally, residents of that city, so recently rebuilt after its great earthquake. Others might have done better to take the story as Bunin meant it, as a parable about the vanity of a life spent chasing money, comfort and amusement, a life most of them knew rather well. To some it seemed that everything that had happened was payment for those sins; that, like Napoleon, they were being sent to their Elba to think it over, and if they failed to understand, then on to their own St Helena, for the rest of their days. In practice it would not be so tragic. Not for all of them. Even in late August, not all of them were ready to give up the trade of pleasure.

Among the first in the queue for a "lucky ticket" to the unknown world across the Pacific were faces from our evening at the professor's. Five days after it they had banded together into one party, and they meant, it seemed, to settle in Los Angeles, one of the largest cities on the west coast of the United States. That was the commonest plan. No ships were going to South America, and getting there was hard; and in any case why bother, when there were Canada and Mexico? Those with enough means, usually in the form of precious metals and diamonds, made their way to Europe. The poor majority, of course, were not going anywhere.

Several thousand people of middling and high fortune set about choosing the best possible vessel, the softest and the fastest, and the one their neighbours would envy most. But that applied only to the hardiest dinosaurs of the old world. Most of those preparing to leave were a good deal less rich, and a good deal less eager.

There were, broadly, two kinds of them. The first were the "touring company": people who had travelled the country in step with the Whites' victories and defeats, strange people, not cowards exactly, but unable to live without action and intrigue. They had been the Whites' paymasters, some of them, and many were great landowners who had not got out of their provinces in time and had been riding round the Land of Magnolias ever since, waiting for the counter-offensive that would give them back their estates. They did not stand

in the queues that the clerks required. They were known by name, and there were no more than a dozen of them in the city. Twenty years earlier the young Dzerzhinsky had written to his sister Aldona about people of this sort, and for once he was not wrong: "It is a hundred times better to work for less pay for a good man than for the scoundrels who, for the money they pay you, are ready to suck out not only your strength but your nerves, your health and your life. They want to buy not just your work but the whole man. They turn a man into a commodity, and that is the most terrible thing of all." What Dzerzhinsky went on to build out of his indignation is another story. To this first group one might also add the professional propagandists, public men who wrote tales true and false about their enemies for the local press, such as the journalists of *Slovo*, fierce anti-Soviets from mostly wealthy families.

The second group was more peaceable: conservative doctors, scientists, teachers, some of them from the universities of the capitals, whom fate had driven to this edge of the world; a small party of clergy; a great pack of officials and their endless deputies; a few soldiers; and some of the local merchants. It was the merchants who wailed loudest over their great trunks, and tried to bury in the woods whatever they could not take within the baggage limit. That short season was rich in hiding places and buried treasure, laid down in the hope of coming back one day. Some of the stranger hoarders hid their goods underwater, carelessly heaving whole households off the clifftops into quiet coves, furniture and all, which naturally smashed to pieces. *So long as they don't get it*: the motto of many a fool. They would never learn that the proletariat's bloodhounds dug up a good part of it, and that hardly anyone ever came back for the rest.

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The first ship meant for the evacuation came into port on the fifth of September. She was the same ship that had slipped out at midnight three weeks earlier for what was officially called *consultations*. What exactly she had been doing in the meantime one could guess, but there was little point in saying, and I was not there to hold the candle. She was to sail on the fourteenth. Some seven hundred people had been given lucky tickets, and it was understood that she would pick up more who needed "saving." Nobody was permitted to strip the city bare. There were soldiers aboard, but only retired ones, of high rank, and wounded officers, and certainly no common privates.

She was not without luxuries, as was proper for such a ship. It was plain enough that people were not the main part of her cargo. I will note only that for the three days before she sailed, with short breaks, she was loaded not with passengers' trunks but with large, heavy wooden crates, and now and then with zinc-lined boxes. The work was done by a gang of about thirty men of phenomenal strength and endurance, all of them looking like brothers of the great wrestler Ivan Poddubny. No one else was taken on, except a few nimble boys who were needed to roll absurdly small kegs into corners the broad-shouldered men could not reach. It gave them at least some pay in a time when there was no work.

She left modestly, with few people to see her off. Those who left went as whole families, so who was there to wave? Only those servants, housekeepers and governesses who for some reason had not been taken on the long voyage. Early in the morning she cleared the harbour and went ahead, like a flagship, to break the road to that distant, incomprehensible America, overgrown with legends.

They knew a good deal about Europe. About the New World, the one thing many of the passengers remembered was that it had fought a civil war of its own half a century before, which did not reassure them in the least. What if it happened again? Would they have to run again? The world is not so very large. And over everything hung the ghost of world revolution. Many had laughed at the revolutionaries of 1905, and been wrong to. No one had believed in revolution in Germany, and it had happened, so what could one say about the Land of Magnolias? Few now remembered how they had smirked at the students and their bungled bombs, aimed at provincial governors in every corner of the empire; it had stopped being funny when the bombs reached emperors. They remembered Stolypin's death in the Kiev opera house, too. And they shivered at the thought that the Bolsheviks would track down every one of their most prominent enemies. It was a hard time, when the *rabble*, the *lumpen*, as people here called them, was advancing in seven-league boots on every front of life, and to be one of the prominent enemies was to stand one step from the block.

The second ship was promised for the twentieth of September, and this time it was much easier to get a place. In a kind of informal queue, most of the people from the professor's evening found themselves on her list, in first or second class according to some mysterious system of allocation. On the seventeenth the postmen brought the letters round. Each was in an envelope

of cheap paper, typed in multiple copies, identical except for the name of the addressee and the stamp and signature of whoever had granted permission. Departure was set for the twenty-fourth.

The city was still living its peaceful life. Spassk was holding. The Japanese had not yet left. Everything was as it had been a month before, except for one thing: the moment when life would turn over yet again was coming on, without mercy.

The time of farewells began, and of joyless packing. The townspeople understood for the first time that they were losing their homes. The newcomers had been through that already; their houses had long since been burned, looted or taken by strangers. It was touching to watch the refugees comforting the tender-hearted local ladies who wept over everything they could not take, in one case a pair of worn-out boots that had belonged either to a brother or to a husband. There was a strict limit on baggage, a few poods per person. At first pets were forbidden. Nobody asked for travel papers for a dog in those days, but the hysterics of wives and children, dripping steadily onto the grey and balding heads of the fathers of families, produced a collective petition to soften the rule, and the petition was granted. A limited number of dogs and cats were permitted to leave the Land of Magnolias and to leave no further descendants there. A great loss, of course.

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The salon was not a hundred paces away now. It occupied a rather striking building on Svetlanskaya Street, which was named after the frigate *Svetlana*, in which Grand Duke Alexei Alexandrovich had visited Vladivostok in 1873. Most surprising of all, its first name had been American Street, after the steam corvette *America*, the first Magnolian ship to survey the Bay of Peter the Great, in 1859, and it had become the city's main street, and by some accounts its first. In a couple of years it would be renamed again, Leninskaya this time, as obviously and as foolishly as in hundreds of other towns: building the image of a "divine" leader by hastily destroying whatever had been the present only yesterday and had become the new regime's curse today. But that is for another time.

On this day everything was still the old way. The captain, in full uniform, since he had to call at the port office afterwards, took the boy to his own barber, an old Jew named Boris Moiseyevich, who was a close friend and was

also planning to "cast off" soon. His was the first and best salon in the city; his father had opened it, and it had passed to him by inheritance.

The captain asked his friend to find a master who could manage the fidget he had brought in, which produced some odd looks from the regulars, who liked to sit here over coffee and excellent pastries while they waited their turn to have their hair, beards or moustaches trimmed. The salon had an atmosphere all its own, in which the haircut was not the main thing but only completed the scene: the smell of a newspaper just bought from a boy in the lane, and of something else. Boris Moiseyevich's was not the only such place; that was the manner of the time, and the time was vanishing fast. There would never be another like it. Everything would become a good deal more prosaic.

Yevgeny left the boy with a gesture the others did not understand, said he had to step out for an hour, and that if he was late they should give the boy something to eat and he would pay for it. And on the doorstep, having nearly forgotten, he said they should cut the boy's hair however they saw fit, since neither he nor, naturally, his shaggy ward, with hair hanging to his shoulders, knew anything about that complicated business.

His arm hurt mercilessly, but he gave no sign of it. With a light step, like a young man, he set off for home as fast as he could, and in a quarter of an hour he was in the flat. He took his keys and went down to the cellar. Yes, his house had a cellar, and in it, among the empty wine bottles, he found with trembling hands the little bottle he had hidden there, a bottle that had once held smelling salts, perhaps, and now held a white crystalline powder. He had been using it for two months, ever since the terrible pains had taken hold of his arm and threatened to cost him his work, which he so badly did not want to lose. It was morphine.

He dissolved it in water he had ready, in the right strength, drew it into a syringe, injected himself just below the shoulder, and licked his lips in anticipation of the blessed relief. He had made it in time. The smallest delay meant unbearable pain in the muscles, the joints, the bowels, bloody flux, vomiting, a faltering heart and breath, terrors and dreadful visions.

As soon as it reached his blood the pain began to recede, and in its place came a mythical euphoria. The doctor who had prescribed it had forgotten to tell him one thing: that it must not be used the way the captain was using it. He did not know what the drug did. To him it was only a painkiller. Morphine had been travelling the world for decades, and it always brought dependence quickly. It conquered the captain quickly too, though he did not know it yet;

he thought he was treating his pain, and the pain was by now a phantom. For a month or so he had been in the first stage of addiction. Why the doctor had sold him so much powder, no one knows. It was not even pure morphine but some adulterated substitute that made the effect stronger still. He went pale and leaned back in the chair. His pupils narrowed to points; his breathing and his heart slowed. For half an hour he sat like that, feeling his burning wish to be free of pain satisfied. Why he never went back to the doctors is a mystery. He should have understood that dulling a pain is not curing it. But there was no one around him who knew, and slowly and surely he was beginning to kill himself.

At the same time the boy's craving was tearing its way out of his body. It was the fourth day since he had stopped smoking, and nicotine has much the same cunning hold as the morphine described above. And he too was lucky, in his way. A man in the next chair, a dedicated smoker, spent the whole haircut tempting the boy's nose with the smell of fresh, "delicious" tobacco, provocatively lighting up one cigarette after another, until the boy's small foolish brain could think of nothing except escaping from the barber, who was entirely unnecessary to him. He fidgeted and pulled faces at the mirror and kept the man from doing his work. The barber even took offence and stopped trying to calm him, not understanding that the smoke in the next chair was a red rag to a bull. And then the boy's gods heard his prayer. Without the slightest twinge of conscience the smoker offered him one, and the boy was boundlessly grateful. After his long abstinence the pleasure was immense, and so was the pleasant weakness in his legs. For a little while he imagined himself one of Lermontov's young officers in the Caucasus, fighting to the death in the mountains. He waved his arms about without a word, frothing a little at the mouth, which was strange; but these things are individual. Gradually he came to himself, and remembered that he ought to run back to the barber's for the man who had taken charge of him, having briefly forgotten even his simple name.

So the two fools, each hiding his sickness from the other, one old and one young, were reunited, and wandered home. There the captain, carried along by his "dose of lightness," sang some song or other as he made dinner and fed the boy, and the boy was not half as glad of the food as of the dried rubbish hidden in his pocket. A cigarette smoked down to the end does not leave much appetite.

Soon after dinner Yevgeny Nikolayevich went to the port, where he began working with the crew that in three weeks would sail for America. The three

weeks that followed were very dull. They passed from dose to dose, in the careful and rather successful concealment of his habit, and in the late understanding that he could no longer free himself of it. For a while Vanya lived with him. Then he vanished for nearly two weeks, which disappointed the captain's weary life more than ever, and reappeared in the middle of the month as if nothing had happened. The doses kept growing. The morphine would run out soon, though for now he had plenty.

He spent every day at the ship, and Vanya, out of curiosity, often came with him. Yevgeny called him his son, and although everybody knew his son was much older, nobody asked awkward questions. Nobody had time.

The route was worked out. It would have to call at Petropavlovsk on Kamchatka for coal and stores, and then, since even that would not be enough fuel, make a change of course to put in at Vancouver as well, before the last leg to Los Angeles. It promised to be a long voyage, and the sailing, first planned for the first of October, was brought forward by a week, because the ship was not well suited to what the harbour authorities called, in so many words, "weather phenomena which may manifest themselves in the autumn and winter period." Yevgeny got the post he had been promised, first officer. When people asked about his family he joked his way out of it and told no one that they were dead, for reasons he could not have explained.

Everything took its course. The first ship had been seen off without incident, crowded with people. The second, Mr Vrublevsky's, would be more modest, but she would show the way: seven more steamers of her size were meant to follow the same route. Our hero was the only man in her entire crew, I repeat, the only one, who had ever set foot on American soil. He had sailed a different route then, but even so. Even the master of the ship had never been there, except for one long-ago voyage near Alaska when he was a whaler. The crew numbered twenty-seven men, where thirty-six were needed. That was the decision of the naval department, or rather of whatever body was at that moment in charge of the "maritime" side of the evacuation, which simply did not have the men.

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How fortunate that the cities of the Far East had not yet sprawled the way London had, with its endless slums. Vladivostok was a young city. It had its narrow lanes down by the port, but you could still breathe here at your

full height; there were still pines and firs, and of course the enchantment of the Golden Horn Bay. On the twenty-third of September, a warm and cloudless day, the day when night once more takes over from daylight in the northern hemisphere, anyone strolling along the Embankment towards the Semyonovsky market, along Semyonovskaya and Fontannaya Streets, and later along the Nikolayevsky and Central prospects, would have seen a curious sight.

Among the ordinary passers-by there were little groups of ladies with handkerchiefs and frippery, all in tears. This was how the masters of the old life said goodbye. Men walked separately through the streets they had known since childhood, or that had become dear to them in a short while, all in their best suits and all carrying canes. They did not carry canes because they were lame but because that was how it was done, by an unwritten rule. Scrubbed and scented children marched between their parents and blocked the road to the rare motorcars of the time. People said goodbye to the trams too, Vladivostok's pride: ten years earlier it had become the first city in the Magnolian Far East to have them. The founders themselves took a last ride, the engineers and the chief of the first tram depot (the second, as it turned out, was never used for its purpose). They would not celebrate the tenth anniversary of the line in the small circle of those who had built it. Tomorrow most of them would leave the city against their will. Some would stay, and die a martyr's death for having worked with the "bourgeois" and sympathised with them. And some would be lucky. Many tears of parting would be held back that day, and many more shed. That is natural, as a citizen's love for his home is natural, so long as it is sincere.

The luggage was packed, the keys handed over, the instructions given, the keepsakes exchanged.

Through this city, so entirely foreign to them, walked three gentlemen from "Moscow" who had never set foot here before, not even in passing. The journey round Spassk had exhausted them. They had nearly failed in their orders; only by bribing an official of the White administration with gold had they got permission to sail, under hastily prepared papers and cover stories that made them journalists from some small town in central Magnolia, Tula or Oryol, so that no one would take them for men of Moscow, or, God forbid, of Petrograd itself. There were too many hidden rocks and too many chance acquaintances in the capitals, and they had chosen wisely.

In the time they had been here they had made contact with the right underground cell, passed on the fiery greetings of Bolshevism and something more

practical besides, without unnecessary embraces, and been given lodgings at the very edge of town, on Lugovaya Street, in an abandoned cottage built of sea stone, entirely unremarkable to look at. There was no electricity, which did not trouble the guests in the least: a few candles they bought and a storm lantern they found saved the situation. The cottage was very modest, two rooms under a flat roof, more like a hunter's hut than a house, except that its walls were stone instead of logs. Food was no problem. A couple of days later they traded some trinkets for paraffin with a blind old woman who had no use for it. In the evenings they played cards; in the daytime they shadowed the men they had been assigned.

It was dull work. They had been allowed to read the files on their targets, carefully stitched together by the careful hands of the future Soviet intelligence service, which set out in crude and simple terms the crimes of agitation committed by these whiskered villains and the empirical proof of their most destructive activity against the young Soviet system. The Soviet Union itself was still four months from being founded. To tell the truth, the three were not much impressed by the stories of the men they were to watch. Two of the dullest bourgeois imaginable. One was a scrawny scribbler, thin as death, whom you could strangle with a handkerchief: a pamphleteer of the anti-Bolshevik press called Sobesky. The other, to borrow from Chekhov, was the fat soldier of the pair, a cavalry general who had made his name by what would later be called the White Terror. On that score the files did not exaggerate. There were villages in Transbaikalia that remembered him well, and the memory was not of whiskers.

Among themselves the troika (no, not of horses) assumed that both men would simply be killed. But the leadership thought it sweeter to finish them off across the ocean, and it would have been foolish to argue, for revenge is a sweet fruit, and the better it is arranged the sweeter it tastes. So far very few of those who had fled had been killed on foreign soil. That would come, and soon. For now the Bolsheviks had other things to do. All three were delighted at the chance to see what they called nothing but "the States." They were about thirty, and had distinguished themselves in Petrozavodsk and later on the Caspian.

"I'll remind you that we sail tomorrow. No drinking and no foolishness. I know you're not that sort, but all the same. And another thing: you, what are you now, 'Mister,' ah, Bogodukhov, yes, it does sound funny, doesn't it, Comrade Neuter? I remind you officially that from now on you address people

as *vy*, with respect, and you drop those stupid jokes of yours. On the ship nobody will understand them."

This was said over the morning table by the overgrown raspberry canes, by the man in charge of the operation: a former officer of the Samara branch of the tsar's own secret police, the Okhrana, a man of about forty-five named Semyon Semyonovich Bobrov, who for the purposes of this operation had taken the professional name of Semyon Petrovich Neglasov.

"I don't need the lesson. I've learnt it all, it's all clear," the third man declared with a guffaw, after a silence from Comrade Neuter-Bogodukhov, to whom it had all been addressed. The third man's name was Roman Mikhailovich Morozov. They had not even given him an alias.

"Well, that's all right, then," said Semyon Semyonovich, once again, his favourite phrase. He had said it over and over in the February days of 1917, while he set fire to the Samara police headquarters he had served for years. Everything burned, except the archives he needed, which he and a few like-minded men carried off and handed to the Bolsheviks, earning great honour and a good post. After that he did nothing heroic, but sat happily in staff offices in towns well behind the lines. He had volunteered for this operation, been given permission without difficulty, and decided to "get some air." A man who has burned one set of masters' files can serve any master. It was a quality the new state valued as highly as the old one had.

Neuter-Bogodukhov gave his chief a strange look, almost the look of a beast of prey. He was offended at being interrupted, and he did not get on with Semyon Semyonovich. He was an odd comrade altogether. In the short time they had been together the two had failed to find a common language, and only Roman kept the growing dislike between them in check. What it was about, no one could say. Semyon understood that if it went on like this it would be simpler to be rid of Neuter, and understood too that this was impossible, and unnecessary. They had agreed together to get close to their targets during the "cruise," or perhaps only once they were in America. Everything depended on the Centre's instructions, and so far those were vague, a limited task that seemed simple. That evening came the last communication through the telegraphist, and there were no further orders. The telegraphist at the port was rather irritable in any case, because they had interrupted him in the middle of transmitting the lists of everyone leaving the city, which he had stolen a couple of hours before.

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At about the same time, on the twenty-second of September, the captain was packing the last of his things, and Vanya was with him. Instead of a long speech, he said this:

"You understand that I'm leaving the city, most likely for good. Maybe I'll be lucky and come back on the same ship for the ones who are left. I want to say goodbye to you. I'm sorry, I can't take you aboard. Forgive me. Don't say anything. We've grown close, and in this time you've become a son to me, but no, it can't be done. I'll leave you some paper money. Spend it wisely, and quickly; soon it won't be worth anything. I'm giving the flat to the neighbours. You can live here another week, and then their relatives move in. It was all agreed long ago."

Tears came into Vanya's eyes. He was bitterly disappointed. But he found the strength to say just one thing.

"I understand. All right. But I'll leave with you. Back where I came from. To the port."

"That's your right. I'm sorry. In a couple of hours I go."

The captain walked about the rooms touching the walls of his flat with his hands, barely holding back his tears. He was drowsy. He had taken a sleeping draught borrowed from the neighbour in the first flat, a herbal tincture that knocked him out almost at once. He had tried it twice, to quiet the growing urge to inject, and so far, after a fashion, it had worked. He understood very well by now that he was caught in morphine's trap. If only he had had more time here, on land, he would have gone to a doctor. But there was no time. The withdrawal had begun; he had gone nearly two days without. Believe me, that is hard. He was pale, but he held on as best he could. *If I can only last until we sail, and the first watch*, he thought. But that seemed a fantastical hope. His heart ached, and there was a pain on the side of his liver, and the day after tomorrow, or almost tomorrow, he was to be one of the two men in command of a ship and answerable for several hundred lives.

They sat for a moment before the road, as Magnolians do, and parted, each hoping not to see the other again, and each going, supposedly, in a different direction.

That night the coal was loaded. By morning the stevedores realised that their labour had been for nothing. In the dark, instead of the hard steam coal that

was needed, they had loaded tons of brown coal, and poor stuff at that. On fuel like that the ship would not get far, as a rough reckoning of its heat value made obvious. The thirty-five tons they had managed to load (luckily they had not hurried) were taken off again and replaced with the right kind. It turned out the brown coal had been meant for a Japanese ship moored alongside, which had put in on her way through for no other purpose than to collect it. It was not much of a prize, but nobody was willing to let it go.

In the wheelhouse a great council was held on the route. It was adjusted again, slightly, for internal reasons. The passenger lists were checked, and the stores, the drinking water and the provisions.

On the afternoon of the twenty-third, telegrams went out to the ports of Vancouver, Petropavlovsk and Los Angeles: the ship would sail the next day, and by the calculations would call at those ports after so many days.

She was an iron steamer with two masts for sail and one great tall funnel. Her hull, divided into three decks, was over two hundred feet long and thirty, perhaps forty feet in the beam. She had three holds, fitted with steam cargo winches, and could carry up to eight hundred tons of cargo besides the coal in her bunkers, which had been enlarged by half in a refit a couple of months before at some Japanese yard. A ballast tank sat in the middle hold. In all of this she was very like the old *Vladivostok*, the cargo and passenger steamer of the Volunteer Fleet, sister of the *Kamchatka*, which had been built in the same yard and bought from Britain in 1880 for what was then an enormous sum. The old-timers remembered the *Vladivostok* fondly. In the spring of 1891 she had escorted the cruiser *Pamiat Azova* with the heir to the throne aboard, Nicholas Alexandrovich, the future and, as it turned out, the last emperor, on his visit to the Far East, Japan and China. The *Vladivostok* was not with us any more. On the fifth of October 1893, already battered by the sea, her hull broke in two and she sank, and the halves were soon sold to the Japanese for a laughable thousand roubles. Our iron monster was driven by a compound engine of the same type, of eight hundred horsepower. She was probably a younger sister of the *Kamchatka* and the *Vladivostok*, built ten years or so later, modernised inside but very much like them to look at. Her real name had been carefully scraped off everywhere. She was in decent condition, though she needed some cosmetic repair.

She was called *Helvetia*, a name presumably given her by previous owners who were Swiss, since it is hard to think of any other reason for naming a ship after the personification of a country with no coastline. Stranger still, the name

was painted in Cyrillic, not in the Latin letters it ought to have had. Nobody paid any attention. Nobody had time for guesswork. Of the dockers, few even knew where Switzerland was. *Vladivostok*, now: that was a name that pleased the ear and warmed the heart.

In the afternoon the flag of the Empire of Japan was lowered from her. For some reason the St Andrew's ensign of the old navy went up in its place; then someone realised that this was not right, and the Japanese flag was put back, and beside it on the first mast they hoisted an old black-yellow-white flag that had been gathering dust in some office: the heraldic colours of Alexander II's time, the black of the double-headed eagle, the gold of its field, the white of St George slaying the dragon. Many people were surprised to see it, after twenty years out of use, but nobody objected. On the third deck went up the familiar white-blue-red flag that had become official in the last years of the empire. Both were anachronisms by now. There was no empire, and so no symbols to represent it, no arms and no anthem. To sing "God Save the Tsar" would have been blasphemy; anything else, indecent. No one held a ceremony this time.

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On the night before sailing, our captain pleaded a touch of fever and lay down in his cabin, where he hoped to try the sleeping draught again. This time it failed him. He lay wrapped in a rug, curled up with pain in the grip of withdrawal, and resisted, somewhere below the level of thought. He held out like that until two in the morning. Then, on the fourth day of abstinence, he reached for the healing bottle, mixed the powder with hands that shook and burned with fever, as if he really had caught a bad chill, prepared the glass syringe that had become his friend, and injected himself, and was given relief, and a reprieve of about a day.

All the cargo was aboard. The stevedores went home with a sigh of relief and their pay for the hard labour, and tomorrow they would surprise their wives and children with simple presents.

Sailing was set for ten in the morning. At seven they began to board the passengers. The steamer lay against the landing stage, and on the quay a crowd was waiting its turn, nearly four hundred people. The boarding of a passenger ship is always a moving and interesting thing to watch, especially for an outsider who has no part in the "festivities." The passengers hurry, but the onlooker has nowhere to hurry to, and can watch the sincere tears,

the sincere anxieties of families, how they look. The gentlemen stood humbly awaiting their fate. They were leaving the city. Everything went as it should, calmly, without fuss; there were fewer people this time, and they were easier to manage.

Among the orderly lines stood our acquaintances the neophytes, the three hidden guardians, or rather overseers, of morality and the new ethics. They looked comical, especially the "junior ranks" of the honest company, who made mistakes of manner. They stood rather awkwardly, not at all like the mincing, sugary, self-important gentlemen beside them. And very close to them stood the guests from the professor's evening.

And once again, a month after that August night, there on the quay, a spark of the old quarrel flared up. The grey-haired young man, for some trifling reason, made a light joke at Sobesky's expense, in return for the old man's barb of a month before. Sobesky, who for years had taunted him with certain details of his life that, to the old man's misfortune, he knew all too well, understood him perfectly and cut him off before he could say more.

"Do not judge another man's past," he said. "You do not know your own future."

It cut the talk short at the root, exactly as before. The little scene caught the attention of Semyon Semyonovich. It was Sobesky, as you will remember, who was one of the two figures for whose sake this home-made witch-hunt, as the Reds conceived it, had been got up.

They all breathed more easily when the steamer gave her farewell blast and began to draw away from the quay at three knots, saying goodbye to a city that was foreign to her, though not to her tiny inhabitants. The Land of Magnolias was being left by the cleverest and the stupid, the strong and the weak, the honest and the dishonest, the principled and the unprincipled, the young and the old, the kind and the not so kind; but they were all people.

And the pets? By special form, thirty-three animals were registered: nineteen dogs, ten cats, three parrots, and one tame hedgehog, so sweet that everyone who had the honour of seeing it wanted it for their own. Those who travelled with animals could be spotted a mile off. I exaggerate, of course, but there is some truth in it, because they were mostly given away by baskets covered with shawls, or, in the case of the birds, by cages.

And so the moment came, that moment which had been stretched so long in *chronos* (not to be confused with the mythological deity). There is nothing more to say. Only a hack could describe the first minutes and hours of such a

voyage as an everyday thing, or else someone who had just discovered the whole palette of feelings that make up a sense of the world; and I take it you do not deserve to have your precious time wasted on such enormous foolishness. The soul was so empty, and there was nothing to think about.

CHAPTER FOUR

# Trap



They were all there now, at the point where the past and the present no longer meet. The first-class cabins were taken, though there were not many of them. Second and third class were much of a muchness for comfort. Three hundred and fifty-two passengers in all, and the crew already mentioned.

Or so the lists said. The lists were wrong.

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And Vanya? Did he watch Yevgeny Nikolayevich go?

No. He vanished, as if there had been no August night on the jetty, no bakery, nothing at all. But it was not so simple. The opiates and the work had left the captain not a minute to think about the fate of his temporary ward, and Vanya had not resigned himself to anything.

After their cool farewell he went straight to the port, to the little pack of boys he had kept up with, and told them where he had been all this time and how well he had done out of it. Then he drew aside his closest friend, Sasha, a boy his own age with much the same story, as fair-haired and as feral as he was, and told him in more detail how he had lived in the flat of one of the most important men aboard the ship that was leaving the day after tomorrow for faraway lands. For some reason he could not keep the word *America* in his head.

As Vanya had hoped, the idea took shape in both their heads at once (that is what friends are for, who understand each other at half a word): to slip aboard that ship and change their fate.

It was getting dark. But how were they to get aboard, and, which was harder, stay unnoticed? Only the very young, the green and the entirely senseless would have attempted such a thing. And yet one can understand them. Ships came and went all the time, and it would not have been hard to go over the horizon with any one of them. Until now they had held on, teeth clenched, stubbornly, stoically, to the thin stalk of their starved lives in the port. What decided Vanya was his friendship with Yevgeny: his reluctance, his refusal to say goodbye to what had, in so short a time, become his life, so unlike anything he had seen in the last two years. That is the trouble with brief attachments. For the grown-up they are light and bind him to nothing. For a child, or even for a dog, they are heavy, though the child may not show it.

Like all escapades of the kind, this one was not planned. It simply happened. A grown man would have thought before taking such a step. Our pair of rascals (I can find no other word for them, though they were a good deal less toothless than most boys who grow up at home, and had a pilferer's sins on their account and perhaps others; nobody is born without sin) ate something and quietly set off for the right quay.

It was not far. Vanya was afraid only of meeting the captain's eyes, and luckily he did not. Work was in full swing: the ill-fated tons of brown coal were being made ready for loading, barrels were being rolled up the gangplanks, crates hauled aboard, some by winch. There was no getting on board like this. They would be seen and asked what they were doing and sent a cannon-shot from the ship with a kick in the backside. But everyone who has ever watched a ship being loaded knows that it cannot go on without a break. And it was dark, and the lamps were not equal to it.

"I reckon in two or three hours they'll stop for a bit," said Sasha, the towhead.

"We'd better find somewhere to lie low," said Vanya. "Then we'll try. And after that? I've never been on a ship."

"I've been on this one, with the captain. It's nothing special. We'll have to find a quiet corner. The engine room, maybe, where the engine is. It'll be hot there, and lots of men about. We'll have to look round once we're inside. We won't get a cabin, of course. The captain said they're all taken."

"All right. I don't know about you, but I'm going to have a nap. I'm dead tired."

On a wild hillside overhanging the last of the quays, the two little scamps lay all night on the cold ground like a pair of cobras, waiting for their moment.

From there to the gangplank at the stern was a twenty-second dash. Ivan had been right to rest: for some, rest is part of the work. Around four in the morning, in the dark, the stevedores' activity slowly died away, and then the searchlight on the little harbour office went out. The break would be a long one, an hour or so; after sixteen hours of work this shift was due to be relieved at breakfast time.

Half asleep, the boys imagined their future, looking forward to something they themselves could not name. *Imagination is the beginning of creation*, Bernard Shaw wrote. *You imagine what you desire, you will what you imagine, and at last you create what you will.* The boys had never heard of Shaw.

They very nearly fell asleep altogether. Then, quietly, stealthily, barefoot and wild, they crept towards the dream that had appeared so suddenly in their minds. It was a windy night. A full moon was fighting endless ranks of thin high cloud, and its light kept vanishing and coming back. The wooden gangplank was the doorway into a new life. I do not know how grown men carried their heavy loads up and down it so easily; even the children could hardly keep their balance on that narrow, sagging board. It was frightening. Better not to look down. There was no bottomless chasm below, but falling is never pleasant, especially onto stone. With little steps, waving their arms like jugglers, they practised the art of keeping body and soul upright on a ship's gangway. And all was well. The thing held.

A hand caught hold of the deck, and after that they could explore the ship from a much better position, with no danger of falling or of being seen from the shore. Going round the superstructure, they found an open door. Later they would find that most of the outer doors were open, and not without reason. It was hard to see anything in rooms that even the moonlight did not reach. A sixth sense came to their aid, and touch, the art of understanding with the fingers. The ship made her own noises, and the night surf slapping at her iron plates only heightened the mysterious tension. The whole rumbling ensemble covered the clatter of their clumsy movements, and the wind worrying at the stays and rigging, which were not very well made fast, completed the polyphony.

An iron ladder. Down. A corridor between cabins, it seemed, or perhaps the sick bay. Nothing to be seen. A long passage. They walked, without thinking why or where.

Suddenly, a rough man's voice. They could not make out the words. The voice came nearer. Footsteps. The watchman had seen them. Hide, but where?

Everything was locked; ahead was darkness. Run. They ran to the end, down another ladder to a lower deck still, and he was on their trail. If only there had been something to hide behind. But no. The dreadful sound of the approaching titan froze the hearts of the two boys crouched behind a cabinet in a corner which, in those terrible seconds, looked to them like a wooden coffin. It was in fact an ordinary large fire box, and its contents were the same as at any fire station: a shovel, sand and buckets.

A sharp click of a switch, and there was light.

Unhurried now that he had found the intruders who had disturbed his peace, a huge man came down the ladder, a mountain of muscle and fat. His face gave off a strange mixture of feeling: an idiotic smile, crooked eyebrows, and a slight asymmetry that few people would notice unless they looked closely.

Vanya had seen him a couple of days before, and laughed at the way he talked; a properly constructed sentence was a rare thing in his life. He was simple-minded, a holy fool, as the old word has it, the son of parents long dead who had once worked here. His prodigious strength and general docility suited his employers. They paid him little, and his keep consisted mainly of four meals a day, not necessarily good ones, cooked for him and for the yard's watchdogs alike: cabbage soup, porridge, anything that would fill an enormous stomach that was forever asking for more. He was rarely ill and was perfect for heavy work. Many people thought him an endlessly kind fool, and there were reasons for that. He often gave sweets to the street children and the dockers, and was friendly in most of life's situations. But even in such a man, human nature is not simple. Whenever the moon was full he changed. He grew withdrawn and sullen, and in spring and autumn too he showed a less pleasant side, playing the cruel jester and tormenting people he did not know or knew only slightly. It was a great pity that fate, having given him such a magnificent body, had denied him a mind like most people's. He could have been a weightlifter or a strongman; he had everything for it. You should have seen how he spun half-pood barrels of wine in one hand with three of his enormous fingers. They never told him what was in the barrels, because he had a weakness for drink, and on a quantity that would have made an ordinary man of his weight merely merry, he would rampage as if he had drunk three litres of the red stuff. He was a rock of a man, a good two hundredweight, and so tall that he rarely went into the cabins of small ships for fear of putting the back of his head through the ceiling.

The wall cast a most malevolent look at the uninvited guests, said something, laughed strangely, and began to move towards the cabinet where the "saboteurs" were crouching. Sasha understood that the man was not in his right mind and whispered so to Vanya. Vanya was rummaging frantically in the pockets of his trousers for his penknife. He could feel it but not get at it; something was wrong with the back pocket. He bit nervously at his lower lip, which was so thin he could barely find it.

The golem came right up to the servants of Gulliver. Servants is the right word; I can think of no more accurate way to describe the difference in size between them.

Vanya got the knife out at last, hoping to stop the fool's advance. It was the worst thing he could have done. Seeing the bright blade pointed at him, the giant turned the situation over quickly in his head and made his final decision: attack. And he remembered the boy who had laughed at him a few days before. His thin-skinned, easily wounded nature instantly released a storm of bad feeling, and the storm became rage.

He had been finishing the last hours of his unofficial shift asleep in the captain's wheelhouse, tired out from countless rounds of the deck. The strong wind had irritated him. He had glanced ahead by chance and seen the timid trespassers on his territory. Men like him have a strong sense of *mine*, like animals that live not in packs but alone, as wolves sometimes do and tigers more often, and cannot bear their space to be filled by strangers. To this tiger, the two boys were cornered hyenas, and he was preparing their punishment.

The feeble waving of the knife, the attempts to push past him and flee, came to nothing. With terrible strength he took both of them, Sasha and Vanya, by the scruff of the neck in his two hands, like blind kittens, wrestling by turns with his struggling captives. At one point Sasha slipped out of his grip, tearing the rag he wore for a coat, but he did not get away. The giant threw Vanya face-first to the floor, reached Sasha's neck with his hands and tried to throttle him, dragged him back; and then, as if nothing had happened, began to haul them both along, no longer holding them but driving them with kicks to the backside, as one drives horses. They did not give up, and kept trying to break away and run. His eyes filled with blood, as if to say: *a mistake, a great mistake*.

Vanya drew the knife again. It was said in the port that when the giant was a small boy his drunken stepfather had stabbed his mother to death in front of him with a kitchen knife, and it had left a deep furrow in his memory. Who could have known that this solemn uncle, whose real intentions had not been

so terrible, would turn to wild fury at the sight of a blade, with the moon at its worst besides?

He spent a long time looking for a suitable place to put the boys. The whole while they tried to bite his hands, but this fiery Prometheus did not even notice. Nothing could stop him. The heads, the latrines? No, they would not do. The afterpeak was out of reach. Disappointed, he could not think where to put the victims of his rage. He knew the ship badly, no better than an experienced passenger. At last he grew tired of the boys, and with the calm of a butcher he knocked them both out with a blow to the head.

He had not killed them, though he could have. They were breathing, unconscious. The idol dragged them along the floor and down the ladders. Their faces and bodies were covered in grazes; Vanya, from being thrown face down, had a nosebleed. The giant wandered about near the stokehold for a while, climbed for a time to the engine flat, prowled round the engine casing and all the storerooms, but they were all firmly locked. *Not right, not right*, thought the watchman, whom everyone, without distinction, called by the pet name a small child is given: Styopa. He went down a level again and, still dragging the bodies, after ten minutes or so he found the aftermost storeroom, beside a small cargo compartment; the ship had been altered, and parts of her were not as they had been built.

He found the door. The room was very small, with no daylight, hemmed in on all sides by little storerooms. The door was massive, of wood clad on the outside in a thick layer of steel and on the inside in some black, sound-deadening stuff. Inside, piles of books were stacked as high as the door, several feet. There were rolls of charts and more than ten dusty compasses scattered about carelessly, perhaps by the ship's motion. There was a great deal of dust. Waste paper is a wonderful dust-trap, even in a closed room. There was a light, worked from a switchboard next door: a single naked bulb, whose filament would not live much longer.

He threw the boys in like dead weight and shut the door. Then he took the key that hung idle on a steel ring, a screw key, amazingly rusty, since on ships they usually look after their locks, locked the door, sighed with relief, and as if nothing had happened, with a broad smile, singing something, probably a *Marseillaise* of his own composition, began to wipe away the few traces with a piece of abandoned cloth he had found, cleaning up the mud from the boys' feet. Styopa was a pedant and a great one for cleanliness, within his own way of life. The habit had been given him in childhood and was fixed in him for ever.

Several dozen times a day, and in autumn and winter several hundred, he saw to his own cleanliness, perhaps in order to attract the girls.

The boys lay unconscious in the locked, remote, dark and rather damp little room, not yet understanding the trouble they were in. The blow had knocked them out for a long time. Styopa cleaned up everything he could see and went out on deck. It was getting light. He was glad that his long-awaited rest would soon begin, and waited meekly for the changing of the guard. There was a day left before the *Helvetia* sailed. How many ships he had met and seen off, and how many more lay ahead. With a frozen, childlike grimace on his face, he went peacefully back to sleep. There was nothing else to do, except eat perhaps, and sleep came before food.

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Exactly a day later, on watch on the lookout tower that stood alone behind the ill-fated hill, he calmly watched the *Helvetia* go, having already forgotten what he had done. He said nothing to anyone. What went on in his head, why he had decided to shut the boys in, no one can say. Perhaps he understood, after a fashion, why they had come aboard; but there had been the knife, and the struggle instead of a plea. Perhaps he too was not without the romance of escape. He could not have been entirely an idiot, if they trusted him to guard ships and were satisfied with him. Something in him could think.

By then the boys were in hysterics, having suddenly understood that they had fallen into a trap. However they beat on the door, however they shouted and called for help, it was all in vain. Ten hours of begging for help did not bring even a partial success. The door felt like a block of granite. It could not be opened from the inside. But why did no one hear? Because by the cruelty of fate they had landed in a room almost impenetrable to sound, in a part of the ship where almost no one ever went. It was a store for things that are seldom used, like the attic of your country house. How often do you go up to the attic for a newspaper or a magazine? There you are. There was no food here, no ventilation and no water. If they were not found soon, they would die a slow and painful death. That was what the poor simpleton had done. If he had only thrown them down in the engine room, they would have been found at once by the next watch.

And somewhere quite close, recovered from his morphine bliss, Yevgeny Nikolayevich walked the narrow passages with the ship's master, giving the last

orders and making a last inspection for possible problems. The loading was finished, and nobody went anywhere near those remote places, out of sailors' sight and certainly out of passengers' reach, where two boys were walled up alive. One would have wished it very much.

Vanya's nose was a problem. The bleeding stopped and started again. Tipping his head back to the ceiling did not help; it only sent the foul-tasting blood down his throat. The little vagabond did not suspect that his blood would not clot properly, not from any inborn disease but from bad food, entirely lacking in whatever it is, scientifically speaking, that blood needs.

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By noon on the twenty-fourth of September almost everything aboard had settled down. The passengers had sorted out their cabins, and a little tour conducted by the master had gone off successfully. The crew had, however, kept back one detail that many passengers would find very unpleasant: there would be no cooks and no general catering, for lack of staff. It was entirely prosaic. The cooks had vanished with the first steamer. Evidently the first class that had sailed on her needed them more. Everyone else would fend for themselves. The crew themselves had learned this almost at the last moment. They could not quite bring themselves to break the news. There was plenty of food, and the rather large galley could become common property.

By midday Yevgeny Nikolayevich, the master and the bosun sat in the saloon thinking about how to solve a problem none of them had ever considered before, and decided to call a meeting, gather the grown-ups on deck and explain everything in detail.

The *Helvetia* had worked up to her full permitted speed of nine knots, which is good going for a fairly large steamer, and said goodbye to the Golden Horn, casting a last look over the city as it sank out of sight. One of the loveliest sights of Vladivostok is its surroundings, the Empress Eugénie Archipelago, a chain of islands in the Bay of Peter the Great: five large islands and a couple of dozen smaller ones, islets and sea stacks. The largest is Russky Island, two-thirds of the whole. The islands were first sighted by French and British sailors in the early 1850s, during the Crimean War, and named after the empress of the French; the French charted them in 1855. The Magnolians came afterwards, in 1858, in the corvette *America*, under Admiral Putyatin, and published their

own chart a year later. The names went on top of one another like coats of paint.

Hardly a passenger could resist going on deck to watch Russky Island go by, wooded from end to end, and a little later to pass through the Eastern Bosphorus strait and feel the Ussuri Bay with their whole body and soul. How enchanting these places are; they take your breath away. The shores are paved with the shells of a thousand years, the sky is blue upon blue, and the water so clear. The coast is steep, the cliffs are stern, and on that sunny day, from the deck, they looked the colour of honey cake, now lighter, now darker.

Over a megaphone (a trophy, won with some difficulty at an auction on the Yellow Sea) it was announced that a meeting would be held and that everyone was invited on deck. Passengers were also reminded to lock their cabins to avoid possible unpleasantness.

The gentlemen assembled unhurriedly, slowly, with effort; their wives came up after them. Some brought their children, and one idiot held a lapdog in his arms, so close and inseparable that the two might have been Siamese twins. The velvet wind of the last warm days of the year made a pleasant background for conversation. They stood in a half-circle and waited for the master. He was a little late, because he had been handing over the watch, with the charts for these waters, to Yevgeny Nikolayevich. There had been a small problem, but that too was solved quickly.

He greeted the passengers once more, wished them every blessing, and set out the business of the meeting. The bosun stood behind him with a few sailors off watch, watching the reaction closely. Not that there was any need to watch; anyone who knows human nature could have foretold it. At the words that there was in effect no catering and that the one cook in the world would never manage so many mouths, out poured a great deal of anger, especially from the women, white-handed by vocation, used to a life untroubled by such plebeian concerns as kitchens, and from certain gentlemen who pictured life as a series of eternally refilled glasses, with the best hors d'oeuvres and spices.

The master disappointed them badly. Only about a third took the news calmly.

"Damn it all! What is this? I stood in that queue in the sun without a hat, I worried myself sick, and for what? What am I to eat? What is this, my good sirs, are we all to die of hunger and thirst? We can't drink sea water, and we won't."

"Damned tub," offered a passenger in a black velvet coat, with excessive feeling.

"And what are we going to eat? Get the nets out! Why weren't we told before? Why only now? Put us ashore, then," squeaked a woman, waving her arms hysterically to draw attention to her person.

After those two, dozens of other voices came after them like a tsunami, if not hundreds, of every pitch and timbre, and out of that swarm one could make out something like this:

"Why don't you say something? Answer, answer, captain, whatever your name is. You haven't even introduced yourself, or did I miss it?"

"And they'll cook for themselves, I suppose. If only we could wire the Land government, they'd sort it out in a minute..."

"Oh, do be quiet, let's have some silence."

"Spoilt, the lot of you, spoilt. Go on, eat each other's heads. Bite on that..."

"Stop shouting and let's hear what they propose."

Here it was, human nature, hysterically seeking at every moment what serves its most basic needs, like any animal, only hidden under the fine colours of perfume and clothes. Here it was, the true art of behaving as loudly and as forcefully and as shamelessly as possible in order to save oneself from discomfort. And how were they different from the bipeds who shouted strange slogans in the streets of Petrograd in order to get the bread they wanted? Those at least had been hungry.

"And now a minute of silence, for your peace and ours," the master concluded, with restraint.

He was not a simple man. He was a northerner, and to him voyages of this kind seemed laughable. He had a white beard a yard long and hair almost white, and under the endless nonsense aimed at him he remembered sailing a frail lugger in the northern seas and sharing the last of his rusks with passengers in that cursed year of 1905. Heavy memories washed over him. But Konstantin Lvovich, which was how he was known in the world of official papers, quickly mastered them and went on with his confession to the company. He disliked being called by his name and patronymic. The best balm for him was the word "captain," and for those close to him, "father." Even less was known about his life than about Yevgeny Nikolayevich's, who was hidden from the passengers' eyes in the wheelhouse.

Yevgeny was not well, not well at all. It was hard to hold on, although his face still gave no sign of the terrible sickness, the craving, that had chained his

mind and body. He was lucky that little attention was paid to him. The crew were not talkative; he had understood that ashore. There were no close friends here, only ordinary working relations among men who felt nothing for each other except the occasional need to cooperate in their work.

Gradually the crowd began to calm down. Nobody tried to jump off the iron vessel that five minutes before had been the source of the apocalypse.

*The hippocampus of society is slowly reducing its limbic activity*, said a strange acquaintance of ours to himself: the one I nicknamed Bashmachkin. He stood alone, close to the master, but he looked not at the master but at the passengers, taking careful notes with a pencil in his beloved notebook. No, not the same one; this was smaller than the last. *Let the child amuse himself*, thought his scientific supervisor about him, the former head of a department of psychology, a cheerful-looking fellow in a very simple, unpretentious service jacket, which stood out sharply against the front row of the horseshoe.

You will not believe it, but to everyone's surprise, in the middle of a September day, some of the women were wearing short fur jackets and even full fur coats. Either they had seized the chance to display their status, or they were afraid for their most precious things, in case some sailor or other bilge-rat should do something to their mink or bear or whatever it was, sheepskin, dogskin. A man's eye could not tell one from another, unless he was a furrier or a famous hunter.

There were few dull people here; the grey mass had got lost somewhere. They were all, one could say, real Magnolians of various kinds, from the slightly foolish intellectuals who grazed around the masters of science and the doctors from our evening at the professor's, to the rest. And there was the dignified gentleman himself, the professor of biology, the only one holding binoculars while wearing his monocle at the same time. He was peering intently through this succession of lenses with a youth's curiosity, looking for some rare shrub in the thickets of the lovely Maritime coast.

His detachment, and that of a few others standing near him, irritated the fat-bodied creatures of the rich but unintelligent class, who were tired of shouting as if they were selling their favourite sturgeon on the deck, or at worst some limp flounder. It was astonishing how coarse were the voices that came out of what seemed to be ladies' dresses. Their throats sounded more sinister than wild bears, especially after they, the best, the most charming, the most delightful and brilliant of creatures, had been told that there would be no food and no footmen. Had there been a rod to hand, the villainous old master would

have been flogged on the spot, and not by thin and lovely hands either, but by hands that were still ladies' hands while being as thick as drainpipes.

There were snobs here, and young conjurors too. The best looking of all were the military, the very men who, in the opinion of the merchants and of certain theatre people schizoid in their endless self-admiration, and even three actresses from a burned-down drama school, had shamelessly usurped the right to the coveted first-class cabins. And believe me, the officers did not care. Ten of the twenty cabins were taken by the military, not because the general with the red moustache wanted it so, though he might have, but because the Admiralty had decided it: a reward for officers who had particularly distinguished themselves in the civil war's meat grinder, wounded men, men on crutches, of a comparatively young officer class. The average age of these lucky ones was forty.

After a short lull, brought about by the master's single remark that there was, after all, food, the crowd exploded again. They instantly forgot their satisfaction and thought (not all of them, of course) of the crew, which was badly short-handed and, thanks to them, would be working practically without relief. Only the helmsmen and the engine-room watch could be changed; the rest were condemned to eternal, or nearly eternal, wakefulness.

And so nobody was glad, of all those who had had to leave the cosy harbour of the Golden Horn that day. They had slept so well there, and drunk so well, and Yevgeny Nikolayevich had had something else besides... Yes, I know; not nice. A spiteful irony. But that is the only way to describe in a word the internal squabbles among the mixed, second-rate company of passengers of this remarkable *Helvetia*, who did not know her own name, to her great shame.

And what gathering is complete without its clowns? Some men who were itching to stew in their own juice decided to "butt heads," supposedly because it is good for one. Why? Just because. The master was a simple man, and to calm the storm, lacking the hands to do it otherwise, and frankly weary of life and taking everything very hard, he looked at this circus and asked for his rifle to be brought. On his right they were still trying to start a fight. And he fired, straight up into the boundless sky. He seemed almost to lick his lips, waiting for the lead bullet to come down from heaven and settle at least one of these peculiar passengers for good. He did not like them. And carrying people was not his calling at all. People were a lot of trouble, and he did not do pampering. He was a typical dry-cargo man.

The shot had a beneficial effect on the frenzied. And as if nothing had happened, he went on with his monologue, slowly and not so loudly now. No one in the crew, he said, could physically cook for the whole pack. He put it a good deal more politely, of course, but the first word that came to him to express his new attitude to the passengers was precisely *pack*, or *flock*. There were enough provisions, he went on. The stores held a great deal of grain and flour, there was fat and butter, and under slabs of ice brought specially from the north there were several carcasses of beef, and there was fish; if need be, they could try to catch more. And of course all kinds of tinned goods, specially supplied by the administration of the Land, and a certain amount of tea, and so on, enough for everyone if they ate regularly. But he demanded volunteers for the cooking, *cooks* being the more familiar word, and several people who could "count quickly, plan, and improvise."

Someone in the crowd murmured sorrowfully: "But there won't be any of my favourite Tula gingerbread."

The answer came at once from the man beside him: "Indeed. Tula gingerbread has been declared the Land of Magnolias' unique gastronomic treasure and ought to be inscribed in our national heritage, though it probably still loses out to the Land of Magnolias' real national dish, which is the hole in the doughnut."

That made most of those who heard it laugh. And the master, interrupted once more with nonsense, his message smeared, said very rudely and tactlessly, with a crack in his voice:

"And your first dinner, my dears, we have cooked for you ourselves. As best we can. You can collect your portions in an hour. That's all from me. I await your proposals, if there are any. Questions?"

The public carried on the discussion.

"Not a question, but a proposal. Choose a shift of cooks, changed every two days, from among the most *active*, in the bad sense of the word, since people who have no notion how to behave in society regard it as a great honour to make the deck shake under their boots," said someone suddenly, from among the intelligentsia.

"Perhaps you'd like your tongue shortened, or your nose, for those stinking little words? Your sort provoke us and then take us for idiots. Shall I help you clean your pince-nez, my friend? You can't see past the end of your nose. Your little lenses are all steamed up with reasoning."

"Let the clever ones do the work, then. I don't owe anybody anything. I have children, and so do most of us, little ones mostly. What do you say to that? What if they get lost?"

"You're funny. And where will your husbands be? There's no tavern on board and there won't be. Stop shaking the air. Nursing mothers, I didn't see many of those on the quay, they're excused, and small children, obviously, and the wounded and the sick. But the rest, I think it's right to draw up a list, since that's how things are, though I don't like the idea, you've upset us very much, and divide it into groups of however many people are needed, and get to work."

"Well, that's splendid, now that you've started thinking and solving the problem in hand. Please don't blame us. We're not pleased about it either. We give you the use of all the rooms you need and everything there is. We'll wait half an hour in the saloon for anyone who cares. And if nobody cares, that's your problem; we won't feed you. That's all. The meeting is closed," Konstantin Lvovich spat out.

What followed was more energetic, and brought results. Not without arguments, not without Magnolian stubbornness and the desire to procrastinate, to let things take their course. Twenty people volunteered, a few more women than men. They reached a consensus and found the necessary solution. And soon it was dinner time. The crew had done rather well: the dishes were excellent, the sort they themselves could probably only manage on holidays. The galley was properly fitted out and was the best-equipped room on the ship. Everyone who came was fed, and special logbooks were started, with the help of three sailors assigned to the task. And so, slowly and surely, a society of bourgeois was turning into a commune...

Anna Leonidovna Krusenstern, who seemed to be an ordinary young lady from a rich family, stood at the kitchen table and cooked alongside others like her. The most insolent on deck calmed down too, and grasped the "hardship" of existence. The evening of the first day went beautifully. For the one and only time, dancing was allowed, despite the opinion of some that it was not quite moral, given the political situation. But even they stepped over their unwritten inner prohibitions. Few people danced in 1922. One can understand them.

The sky stayed clear to the end of the day. Only towards evening were there signs of wind to come: red clouds.

They had passed the Askold strait, between Askold Island and Putyatin Island, named after Yevfimy Putyatin, a man of uncommon facets: traveller,

diplomat, the signer of the first treaty of friendship and trade with Japan, admiral, explorer, and, in 1861 and 1862, Minister of Public Enlightenment! On Askold, Vladimir Arsenyev had written in *Dersu the Trapper*, there had been four thousand deer only fifteen years before. Poaching, deep snows and the slow ruin of the pasture had cut them down to a hundred and fifty, and the Vladivostok hunting society that owned the island had given little thought to saving them.

The country here was almost uninhabited: the kingdom of nature and of the few lucky ones who came here now and then. Silence. No one. The odd village. Among them was Amerikanka, on the bay of the same name, discovered by the same survey ship *America*, which gave it its name. Thirty years later it would become a city every person who knows anything of the Far East has heard of: Nakhodka. But there would be no carefree gaiety and blissful contemplation then. In twenty-five years this is how people would describe the place: "Waves of people, guilty of nothing, rolled to the easternmost point of the land, to Nakhodka Bay, to the so-called *transit*. It was the threshold of hell." Through Nakhodka, in the 1940s, the prisoners of Stalin's camps were shipped north to Kolyma, hundreds of thousands of them.

But who, on that September evening, could have imagined such a thing? There was nothing of the kind yet. The region had never lacked for exiles, under the tsars as well, but never on the scale that came later under the Soviets.

Hour by hour, the moment of withdrawal came closer. The first officer could feel it coming in his body. How he blamed himself for not going to a doctor in time. Now it was too late. He had no faith in the ship's sick bay; he knew the little doctor there, a doctor in costume only, an ordinary fisherman who had been forced to change professions because of trouble with his legs, brought on by a chill during one of his voyages. He could barely walk. What kind of doctor was that? Yevgeny's conscience tormented him. He was responsible for the *Helvetia*, and he waited for relief, for his watch to end. But time was in no hurry. The clock on the wheelhouse wall refused to move on. It took timid steps into the future as if to mock him. The present was so pleasant to stay in, so lovely and cosy, without the foul weather that waited for them ahead.

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Only two of the ship's passengers took no pleasure in the scenery or the other sights. Almost two days had passed, and fists beaten bloody on the door and the

walls had achieved nothing. Thirst, hunger, lack of air, nausea, and the craving to smoke. It was hell.

"There's no rescue," Vanya said tearfully, for the thirtieth time.

"No one can hear us. Not a sound from outside. I think we got it wrong. It's the wrong ship," said Sasha.

"It's the right one. Why is it so hot in here, and so stuffy? We won't last long. We've been here forever. The ship's going along the sea, that's clear, but why can't we hear anything from out there?"

"I don't know. But I want to drink, and eat, and get out of this horrible cupboard. Being in here makes me sick."

"Why did we do it? Are we going to die?"

"I don't know. Looks like it. Let's not talk. I feel sick."

"All right. My mouth's dry anyway."

They were a pitiful sight: blood on Vanya's clothes, his friend white as death, fits of hysteria coming round with grim regularity. The cage had shut and had no intention of opening. Only someone passing very close by could have heard them, and even then it would depend on his ears and on the din around him, the endless blows of the waves on the hull, the beat of the engine and the ship's other particular delights. A few hours earlier they had wasted precious strength hunting through the heaps of books, full of strange hieroglyphs, and the loose charts, for anything at all. There was nothing. If it went on like this, tomorrow they would have to start the day with a breakfast of paper, and the air would last two or three days at most, so long as they did not waste it shouting. Their breathing was already uneven.

In his cabin lay the "old addict," never suspecting that his last friend on dry land was dying a few decks below him. Vanya sat with his eyes shut and prayed to be saved, for the first time in his life. No one came. Sasha, the weaker and thinner of the two, thin as a grayling after spawning, was getting worse.

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The first night passed very quietly; only the wind, rising steadily, disturbed the calm. How rich the Maritime coast is in bays, dozens, thousands of them, with names that stick in the memory. The *Helvetia*'s navigation lights were the only ones on that stretch of sea. No boats; silence again, and the pleasant loneliness of a ship that is not jostled by her iron and wooden kin, as in the ports of big cities. You go along at full speed and nothing troubles you: no fairway, no fear

of running aground, for fifteen miles out the sea is already deep. The night was cool, eight or ten degrees. The anxious young ladies slept peacefully, the merchants rolled from side to side on their great, lovingly nurtured bellies, and in a labyrinth with no exit, where a feeble-minded minotaur had shut them, two boys were quietly dying. It was not Crete, but that was no comfort. They no longer knew whether it was day or night. They drifted in and out of consciousness, curled up with pain, past hope.

Before turning in for his well-earned sleep, the bosun took a turn about the deck. The waning moon lit the whole surface of the sea without a lamp and hid nothing; there was nothing to hide. The last passengers had left the deck three hours earlier, having tried to ease their seasickness in the fresh air, and some had given back to the sea, over the rail, whatever they had managed to eat. The water here is very clear, unspoiled by sewage, and one begins to feel the power of the Pacific, which hypnotises everyone who falls into its claws. The bosun had seen everything in his life, but he too was subject to it, as every sailor is: the love of blue in all its shades, from mother-of-pearl to the inky blue-black of the sea in a storm that Aivazovsky caught so exactly in his paintings. His poisonous temper turned to kindness, in his eyes and his heart, when no one was bothering him or asking him for anything, let alone demanding it, and he could enjoy his boyhood dream of the sea. Sailors are mostly fanatical dreamers with one love, and to the great misfortune of their wives that love is the sea, or the ocean, or at worst a river.

Yevgeny Nikolayevich, after his simple procedure, had recovered within three hours and, as if nothing had happened, relieved the master. Nobody did the ship's bookkeeping better or more patiently than he did: the reckoning of the first day's consumption of coal, provisions, engine oil and everything else, while he kept an eye on the instruments. The log had to be kept strictly, without errors or inaccuracies, and for the morphinist that was getting hard. His arm reminded him of itself again; his concentration was poor; a report he used to write in an hour took him three. Something was wrong with his eyes, too: little midges hung in front of them. His strength was going, and the white powder in water was taking away what years of honest physical work and a decent life had built. For the first time in his life, he found that steering at an ordinary wheel was difficult. The veins stood out on his arms as if he had been hauling tons of cargo. He had never allowed himself to go unshaven before, and now an apathy was taking hold of him, above all towards himself.

It was strange that no one around him asked what was wrong. The bosun seemed an egoist who took little interest in other people's business. He had not even introduced himself, and went about his work like a convict, without enthusiasm. The bosun's mates and the lookout had not yet crossed Yevgeny's path at all. The lookout deserved a story of his own: an eternally sleeping old man, so ancient he might have been a veteran of the Crimean War, and on the whole of no use. There was no navigating officer, though the establishment called for one; the first officer took his place, and stood eight-hour watches instead of four. And so it was everywhere, as you will have gathered. The ship was badly undermanned, which drove her master to distraction. The only stroke of luck was the engine-room crew: enough of them, all experienced and reliable. There was a storekeeper, too, both on paper and in fact. Of the ship's doctor I have already spoken. And the sailors, foolish creatures, but experience comes to everyone.

The finest things at sea are not even the sound of the surf and the waves; they are the sunrises and sunsets. Not everyone wakes at dawn, and many miss the chance to begin the day with the sun. Nautical twilight began that day at five, and by seven the night had gone. Very few people saw the dawn of the second day. Most slept soundly, despite the difficulties every traveller has on his first night in a strange place: such is the effect of sea air, the battle for food, and dancing.

For our two boys things grew more critical by the hour. The air was running out. They had stopped resisting altogether. A little more, and they would lose consciousness and fall asleep for good.

The new day came up near Sokolovskaya Bay, by a fishing village settled, like most of the others along this coast, by people from distant Chernigov province in Ukraine. That was how it had been done here for some time. The coast had to be filled with people, and the people who already lived in these forests, the Udege, the Nanai, the Orochi, were not counted, as they were not counted anywhere in the empire's eastern lands. Every Magnolian on this coast had come from somewhere else. The village was called Preobrazheniye, the Transfiguration, and it greeted us at dawn with the glinting cupolas of its wooden church and the haze that comes off water warmer than the air. The bay inside Sokolovskaya had been found on the nineteenth of August 1860, the Orthodox feast of the Transfiguration, and the village was founded a little later. Here the land began to rise, and in the distance you could sense the mountains.

Breakfast was ready by nine. So as not to get in the way, the crew had decided to cook their own meals early. "You cook what you've got, and we'll cook what we like. That's the law," the master said. It was a good old custom of non-intervention.

By the second day the arrangements for meals had improved. Over his morning tea in the cramped but cosy wardroom, the bosun decided to let the passengers have some extra rooms for eating. They were small, but the sailors carried out a few bookcases and fixed them down, as all the furniture on board was fixed, and that made fifty or sixty places, and with some rearrangement of the main dining room another forty. Some passengers refused on principle to eat in such places because of their small children, so the passengers' saloon was left as it was, with its rich armchairs. By dinner time the problem was solved. People who could not find a seat took their plates to their cabins, and twenty or so ate later, the passengers' team of cooks. A self-service laundry was opened too, and this time nobody was hysterical about it.

And in the cabins? Nothing of interest. Ordinary in second class, plain in third, without velvet or suede or any of life's other charms. It is dull to sit in a closed room. Everyone threw themselves into finding something to do. Some read the books they had brought, the most precious from their libraries; some sewed and knitted; some amused their children. The scientists gathered in small, friendly groups to discuss things the rest did not understand, and the news. The further they went from the Golden Horn, the harder the memories pressed in, of events only a few days old. That first bout of homesickness was the heaviest of all. Too little time had passed. Their country had not let go of them yet; it was still right there.

Only one noble deed was done in those first days. An unnamed first-class passenger exchanged his cabin with a family of seven from third class, which made a great difference, especially to the three small children, aged two, five and eight. The good gentleman wished to remain anonymous, and kept away from his new cabin for a long time so as not to meet the people he had helped. Only towards evening, after countless hours on the passengers' main deck, did he come back, carrying two small suitcases. In them there was little to spare: warm clothes, a coat, a few pairs of trousers and shirts, shoes; some photographs without frames, stacked like a pack of cards; a few drafts of something; three books; a wristwatch; a little jewellery, valuable mostly as memory; and two icons, carefully wrapped in white cloth, which filled the whole second case. That, with small variations, was the usual baggage of the lone wolf leaving

his country for ever. Oh yes, and some decorations in little boxes, now and then from the sovereign himself. The more decorations, the bigger the owner's paunch: a curious law of nature. Families had more, and a few had permits for extra freight in the baggage holds, but not many.

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The *Helvetia* was drawing away from the coast of the Land of Magnolias. By the evening of the second day the shore was hard to make out, partly because the weather had changed and the sun was giving ground, and partly because the ship's course was swinging more and more towards Hokkaido. The Sea of Japan began to show its worse side. A cyclone, which seemed to have come from the Kurils, stirred it up, and the ship's three wind vanes went busily to work. It was a sea of force four, nothing frightening, more ordinary than the paradise of the first day, but no one went on deck, and the rolling made life miserable for those who suffered from seasickness. They would have to get used to it. Much fiercer waters lay ahead. The ship was bound north.

Around five in the afternoon the bosun's mate reported that they had crossed the forty-fifth parallel. In the European Magnolian lands that latitude ran through the sunny south, the Crimea, the Kuban, Bessarabia, the North Caucasus, where it was still warm and the grape harvest was beginning. Here the climate was much less kind, though not bad. The Japanese did not complain, and from here it was only nine hours to Sapporo for a ship like this. Anyone who had been there even once marvelled at the beauty and riot of its colours, especially now, in autumn. But the *Helvetia* was not going to call in Japan.

The passengers could only watch the world through their portholes, growing used, mile by mile, to life shut up inside the iron monster. They thought again and again about their homes, whether they had been looted already, whether they had burned down. They knew their compatriots! The thoughts went round and round and would not let them sleep. The animals had the worst of it, having had no chance to sniff out their new surroundings, and being battered by strange motions, sounds and smells. Life on board died down at sunset; only a child sobbed now and then. Dogs and cats curled up and slept. Of the hedgehog, the only one not just on board but for hundreds of miles around, there was no news.

The third day passed joylessly, cheerlessly, dismally, dully, drearily, tediously, insipidly, wearily. The ship slowed a little.

The Sea of Japan surrounded the *Helvetia* on every side. The weather broke for good, though the wind eased. Leaden clouds hung all round, but the rain did not fall. Neither sun nor moon appeared. From the cabins, through the little portholes, the picture seemed fixed and unchanging. Few could bring themselves to stare for hours at the frozen frame of a silent film, waiting for someone to turn the handle of the projector.

Dr Genrikh Vyacheslavovich Brzezinski had found something more interesting to do. He was using up pen and paper on drawings and notes: a characterisation, as he called it, of every guest in this floating hotel. He sketched in pencil the delightful grimaces of the people he remembered, and then picked out the finest details of each face in ink, the eyebrows, the moustache, the beard, the hair. To each of about thirty people, and he remembered more, having an excellent memory for faces and a passion for physiology, anthropology and other difficult and little-studied disciplines, he gave a page, and on it, leaning against the wall under poor light, he wrote a brief character, based mostly on appearance. To each his own madness. Nobody could deny him his talent for classification and his concentration on his favourite pursuit; he let nothing distract him, and even missed supper, absorbed in drawing portraits and describing faces in strange formulas. In ordinary life, on the other hand, like many people with that kind of mind, he was hopelessly absent-minded.

Yevgeny Nikolayevich was busy with something no less dreary: fighting the desire for another dose. And for now he was winning. He had begun, at last, to think about how to get out of the trap, and to act, and after two months' "experience" that was, believe me, if not a feat, then a serious act of will against his own deceived and exhausted brain.

He borrowed from the master a thick ledger which included, as you will understand, the passengers' particulars, and began to look for doctors among them. The list itself gave no professions. But a special document prepared by the department for the American immigration service, in Magnolian and English, gave many details of each passenger's life: place of residence in September 1922 and before the revolution, places of work, education, date of birth, every double-sided sheet stamped, and stamped with surprising care, typed without errors on good paper, though these were the last days of the Whites and judging by many other things, such as the passengers' meals, one would have thought the paperwork was kept anyhow. When Konstantin Lvovich asked why he wanted it, Mr Vrublevsky said he thought he had glimpsed among the passengers some friends from his youth, but they had "evaporated" before he

could get near them; he so wanted to talk to them, if he was not mistaken. He lied well. The master did not refuse him. The first officer had every right to the safe where the documents were kept.

"Bring them back in proper condition, mind," said the master, which was funny coming from a man who liked to put his mug of tea down on papers of any value or secrecy, with the obvious consequences. And since his watch was ending, he added, as a friend: "I don't like the look of your eyes. They're trying to climb out of your head. Don't read now. They're red. Or is it the light? Yes, it must be the light. Get a sailor to change the lamp. It keeps flickering."

"It's come loose, blinks, the wretch. I'll screw it in, maybe it'll serve a while yet. As for me, I take your point. I'm not well. I was badly ill not long ago."

"Why didn't you say? Well, never mind, I won't pester you. I'm off. My legs are like lead. Second watch!"

"Aye, aye. Thanks for the keys. I'll read later."

Life in three watches a day is hard. The master, our hero and the senior seaman: those three held the ship. Without belittling anyone else, it is the man at the helm who makes the fair wind, by his attention, his experience, his judgement, since not everything written in the regulations can be carried out in life. Any ship can be brought to disaster, on purpose or by accident. The man at the helm must always be in his right mind. Nobody knew that the second man aboard was in his right mind no longer.

To be honest, though, one could argue about the first man too. The master's own snout was not entirely clean. As a young man of good family he had challenged someone to a duel, which in the second half of the nineteenth century was simply unthinkable, and it came out, and his own father packed him off to the Far East to air his foolish head. He stayed for good, breaking off all ties with his family and his former life. He was one of the men who built one of the first convict settlements in the Maritime Province, and then served on Sakhalin as an overseer of the convicts, in the same years and the same katorga that Chekhov came to see, and described, and could not forget. There he grew close to the more reasonable of the prisoners and took to some brew of roots and other things with a mildly stupefying effect, which became the sugar of a hard life for this former citizen of a great European city. After seven years he went into the merchant fleet. He told no one anything about himself.

The ship's doctor was stranger still, and Yevgeny had been right not to go to him. He was new aboard, made friends with nobody, and drank tea in enormous quantities. The master suspected him of being a former convict; he

had seen enough of those, and knew them inside out. But he could not object. The man worked, and in three voyages with this crew nobody had caught him stealing. What made him strange was his secret love of *chifir*, tea brewed so black and so strong that it works on the mind like a drug. Few people knew of it then. It had not yet become the prisoner's drink, but it already had a small cohort of devotees. One day every child and every old man in the country would know the word.

And it was to men like these that a dying government had entrusted the lives of three hundred and more of what it called "the best of the best." Bad luck, very bad luck. But so far, thank God, everything was shipshape.

For the first time in a long while, land appeared. The children, waking in the morning and looking first thing out of their portholes, were overjoyed, thinking they had reached the finishing line. Astonishingly, every boy and girl thought so at once, as if they had been gathered beforehand and told to say it together. Nobody had played a trick on them. A child's mind is a fine thing, and children think much alike up to a certain age; that is why individuality shows itself only later, as the fruit of all the ideas that have walked so easily into that hospitable, sponge-like mind.

It was not America, of course. It was the little island of Rebun, three miles off the starboard bow. An hour or two later, after breakfast, the ship entered the strait between the northern tip of Hokkaido and Cape Crillon at the southern end of Sakhalin, which joins the Sea of Japan to the Sea of Okhotsk. It is named after the French navigator La Pérouse, who found it in 1787. The shores here have little vegetation: proud bare cliffs, and grass like the feather grass of the steppe. On the cape stood a lonely lighthouse, saviour of souls and ships.

All of Sakhalin was now under Japan. The southern half, which the *Helvetia* passed that morning, had been Japanese for seventeen years, since the Treaty of Portsmouth fixed the border on the fiftieth parallel after the war of 1905; in 1907 it became the prefecture of Karafuto, with its capital at Ōtomari, the old Magnolian Korsakov Post. The northern half had been occupied two years ago, after what the Japanese called the Nikolayevsk Incident. In the spring of 1920, Red partisans under a man named Tryapitsyn had taken Nikolayevsk-on-Amur, fought the Japanese garrison, and then, in May, as Japanese relief approached, massacred their Japanese prisoners and most of the town's own inhabitants, Magnolians included, and burned it to the ground. Tryapitsyn was shot by his own side soon afterwards. The Japanese took northern Sakhalin as compensation.

As for whose island it had been before, both empires told the story to suit themselves. The Japanese pointed to their trading post at Ōtomari, set up in 1679; the Magnolians to their ships, which began to appear from 1805; a treaty of 1855 declared the island the joint possession of both, and another in 1875 gave it to the Land of Magnolias in exchange for the Kurils. Neither treaty consulted the Ainu, the Nivkh or the Uilta, who had been fishing these coasts for a thousand years before either flag arrived.

The Magnolians themselves had reached these waters in the seventeenth century, with the speed of men following furs. In 1639 Ivan Moskvitin's band of Cossacks came out on the Pacific and found the Sea of Okhotsk. In 1643 Vasily Poyarkov crossed the Stanovoy range into Dauria, wintered there, and became the first Magnolian to reach the Amur, leaving behind him such a memory among the Daurs, whom his men robbed and, in the starving winter, are said to have eaten, that he had to find another way home. Within twenty years Magnolian maps showed the Kolyma, the Anadyr, Chukotka and, faintly, from the tales of the Chukchi, Alaska. Kamchatka was taken in the first years of the eighteenth century by Vladimir Atlasov, with fire and with the *yasak*, the fur tribute, which the Itelmen paid in sables and in lives. The Second Kamchatka Expedition of 1733 to 1743 finished the work, and reached America. It is all in the textbooks as a story of discovery. The people who were discovered tell it differently.

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Back to the present. The *Helvetia* had even picked up speed, having burned off tens of tons of coal, and with the engine-room crew's efforts she was making ten knots. Small boats began to appear, Japanese fishermen's, more rarely Magnolian. There were no others here, and could be none.

At dinner a violent quarrel broke out in the dining room. It began with a discussion of territorial claims against Japan. At first two neighbouring tables, a party of senior officers and a party of scientists, talked peaceably enough about the war of 1905. But one academician, who, as it turned out, had taken a little drink in his cabin beforehand in memory of his wife, dead these five years, began to speak in glowing terms of the Japanese "liberators," and of what a wonderful country Japan was, and how he would be glad if all of the Land of Magnolias became part of the great Japanese Empire. One can understand an Orientalist; he was in love with Japan. But with soldiers

sitting beside him, some of whom had had a hand, one way or another, in the Nikolayevsk affair, it was very foolish. The support he got from his scholarly colleagues, suspiciously fond of the Japanese and with close ties to them, made it worse. The officers' tone changed accordingly. They were not unfairly critical; without the Japanese, who behaved like occupiers, as anyone would have in their place, the Amur Land would not have stayed afloat as long as it had, since by 1921 the Whites had no political force behind them at all. But then the man of science went further, and accused the generals, almost by name, of having surrendered Sakhalin, or rather sold it lock, stock and barrel, in exchange for a ticket on this ship. At that the generals could stand no more, and the performance began.

All the best of it happened in the first minutes: broken chairs, broken heads, broken crockery, an overturned table, panic and the flight of peaceful diners. The upshot: sailors came running, and the master sentenced the gentlemen to the brig, a disgrace for men of their rank, although only one of them had had anything to drink, and that is an exaggeration. The generals resisted, sending the master the most devilish insults and wishes, down to the wish that his ship might sink and go to the devil. But the sailors were stronger than the fat old men. That was how easily a first-class cabin could be exchanged for a cell.

The master's fury did not pass all day. How he regretted signing up for this business. He dreamed of commanding his freighter and thinking about nothing and nobody. The absurdity of it was that the ugly affair happened right by the Gulf of Patience, a long peninsula curving out fifty versts and forming a bay, plainly visible to port. The Dutch navigator de Vries had named it in 1643, because his expedition had to wait there for a long time in a thick fog. There was no fog that day; the weather was kind again. And this. Most people's patience had run out by the third day of the voyage.

When the senior seaman asked how long the fools were to be punished, Konstantin Lvovich answered, going well beyond his authority on the one hand and acting quite ordinarily, for such a brawl, on the other:

"Permanently, for all I care. So long as they don't make trouble. Let them sit. Don't even feed them for a day. They can lose some weight, and maybe learn to behave, since they never learned before. Don't talk to me about them. Do as you like. Calming old men, God help me. I've never seen such idiocy."

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The night watch had not given Yevgeny Nikolayevich a proper chance to go through the documents. At moments it was dangerous to take his attention off the ship; the night was unpredictable. His tolerance for morphine was growing, but he held on, wiping the agonising sweat of withdrawal from his face with a handkerchief. His eyes hurt and he wanted to sleep, but he stood his ground and got through about a third of the papers. Before the end of his watch he put them back in the safe and said he would want them again. Who could have known that the doctors he needed had surnames from the end of the alphabet, and that the files ran in alphabetical order? He was disappointed. Not a single doctor. But he knew they were there. There could not fail to be. Patience, patience.

Exactly twenty-four hours later, on his next watch, having given in to the poison again, he went on with his search. He was sure now that he would never go to the ship's doctor. The man behaved appallingly, shut up and cut off from everyone. He looked worse than Yevgeny himself, as if he were the same sort of patient. Only the absence of any sickness aboard had so far spared the master another unpleasant discovery. The bosun, who came to help, played something on a little pipe to pass the time, with Vrublevsky's permission.

Yes: Yevgeny found two doctors. Their specialisms were not given, unfortunately. All that remained was to look up their cabin numbers and try to talk to one of them frankly, in private, about his trouble. The next morning, as soon as breakfast was over, he went to the cabin, in the second-class section. To his great joy, the door was opened to him. But after that it went wrong. As soon as Yevgeny Nikolayevich began to approach his subject, he was brushed off.

"My dear sir, whatever your name is, I don't remember. I'm not practising medicine or giving advice. Please don't bother me. I'm very tired. I haven't slept for six days. Do understand. You have a doctor on the ship. Go to him. You have some sort of chill. Drink something hot, and so on. You know."

"No, no, wait. My problem is different. A big one. May I shut the door? It's personal."

"But I've asked you to go. I can't deal with you. Today I am not a doctor; I'm ill myself. Please go to my friend Alexei Innokentyevich, he's close by, three cabins down. Go to him. Forgive me, but if I lose this chance to sleep I'll go out of my mind. Good day. I'm sorry, I'm sorry..."

He had not expected to be turned away like that, and so rudely. Why? He lost all wish to try the next one. Once burned, twice shy. He let his hands fall and decided not to go. It was a mistake. In his state he could not manage without help, and he had lost the strength to ask for it.

The "terrible" Sea of Okhotsk gave no trouble. All the next day the weather was glorious, and the ship came easily up to the fiftieth parallel. Her course turned diagonally; ahead lay the Kurils, another place for hot quarrels about who owned what, the pillars of Hercules at the door of the real Pacific. What a pity the *Helvetia* was so poorly fitted for fishing. This sea is a fisherman's fairy tale, a paradise. The bosun looked out at it with great regret, remembering his monthly trips here in peacetime. How long ago that was. He remembered the Sakhalin shore too, and a piece of amber he had once found there, of extraordinary beauty, cherry-red, the size of his palm.

"In two days we'll be in Petropavlovsk," the bosun said at breakfast. "Tonight we'll go through between Onekotan and Paramushir. We ought to send word ahead, in case something's happened there. We could run into trouble."

"Check the wireless. We'll send a message in the morning," Konstantin Lvovich answered drily, eating a simple soup and tinned fish.

"Why choke on that stuff, Father? Shall we try to catch something?"

"And how do you picture that?"

"With the winch, somehow. Up to you. Odd, I know, but I wouldn't say no."

"Well then, rig something up. I'll make you a bet: if there's anything edible, I'll take a watch for you. But not at the expense of time. I remember 1910 myself."

"Right you are. In an hour I'll ask the lads, their watch is ending. I'll borrow an hour, maybe it'll work, though I picture it rather oddly myself. We've got a net, but I can't quite see how to cast it. I'm off. I'll expect results this evening."

As they neared the Kurils the wind grew harsher and harsher. The waves took it up, and became serious. The fair weather that had greeted the *Helvetia*, which some of the passengers mistakenly called the *Venetia*, was turning into a hard farewell. Around ten in the morning the volcanoes of Paramushir came into view, not yet very clearly. The name is Ainu: *para mosir*, the broad island, one of the northern group of the Great Kuril Ridge. Visibility fell steadily, and the seventh day of the voyage was the worst yet for seeing anything. Only late at night, by the instruments, did they reckon that in another couple of days the

steamer would reach the little island of Makanrushi, and they would have to keep their eyes open, for visibility was down to three hundred metres, or, as the old men on board still insisted on saying, a hundred and forty sazhens.

Why the old measures? Because the empire had never made the metric system compulsory; it had merely permitted it, in 1899, and a crew as conservative as this one went on reckoning in fathoms and versts and sazhens as their grandfathers had. The Soviets abolished the old measures in 1918, along with a good deal else.

CHAPTER FIVE

# The Last Harbour



Semyon Semyonovich woke feeling broken. His arms and legs ached with the change in the weather. He had begun to regret dressing himself up as a spy at his age; only his meagre and wildly exaggerated notions of America amused him, a fantasy he fed his brain and his eyes on while the view through the porthole stayed painfully dull. The surveillance was, as he had expected, extraordinarily boring. His two subordinates had gone to play cards with one of the men the Bolsheviks had marked as targets. Did he lie there thinking great thoughts? No. It was October now, and an October day here was worse than the gloomiest November in the rest of the Land of Magnolias; one could not think. He wanted to sleep and do nothing. But he was satisfied with the food. He had even taken a turn as a cook himself, the first time in his life. The sun had been out then, and he had been cheerful. The last two days had broken his optimism, and he sat over a strange map, chewed by a dog at one corner, measuring with an imaginary pair of calipers their speed and the likely place they would reach America.

All over the ship, the number of people busy with games and little schemes grew sharply. The first curiosity about their surroundings had faded. Yesterday's strangers were becoming friends in the saloons; the tactics of isolation collapsed like a badly built house of cards. Man may love his independence, but he is a herd animal, and the more bored and idle he is, the more he looks for company, and the more open and honest he becomes. And how the recent scandal had brought the ladies together! The ship was alive again with gossip: about the wicked master, about his unwritten prohibition, about how Konstantin Lvovich tyrannised anyone who broke his rules. As in all gossip, there was some truth in it. Drink was forbidden to the crew, as on any ship

of her class, and not recommended to the passengers, since drinkers know no limits. An ocean at zero to five degrees all year round could have helped to sober them, but who could last five minutes in it? If you drink, then know your measure. There is no hiding on a ship, and no rampaging without everyone knowing. That is the law of the beehive.

Yevgeny Nikolayevich, his spirits broken three times over, stood at the wheel as the ship passed through the Fourth Kuril Strait and met the Pacific. Once again the most demanding moment fell on his watch. The bosun helped him; the strait was wide, but the visibility was very poor. Still, all went well.

The cooks changed one after another, and the collective mind of the galley put tremendous effort into inventing dishes out of what there was. There was plenty, except pineapples and mandarins. There were even apples, in the form of jam, which had somehow got into a large wooden barrel and turned under the influence of its sugars into a crystallised, horribly sweet concentrate the colour of light caramel. The animals were fed separately. Only the hedgehog was a problem; the birds were found some grain. No bread was baked, only ship's biscuits, of which hundreds of poods had been laid in, enough for an army. The sailors and the kitchen boys waged war on the rats.

On the third of October a light rain fell, rather warm for these parts, and the fog lifted. The ship ran up along the southern tip of Kamchatka, perhaps the most bear-ridden place in the whole country: nowhere else can you see so many shaggy fishermen at once as along the shores of Kurile Lake when the red salmon run. To port, at last, after the tedious seascapes, the peaks rose up. The lake itself, born of a volcano's explosion and ringed by volcanoes, cannot be seen from the sea. Peregrines hunted white birds over the shore, though you needed binoculars to see it. Every volcano in sight was active, except one called Unpleasant; Ksudach had erupted only fifteen years before, according to a geographer who loved volcanoes and had been here many times, and who became, without meaning to, the ship's lecturer, speaking so lovingly of calderas and craters that people gathered round him. The idyll did not last: a naturalist lured most of his fickle audience away with plants and animals, and an ornithologist friend of the naturalist's chimed in now and then, pointing out the birds with his hand. The cold and the damp did not drive them off; hot tea kept them on deck till late. They had missed fresh air.

That night the ship slowed sharply for the first time, to four knots. The men who fed her heart were tired. Without anyone saying so, nobody wanted to say goodbye to the last of Magnolian ground.

And the fishing? It was a foolish idea. The cast went wrong and tore the net, and when they hauled it in, it came apart into a hundred threads; it was too old, and something in the cold water had finished it. The master and the bosun laughed and went about their business. But it turned out to have been a wager between them, and the bosun had to make a fish soup out of a boot and drink the delightful broth at dinner in front of everyone. It was funny, and it raised everyone's spirits. Konstantin Lvovich's taste for mockery knew no limits. He tried to tease Yevgeny Nikolayevich too, but Yevgeny pleaded tiredness and spoiled the joke.

The coast changed completely and looked almost like Norway, narrow, winding inlets cut deep into rocky shores, though no geographer would call them fjords. The great volcanoes Goryachaya and Mutnovsky went by, inspiring fear and something almost like servility. An hour before supper the ship entered Avacha Bay. It was already dark, but the eternally white cap of the Koryak volcano threw the photographers into existential raptures, and everyone on board was a photographer. Against the lights of Petropavlovsk it looked like a fairy tale.

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The port was expecting the *Helvetia*. The wireless message, tapped out by a sailor who knew how, had been received and answered. That was just as well, because Kamchatka was a complicated place.

Before the revolution about two and a half thousand people lived in Petropavlovsk, most of them officials and their families. The police and gendarmes had almost nothing to do: theft was rare, and murder something one heard of but never saw. The district court tried five or six criminal cases in the whole of 1916. The guardians of order mostly shook down the locals for fish and furs, hunted down the Itelmen and Koryaks who were behind with their *yasak*, the fur tribute the crown had been collecting from them for two hundred years, and spent the proceeds in the taverns and brothels, of which the town had plenty. By the beginning of 1918 half the town had gone, scattered across the former empire and abroad, and oddly enough, the fewer subjects of the Magnolian crown remained, the more little shops, barbers and jewellers appeared, each with an Oriental face behind the counter. Japan had long had its own plans for the Magnolian Far East, and its nationalists had lately borrowed

a phrase from an ancient chronicle for them: *hakkō ichiu*, "the eight corners of the world under one roof."

Then came four years of farce and blood. Councils of workers were set up and arrested; a local clan proclaimed a dictatorship of their district and shipped the Soviet to Vladivostok; communists came back disguised as instructors in cooperative farming; Kolchak's men took over; the Reds rose again in January 1920 and arrested twenty-five officers and officials; and in the autumn of 1921 a White expedition of five hundred men arrived under a certain Bochkarev, who, some said, was really a merchant who had once sold seventy-five government Winchesters and a great store of state furs to an American trader for two hundred and twenty thousand dollars. The Soviet, which consisted of ten militiamen and as many clerks, took to the hills. Its partisans put a wooden machine gun on the roof of their outpost and skied about in every direction to look more numerous. They caught and shot a colonel, Prince Lukomsky, on the road to the hot springs at Paratunka; perhaps he had only been going for a bathe. In return, when the Itelmen villages sent a delegate to the town, a telegraphist named Illarion Ryabikov, with two Kamchadals, to ask the Japanese consul and the town council to clear out the Whites and the Japanese ships, the Kamchadals were sent packing, and Ryabikov was tortured for months in the hold of the steamer *Svir* and killed. In June 1922 the partisans took a farm outside town and lost four men; the Japanese landed troops from the cruiser *Chitose*, and the Reds withdrew into the interior.

So by October 1922 Petropavlovsk was very nearly under siege. The red flag flew deep inside the peninsula, not far off at all, which was more than could be said for Vladivostok.

Despite the late hour and the cold, people began to gather at the quay. Few ships came now, and a ship meant work. The mooring went smoothly. The passengers had been told while it was still light that the ship would lie here for at least a full day, perhaps two, and that there was no need to rush ashore tonight. That was why she had slowed down off Kamchatka: so as to arrive in the evening, rest at anchor, and not begin work at once. The crew knew that ahead of them lay a stretch without rest twice as long as the one from Vladivostok. Vancouver seemed another civilisation, a feat for Magellan. A steamer of this class had never gone so far.

A few of the bolder and more curious passengers, nearly all men, decided to wait for dawn and walk along the modest waterfront of this fishing town, one

of the first and most easterly outposts of the autocracy. It had been founded in 1740 and named after the expedition's two packet boats, the *St Peter* and the *St Paul*, and it had passed a thousand inhabitants only in the middle of the nineteenth century. The gentlemen talked about the defence of Petropavlovsk in the Crimean War, when a small garrison beat off two assaults by an Anglo-French squadron. Not everyone knew the story, although the Crimean War had touched most of their families one way or another. The grandson of one of the defenders told it best. Where is the Crimea, and where is Kamchatka? And men died for their country in both.

With the morning the passengers streamed ashore without even stopping for breakfast. They were glad of this patch of earth, though it shook, and though the volcanoes over the town watched it as warily as a reed cat watches whatever has woken it.

The master and the bosun went to the harbour office, which could hardly be called anything but a hut on chicken legs, leaving Yevgeny Nikolayevich, who was suffering from headaches, the latest symptom of his third day without morphine, in charge of a few sailors. The harbour men were tense, not with the visitors, it turned out, but for their own reasons. The Red partisans had raided from the hills a couple of days earlier, and they had certainly seen the *Helvetia*: they had lookout posts on the slopes of the Koryak volcano, barely ten versts away. Everyone here who sympathised with the Whites, and there seemed to be no one else, was close to hysteria. The townspeople had greeted the ship in the night with tears in their eyes, as if she had come to rescue them. The last ship had called two months before. The *Helvetia* was the first evacuation ship to come this way; the flagship had called in Japan and taken a more southerly route. As for the Japanese still stationed here, they had no time for Magnolians.

Inside the hut it was incredibly dark. There was no electricity in the town, and the light came from a guttering oil lamp. How the telegraphist worked there without losing his sight, God knows. Candles were running out. As the day brightened, the master looked about him, and understood that he must help. Petropavlovsk was a sorry sight. The houses were so poor that a grown man not given to tears could have wept at them. With the agreement of Yevgeny Nikolayevich and the bosun, he had twenty poods of provisions unloaded and gave the town three paraffin lamps, a store of paraffin and a few other small things. Generosity is the best kind of self-interest, and the only kind that ought to be allowed.

The people here were starved of news. Their wireless had broken down badly, and had only lately been mended. They were prisoners of their own geography.

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As arranged, the coal was waiting: tons of it, dry and black, laid in during the summer under two layers of thick tarred cloth in long bunkers ashore. The ship needed every ton. Her refits, first at a Japanese yard in 1909 to 1911 and then again in 1920, had lightened her engine, enlarged her bunkers at the expense of her holds and cut her passenger berths from four hundred and eighty to four hundred, and on paper she could now steam some three and a half thousand miles at economical speed, enough, just, to reach Vancouver. The sailors called her *Hella* for short, though not, it is safe to say, in honour of the princess of Greek myth who fell from the golden ram into the sea and gave her name to the Hellespont. She still carried a mast and sail amidships, a vestige of older times, just in case. Masters of sailing ships had once ground their teeth at the stokers' oily paws in the sugar bowls on starched tablecloths, but they had been forced to admit that steam was better than wind.

Loading began at eleven. Twenty-five local men and almost the whole crew took part in the hardest job aboard, the other side of the coin, the price of thousands of easy miles for the passengers. The ship had no coal elevator; that was a luxury for the great merchant ships. The passengers were quietly advised either to go ashore or to stay in their cabins. The local women were hospitable and invited the visitors into their homes to eat the gifts of the sea, which were all that kept the town alive.

The local men had packed six hundred sacks, each weighing about eight poods, and those went aboard first, seventy tons and more. The rest went up by the tub, a ton at a time, a dozen minutes to fill, a few more to hoist, a quarter of an hour to tip into the bunkers, through the afternoon, through the night, with breaks only for meals. Thirty tons more were heaped in a fenced pen on the main deck, fifty feet by eight and ten feet high. The crew complained about the way the locals had tied the sacks, until they understood that the locals knew exactly what they were doing. The night was sleepless for everyone aboard who was not deaf.

The old sailors used to say that when the stokers came into the mess, everyone stood up. On the *Helvetia* nobody stood, but the three watches of four

men who fed the furnace enjoyed the same respect as the master. Now, filthier than ever, they were hauling their own fuel aboard by the ton, knowing what days of unbroken work it meant for them. The boiler was kept warm through all fourteen hours, fed a little every quarter of an hour, for fear it should go cold; starting it from nothing was hard work for these "watchmakers."

The ship's old hands had a strange custom, kept up since about 1915 by every master she had had, of whom there had been two. Every time she took on coal, the master would take a dirk that had come into the ship's possession under unexplained circumstances, choose the most striking lump of coal, carefully cut off a sliver, lay it on the blade at the one correct angle, lick it, swallow it with a monstrous expression on his face, and then spit it into the sea. The whole crew had to watch.

When he saw it, Yevgeny Nikolayevich retreated to a cabin, either from nausea at the sight or, more likely, in the fog of his worsening withdrawal. Even the sailors were remarking on how bad he looked; luckily for him, the master had stopped noticing. But he was fighting like a lion, and for now he was winning. He had hidden the jar in the master's small safe, to which he had no key of his own; that was a sensible thing to do. His case was an odd one. The pain in his arm, which his brain was inventing, still deceived him, but he was beginning to understand that it would pass. He had not studied medicine for four years for nothing, however out of date it was. And yet whenever he thought about how long he could last, he felt sick. He had not slept for three days. Without a word to anyone he ran to his cabin and tried to sleep before the night's hallucinations took hold of him. It was the seventh day of his struggle. This one was better than the others, but the anxiety that came with the poisoning made everything worse, and the thought of the drug kept coming back and back. Few men could have held out so long. But there was no room for illusion. He could break at any moment, and most likely would.

By the end of the day all of them, gentlemen and sailors alike, were black as miners. Luckily it did not rain. They washed in the bathhouse, a surprisingly large building on the second street back from the waterfront, and everyone was delighted except the stokers, who laughed at the rest, since they had to wash off the black every watch of their lives. Ash was dumped from the furnace, the boiler was cleaned as far as it could be, small faults in the engine were mended, and fresh water was taken on from the Avacha. Where the coal had come from, in this God-forsaken town, nobody would say. Kamchatka has coal of its own in the north, but it gives much ash and little heat. This had come long ago on a

Japanese ship, before the evacuation of Vladivostok was even thought of. The Japanese, some locals believed, had been planning to make Petropavlovsk their base for taking the whole peninsula. The work was paid for partly in goods, partly in gold.

As agreed in Vladivostok, six Kamchatka men joined the crew to make up the numbers. They left unwillingly; they could not come back before spring. Their pay was given to their families in advance. Sailors' wives are used to that.

The master decided to spend the night in Avacha Bay and sail at five in the morning, which was hardly morning at that time of year, since dawn was still far off. The tired sailors were glad of seven hours' sleep, though it was against the schedule. The passengers said goodbye to the townsfolk, and a few exchanged little keepsakes. The local men went aboard with sad faces. It was one thing to go out in small boats for a couple of days, and quite another to go all the way to America.

And the master got what he wanted at last: fish soup made from Kamchatka salmon. Three hundredweight of splendid fish came aboard by way of barter, in four wooden barrels, two salted and two packed in ice borrowed from the mountain: humpback, red salmon, Pacific salmon, and sea trout. A paradise for anyone who loves fish.

The engine was started, the boiler heated, the cargo slings stowed, the deck coal covered with tarpaulin, the running lights lit, and the ship began to move. In less than an hour she had left Avacha Bay behind.

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At nine knots the steamer ran due east, towards that intangible line, unmarked on most maps, where the date changes. It is a curious, paradoxical line. Time runs by its own rules around it. Baron Munchausen, that celebrated liar, told his astonished listeners that on his visit to the North Pole, besides hunting polar bears, he had thrown a stone over yesterday, and taking a good run, had jumped from today into yesterday. Nowhere except in Antarctica does the line cross dry land. Between the two Diomede Islands, only four kilometres apart, it runs exactly down the middle of the strait.

But they had to reach it first. The ship was out in the ocean now, in earnest, with no bays or seas to shelter her. Two whole days passed without anything worth remembering. It was the season of diaries. Everyone who could write wrote, which meant everyone except small children and perhaps the wives of a

few merchants, composing great letters to themselves about how sad they were, poor things, and how the ocean "would not end," like the lands of Magnolia, and what a pity it was that all of it would soon be surrendered to the devil. All of it as if copied, only the names, the hands and the length differing. Those with plenty of ink, about ten of them, wrote without restraint; those with little traced every letter. Only a few did anything more useful, writing out lines of something like science.

There was an artist aboard, as there should be, though without his easel, which was packed away. He drew caricatures to amuse people and made rather good money at it. In his half-dark cabin he was visited now and then by unhappy subjects of his caricatures, mostly the husbands of the ladies who had ordered them.

Nobody aboard knew what was happening at Spassk, a name that meant so much to them. And what was happening was sad, for many. On the calendar it was the eighth of October, and the soulless Pacific surrounded the *Helvetia* on every side.

On the seventh of October the shock group of the Red Army's 2nd Amur Division came up to the fortified district held by General Molchanov's Volga Group. On the eighth they stormed the forts, took the third of them, and dug in on the north-western edge of the town. On the morning of the ninth they attacked all along the line; by noon they held the northern part of the town, and by half past two four more forts had fallen. The Whites fell back to their last line by the cement works and then, threatened on both flanks, abandoned Spassk. They lost more than a thousand killed and wounded; the Reds took nearly three hundred prisoners, two batteries, three regimental colours, the Volga Group's staff, and even an armoured train. The road to Vladivostok was open.

The Reds would make a song about it, about the storming nights of Spassk and the days of Volochayevka, and Soviet schoolchildren would sing it for seventy years without ever asking what those nights had been like for the men in the forts.

CHAPTER SIX

# Whale Weather

In Vladivostok the evacuation went on with fresh urgency. Steamers left one after another, and the Japanese were leaving too. The news of Spassk reached the city a couple of hours before the town had actually fallen, or been liberated; I will not judge whether it was an occupation or a cure.

Yevgeny Nikolayevich was coming to the edge of his reason. He broke. Why had he lied to himself? He had carefully left a few grains of powder in his cabin, just in case, and the syringe was always with him. The eighth day of his struggle ended in collapse, as might have been expected. But now he understood, painfully, that there was not much morphine left, and that it would run out, and then what? The mere thought that it was nearly gone drove him out of his mind. His dry cough, a side effect of such substances, was getting worse. The master had begun to look at his second askance, and a few days later, nearing the Aleutians, he asked whether Mr Vrublevsky might have consumption. Once again Yevgeny invented a good story, one that both the addict and those around him could believe.

Only a few people were not bored in those October days, among them our undercover Bolsheviks. They tried to banter with the public, joined in conversations, argued, and studied the habits of the men they were watching. They never managed to get close to them; the "patients" were too hysterical, and took a dislike to the three of them. But they did learn a few remarkable things, which they even wrote down, in case they forgot: stories told with untroubled pride about certain deeds that the Bolsheviks regarded as crimes.

"Never mind. The time will come, and we'll take our tax out of their own hides. Vermin. Let them burn."

Bobrov-Neglasov was in a fury, stirring his drink, which had gone cold, as if he were grinding something with the spoon. What he was grinding was his ideological and personal hatred. Even the experienced Semyon Semyonovich could not bear the evening speeches, which had become a tradition, in which the targets of his surveillance were often praised to the skies. All of it together left a peppery aftertaste from too long a stay in such unpleasant company. And he could not let himself go. How he wanted to.

On the tenth of October, the waters of what had once been the empire came to an end behind them. Not a ship, not a bird; nothing for the eye to hold on to. The *Helvetia* ran parallel to the Aleutian Islands and the Alaska Peninsula, and, as Euclid teaches, parallel lines do not meet. Not one of the hundred-odd islands, with their twenty-five high volcanoes, could be seen with the naked eye, or with binoculars either. They crossed the hundred and eightieth meridian, which became for the travellers a kind of equator.

The region was not a busy one, but it was not empty either. Americans often came to Kamchatka and Chukotka to buy furs, which they sold on the mainland at speculators' prices, and made profits worthy of the gold rush that had roared through Alaska and Canada not long before and now yielded nothing but insultingly tiny nuggets overlooked by the hordes. And there were whalers. On the morning of the thirteenth of October, the *Helvetia* met some.

It happened off the Fox Islands, sixty miles south of the southern tip of Umnak. That morning, for a couple of hours, the master left the ship more or less in the care of God. Almost the whole crew sat together in the mess, except two sailors keeping warm in the engine room, and talked about everyday things as if they were passengers themselves. Neptune could do the work for a while. It was a release, though a risky one.

"Do foxes really live out here, in this cold, with the sea all round? Rats, I can believe. We've passed the Rat Islands already. But foxes? Foxes aren't that stupid. They'd do better on the mainland."

"They do all right there. Except in a storm. Same as everywhere here," said Konstantin Lvovich.

He did not mention, because he probably did not know, what else had happened on the Fox Islands. It was here, in 1763, that the Aleuts of Umnak and Unalaska rose against the Magnolian fur hunters who had been seizing their women and children as hostages to force the men to hunt sea otter for them, and burned four of their ships. The reprisal was led by a trader named Ivan Solovyov, and the Aleuts remembered it for generations; it was said that he

tied men in a row to see how many one musket ball would pass through. The Aleuts had numbered perhaps fifteen thousand when the first promyshlenniki came in the 1740s. Fifty years later there were fewer than two thousand.

An hour later, at reduced speed, they came upon a sight that stirred mixed feelings even in experienced men. Five kilometres to starboard, the whalers' boats were spreading out, more of them every minute. A hunt was beginning.

"Whale weather. Just right," said the bosun. "But there's a lot of them got up. Why so many boats? They'll be watching the poor beasts' routes, I suppose."

"Must be more than one whale, if they're lying here at slow speed. Not a bad ship they've got. Americans, I take it?" It was the first thing Yevgeny Nikolayevich had said in several days.

"Quick, give me the glass. I want a look. Yes, who else? Saxons, Saxons. The Pacific Whaling Company, God help me remember my old employer, Count Keyserling's, never came back. Ours haven't gone out properly since the war with Japan."

"There you are, Father, what you asked for. Americans, all right," said Fyodor, a sailor, coming up with the telescope. "Eh, they shouldn't have sold Alaska, the blockheads."

"You know how it was. And what's Alaska now? The whole country's collapsed. No Poland, no Finland, and in Moscow and Petrograd... a thousand worms in my hand!"

"Sons of harbour sluts sitting in the Kremlin. Foul."

"What's the use of grumbling? It's all been decided without us. Maybe it'll all come round again. The godless won't last long."

"Last time I went after whales was February of the year three. Caught four. Then the war started, and the Japanese took the ships. In the year seven I went once, a bad trip; we lost men and never got a whale. Brr, when I remember it. The frost, the wind, wild, and then it came over us, I'd already said my goodbyes. But no, here I am. Fools we were."

"Americans all the same. That's the striped flag. Tell the passengers, let them look. We'll go a little closer. They've never seen a whale alive, only in a picture in some ABC. And another thing," said Konstantin Lvovich, "put the ship's clocks right. We're still living on Kamchatka time. It won't do. Tell our guests too."

The passengers were at breakfast, by the wrong time. The senior seaman came in, greeted them, wished them a good appetite, and announced that in

the next few hours they would have the chance to watch the hunting of the largest creatures of the unknown ocean. That interested them. Some watched from their portholes, some from the deck. But for a long time there were no whales to be seen, even through binoculars. Then, towards noon, when they had met a second whaling ship, the boats began to close in on a family of grey whales, father, mother and calf.

It was a dreadful sight. The two grown whales knew they were being hunted and kept trying to slip away. But the calf could not stay under for long, and had to come up every few minutes, and the mother would not leave it.

The *Helvetia* was three miles off. The master watched through his telescope, and his attention, as an old whaler's would, went to the harpooners. They fired Svend Foyn's harpoon, the Norwegian invention of 1867, the year Vladivostok turned seven: a gun on the bow of a small steamer, and a harpoon whose barbs opened inside the whale like an umbrella, breaking a glass phial of acid that lit a fuse and exploded a charge of powder inside the animal. Harpoon and lance in a single stroke. Before it, men had gone out in open boats and thrown their harpoons by hand, as their ancestors had thrown spears at the mammoth, and the whale had dived with the line and dragged the boat after it, and often smashed it with its tail and drowned the men who had wounded it. Now the men did not drown.

A bang. The bull, forty feet long or more, was still breathing, still sending up his fountains. The charge struck the front of the skull. He died almost at once. He drew one last breath, by reflex, gave a sound that lasted a single second, and sank into his own hot red rum in the icy water. Blood does not clot in the sea.

The master lowered the old four-draw telescope and sighed heavily. He knew that they would take the mother and the calf next. Whether he had grown sentimental with age, or whether he had only now understood his old trade, watching it from outside, he could not have said. That is the strange thing about human sight: short and long at once. When he was among it he had seen nothing; now, from three miles away, he saw everything. Wisdom usually comes, but late.

The passengers were not so long-sighted. In high spirits they cheered for the hunters, not the hunted. One might speak of bread and circuses; one might say that people have always loved a cruel spectacle and always will. Here were people who had fled a war, who had seen more than enough of suffering, and they clapped. Perfume and rouge and lipstick change nothing. When the oldest parts of the brain decide, they ask no one's leave. Sharks smell blood from far

away, and so did these people, licking their lips. Only the smallest children, not yet spoiled by their hormones and their upbringing, were truly human that day; one of them wanted to jump overboard and swim out to save the whales, which had never done anyone any harm or any good. And what fools their parents were, to teach them to watch.

And for what? Not for meat; whale meat was hardly eaten then, though it is said to taste well enough. For oil, and for whalebone, the horny plates in the mouth that strain the sea for food. For lamp oil and soap and perfume and margarine, and, lately, for nitroglycerine: in 1912 Norway alone had thirty-seven floating factories in the Antarctic and drew half a million barrels of oil a year, much of it for explosives. The Basques had hunted the Biscay whales until there were none; the North Atlantic grey whale was gone by the eighteenth century; and now the hunters had reached the edge of the world, so that here too nothing should be left of the leviathans, not even bones. The world had pigs. It had other fats. It did not need this. In October, besides, every whaler knew the whales were thinner; but human impatience is stronger even than the instinct for profit.

The compressors began to pump air into the bodies, so they would not sink. The calf was dead too. It was probably not yet four years old. The second ship was closing in. Any whales that had strayed near the Aleutians in those days were doomed. The age of killing without limit was nearly over, and the whalers knew it, and hunted all the more greedily, like gold-diggers after the last nuggets in a fast river.

All evening, in the warm saloons and the dining room, people talked of nothing else: tales of courage, tales of their own part in this "great enterprise," never before told even to their families. It was sickening to listen to. But the talk died down, as the ship drew away from the place of slaughter, and the last of the onlookers vanished, along with the good weather.

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Foul weather, treacherous currents and unreliable charts: the trouble began on the morning of the fifteenth of October, when the *Helvetia* reached the Gulf of Alaska. The gulf is bounded by a horseshoe of coast running from Kodiak in the west to the Alexander Archipelago in the east, a coast cut to pieces by glaciers, which pour their meltwater into the Pacific in rivers and streams. The ship had no intention of going near Alaska. She meant to cross the gulf length-

wise and then, correcting her course, run down Hecate Strait past the Queen Charlotte Islands, in Canadian waters, in the province of British Columbia. The last dash would take about a week and would be the hardest, because the sea was unpredictable and there was no running for shore. The shore was far away, and there was hardly anyone on it.

Yevgeny Nikolayevich was at the end of his strength. He had three doses left in his cabin, and about as much again in the small safe to which he had deliberately given up his key. He decided to go to the second doctor after all, though it took him a long time to remember where he had met the first. His head would not work. And he had to fight the rising wind and correct the course.

This time he was heard. At four in the afternoon, after his watch, he found the cabin of the second doctor, who asked not to be called by his name, only "Doctor." He asked why Yevgeny had not gone to the ship's doctor, got his answer, and they talked for a long time, alone; the doctor's family had gone visiting. The doctor turned out to be a dentist, not a physician, and certainly no expert in addiction. He knew the word morphine, of course, but had not thought it destructive, though he reasoned that if a patient had come to him, the painkiller could not be so harmless. There is no medicine that dulls pain without harming something else, the liver, the kidneys, the heart; anyone with a little medical education knew that. After a long and tedious conversation about the symptoms, the dentist told Yevgeny what he already knew: yes, he was in the bondage of an addict. Stories of the Opium Wars, and a few books, helped them to put a name to it. So even novels, which in my humble opinion are mostly useless, can sometimes be of help.

But the dentist had no way out to offer. The Land of Magnolias whose mind this ship carried had never been ready to study such things. The world itself was only beginning to grasp what certain substances could do to human lives. In 1898 the firm of Bayer had put on the market a revolutionary new medicine and called it heroin, because it fought illness heroically; until 1910 it was sold in pharmacies all over the world, with an assurance that it was not habit-forming and was safe even for children. Morphine was beginning to be condemned, timidly, but what comfort was that to morphinists who had been told only yesterday by doctors reading old instructions that it was not addictive? It was a time of terrible experiments on mankind, when some were killed by mustard gas, some crushed by tanks, some drowned by submarines, and some destroyed by treacherous medicines. And a time when yesterday's

master became, overnight, a man who knew nothing, like this dentist, who had last heard a lecture on general medicine thirty years before.

He had sworn before God to save people. He understood that neither he nor his friend, of the same trade, could save this one. And he made what seemed the right decision. He passed the problem to a priest, a wise man, much more experienced in all sorts of things than in teeth, who had a cabin three doors down. And in keeping his promise to say nothing of what he had heard, he made a mistake, without knowing it. He should not have kept silent. Yevgeny had told him everything: the blackouts, the withdrawal, all that his poisoned mind could understand. A man in that state should not have been one of the three guardian angels of nearly four hundred lives.

They knocked, went in, and the conversation began. The dentist soon left.

It was not long, but it was exhausting. Questions, more questions. An invitation to a full confession. For a priest is not just a kind man; he has been given the power to forgive in God's name.

"The greatest human folly is fear," said the priest. "Fear of acting, of speaking, of confessing. We are always afraid, and that is why we lose so often. Tell me everything you are carrying like a dead weight, and then we will talk further, and we will certainly settle your trouble."

"What is there to tell? A man like any other. I was wounded in the arm three months ago. The painkiller turned out to be a terrible thing..."

"No, no, not that. That comes later. Your sins. Free your body and soul of them. I can see you carry a weight of a pood before your heart, and it is bending you towards death."

"I have no sins. Small things."

"The Lord has promised not to judge the penitent. Open yourself. Nothing will leave the walls of this cabin."

"I don't think it would interest you. Childhood stories, little misdeeds you can hardly call sins. I lived like anyone else."

"And where is your family?"

"I have a family. They're far away now..."

There the conversation all but ended. There is no point in repeating it word for word. The priest, who was dressed nothing like a priest, which was hardly surprising, tried again and again to bring the man round, but Yevgeny sat with his teeth clenched and could not speak. There was a great secret in him, and a great mortal sin. The sin of murder.

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Three months earlier, in the Maritime Province, north of Spassk, he had been wounded in the shoulder.

The Vrublevskys had a summer house in a small settlement along the railway: forest, a lake, peace and quiet. The elder son lived in Harbin; that was where the family meant to go if the defenders of their old country collapsed completely. At the end of July a few Red cavalry scouts burst into the defenceless village and began firing at random at the houses, hoping to draw fire. The village had been forgotten by both sides; there were only three White soldiers there, back from a sortie near Bikin. Shutters and windows were smashed, a few animals killed, a scarecrow shot to pieces, and three villagers hit, one way or another. One of them was Yevgeny Nikolayevich, who had been sawing logs for the stove at the edge of the village. His wife and younger son were in the house and escaped with a fright. The raiders paid for it soon enough; the three soldiers had a machine gun.

The wound at first seemed simple. The family went back towards Vladivostok, stopping for a week at Khvalynka near Lake Khanka, in an old cottage, so that he could recover out of sight; at the port, a wound like that would have been impossible to hide. Four days later they heard that the village they had left had been taken. The pain grew. The bullet had struck the head of the humerus, a dangerous place. He had to go to Spassk for an operation; the bullet was a strange one, doubled, and while the main part had gone clean through, a fragment smaller than an unripe pea had stayed inside. The village doctor, watching the pain grow, prescribed the medicine he had somehow got hold of, from the army probably. The injections began, and the pain went. By about the fourth injection, the first stage of dependence had set in. They stayed two weeks instead of one. Yevgeny began asking his wife for injections to feel better still, and she did not know what she was doing. Nor did the doctor know that what he had given them was a mixture of several alkaloids, made worse by a foolish nurse who had handed over a dose meant for two patients. He understood too late. The family had already left, taking the jar of white powder with them.

Nothing robs the mind of its reason and its power to act so completely as fear. On the third day of the journey to Vladivostok, by cart, the jar that had stood on the windowsill could not be found. Yevgeny had grown irritable, but

that did not alarm Maria Leopoldovna or little Miroslav; a wounded arm does not make a man cheerful. When he demanded his "dose," his wife could not find it among the things. There was a quarrel. He was still in his right mind and broke it off, deciding he could bear the pain without the medicine; and he did not want to make a scene in front of the old man who had agreed, for good pay, to drive them, on a cart so light and flimsy it felt as if any waved arm would tip them all into the road.

But the craving grew by the hour, and the next day it burst. The old man was driving through an oak wood where there was neither man nor bird. After a peasant's lunch among the trees, Yevgeny's mind clouded over altogether, and the evil came out. The good gentleman turned suddenly into a raging tyrant and cursed the person closest to him in every way he knew. She was a free spirit, and would not stand such humiliation, and gave as good as she got. Then he stood up, and some things fell out of the baggage, among them the precious bottle, which by a miracle did not break.

Hysterical, he made the driver stop, picked up the lost bottle, and at once began to strangle his wife, believing she had hidden it to torment him. The five-year-old boy saw it all. He tried to come between them. The man was stronger, and under the worst of all the evils made for mankind he set about destroying everyone who stood between him and his dose. The driver, horrified, reached for his gun to save the woman. In front of them all, wounded arm or no, a killer's strength awoke in Yevgeny, and he broke her neck. Then he saw the gun the old man was reaching for, took it from him, and, not knowing how to shoot it, clubbed him over the head; a few seconds later he was dead. The boy ran, but the wood was sparse, and he could not outrun his father. He became the devil's victim too, in the most terrible way: the father of the respectable family kicked him to death.

The bodies lay where they were for a long time while he searched for the syringe, so as to have at last what he had sold his soul for. Then he dragged them into a heap in a little gully, straightened his clothes with wild eyes, and tried to take the horses, which were screaming at the whole wood, knowing that something was wrong. They were two fine Orlov trotters, which the driver, who did not own them, had been taking to sell at the port and had thought to earn a little more by carrying a peaceful family. It was a mistake for all of them. Yevgeny could not master the horses. He abandoned the cart, loaded himself with the luggage, and walked. It took him five days to get home instead of three. When he arrived, it dawned on him what he had done, and from then

on he never let the bottle out of his own keeping. Then he tried to kill himself, remembering suddenly what had happened. And then he forgot again.

As for the horses, the wood was a lonely one, and full of wolves. That same night the horses too died a martyr's death, though the man himself came to no harm, and walked on through that wood for fifteen hours more. Why the old driver had taken the short cut instead of the road, no one will ever know.

But something stayed in Yevgeny's head, and he learned to build inside himself a new reality, in which his family lived a life of its own, apart from him, while he, the breadwinner, saw them seldom; and to anyone who asked, at work or elsewhere, he told tales. A whole bouquet of hidden disorders was flowering in Mr Vrublevsky's mind, and the white powder was the catalyst. Nobody knew. Fortune, unfortunately, was on his side, and it should not have been. Such things should not go unnoticed.

"What are you thinking about so hard, Yevgeny Nikolayevich? Can you hear me?"

"Yes... yes. A man always has something to think about..."

"I can see our conversation isn't going anywhere. You're not ready yet. I'll give you only one piece of advice, though I still don't understand your trouble: anything can be overcome, if you have a reason to overcome it. Find it. Repent. Come back, and as soon as you can. Think it over alone, and come in. I'll be waiting."

"Yes, yes. Goodbye." Mr Vrublevsky left the confessor's cabin like a shot.

"God keep you," said the priest, with hope.

When the door had shut, Yevgeny thought something absurd, like a boy who has done some small mischief and is ashamed of it. *Ah, Zhenya, why are you alive? You have already taken three lives.* He ran to the shower and stood under it fully dressed. As if stung, he was running away from salvation, though he had been on his way towards it. The man was really going mad. By a strange piece of luck, none of the passengers saw him, except a little boy wandering in one of the corridors, and when he came to himself he did everything necessary to make himself look normal again. They were already looking for him. He was an hour late for his watch. Dishevelled, his hair standing on end, he pulled the captain's cap over it, which looked comic on his round face; he had never liked wearing it, being self-conscious about how he looked in it. He told them it was the twenty-fifth anniversary of his service at sea. And it was true. He had suddenly remembered that trivial detail of his old life, which no longer had anything to do with this one.

Patience had once been the main virtue required on this voyage. Now it was calm.

CHAPTER SEVEN

# The Gulf



For three days the sea had given no one any sleep, and it seemed only the beginning, as if the dying whales had taken their revenge on the gawpers. The waves reached force five. Attempts to get a weather forecast by wireless failed. On the sixteenth of October, in that heavy sea, the day's coal had to be brought up from the furthest holds. Hail came down twelve times, and once something like snow. The wind went round to the north-east, though the day before it had been westerly, and it became clear that the Gulf of Alaska was the scene of a collision between two cyclones of equal strength. The Gulf is the great breeding ground of the storms that march south along the coasts of British Columbia, Washington and Oregon, and the *Helvetia* had become an unwilling party to the making of a fresh one.

"We didn't make it in time," said the master, reading the recommendations he had been given in Vladivostok, shaking his head. "We should have gone a little earlier. It's very bad that we've reached the storm zone at the worst moment."

"I reckon in two days we'll be in the very middle of it," said the bosun from his armchair. "She's getting harder to steer. We're being set off. We'll have to check with Kolych." That was what they had lately started calling Vrublevsky between themselves.

"Do we have proper charts of the west coast?"

"Should have. In the third book store, I think, or the second."

"Get them out for me tomorrow. I want to look. Perhaps we'll go in closer to the shore and take some of the force out of it. I don't like where we are at all. Who's that running like a hippo up the Limpopo?"

A filthy stoker from the third watch, one of the new men from Kamchatka, burst in, out of breath.

"We've got trouble. A loading cable's parted at number five bunker, and it fell on one of ours, and another went to help him, and the roll brought down a heap of coal, two tons maybe. They're alive, I think. One of them's moving. We can't get them out."

"Harpoon me through! Who skimped on the canvas? Yevgeny, take the watch. We're going below."

"Aye."

When Yevgeny took the watch, he could not believe his eyes. A quarter of an hour earlier he had been able to see a little: thin rain and snow, with breaks between. Now the visibility was nil. Ahead of the bow there was only milk. It was not his watch. He was not due for three hours. But he took the wheel and noted the readings on the traverse board, an old English contraption of holes and pegs for recording courses and watches, which had come with the ship from the yard where she was built and was still in use, though most ships had long since given it up. The anemometer showed seventeen metres a second; in the morning it had been thirteen. Force seven on the Beaufort scale, where three days before it had been three. By night it was force eight, and people were frightened. But there was no one to calm them.

For four hours the rescue of the two stokers went on, and the ship lost speed. The waves made up for it in feeling, so that Yevgeny did not realise that she was making less way, but he could see that she was being set off course. Instead of east-by-east she was heading north-east, some twenty degrees off. He thought he could correct it. He had never steered through a storm like this, and there was no one to ask. The code did not allow him to leave the wheel. He waited for the master and the bosun, or at least the senior seaman, but they had all forgotten him, playing the hero in the hold, fighting the shifting coal and the moans of the poor devils under it. Twenty men were working at it, with tubs and every other tool, and still they could not reach the second man.

In the sixth hour of the watch, Yevgeny ventured to leave his post for a call of nature, reckoning that the wireless operator or the doctor would see to things if anything happened. But they were both asleep. When he came back he noticed no change. There was one, and he half heard it. The steering gear was behaving strangely. He began to suspect that the rudder stock was jamming now and then. Troubles never come singly, and this when the course needed correcting. He was getting worse and worse. His head was splitting, as if someone had emptied his skull, poured in dried peas through the hole at its base and added water to let them swell. The weather, no doubt, made the withdrawal worse.

He had one dose left. The pain was so unbearable that he leaned back in the chair and passed out, despite the hail storming the wheelhouse like the Romans at Syracuse, despite the whole symphony of the approaching ninth wave.

It soon played a cruel trick. The hydraulic part of the steering gear began to fail, grinding away its many cogs. For now the wheel showed no sign of serious trouble. The hidden danger had not yet come to the surface.

At midnight the storm reached its height. Every passenger was shaking in his cabin, from the smallest to the greatest. A few lucky ones managed to sleep; most wandered to one another's cabins, clinging to the swaying walls. In the sixth hour of the rescue they got one man out, cut and grazed all over, and carried him to the sick bay, where they practically bathed him in spirit, since every limb had been sliced by the sharp little lumps of coal. The master and the bosun did not think of going back up. They assumed all was well above, though they felt every bit of the storm. Some remembered tropical storms they had lived through, some hard voyages in the ice, but they all had one task: to get the stoker out before he died. To last even a minute under a heap of black stones is heroic, and he had lasted hours. The coal kept threatening the rescuers too, as the ship rolled more with every hour.

The *Helvetia* was falling off her course by a few degrees every hour, and the wind played with her like a toy. The barometer went wild. The passengers with weak hearts had been feeling very bad since the day before, and for the first time gave the lazy doctor some work. And Mr Vrublevsky lay almost in a coma; his heart could not take it; he was entirely unconscious.

On top of everything, the storm acquired a new danger: in place of the icy hail, a thunderstorm broke through.

Only in the morning, at the end of an eleven-hour watch, nearly three times the four hours of a full crew and half as long again as the eight hours allowed on this ship, did the master and the bosun come back to the wheelhouse. They were late by an hour, having spent a long time washing off the coal; luckily they had thought to change into working clothes, or their uniforms would have been done for. By then Vrublevsky had come round, had used his last dose of morphine, and was feeling "normal." The only thing that could have exposed his blackout was five hours without an entry in the log. But in the darkness of that storm, which had steadied now at twenty metres a second without dropping for a minute, nobody was checking logs. A few words, and that was all. Still under the drug, which he had taken only three hours before, Yevgeny had forgotten everything, said all was perfectly normal, and went to sleep.

The bosun, half asleep, fought with a chair that kept sliding round the wheelhouse, and in the end moved to the armchair to keep the master company. Neither of them noticed the strange behaviour of the rudder either; they took it for the ordinary groaning of a ship in foul weather.

"I'll sleep a little, and after dinner, if there is any, I'll see to your charts. We'll be off the coast of Canada tomorrow, I take it?"

"Looks like it. Have to take readings and fix our position. There's nothing in the log. Odd. The weather, I suppose; he didn't get round to it."

"Right. Sleep, if you can."

"I need to knock back some tea or I won't last. Too much lightning. No lightning rod will save us. Pray, pray, and pray again. The devil brought us here; I thought we'd make the whole voyage in peace. My legs ache, my arms no better, my neck's breaking. I've got to give up ships, or I'll have a stroke. I've felt poorly since the rescue."

"Good luck, then, Father. Keep talking. It's better than the noises in here. I'll listen with half an ear. I've got a rug, something's making me shiver. That thunder-beast will keep us company all the way to Vancouver. How did we miss it? Though the barometer's been playing up since the whalers..."

Konstantin Lvovich went on mumbling more or less like that, stringing words together slowly but surely so as not to fall asleep.

The crockery broke of its own accord. Seven cups lost their handles. The cats had it worse than the people, and some of the dogs; their inner ears could not cope. The food that day was the worst of the voyage, since some of the volunteer cooks did not turn up, and everyone understood. The children cried. The waves reached the level of the third-class cabins, and from the night of the seventeenth, the second-class ones too. Conversation stopped. Everyone was waiting for something.

The compasses behaved strangely and stuck stubbornly where they were. The wireless still did not work, which could be understood: what signal could get through such weather? The *Helvetia* went on growing thinner, devouring tons of coal and hundredweights of provisions every hour. Being an optimist, the master did not dwell on his instruments. His ship would not turn round in a force eight, and any lesser error his crew could correct as easily as anything. The coal was another matter. There was no real reserve for Vancouver; if the ship was being carried, as they now guessed, well to the north-east of where she should be, the last three hundred miles might have to be made, God help them,

under sail, with a following wind, in a steamer of two thousand tons. For now they must stand and keep their losses down.

The lightning went on striking close by. In the third hour of that wretched day a bolt burst right beside the mast, which terrified everyone. You should have heard the crash. The foremast stood, but the shock wave shook the whole ship, and afterwards everything aboard went still. It did not happen again, but the lights went out. The current had evidently passed into the metal of the ship, and in those days, long before proper earthing, the deck wiring for the running lights and signals could be given up for lost. That remained to be seen; perhaps only the bulbs had gone.

In such hours a dark puritanism enters every cabin where there was epicureanism before. It is often fear that teaches people to want less of life.

Some of the passengers tried to master themselves on paper.

*My eyes are going, but I'll write. Maybe I'll read it some day. To myself, plainly. Three weeks on the ship now. Sakhalin behind, Kamchatka; they say we're near Canada and Alaska. How do we live? Not merrily. Storm, wild wind, the ship tossed about as if she were a bucket and we were ants. On days like this I want to think about philosophy, to argue. But there is no one to talk to. I am sick of the gatherings in the saloon, where the talk is of who ate what and, forgive me, how happily it went down the latrine. I am homesick for Vladivostok, and my heart grows heavier by the hour. Something is wrong, it tells me. I shall never see my home again. I have no faith at all that we will win. One does not win by running; I cannot remember when flight ever turned out a success. I see many faces and look into their eyes, but I hardly ever find any like my own. Yesterday I saw a rat in the cabin, and it finished me. It is not for nothing. For three days now we have been in purgatory, which boils and tries to pull us in, as in the* Divine Comedy. *I would write and write, but I have no more ink or paper. I hope to trade something in this Vancouver, if we stop there. Sun, come back. Without you it is so sad, so much lonelier, so much more frightening.*

*I put the light on for a couple of minutes to write that I am afraid. Raisa can't calm Antosha. He cries all the time, louder these last days. I don't know what to do. He can't sleep, and so neither can we, nor our neighbours. The walls here are so thin, it turns out. Patience, patience...*

*Seventeenth of October. Holding steady. All around, melancholy and phlegm. Gloom and sadness. I am trying to learn to dance, but I need more room. Why am I writing this nonsense? But I write what I think, or I'll go mad. I dream of autumn woods and white mushrooms. What can it mean? Pity I have no dream book.*

*
**

Towards evening the weather settled. The wind dropped a little, though that meant nothing, and could even be a sign that things were about to get worse. The master's tongue loosened, and he talked with the bosun, who had rested a little and suggested tea to keep them awake. The bosun disliked his own name, and wished to be called only "Bosun." What people! One must call this one Father, and that one by no name at all. The shortage of officers, let us call it that, was becoming obvious.

"I think we've been set about a hundred miles off course, to the north-east."

"I reckon the same. But in fifteen hours or so we should sight land, and then it won't be hard to correct. We can still tell north from south, can't we?"

"I wouldn't joke. I like instruments. It happened to me once before, we got into some zone with a lot of iron in the ground. Maybe here too. The compass has come back to life now, at least. But I'd like more than that and the eternal anemometer."

"It's not our fault. I never got a proper report from Yevgeny's watch. He's seemed suspiciously odd to me lately. Has he been drinking?"

"I talked to him the other day. Says it's his last voyage, his health has gone suddenly, and he needs the money. I understand, I'm the same, but sometimes he surprises me, and not in a good way. They told me ashore he'd been in the fighting last year, but I don't know. Something wrong with his head, a concussion, from the trenches or from life."

The conversation was broken off by a sailor, who arrived at the appointed time with wild punctuality.

"Here's Orishko. Good day to you, or good night; I can't tell which any more."

"And to you."

"Go with the bosun to the third block, third room. There are charts there. Bring them all, between the four of you."

"I'll get the keys. One minute," said the bosun.

They took the keys from the big safe and went where they were sent. The master took the bosun's place for a while. There were three hours left of this watch. Then Mr Vrublevsky was to take over.

They opened the iron door, and gasped.

It was the very room in which two boys, Vanya and Sasha, had been walled up alive. The smell of death came out and poisoned the bosun and the sailor for a long time to come. It was a nightmare. To a professional eye, the boys had been dead for more than ten days. Every sign of the decay of flesh and organs was there. It was impossible to stay in the room, and what made it worse was that the bodies lay on the charts. Using them was out of the question. They slammed the door shut and went up to the wheelhouse, where they at once "delighted" the master.

"Father, we've got trouble," they said together, green in the face.

"What is it? The ship? No charts?" Konstantin Lvovich fired questions like a machine gun.

"In that room there are dead bodies. Children, seven years old maybe. They've been dead..." The bosun sighed heavily and did not go on. "A long time. But we need to find out properly. Maybe Yevgeny can help us, or one of the doctors, the ship's doctor even. We need to understand what happened, and when."

"Wake Vrublevsky, and Lazargansky, the ship's quack. If need be, we'll ask the passengers. There are doctors enough aboard; someone will understand. But where did they come from?"

"There's no one missing among the passengers. And how would they have got in there, on the second day? It's all locked and sealed. It's nowhere near the living quarters."

"Then who'll take the wheel? Who's next on watch? Vrublevsky. Let him have it, then, and we'll go. Judging by your faces we won't be sleeping for a long time. And not because of the storm."

"It's bad in there. But we have to clear it up, or they'll drag us through the courts afterwards. You understand. It's not a dead marten or a pigeon. I've never seen anything like it, and I've seen everything except Paris."

Yevgeny was breaking again, like a log that no one could quite split. He had slept four hours. The rest of the time he paced his little cabin like a pendulum, seven seconds a swing, inventing remedies for the piercing pain in his temples, for the dryness. He looked like a man struck by the plague but not yet killed

by it. All that was missing was a cross on his door and a wait for the journey to hell. His health had collapsed three days before. He thought slowly, did not eat at all, and drank enormously: a full glass of water every half-hour, as if he were in a desert. His face was swollen and looked worse than ever, his liver ached, and he wanted to tear someone apart. He knew there was a little more in the safe. He had learned to take the powder by licking it, sniffing it; it worked "quite well." If only he could take the watch, and make the master give him the keys.

There was a knock. He opened the door and was surprised to find half the crew come to wake him. He asked for a few minutes to make himself presentable, and then, belatedly, he took in his colleagues' faces and asked what disaster had happened. They told him that the bodies of two boys had been found in one of the stores. He reacted at once. In a second he had thrown on a coat, not the regulation one, asked to go and see, and handed the wheel to a sailor who was not at all eager to see it for himself.

And so he, like most of the crew, saw it with his own eyes. The master looked at him strangely, not understanding his eagerness; he himself had no wish to look again. The faces were horribly distorted. The bodies looked worse than an hour before, for reasons of biology I will not go into. The smell drove all curiosity out of them. The master could not hold the door open for more than a moment. The bosun said afterwards that he understood why the door had been so hard to open for the first three seconds: the boys' souls were trying to get out. They had been shut in that room for three days and nine days, as the old belief counts them. The ship's doctor, barely keeping down his recent meal, said at once: two weeks or so.

The sailors were told to seal every room in that section. Sleep had left the bosun and the master, and Yevgeny Nikolayevich too. Not everyone could have borne it. They went up in silence to the mess, where the master, a man who categorically would not tolerate drink aboard his ship, suddenly took two bottles of vodka from a secret oak cupboard. There was reason enough. He sighed, waved his hand without looking at them, and pointed to the wheelhouse.

Slowly, like a giraffe, it dawned on Yevgeny that he knew one of the boys by his clothes. Yes. No, it was certain. It was Vanya. He went red, and his hands began to shake.

The master waved the sailor away from the wheel; he was ashamed to be seen like this. He put the bottles on the binnacle and looked at the compass,

putting off the unpleasant moment as long as he could. For the third time he checked the binnacle for anything that might throw it off, since the compass needle kept wandering out of all reason, and the hand compasses were worse. Iron nails in old binnacles had once caused deviation, and iron ships had made it worse still; corrector magnets were placed in the binnacle to make up for it. But he found nothing wrong. It was very strange. And he needed a bearing so badly. Outside the visibility was still poor. The storm had not gone anywhere. For three full days the wind had kept altering the *Helvetia*'s course.

"Right. Call everyone who's awake to the mess. In twenty-five minutes we'll remember them properly. Yevgeny Nikolayevich and I will sort out the navigation and then come down. Take the bottles. We'll drink to them all together. Don't open them before. It's nearly supper anyway."

The bosun went at once.

"Well. I never thought I'd come up against anything like that. It seemed to me you knew something. You reacted strangely when you saw the bodies. Or am I wrong, Yevgeny Nikolayevich?"

"No... no. I know nothing. First time I've seen anything like it. It turned me over. I'll take the reading off the anemometer."

"Good. Then you can help me with something else."

Mr Vrublevsky was held by a single thought, and the damned anemometer did not distract him from it; it only drew him towards the safe. Where to get the keys? From whom? That much was clear. But on what grounds? He was past thinking of grounds. He had become a beast. And yet even through the fog he could not simply, insolently, demand them of his commander.

The thunder still rolled, but the lightning was striking further off now. The storm had not gone. And it seemed that the shore was close. One felt it somehow; there was something in the air like the smell of earth, of land. Perhaps that was an illusion. But there were technical grounds for thinking that in the next few hours the ship might come right up against the coast of North America.

At last the master found a working gyrocompass, and was as glad as if he had found a jewel. The ship's own had been smashed, and there was no other; who had smashed it, he had no time to wonder. Unlike a magnetic compass, a gyrocompass is not fooled by the iron of the ship, and it points to the true pole, not the magnetic one. He began to fix the cardinal points properly.

Yevgeny could not open the side window to get at the anemometer; it seemed to be jammed. He needed a tool. A knife. He asked the master for one.

"Take it," said the master, with some ceremony, absorbed in his calculations and somewhat bewildered. The magnetic compass had deceived him by seventy-seven degrees.

Yevgeny took the ordinary seaman's knife with its heavy blade, and stopped, bracing himself against the roll, and stood a while, thinking. His eyes glinted red. He went up behind the master, who stood with his back to him, and threatened him with the knife. He demanded, as might have been predicted, the keys to the safe. The master, in an awkward position, took it for a stupid joke and jerked away, and the knife slid across his face. He tried to take it from him and failed; doubled over towards the wheel, he could not get a purchase.

"Give me the key to the small safe. Give it to me."

"Yevgeny, what's wrong with you? What do you want it for?"

"Give me the key. Quick. Quicker."

"I'll give you nothing. It's against regulations. It's my safe, and you have no business with it. Explain yourself. And put that knife away."

He wasted his time talking. He was older, but he was still a strong man, strong enough to turn the tables. The truth is he had not yet grasped what was happening, that he was a hostage on his own ship; his head was still full of figures and bewilderment.

"Ah, there they are, the keys."

Yevgeny had spotted the bunch. He knew it by sight. It lay on a small shelf beside the wheel, to the left, half hidden by papers and instruments. He reached for it clumsily, being right-handed, and could not reach, and took a fist under the ribs, not a good one; he doubled up with pain but did not fall, and the master tried to get the knife. Then the roll of the ship brought down a fresh weight of sea on the hull, and they both fell, and the fight began. The door was shut. Had it been open, somebody would have heard. As it was, no one did. Two great marlins thrashed about on the dirty wooden floor, each trying to overcome the other as if they were the bitterest of enemies. Yevgeny struck at the master's face with his fingers; strange blows, but painful. The master, shorter and with shorter arms, fended him off with his hands and kicked at him with his feet. It would have been comic, if it had been a game. It was not. Trying to get up, kicking at his opponent, Vrublevsky struck the hand log, the instrument for measuring speed, which was not well secured; it fell on his legs, and the pain shot through them, and then, falling on top of the master, he landed the decisive blow on his body. Instruments came crashing down around them. Nobody noticed. Yevgeny had become a beast entirely. He gathered his

strength, pressed the grey-haired master down with his weight, and after a brief struggle the knife was in his hand again, and moving towards the master's neck. He meant to kill.

But even more, he wanted the keys, lying there a little way off. He wanted them above everything, so much that he foamed at the mouth in anticipation. In three minutes a man had become a mad dog. Thirty-five hours without the drug, and an addiction grown worse, were the reason.

The struggle grew fiercer, and the master's defence weaker. Then, without ceremony, the knife went into his neck and found the great artery. The old man was doomed. His fixed eyes held only fear. The blood spurted with extraordinary force, and "rewarded" his killer generously.

"That's for Vanka, you swine..." said Yevgeny hoarsely, covered in blood, barely able to stay on his knees.

Konstantin Lvovich had no time even to draw breath. It had all happened very fast. He could not say a word; the blade had gone right through his neck. Half sitting, he slid down quietly and fell over, to the left.

The murderer reached for the keys and began to try them. He could not remember which was the right one. It took him several minutes. His hands shook terribly, as if trying to make the bunch slip out of his bloody fingers.

And what was happening aboard the *Helvetia* meanwhile? Nothing much. It was evening, past five, dark, the weather vile. The passengers had gone to their cabins; a few talked quietly, though they were sick of three weeks of retelling the same stories. Every subject lives exactly as long as people want to know about it. The past was exhausted, only bores talk about the present, and the future is better dreamed of in bed. The stokers' work had got harder since the accident in the bunker; two men were out of it, and their bruises would keep them in the sick bay for a long time. The doctor had at last come to his senses and was practising his profession, consulting the poor passengers as well. The ship's cook, the only one aboard, had begun to curse his work, and to thank God even more that he did not have to cook for the whole regiment, or he would have fallen dead into his own cauldron. There had been no vegetables or fruit for a long time, and the little fish was long gone, but there were tins of meat and fish in plenty, many of them foreign.

"An extraordinary dinner today," one passenger remarked. "The meat reminded me of something I ate in the good old days. The same smell. The tin was called *Cabbage soup with meat and kasha*, from the capital, one pound seventy zolotniks. Ah. Lavrushka, remember?"

"I remember, I remember. We should have brought some for a keepsake, fools that we were. You've reminded me, and my heart's gone warm."

The ship ran on by herself. Everything had been left to those in the wheelhouse, and the lookout had been taken off his post back at Petropavlovsk, so nobody suspected that the sea had a nasty surprise ready. Two hours earlier the trouble with the steering had at last come fully to the surface, and since then the rudder had been almost useless, a phantom rudder, like a toy on a boy's model boat. The ship had begun, imperceptibly, to list, six degrees, but it happened smoothly, and the storm hid it. The master, growing cold on the wheelhouse floor, had died without ever knowing that his ship was in distress.

The door of the iron safe stood open. In its bottom right corner, carelessly hidden among notebooks of calculation tables and the ship's papers, lay a little bottle on its side: the treasure that had now taken four lives.

Below, all was ready for the wake of the two little vagrants who had so strangely wandered aboard. Twelve men who were off duty had gathered for it. It was promised that the dead would be given a proper funeral and buried on American soil, and that the matter would be cleared up. Glasses had been set out; no shot glasses could be found, though there had been some. Stolen, evidently. Theft is the usual mark of strangers on a ship.

Up in the wheelhouse Yevgeny Nikolayevich, without a syringe now, swallowed the powder from the very bottom of the bottle. His tolerance had grown; his dose was twice what it had been three weeks before. He slid slowly down the wall. And then, all at once, everything was gone, because the poor devil sneezed, carelessly, and blew the rest away. He began bitterly to lick the last of the dust from his palm and fingers. It was not enough to give him the illusory happiness that had become so dear to him.

At that moment the bosun was on his way to the wheelhouse to fetch them both. He did not yet know what he was about to see. A second shock in a day, even for a man as solid as the nameless bosun, was serious. He opened the door, and had no time to say what he had come to say. The murdered master in that cramped little wheelhouse could not fail to catch the eye. His first reaction was not fear. It was a man's reaction: to look. In the first second, from the corner of his eye, he saw Yevgeny, soaked in someone else's blood. There was nothing to think about. By the door stood a box with a pistol and a rifle in it; everyone allowed in the wheelhouse knew it, and there were six such men. Seeing the madness in the man twelve feet away, he snatched up the revolver, which lay on top, and then realised it was not loaded, and there was no time to look

for cartridges, and grabbed the rifle. That was loaded, by the old Magnolian custom, just in case, a Siberian's habit. Yevgeny lunged at him. A shot. The bullet took him under the breastbone. He fell, and died.

So ended, without glory, a man who had become the victim of a single circumstance and took many other lives with him.

You cannot hide a shot from a Mosin rifle. They heard it, and found where it came from. And at that very moment the ship heeled over hard. The angle seemed to have become critical; the rudder was doing whatever it pleased. What lay ahead? Dense rain and night, and nothing to be seen.

The bosun had never killed anyone before. But he kept his head and understood that what he had done was justified. He did not break down, did not drop the rifle, did not stand staring at the fallen killer. He simply sighed, laid the rifle down carefully, and looked at the signs of the struggle by the binnacle, the smashed dials, the splinters of glass. The master's frozen face showed a whole palette of feeling. Everything bad happens at once. In their heavy sea boots, heedless of the glass and the blood, the bosun bent over Yevgeny Nikolayevich's body to find out what had happened here. He noticed the powder, but did not dare to taste it. There was no time for that anyway.

Then everyone came running. The first reaction was true shock, all the stronger for being shared. Questions upon questions, long talk, a search for motives among the dead. The real aftertaste of a killing, for the living. The dead did not care. They lay side by side.

The bosun and a few others who thought ahead understood how heavy this was. How would they explain it in Vancouver, in Los Angeles? An indelible disgrace, a second incident, awkward questions and lawsuits in a foreign country, without any confidence of a defence. And the passengers, if they found out before they were safely ashore with their baggage, would make life very difficult. If the master and his first officer had not been able to get along and one had killed the other, what of the sailors, ordinary men, tired of one another and of hard, badly paid work aboard a ship that belonged to a dying state? They all had families on the other side of the Pacific. If the Reds took Vladivostok before they got back, the question of getting back would look very different. Nobody would let the ship's company go free at once; perhaps not the passengers either, who would have to begin their new life with interrogations through some strange interpreter in Canada or Alaska, and knowing their compatriots, with scandals and fights, and a nice plank bed in some miserable gaol. The ship herself was to pass, in Los Angeles, into the hands of a firm

called Eastern Ships, which liked to buy old vessels for nothing and run them for decades without repair, carrying delighted tourists along the coasts, and then skim the last of the cream off the tired old things on the Missouri and the Mississippi. The bosun knew something of that, and of how superstitious new owners can be about a ship with blood on her. He would have to think of something. And meanwhile stand watch round the clock, teach the brightest of the sailors, and try to raise whatever authority still existed in Vladivostok, or Tokyo, or Yokohama, or Harbin, or Seoul.

He had held on all this time. Now, belatedly, he began to fail. He felt ill. So did some of the other witnesses.

They held the wake, for four now. It turned out there were not two bottles but a whole case, from which the master had taken only two, but after a word with the two senior seamen the rest was hidden again. Nobody wanted a drinking bout. But they had to take three more bottles; everyone had to drink to the "captains." The bodies had to be put somewhere until they could be buried; the cold stores for food would obviously not do. The blood would not wash off; there was too much of it. It was impossible to stay in the wheelhouse, though the windows were at last open. Their jamming had been, one way or another, the beginning of the fatal fight.

It all had to be managed properly, so the passengers would not suspect, so no one would know, so that... so that... A thousand *so thats*, and the bosun's head was splitting. He had lost a relative. The master was his uncle, or rather his cousin, though the bosun was so much younger that he had always thought of him as an uncle. No one knew it, though it was no secret; they had not had time to grow close.

In the mess his authority was confirmed unanimously. The bodies were moved to one of the cooler stores, emptied for the purpose. It was heavy, painful work. Looking at the bodies, the bosun found it harder by the minute; the realisation of his loss squeezed his chest. He gave his last orders, put off a mountain of questions until later, and tried to hold on to whatever calm was left. He was near a heart attack. He had soaked up the whole of the day's horror like a sponge and let none of it out, and he did not know it. Alone in his cabin he did not even try to sleep. Before his eyes was one picture: Vrublevsky dishevelled, and the old man dead. He ordered that the course should not be changed, that no one should enter the wheelhouse, and that the ship should keep seven or eight knots. That was a fatal mistake. They obeyed him. No one

wanted to go into the wheelhouse anyway; superstition had got into the men's heads.

And the ship began to breed another danger: rumour and accusation. Someone saw fit to say that the bosun had not killed the first officer for nothing; why had he killed him, after all? He had not had the strength to explain, and off it went. The engine room heard, and the doctor heard, and fainted for the second time that day. Luckily the bosun did not know, or there might have been more bodies.

The fact of the killing had been taken calmly enough at first, but the night made everything worse. They should have kept together. The master had been close to all of them, and his loss went deep. They were not children, one would have said. They turned out to be children after all. Quietly, secretly, they decided to go on "remembering." Three sailors had noticed the bottles sticking out of the wooden case under a piece of sailcloth, and the case was opened. Some *curaçao* from the Zlokazov brothers' distillery in Yekaterinburg dulled their grief and their vigilance. Even the stokers got some. Only one of the senior seamen did not join in, and he could not stand against the rest. They did not drink a great deal; they even set some aside for the next evening and hid it carefully. As it turned out, not for nothing.

And the bosun's heart was breaking. A severe attack took away his consciousness at about three in the morning, while those idiots were deceiving him, and he needed their help.

The *Helvetia* wandered about the endless Gulf of Alaska. Her last reliable position had been fixed two days earlier, a lamentable negligence in such weather. After her list she had righted herself. The taboo on the wheelhouse held.

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The bosun came round only in the sick bay. In the morning they had knocked at his door for a long time, wanting orders, and after searching the whole ship they decided to break it open. The keys, luckily, were kept by the purser, who was almost the only man aboard who was not a sailor at all: a minor clerk, the lowest of the fourteen ranks, supplied by the government of the Amur Land, a failure in life who had nevertheless one great advantage over ordinary people, an ability to concentrate entirely on whatever was his job. The bosun lay on

the floor in a strange position. He was alive, and everyone was overjoyed. They carried him straight to the sick bay.

Imagine the doctor's face when, after the day before, they brought him the newly made acting master, unconscious, and of a strange colour.

"What's wrong with him? What is it with you lot? Something every day."

"We don't know. We went to him, he didn't open, he seemed alive, we listened. Maybe his heart, after yesterday. He's bluish, or greenish, or is it your light?"

"No, he's like that. We'll see."

With smelling salts the doctor brought him round, slowly. The bosun mumbled something, as if in a fever. He was very weak and in pain; his face twisted with it. In the night he had had something like a heart attack and a small stroke. What could anyone diagnose in those days? Practically nothing. He could not put two words together. His tongue would not obey him, and he understood words badly too, nodding strangely, as if each nod cost him enormous effort.

The doctor was not a doctor in the true sense of the word. He had been signed on as ship's doctor almost by force, to save people from small troubles. He had bandages, neat spirit, a few mixtures and herbs. He had nothing for this, and no one to ask. Only at dinner time did it occur to him that there might be real doctors among the passengers, and then he spent a long time ashamed, wondering how to admit his own incompetence. *We must have a consilium*, he thought, remembering a forgotten word from his youth.

Sailors went round the dining room and the saloons asking anyone with any connection to medicine to come to the sick bay. There were such people, and they came at once. The doctor explained, and showed them the bosun. Their conclusions did not comfort him.

"There is nothing here that can help him. He will have a fatal apoplexy, a haemorrhage, very soon. A stroke, and the beginning of a heart attack. I don't know how to help."

"Nor do I. I'm very sorry. The man has simply been unlucky. It's acute, and while he was unconscious something irreversible happened."

"Surgery is impossible here, and wouldn't help. Prepare for the worst. I think it is a matter of a day."

"What happened to him? Had he had some shock? Heart attacks before?"

"Gentlemen, I know nothing and can say nothing. Thank you for your time. Please leave. This man was... is... our bosun."

The doctors lost their rather cheerful mood, which had come with the easing of the weather. The storm was losing its grip at last. But the foul weather had moved aboard.

The passengers began to talk about the master's strange absence from his usual greeting in the morning, or at least at dinner. At supper, which drew a crowd for the first time in three days, there was no greeting either. His odd first officer did not come, nor did the sailors. The passengers were left to look after themselves; nobody had time for them.

At five in the afternoon the bosun died. The agony was short, with a sharp blow to the head and the heart. The doctor wept. How hard it is to know that you cannot help. Before he died the bosun had a beautiful dream: a field of strawberries, borzoi hounds playing with him, a little boy, and his grandfather calling him over. He went to him. And gave up the ghost.

"What's going on? This is beyond everything," said the sailors.

"May the earth lie light on them all..."

It seemed that when they opened the door of the store where the boys had been found, an evil spirit had been let loose on the ship to avenge the innocent children: Pandora's box, out of which every misfortune flew. The evening of the eighteenth of October killed the spirit of the crew completely. They drank everything there was, including the medical spirit cut with drinking water. Nobody wanted to do anything. The crew sank into apathy and fear. Their whole command had died strange deaths, and sheep without shepherds scatter. Only the stokers worked, the unrelieved slaves of the furnace; the duty of shovelling coal kept them from sinking into their grief.

The one senior seaman who had been the bosun's friend for fifteen years thought, now that he had drunk, of the small heart attacks his friend had shrugged off, ten of them at least, and blamed himself. It was snot poured down a deep well. Everything had happened as it had happened. Tomorrow they must bury them all, decently and as soon as possible. The dead needed nothing more, and neither did the living. Everyone agreed to settle everything in the morning, with clear heads: the command, the navigation, the wireless. For now, sleep, sleep, sleep.

Night came quickly. In those latitudes the days were shortening fast.

And meanwhile the steamer was coming right up to the shore. Seven or eight miles were left. She had been running for a long time more than seventy degrees off her course, and nobody aboard could see it, though the land was beginning to show. Everyone was asleep. The first more or less normal night

had sent almost everyone into the kingdom of sleep, except the everlasting stokers.

A sharp blow, forward. The bow struck a rock nobody had seen, a single stack standing out of the sea. The clocks in the cabins and the wheelhouse stopped with the shock.

At eight knots, with a following wind that made it ten or twelve, in pitch darkness, the moon hidden by cloud, the *Helvetia* met the new day. The blow went on and on. The ship was trying to go through the rock. Her plates split at once, and then it got worse. Better if she had run aground on a shoal, but the shore here was still deep. A collision with an iceberg or a rock is nearly always death for an ordinary steamer without armour. If anyone had been in the wheelhouse, if only... But the steering had already failed, and the people had failed too. Even at half a mile, in that darkness, against a rock as black as the night, they could not have turned away without three points of helm.

Everyone woke at the same instant. The engine room reacted at once, going full astern without any order, for there was no one to give it. The drunken sailors were sober in a moment. The forward part of the *Helvetia* held mainly stores, but some cabins too. What had happened there they only learned fully much later. In those seconds they understood only that they had lost the ship. Sailors ran to sound the siren, and three of them were in the wheelhouse within twenty seconds, trying on their own authority, without the qualifications, to turn her. She no longer answered. The steering gear was a toy, an empty shell. The screw turned in reverse, braking her.

The passengers were in a panic. They needed someone to lead them, and there was no one. The most sober man aboard took charge, a sailor named Katyshev, once a midshipman on a river steamer, now a senior seaman. Nobody voted; there was no time. Forty seconds after the impact the loudspeakers asked the passengers not to panic and to gather in the dining room within two or three minutes. From the wheelhouse they could see the bow turning to mush before their eyes.

Going astern did not catch up with the ship's dying. There was only one thing to do: lower the boats. The shore was clearly visible now, to starboard. The weeping of the passengers, the tearing of steel plates. The ship ground into the rock for twenty-five feet, thirty, thirty-five, and stopped. She stopped just in time; beyond that lay the parts of her that kept her alive. The first cargo hold was simply gone. The engine room had won those two minutes, and it was a very good result. Water began to pour into the holds. The stokers did not yet

understand it, but in three minutes men came for them, and they climbed up. The secret of survival in such a moment is to get away from the bottom and away from the point of impact.

About two hundred people crowded into the dining room, which meant chaos. Ladies and gentlemen with children in their arms, big and small. The crush was so great that the children could have been killed. Katyshev went to the loudspeaker and told them to be quiet and listen to the sailors. Meanwhile the lights went out in third class, a short circuit no doubt, from water in the cargo spaces where the wiring ran; and soon, as if on cue, the lights began to fail in second class too, the largest.

It was hard to lower the boats, and harder to get people into them. The poor people resisted being saved; they had remembered something they had left behind. Nobody had told them to take everything. A ship in such a case has not hours to live, but tens of minutes. No dogs, no cats; some people, fleeing in hysterics, forgot their pets in their grief. Nothing foolish, only warm clothes, as light as possible, if they had any. The sailors had never lowered this ship's boats before, and had to learn on the living. The first time went badly. There were no rules. Everyone went into the boats except the crew, men, women and children, packed as tight as they would go. The water was coming. Some of the sailors searched the cabins for people who had not heard, looking everywhere, even the latrines. They wanted to save everyone. There was a great deal of screaming, too much panic, distracting from hard work that needed concentration. Lowering a boat is the work of many heads and hands, with its own machinery, and this was not a drill. And there were gentlemen on their knees weeping, begging for their whole family and their friends to be put in one boat, not understanding that those same relatives were standing on the other side of the panicking queue.

The ship began to settle, slowly but surely. It was very cold, as if snow were near. The passengers were a dreadful sight, dressed every which way, and all of it idiotic: underwear with a magnificent fur coat thrown over it, which made a person enormous and took up twice the room in a boat; suitcases, hastily packed or never unpacked since the quay. The crew suddenly understood that there would not be enough boats for everyone.

Would there be time for a boat to come back for a second load? Hardly. The shore was six or seven miles off, and who would row? Peaceful people, most of whom had never sat in a boat in their lives. Two hours to get there, and that one way.

The first hundred people were "loaded," yes, like dead weight, like coral covered with barnacles, in ten minutes. The ship rolled heavily from side to side. A vile wind cut through everything. There would not be enough boats, the crew concluded drily. With four hundred aboard, the boats would take two hundred and fifty at best. There were lifebuoys, a few, but in water like that they would only prolong dying. Why so few boats? Simply because the ship had been designed for three hundred passengers, and when she was enlarged nobody thought to add more, and then a revised plan raised her capacity by a quarter. The greed of the builders had destroyed the one thing that mattered, safety. And why speak of a second-rate steamer, when ten years before the whole world had learned what happened to the *Titanic*, in the North Atlantic, in April, in much the same weather, and with even fewer boats for her people? Here it was carelessness. What did it matter now?

One after another, the sailors understood their fate, and looked with tears in their eyes at the people still left. Could they wait it out on the rock? No. The stone villain, shaped like a giant stalagmite, would give no foothold to anyone; and the bow was crumbling so that a chasm had opened between the rock and what was left of the plating. Two sailors went forward along the deck to look. No, definitely not.

The ship was going down. Water reached the engine room, and soon the lights went out altogether. It was the twenty-eighth minute. Her wound gave her no chance; the four-hundred-ton ballast tank pulled her down. Three in the morning. In each boat several men were rowing, fighting the waves. Thank God the storm had eased; at force four one could live, even in a wooden shell like that. The boats drew away from the dying creature towards the shore. The unaccustomed work went better than one might have expected, after a few false strokes. The tenth boat went. The twelfth, the fourteenth, the sixteenth. In the forty-seventh minute the ship shuddered; the water was pulling her in. She had already sunk some thirty feet. The boats were more and more crowded, and there was a great risk of putting everyone in them in mortal danger. The last boat was filled with tears.

The fifty-third minute. More than a hundred people on deck, of every age. A three-minute pause. The sailors could not bring themselves to say there were no more boats. But the passengers already understood. No, there was one more: the crew's own small boat. A great argument about who should take it. The sailors decided to put in it the men who had distinguished themselves most in the rescue, and the passengers still aboard agreed; there were no children

left on the ship. They offered it to the two senior seamen and to the former midshipman, whose quick wits had decided so much.

The youngest of the crew went up to Katyshev and said:

"Our one law is to save the passengers. But you've earned your rescue too. Don't waste a minute. We'll wait for you all to come back; I believe we'll all live. The *Helvetia*'s still alive."

"The law in the Land of Magnolias is like iron. When it comes out of the furnace, you can't touch it with your finger, and an hour later you can sit astride it. I will not get into a boat while there's a single passenger here."

"You're wasting time. Get in. You'll help them over there. There's not one of us with them. They need you there."

"No, and no again. Stop tormenting me. Don't waste time. Into the boat, quick, yes, you, and you, and you..."

"I'm with Pyotr," said another. "I refuse too. Get in, people. It'll be all right. We believe in you."

Heroes are not braver than other people. Their courage simply lasts five minutes longer.

They watched the last boat go with heavy eyes, but they understood it was better this way than to blame themselves all their lives for the deaths of strangers, and of animals, and of other creatures. The sailors did not even look for lifebuoys. There were none left; the few there had been were rotten.

The boats drew away. The first of them were a full mile off now. People prayed, wept, laughed and remembered their lives. Nobody wanted to look back towards the shore. One passenger threw himself into the sea, thinking he could save himself. He did not. It was terrible to watch. He died in about four minutes. The water was too cold.

At five forty-two by the ship's time, the *Helvetia* drew her last breath and went quickly to the bottom. No one aboard her was saved.

A stupid collision, and the strange curse of her last three days. The master, his first officer, the bosun, the sailors and the stokers, and some of the passengers: they all stayed there for ever. Not one of those deaths was deserved, not one of them need have happened. And somehow, every one of them did.

CHAPTER EIGHT

# The Last Frontier



*And those of you who remain alive will envy the dead.*

Reaching the shore was not easy. The boats came in one after another, and the first joy, the embraces, passed quickly, because from the beach, as from the sea, there was a terrible thing to watch. Every eye kept turning towards the *Helvetia*, and at one moment the ship collapsed. Some saw it happen, a long, drawn-out fall, though the sea's last swallow took less than a minute. Others only saw what was left. But everyone felt the last wave, life's final tribute. Everyone sobbed, and most of all those who had people still aboard. Though that is wrong at the root: they were all brothers and sisters now. This was a new reality, still more frightening, fallen on their heads, forcing them to think how to survive. Nobody understood yet where they were. Their naivety, their belief that the worst was over, misled them. They would soon find a barrel of tar with a spoonful of honey in it: that way round, and not the other.

Not everyone had died aboard. Three small rafts had been put over the side a few minutes before the end, carrying eight people, among them some of the heroes of the night and some ordinary passengers. They did not float for long. Rafts knocked together from wooden crates could not take the strain, and fell apart, and the planks did not save the poor souls from the cold. And not every boat beat the waves. Two capsized, and one of them, as heavy as a lifeboat must be, came down on the people in it and buried twelve souls.

The beach was low: fine shell gravel mixed with grey earth. It was very wet, and the first steps sank in. Still dark. Raining. The empty shore offered no shelter. Behind them rose snow-covered peaks on every side; some had taken

them for a mirage from the ship. They were not. There was no one anywhere. The boats grounded, people were helped out, and the boats went back, and again. Wretched figures in sodden fur coats and short coats and overcoats, smeared with mud. Small children screaming without pause. *It's a dream. Let it be a dream.* But self-deception is worse than a bitter truth. A couple of hours ago they had been resting in their cabins, and now there was nothing left of that. It had all flown past like a fairy tale: screams, the lowering, the oars, bailing with their hands. Some had paid with their lives, and some stood here now, at the edge of the earth, not knowing who they were or what they would do. Some were thirsty, some hungry, some on their knees throwing themselves against the waves because they could not find the people they loved.

Most of them huddled together, like penguins or fur seals, in a formation like a badly drilled Roman tortoise, to keep warm. A few middle-aged men stood apart. One of them wore a khaki trench coat, the British invention that had appeared just before the Great War, and in such weather it was one of the best things a man could have on. He leaned against a boulder, one of a hundred or so in sight, and watched his pocket watch closely, as if he were waiting for someone. He waited several hours like that. Then his stern face changed into the face of a man struck down by grief, lost in everything and for ever. In front of everyone he gave up. He had not, it seemed, lived to see his love come ashore. He flung the watch against the boulder with all his strength, walked down to the water and went into it, with a quick step, like a tin soldier. It took only twelve paces to reach a depth over his head. He drowned quietly, but in front of everyone.

By ten in the morning women and some of the men were beating themselves in hysterics against the shore. They could not understand where their relatives were, who had been coming here in a boat just like theirs. Nobody had seen it capsize, though it was three hours ago now. Three women wanted to follow the grey man into the sea, but this time they were not allowed; they beat their heads, waved their arms, fought and sobbed a few yards from the water's edge. Time passed, and their feet would not take them anywhere. They were utterly lost.

Then, for the first time in all those terrible days, the sun came out. It did them good. They had found themselves on some unknown planet, and a ray of light seemed to show them that home was not so far away, that they must gather their strength and work out how to go on.

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A professor and his wife, understanding how heavy the situation was and how hard a crowd is to move, gathered people round them in a kind of *veche*, an old Magnolian assembly. It looked odd and unpractised. But the diffuse crowd began to turn into a structured group, a horseshoe. Every hysteria, every feeling, good or bad, needs feeding, and usually there is only enough for one outburst; then it passes. The children's tears dried, the women calmed down a little, the men stopped having to hold back their loved ones. The soberest heads seized the moment. They had to save themselves: walk while they had strength, get somewhere, and see that not one of those who had survived here died for nothing, for the sake of those who stayed below in the cabins of the drowned *Helvetia*.

They talked. At first everyone made speeches, which is not the same as talking. Then it turned into real conversation, endless remarks, and that warmed them and gave them a reserve of resistance. When you think, you find a solution.

Some of our old acquaintances did rather well, most of whom had kept their lives thanks to others' deaths. The undercover Bolsheviks proved very hardy. Semyon Semyonovich Neglasov, perhaps the most cheerful of them all, proposed going along the shore: in northern latitudes, as in the Land of Magnolias, settlements were most often on the banks of rivers and seas.

"I'll be brief. My view is this: we go along the shore. The narrow strip of beach will save us. You see the mountains; there's snow on them, so judge their height for yourselves. I don't think we could get over them. And we have no other choice."

"I agree with you. I even have a map, and some guesses where we might be, very rough, but something. One of the sailors, God rest him, gave us charts before we cast off, and he gave our neighbours three rifles."

"And they gave us some food, at least. I'm very sorry for the lads. Sorry for everyone."

"Quite right. But let's find some shelter. It's impossible to stay here. Perhaps there's a grotto, or a rock face. Look, there, on the right."

"In that case give me that map. I know something of geography; I am a geologist by training and by service. And then we must count how many we are, and count everything we have," said Fyodor Alexeyevich Proskurin hoarsely,

the same man who in August had come to the professor's house in his strange jacket to announce the end.

"We were given a list of all the passengers," someone called out from the crowd.

"We need an elder, a chief, the best of us, because there are a lot of us. I've counted at least two hundred while you were talking. A big party. We need our own Moses."

"My dear man, spare us the characters from Jewish fairy tales. I've heard enough today about a saviour. Where is he? Let's have no illusions."

"How dare you! Madman! Seize the blasphemer!"

"Ha! I don't think one has to worship the figures of Sinai to be a Magnolian."

"Oh, these idiots have decided to have it out here too. I address whoever is to be our guiding star. I didn't want to waste time, but I'll say this: those two, yes, him and him, we eat first. The food won't last long, so that's my proposal."

"Alexandrushka, bite your tongue. Look what you've started, you antique blockhead. Shall I calm you down, once and for all?"

Yes, even now, perhaps because of what they had been through, some people woke to malice and aggression. It may have been the body's response to a new reality, the waking of old instincts. Looking round at the hostile, unwelcoming land, many of them wanted to tear one another to pieces from strangeness and helplessness. The weak in spirit always show their aggression at the wrong moment, while the strong keep their calculation and their kindness, for their own sake and everyone else's.

They decided hastily to hold elections and put someone in charge. Each little group (and they had formed of themselves; the boats had done that) chose its own chief, a foreman of ten, who had a voice and was responsible for the lives of his dozen. But a leader for everyone took a very long time to choose, as if in labour. The sense of being one of a great crowd, fear, self-doubt and real ignorance of what to do do not produce leaders. To run ahead: all this "organisation" soon came to nothing. The professors, stricken by the loss of thirty of their number who had not reached the shore, were no use for this; the merchants were afraid of something, and had their children to think of, and lacked the wit.

All the same, two men were found. One was a count of an old family, Povarnin, who thought himself a good hunter, a man of the Far East who had

somehow missed the first steamer and had no intention whatever of perishing here, unlike the soft-bodied people who had lost all faith that morning. Everyone knew him. He was sociable and witty. He stepped out of the grey crowd in a rich mink coat; how he had managed to put it on, God knows. It had hardly suffered, and he looked magnificent. The other was a fine, simpler fellow, just as rich, another soul of the company: Alexei Tereshchenko, formerly the owner of sugar mills in Ukraine and a patron of the arts. It was said his brother had been a minister in the Provisional Government. He was thick-skinned, and his mood had not changed. It remained calm, almost contemptuous, like the mood of the members of his family who had survived with him.

Amid the dull, insulting shrieks of the gulls and cormorants, these two eagles (and Alexei had an eagle's nose) took counsel and decided to try. They were not whiners. They reckoned that rescue was a matter of a week's walk along the shore, ten days at most. All that remained was to take up the sceptre of trust, talk to the clever and the wise (which are different things), and decide where to go. They took charge painlessly and easily, with the support of every class, including the few remaining nobles and the petty bourgeoisie. Tereshchenko proposed forming a gendarmerie of strong men, just in case, for the defence of the tribe, or the herd. The vote was listless and almost unanimous. The sheep wanted a fire, warm clothes and forgetfulness as soon as possible.

The count took the sodden passenger list, looked a long time for a pen, found none, found instead a lump of something black, a bit of coal from the dead ship perhaps, and began to tick off who was there and who was not. It took a long time. With the crew and the Petropavlovsk men, the list ran to nearly four hundred. Each time no one answered, the count said "Dead," and each time the crowd sighed. Even their great longing to sit down, even on cold, unpleasant stones, gave way to the wish to know how many of them were left.

Two hundred and thirty-four people, a couple of cats and a dozen dogs. The hedgehog had not survived. It was lost with its mistress.

Many of them had read a great many books, and found themselves facing the beginning of a real fight for survival, without the disgustingly false romance of literature. Ships do not sink beautifully, according to the rules of drama, and people die not in noble sacrifice but like flies, in ordinary turn. Justice was not the trump card here. *Who's quickest wins.* And whoever keeps moving wins twice. What the shore lacked most at that moment were people with initiative. That, after all, was the whole secret of the Bolsheviks' success: they were not tired of life, unlike the jaded, satiated, broken intelligentsia.

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By a curious chance, these passengers had come ashore on land that had belonged, until very recently, to their own country. The day before, exactly fifty-five years earlier, on the eighteenth of October 1867, at Novo-Arkhangelsk, the capital of Magnolian America, which the Americans called Sitka, the double-headed eagle had been lowered and the Stars and Stripes raised in its place. The flag had caught on the halyard as it came down, and a sailor had to climb up to free it; one of the Magnolian ladies fainted. The Tlingit chiefs watched from their canoes. They had never been asked, and they said afterwards that the Magnolians had sold what had never been theirs to sell. The Magnolians had held Sitka by force since 1804, when they shelled the Tlingit fort, and for sixty years they did not dare go far beyond their stockade.

But was this Alaska? Or Canada already? A few geographers studied the two maps that the dying sailors had pushed into the passengers' hands, and concluded that the wreck lay somewhere in south-eastern Alaska, the Panhandle, because further south the coast broke up into an endless archipelago of islands, large and small, like a shattered pot, and here it did not. For almost six hundred miles the Pacific had broken the Canadian coast into a maze of channels that reminded me, for some reason, of the Volga delta at Astrakhan. Was that maze to the south of their empty beach, or to the north? That remained to be found out.

The cardinal points were easy. Moss grows on the north side of every boulder. And besides, which way is north? Turn your head, look a little above your own height, and there, very close, lay the everlasting ice. The geographers knew they had passed the Aleutians, so the worst possibility, the far west of Alaska, which meant certain death, could be ruled out. The passengers, mercifully, did not know enough to fear it. In any case, the whole of this land had no cities, no railways, none of the signs of progress. Put your finger anywhere on the map of the north of this continent and you will find a bear before you find a man, just as on the Magnolian side, thousands of miles to the west.

Around noon the rain stopped at last, though heavy cloud still hung over that cursed rock, which they could now see in every detail. Behind them the land rose steeply into a mountain chain, the Coast Range probably, or its northernmost part, the tail of the Cordilleras, which run for nearly nine thousand kilometres; a bad joke, when one might have met them so much

further south. There were no compasses. They chose to go towards what they took to be north, along the shore, because the map showed many waterways to the south, and fewer to the north. One geographer was quite sure they were not on an island, and that helped. Or perhaps they could go along the coast in the boats, which were still sound, until the next tide carried them away? Oars against legs? Debatable.

But before anything else, they decided to spend the night here, still hoping for those who had stayed aboard. Perhaps they would come in by themselves, or on rafts.

And there was something just as important to do: bring together everything of value, everything that might help, from spare clothes to maps and food. It went hard. People did not want to give up what the doomed had given them, the bags and bundles the sailors had loaded onto them by the pood. At least a third of them were holding things that did not belong to them. But with some sadness, these tight-fisted people, who suddenly understood that they had nothing else but these strange things and the clothes on their backs, gave them up, or rather set them down honourably on a patch of ground between the boulders. Everything that had been one's own became common property. Dispossession before it became the fashion? No: an entirely correct step.

While people sat round waiting for a miracle, for semolina to fall from heaven at least, twenty volunteers sorted through the heap for what was most needed, starting with the simplest thing, containers, which were the real shortage; people were thirsty, and they would at least have to boil sea water. Two hundred and more mouths wanting everything, the bare minimum of everything.

What had they? Oil and paraffin lamps, fuses, wooden and iron boxes, whatever had been in front of the sailors' eyes. A can of water. Boxes of unknown contents and a great many strange things. A couple of dozen shovels. A few small boxes of cartridges for the Mosin rifles. Someone even found a bundle of kindling splints. But no chocolate, no coffee, no tobacco, nothing that could brighten life. Yes, and a suitcase which turned out to be full of ordinary dry sand. Not a single match. But two poods or so of fat, perhaps the very whale oil itself, or some strange mutton fat, certainly not pork, in paper bricks. Knives enough. Sacks of grain of uncertain origin. And that was about all.

The boats were hauled up by twenty people at a time, men and women both, not because of the weight but because the band of half-water, half-sand between sea and land sucked at them. Nobody trusted the good will of the Gulf

of Alaska. Meanwhile a third group, young men chosen on the advice of a grey-haired man who looked like an old artilleryman and was still as strong as one, went scouting. Staying on the beach, open to every wind, was no idea at all, and the sugar king looked at the scrubby wood above the shore and sent the young ones, who had strength and speed, to run up and look. It would warm them, too; they were not dressed for the weather. Most of the baggage worth having had been in the holds, and had gone down with the ship: the dresses and furs and silver that had been loaded so hastily in Vladivostok so that the daughters of Red commissars should never wear them. Believe it or not, some people had brought samovars, and even musical instruments that had once cost as much as a dozen serfs.

Darkness came quickly. Autumn was in full swing. The boys came back: they must move into the wood, two hundred metres up. The baggage was too much to drag, so guards were left with it and one rifle, and everyone else took what looked like food, and the other two rifles. The climate changed with every step. Everything was very wet, but there were many small trees one could make something out of, after depriving them of life. Nobody wanted to sleep on wet ground at five or seven degrees above freezing, or worse. Evergreens ruled: silver firs, spreading cedars, lush pines, Douglas firs of incredible height. The broad-leaved trees were fewer than they had seemed from the shore.

They needed to make a camp, to boil sea water and mix it with their small store of fresh, to cook something, they hardly knew what, in they hardly knew what. For five people one could manage; for two hundred? And first one had to light a fire. It was full dark now. The wind was rising again, straight at their backs. The fire would not catch, for anyone. There was a fight over water: somebody had taken one of the small cans and emptied it. But who? A group raged, looking for those who cared nothing for other people's thirst.

Prometheus brought fire to men, and was chained to a rock for it, and an eagle ate his liver. Tonight there was no fire. A few children were given the water, by the grace of a few lonely lords. Food was eaten dry, in pitch darkness, without even a half-moon. Strangely, the forest did not come alive at night. No owls, no hunters of the dark; the ornithologists were upset by the silence. Perhaps this place was poor in prey, or the weather or the people had frightened everything away. No wolves or foxes either, all night. I believe such a great travelling circus could have frightened off elephants and the spirits of the rock, so much noise did it make, with what strength it had left and its parched

mouths, sorting out simple things, quarrelling, weeping, laughing as usual and in the fits of a few neurasthenics, and squeaking.

The appetite for command faded, because the obedient people who had seemed so eager to be led turned out to be unmanageable, and not all of them were happy to live as one big family. People divided by acquaintance, by social standing, by other measures. And yet their cowardice, their fear of being alone, would not let them leave the anthill. There was a small group who loved to watch this sorting, the odd gentlemen like our anthropologist with his notebook, and others like him, happy owners of uncleaned monocles. Some had lost their glasses; some had glasses so fogged they could not see through them, and they were too squeamish to wash them in the salt water.

In twelve or fifteen hours, at least four cultures had formed. One set about the work of survival. A second, quite large, stood aside, or took part only under compulsion. A third was made of people broken by fate, who had lost all their strength. And a fourth was made of open misfits.

Some fifty or sixty people did anything useful, gathering brushwood and boughs. They had found their leaders without giving up their own opinions. Round them, in rings, as in a tribe, lay everyone else on broken branches laid out like mats. Finding decent branches among all those needles was not easy, and nobody wanted to lie on another source of pain, even through the skin of dead animals, as their heavy, sodden coats were. Fire appeared in three paraffin lamps, but could not be passed to the piles of wood where people waited for warmth. Everything was too wet, the air included.

Then the sky closed over, and the rain came, slanting, heavy and warm, warmer at least than the morning's. But now and then a frosty chill broke through from behind; the glaciers in the mountains added their share, and made a strange contrasting shower. The cleverest took shelter between the pines, but there were few good places. Those under the yellowing larches fared worse. The squall kept trying to tear off a bit of tree, bend it, pull it out and carry off anything that lay loose. The forest hissed and whistled. If only there had been a shaman with a drum to calm the angry weather. The second act of the end of the world was beginning, with organ and brass, cutting short a lovely, if tragic, interval. The guards on the beach had it worst. The water was rising; it was no danger to them, but it was to the boats. In any case, after the first act of this madness at sea, the idea of the boats was finished. It would be better to go inland than to wait by the sea for the weather. They would have to

decide in the morning. Meanwhile, get wet, freeze, don't sleep, catch the drops in your palms and drink, drink, drink.

No one could sleep. How could anyone, when a branch fell on his face and needles came down from a great height like darts, through clothes and all, and something crawled over his body, or seemed to? The night was long, too long. Watches were useless now. No one needed to know the time, and as for using their glass to make fire, as Archimedes, Lucian tells us, burned the Roman fleet at Syracuse with mirrors, there was no sun to do it with. They drank the rain greedily, as if trying to swallow the whole downpour and stay dry. If the ocean had been fresh, they would have drunk it dry, and I do not exaggerate.

The doctors nodded at one another, knowing what was coming: colds at least, pneumonia, hunger, and a great many other troubles. There was never a more disgusting dinner than the only meal of that day: a handful of coarse-ground porridge of some sort, passed carefully from wet hand to wet hand. Distributing it in the dark was a terrible sight. With difficulty they lit the "icon lamps," and people queued at them for something to stop their stomachs eating themselves. The young took hunger most easily, the old, strangely, worst, and the children worst of all. The moment they received those ten zolotniks of coarse wheat grits was the best moment of the whole time. Whatever inhuman trials were only beginning, and they all knew it, people began to help one another, sharing the last of what they had.

There were tears. Some remembered the hungry years of their youth, and of quite recent times. They had not escaped a Magnolian version of Victorian morality, but there were people among them who had been truly poor, and had lived through the tsar's famines. The empire that supposedly fed everyone had not stopped the hunger of 1891, or 1901, or 1906, or 1911, which struck dozens of provinces. Not everyone here came from the capital. The Reds never imagined that the bourgeois had suffered too. And what bourgeois? Of the two hundred survivors, not more than a third were rich nobles and merchants. The rest were an ordinary middle class, as it was before the war. Need I remind you what kind of family Mendeleyev came from? Nearly half the scholars here were peasants' sons, and they remembered the rule of every grain from their childhood.

"The Magnolian peasant cannot afford meat, eggs, butter, milk, often even cabbage, and lives on black bread and potatoes," the Irish journalist Emile Dillon had written. "Lives, you ask? He dies for lack of them." And one of the tsar's last ministers of agriculture, Naumov, had admitted: "The Land of Magnolias has never really emerged from famine, now in one province, now

in another, before the war and during it." In the normal year 1906 the official "physiological minimum" of fourteen poods of grain a year was not reached in two hundred and thirty-five districts with forty-four million people. The peasants no longer complained that they ate bread made with goosefoot and chaff. They complained that there was no white bread to make a teat for a baby.

So they ate, greedily swallowing the plain mush, and some managed to get two portions, and nobody judged them; nobody could see. In one place they gave out buckwheat. Families stood bent over, holding their children and one another by the hand so as not to get lost, leaning against the trees to take the force of the wind.

The diaries stopped. The urge to write grew, among those used to recording their days in rapturous detail, but why had anyone brought a diary into a lifeboat? Perhaps that night, still half asleep, they thought there would be a show on deck to be recorded at once. Now the notebooks were not even fit to light a fire, being wet, and in any case their owners would not have allowed it. A pocket notebook and a cross were the only sacred things left, part of the body, more precious than clothes or anything they had given up.

It was frightening to look up, and there was nothing to look at. No stars; another way to fix their position cut off. Some of them had studied astronomy once, as part of geography, but even if they had recognised Antares it would not have shown them where they were on the map.

People kept moving deeper into the trees, looking for better shelter. The wind and the rain made excellent shepherds. If only they could have been tamed.

People began to embrace one another again, after the tense evening and the first half of the night, when it had seemed to be each for himself. Drunk on grain and rain, they began to behave as they had that morning, when the shock and the panic had given way to relief that their feet were on solid ground, even sunk to the knees. Then had come the second wave, no less heavy: waiting for a saviour who did not come, and the foul weather, and the taste of mud on their lips, and hunger, and the search for water. No one is made for suffering and want.

It began to grow light. The first day of their new life was ending, a life with no memory in it. The books they had read to tatters were no help, not Dostoevsky, not Kant, not Wilde, and certainly not any of the poets. And if novels were no help, neither was science: it could not make warmth out of

nothing. No rescuers came. There was no village of kind, Magnolian-speaking villagers. This was another continent. Americans, someone said, have no *good* and *bad* they have *works* and *doesn't work*.

The sun was trying to break through the veil of fear. The warm rain had brought another helping of thunder. Lightning struck not far off, always in the water, where the ship had gone down. The *Helvetia*, as it happened, had only finally disappeared with the coming of night, when the top of her mainmast went under and she slid off the small rocky cushion she had come to rest on and vanished for ever. If she had been only a little larger she would have stuck. The guards on the beach, frightened by the lightning, ran for the wood, taking only the rifles. A strange idea, to run from lightning across open ground. Alaska, in the autumn especially, is not a land of thunderstorms. But this weather had been born near Hawaii at the end of September and had wandered slowly north-east, cheating the natural order of the ocean and bringing summer storms to the north. Twelve flashes, and the hellish ugliness wore itself out. The rain did not, nor the wind.

The things hidden among the boulders had been flooded; the ground there drank less than in the forest, and pools had formed, five or ten inches deep. The guards were given some hastily made soup and told to stay for the council. Those who had lived through the night could hardly speak, but slowly the discussion, driven by the wish to live, reached its climax. They would not walk into the wind, back the way they had come. Nobody wanted to drown, and the height of the waves made it plain that there could be no talk of boats. As for the things: sort out what was needed, give it out by need, which, given that the choice was limited to shovels and half-empty suitcases full of nonsense, was quickly done; and set off. The whole camp.

There was no time to mourn the dead. The tears were already coming. The cynical notebook the count had carried, in which the dead had been struck out with that lump of black stone for the sake of those who now looked at him, went at the head of the fading columns. Trampled earth, a few damaged trees, a fireplace that had never been a fire, some rubbish: that was all they left.

Quietly, step by step, they began to walk with the wind, not trying to keep up with it. The wind at their backs did not trouble them; it drove them on like a whip. After a short argument the column was divided into two lines, some forty yards apart. The same men commanded both. The strongest men brought up the rear, as everyone advised, and the weakest walked in the middle. Should they have gone along the shore after all? They had thought of it, and

at first decided for it; but walking across the wind seemed worse than walking with it. They promised to come back to the idea once they had climbed a little. Nobody spoke of crossing the high mountains. But it seemed likely that higher up the wind would drop.

CHAPTER NINE

# Aquilon's Hunt



*When you do not know where you are going, every step seems right.*

Several old travellers said so at once, men who had clambered over half the Caucasus in their youth. But these mountains were nothing like those, in either their shape or their lie.

"If we go on like this, and the wind off the sea doesn't drop, nor this filthy wet, we should try over there and cross there; that'll be our pass. It's low, and the forest's green, not like on the right. I'm afraid this rain may bring snow after it. And we've no fire and no game. We need a reckoning. Are there any hunters here?"

"Mikhail Panteleyevich can't hear. I'll tell him; it's hard to talk over your shoulder."

"Oh, get away. What did you call me for? I can hear, but I'm not going to turn round for a voice; the people behind will trample me if I stop. We said we'd talk at the halt. And what hunters now? I'm your hunter. Hold the rifle steady."

"All right. Later."

Talking in that formation, it turned out, was almost impossible.

The first three hundred feet went quickly and well, despite the thick wood. Everything is relative. The good thing was that as the ground grew less exposed it grew less sodden: for the first hundred paces at the foot of the range the mud fought every step, but after an hour's walking the earth turned surprisingly dry. The undergrowth of northern cedars and small white pines gave way, with every yard, to pine, or rather some close cousin of it that the local experts could not name, and to hemlocks, a tree whose botanical name, *Tsuga*, comes

from the Japanese. Hemlock needles hold three to five times as much vitamin C as orange juice. Nobody aboard knew that yet; one day it would matter. There were no sequoias here, and no poplars, which told them that they were nowhere near Vancouver; but it was not tundra either.

The theft of the water the night before could not be ignored. It was impossible to find the culprit now; they were not in a laboratory but in a landscape that changed with every step, and looking back, settling scores, hunting victims and culprits, would be short-sighted. But a hard rule had to be laid down for the future: *steal, and you lose the right to live*. They agreed on it in whispers, breaking ranks a little, and resolved to announce the new order at the next halt. It was a long way off.

Among the rearguard walked our three envoys. Only their chief, Semyon Semyonovich, was in any kind of spirits. The other two had turned in a day into neurotic creatures, cursing every grain of this earth, which was not sunny Los Angeles but some taiga on a foreign continent. They had been lucky in one respect: their "wards" were, amazingly, still alive, though the watchers did not find this out at once. And after so many misfortunes, nobody much wanted to play at spies any more. Their papers, soaked and unpresentable among the spruce, were of no use to anyone. Neuter-Bogodukhov raged worst of all and could not calm down, and a heretical thought crept into Semyon's head. He detested behaviour of that kind and thought it a sign of great feeblemindedness. He would have liked to be rid of the fool. But there was Roman Mikhailovich, Neuter's friend, the only one of them using his real name. And they all understood that swatting a fly while you are up to your shoulders in a bog only makes the bog worse. One must resign oneself and walk where one was led; or, if one did not care for that, walk alone and feed oneself, and perhaps reach Moscow on foot.

None of them knew that they were not very far from one of the chief outposts of this coast, a place marked on no map they had and in no one's head: Yakutat. Have you heard of it? A small fishing village a hundred versts or less to the north, which by the standards of the American north counted as a centre of civilisation. The Magnolians had come there in 1796 under Baranov, built a little stockade and a settlement called Novorossiysk, or Slavorossiya, a hut and two storehouses, and settled it with convicts and with Aleut hunters brought from far to the west. In the first winter many of the colonists died of scurvy. In 1805 the Tlingit, whose country it was and who had been watching the newcomers hunt out their sea otters, burned the fort and killed most of the

people in it. The Magnolians never came back. The name, in Tlingit, means something like *the place where canoes rest*.

To the south, practically out of reach, lay Sitka, the old Novo-Arkhangelsk, the capital of Magnolian Alaska and then, until 1906, of American Alaska too, until Juneau took its place. Could Yakutat have saved them? Hardly. It had a few hundred people, half of them natives, and the whole band of shipwrecked Magnolians was a moving town by the standards of this coast.

That emptiness was the reason Alaska had been sold. The Crimean War had shown Petersburg that it could not defend thousands of versts of coast with a few hundred men against the British in Canada, or the Americans if they cared to come; better to sell than to lose it for nothing. The Land of Magnolias had millions of square versts of empty taiga and tundra of its own. Muravyov-Amursky, the governor-general of Eastern Siberia, said plainly that the Land of Magnolias could never hold it. The figures bear him out. The Magnolians in Alaska numbered six to eight hundred; there were about nineteen hundred Creoles, children of Magnolian fathers and native mothers, and not quite five thousand Aleuts, all that was left of them. And there were forty thousand Tlingit, who had never considered themselves subjects of the tsar, and fought him. Between 1802 and 1805 they burned two Magnolian forts and killed some fifty Magnolians; half a century later they tried to storm Novo-Arkhangelsk itself. The empire's America was a few stockades on a hostile shore, held by the grace of the people who lived there.

And the Anglo-Saxons were in no hurry to live in such a place either, unless something here could enrich their homes in warm Pennsylvania or hot Florida.

And yet men had fought over this land, or rather argued over it, in courtrooms thousands of miles away. Look at Alaska on any map, at the narrow strip it holds, like a horn, along the coast to the south. The Land of Magnolias and Britain had agreed in 1825 on how the border was to be drawn, but not where. In 1839 the Magnolian-American Company leased the coast to the Hudson's Bay Company in exchange for grain and furs. When the Americans bought Alaska in 1867, the boundary was still a matter of guesswork. Nobody cared until the Klondike gold rush of 1897 and 1898 brought thirty thousand people and more into the country, and a hundred thousand through it, mostly Americans, and suddenly everyone wanted to know whose the ports were. Canada wanted a way to the sea for the Yukon. A tribunal of six sat in London in 1903, three Americans, two Canadians and one British judge, and the British judge sided with the Americans. The Canadians refused to sign. The Yukon

was left without a coast, and Canadians never quite forgave London. "So long as Canada remains a dependency of the British Crown," said their prime minister, Laurier, "the present powers which we have are not sufficient for the maintenance of our rights." And so our castaways stood, though they did not know it, on land that had been American beyond dispute for barely twenty years.

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The rain had stopped, but the wind shook enough water from the branches of the green beauties to make it seem as if it had not. The spray got into their eyes and hid the ground at their feet. If you bent double and shielded your brow with something, you got less of it, and tired faster. And the ground was changing. Under the carpet of fallen needles (yes, evergreens shed their needles too, as anyone knows who has ever crawled out of the comfort of the pavements into a forest, or at least into a botanical garden) the rock began to show through, in treacherous scree. The slope steepened. The brisk pace fell apart into constant stumbling. Their legs were tired, though they had gone no more than seven hundred paces, and more along than up.

Then the slope eased off, but it had already cost several dozen people the use of their legs, with sprains and fractures great and small. In such a place, to lose the power to walk is mortal. No one will carry you; your family, yes, but not for long.

An old bachelor broke his leg, stumbling twice and then falling. Nobody helped him. They walked round him as if he were a log, some strange chimera. He tried feebly to go on, crawling more than walking, his ankle smashed and bloody. The column did not stop. Neither faith nor unbelief offered him a hand. Some children tried timidly, pushed on by their parents' great sow-like bodies. One could not afford to grow thin here, and every minute of standing still seemed a disrespectful luxury to these mighty people steeped in all the grandeur of culture, who wanted only to eat. Someone even stepped over the man, slightly wounded and alive, without giving him the chance to get up and bind his leg and walk on. Never get in the way of a herd of elephants that wants something. It is always fatal.

Only a shop assistant from a grocer's, a man rather like the injured one to look at, finally helped him. It was horrible to think that before that he had been trampled, or, more criminally, ignored. Have you ever seen a man tear up his

own greatcoat? A greatcoat was worth fifty pre-war roubles. The grocer's man tore his at once, and the strip from the right side bound the old man's ankle.

A day before, they had been saved by the kindness and self-sacrifice of people who had left this world for ever. Already no one remembered them, except where a family had been torn apart. And there were no old friendships here to hold them together. The melting pot of the evacuation had thrown together people who might have known one another by sight, Vladivostok being a small city, but who depended on no one. There were hardly any families here who had known one another for twenty years.

Someone sobbed now and then. And yet the whales who had wanted to beach themselves only yesterday, and a few of them were still left, now clenched their teeth and walked after their prophets instead of turning into motionless creatures without the will to live. No; they wanted to live after all. As soon as they were told to get up, they shook themselves and went. Their grief was driven inside for a better time. It would show itself again, no doubt, but it is better to grieve over tea with milk. The march stopped them whining. Or perhaps it was all an illusion, and the gleam in their wind-worn eyes would turn to grief. Who knows?

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By one o'clock they had made the climb. From the shore it had not looked so high. They had imagined a mountain with a proper conical top; what they reached was the edge of a high plateau, with a view.

The last hundred and fifty paces were the hardest and the richest in injuries. First, near the top, hidden among the pines, they found a mountain stream, three or four feet wide. Their first thought was joy, and a rush to drink. The rain they had caught in their hands had filled their stomachs, but it had tasted bitter and a little salt, cloudy stuff, like the nostrums sold in little bottles by quack chemists in the south as a cure for every disease of the lungs, consumption included. Even the icicles off the roof in childhood had tasted better.

The stream's treachery did not show at once, as if it wanted as many victims as possible in its grip. It was not five merry hussars with their horses who had come to drink but a whole tribe, or rather a herd. The water was perfectly clean, sullied by nothing but the feet of a few fools who had waded in, perhaps thinking the water in the middle tasted better, or was more nourishing. There were no trout or salmon in it. Alas.

The trouble began when the dirty feet began to cross. The rain had undermined the soft sandstone on the northern bank, and the slope gave way: not a dangerous slide in truth, but a rush of sliding stones that turned the people in the water into lunatics made of clay. The others leapt clear like gazelles and then, without enthusiasm, not wanting a mud bath themselves, pulled the unfortunates out. Do not take it for kindness or solidarity. It was cold calculation. You never know where you will end up yourself. The same people would walk past a grocer's man without blinking.

Then someone cried out, alone at first, and then the whole crowd took it up, howling. A small boy lay motionless in the mud. He was not buried deep, but the blow had twisted him into a strange position. He seemed to be dead. His father had been walking ahead, and had put the child down for the first time in three hours, out of tiredness, thinking perhaps that it was safer; he had slipped and started the slide, and the five-year-old had fallen with it, head first into the shallowest part of the stream. The blow to the back of his head broke his skull.

It was the first death on land, as stupid as life itself. All the other dead had last been seen alive. This was not the road that this fair-haired boy should have walked. His parents were beside themselves. The march, already numb, stopped altogether. They decided to bury him. Nobody drank any more; the stream had turned out to be a murderer. There was no priest; he had stayed aboard the *Helvetia*. There was no one who knew the rites. *It isn't right*, the women said through their tears; but there was no way to bury him properly. They begged and shouted and prayed and cursed, and dug into the ground with their little shovels, to lay the body in it without a coffin, still warm. And it seemed that such a stupid death, by no means the first, was only the prologue to a real dying-out.

The grief brought people together round it again, and, as it turned out, not for the better. The ties that bound them proved to be rotten to the core. It started with one remark in the crowd, which caught like a spark in a summer field of rye.

"Minus one," some fool summed up cynically. "And soon we'll all go. If you don't break your head, you'll eat your brother, or he'll eat you."

"This isn't skipping down the steps of Kerjean Castle, my friend," said a gentleman in a dark burgundy coat, which stood out among the others' quieter clothes.

"Well, I'm no match for you, with that suitcase of yours, which holds everything the ladies and gentlemen here are dying for. Aren't you planning an *escapade*? Or should I say *escapad'*, with a hard sign, in the old spelling?"

"I beg your pardon? Do I look like a prankster, or a runaway? Explain yourself. You've stolen a lot of words, and now you insult my honour."

"Don't you have it all, though? Plenty of tobacco! People!"

"What are you talking about? Breathed too many essential oils?"

"Calm down, you leaky heads."

"And you, you hen's spawn, shut your mouth. Go and sell your chickens; you've got above yourself completely. Look, we'll bury you soon, like that child. You are a child, only a fat one. Had you planned to come here? Why didn't you warn me, my treasure?"

"Look at yourself, you heaven-sent oaf. And you'll pay for what you said about my sister. If I had a gun, you'd be lying there, better you than that poor little one."

"Blockhead. Go for a walk. Maybe you'll fall off. Look what a lovely view."

"Stop it, you holy fools. Stop turning a funeral into a circus. My ears are wilting from your snobbery mixed with village muck."

"Look who's talking. Cross yourself, you mangy thing. You carried lice for twenty years until you got out of your filthy Kaluga. Go and feed the worms, quick, to the scaffold."

"Shut your mouth or they'll tear you apart."

"I didn't ask you. And here's some advice: don't interfere, if you call yourself my friend."

"But you're not behaving like a human being."

"And are these human beings? No, swine. She's standing there rubbing against me. I'm to perform in this mantle in New York!"

"Yes, there's your New York. If I hadn't listened to you, I wouldn't be stuck here like a donkey in a desert of snowy dreams."

"Oh, stop your mouths. I'm sick of your self-admiration."

"How funny this goat's son is. Since you've brought animals into it, I'll keep it up. Your profound ignorance of the language!"

"Never mind that. Show us your luggage and explain whether I'm a goat or a jackal. And you've got swine all round you, too. Overdone it, have you? Had too much parsley up the nose?"

"What? You great dolt. And you, shut up, all this wailing. So he died; one less to feed. You'll have another Ivan, or whatever. I see no reason for grief,

except the lack of a bottle of wine. What's this, a zoo? Bare your teeth? Go on. Plebs, rabble, lumpen."

"Look who's talking. I'm a nobleman, and what are you? An actor from a theatre that burned down before any of this even started?"

"Forgive me for interrupting your charming conversation, but I thought I heard there was something to smoke here. I'd take chewing tobacco. I can pay with a watch. Is that possible?"

"Me too, me too."

"I'd take some too."

"He's got a whole bag of it."

"Don't make me angry, you idiot. What tobacco? It's my things."

The crowd caught fire again, sharpened its teeth, and began feverishly to pass ideas and rumours to and fro. The news that one of the passengers had a whole suitcase, of tobacco no less, and was hiding it for himself to trade for something, shocked everyone. And it did look strange, since he was the only one who had not handed in so large a piece of luggage. It had never been opened. He looked strange himself, in his rare, defiant colour among the pastels. This gentleman, Mr Panasevich, who happened to share the dead Vrublevsky's name and patronymic, had stirred people's minds before with his airy behaviour, though he had always stayed half in the shadow of the acknowledged masters of conversation and popularity. And now this. A white crow among the black, with a "medicinal extract" besides.

Even those indifferent to tobacco looked up from the joyless ceremony, though many people loved a funeral and always had a fine Ivanovo handkerchief ready for weeping over respectable members of the intelligentsia. The leaders noticed too; they felt the force of the shouting, which sounded like a market woman insisting on her price for a not very good, bluish soup hen, the colour of faded indigo.

Meanwhile the digging was going badly. The first strokes of the shovels went in well (at least something useful had come from the ship), but then the ground would not give. Digging in the mountains, or near them, was torture: limestone, heavy wet sand, thin layers of rock. Three men, one of them the grief-stricken father, struggled for depth. It would take four hours at least.

The father heard every word of the babble, close by, and could barely restrain himself from throwing himself into the crowd to pour out all his rage, his pain, his anger. The mother had it worse. Several people tried at once to calm the crowd, among them the count and the sugar king. Talk achieved

nothing. The rumour about the tobacco, taken up by the sullen majority, had done its harm.

The smokers demanded that the suitcase be opened and kept trying to get at it, while a small group, drawn up in something like a Roman tortoise without the shields, stood in defence of private property. They too, it turned out, had held back some of what they owned. When people like you are attacked, it is better to fight off the attack on him than to fight later alone against those who have never known defeat; so runs a military maxim, as paraphrased by your humble servant. Samuil Elkanovich shrugged, seeing how pitiful it all was. What more did they want? What a view there was from that sloping shelf above the shore, onto a stern, unpretentious nature, virgin and primeval: the place where the *Helvetia* had died, the absurd little bay that was not really a bay, with mountains to right and left, nothing like the classic bays of the Crimea, of Koktebel or Balaklava. Though it showed them nothing of where to go next.

One shovel bent, but the work was done. A small grave, about a metre deep for the child's height, was dug in about two hours. And meanwhile the quarrel among those who were not burying anyone had flared up; fights broke out, and the sober and neutral could not hold back those who wanted what the gentleman surely had. Had he been alone, it would have settled itself, the bigger side winning; but some doctors had been told by their magpie that a good man was being accused of theft and must be defended, instead of looking at what was obvious anyway. And the ladies, the devotees of smoking and chewing, were very active. They wanted to smoke, mercilessly, right now. It was obscurantism in the flesh. They started a fight, and there was a brawl.

The gravediggers stopped work. The dead boy's father went towards the furious crowd. But one thing is anger, and another the rage of a man who has lost his son; and his mind was clouded not only by two catastrophes but by simple hunger. What they had eaten could hardly be called food, and the last real supper of their lives had been nearly three days before.

As might be expected, guns came into it. The leaders' patience gave out. A shot into the air deafened everyone; the mountains threw back the echo. The count did not want to waste his cartridges, but this had turned into a hideous farce. Forty-five minutes of it did not cool anyone down. And the count was as irritable as the crowd. Perhaps their tension infected him; but I think the trouble was his osteomyelitis, which flared up now and then and had become chronic. Since the evening before he had not spoken, because the pain had

locked his jaw. He fired, hoping to calm them all. They looked at him as if he too had a golden suitcase.

It was colder here than on the shore. The snowy caps of the mountains no longer seemed far away, and the whole circus had perhaps been got up to keep warm. Dancing would have been bad form, even for such boors, and as for digging graves and making fires, *let the cook's children do it; we'll go and take the tobacco*.

The man who had started it all fell silent. He suddenly understood that his spiteful, envious words had turned into fights in which a man could be beaten or shot dead before his time, and few wanted to share the dead boy's fate. Panasevich, holding the object of the battle, did not care. Suspicion and pressure did not frighten him. He even seemed to enjoy it, and smiled unnaturally, as if he knew he had a powerful bodyguard, which in truth was only the naive impulse of a few people like himself to help one of their own. And if he had stopped talking, that was cold calculation: his mouth was already drying out, and nobody wanted to bring on thirst.

A second shot followed, and at last the crowd took notice. It was Tereshchenko who had fired. He had had a word, as far as he could, with Povarnin, and taken on himself the business of finding out what was going on and stopping it. He began to push through towards the centre. At the same moment the father was forcing his way there too. It all happened fast, as it does, and most people did not even see it. A shot in the leg; whose leg, it was not clear. The crowd stirred and drew back. Tereshchenko spoke harshly, in a deep, low baritone. And at last the reasonable people stepped in.

Meanwhile the gravediggers were arguing with the mother, who was on her knees begging them not to bury her child, because he was still warm. They stood firm. Someone who had nothing to do with the brawl was making a cross, or something like one. Someone insisted the grave be deeper, so that no animal could defile the poor body. But a third shot made it clear that something strange was happening, and they hurried. In a quarter of an hour, on the slope of the rounded summit, eight men did everything they could. No coffin, no priest. But at least that.

They did not notice the father at once. Only later did they learn that he had been hit, a graze, because someone took him for the most active of the brawlers; he had burst in just as the sugar baron reached the people defending the suitcase. They drew back. A long and thorough conversation began, with

many unpleasant words, and the leaders' helpers, the "sons of the fatherland," came running.

Now Panasevich was a little embarrassed, since it was to Tereshchenko that he had lied that the suitcase held nothing much, having shown him its contents only from the side. Now he was made to open it. At first there was nothing in it: clothes, rags, a wristwatch, papers, all in a dreadful state, packed carelessly and in haste, like everyone's. Tereshchenko, knowing he had to find whoever had deceived the people, began to close the case and to deliver a speech of mixed reproach and excuse: "Well, sir, you should have shown it to the people at once." He turned to the gentlemen around him with a fine, well-built speech, to find out which of them was the troublemaker, so that he could be left as a watchdog at the boy's grave for eternity. Meanwhile the suitcase, thrown carelessly to the ground, had cracked along its lining from the small blow, and its secret was showing. But nobody looked down yet. The conversation was being conducted eye to eye.

Soon the culprit was led out. He had tried to hide in the crowd of those who had taken no part in the bacchanal. The fool admitted his guilt at once, but kept trying to build some defence, saying they ought to look more carefully at the shaggy fellow. A minute later he was on his knees. It turned out the gentleman had a rare gift for kissing boots right through the leather. Tereshchenko liked that very much, more than presents. But the count did not care for such a slow sliding off the rails. He wanted to drive the full force of an armoured train into the enemy station and bring it down, so that no one would ever try it again.

And then salvation came from where nobody expected. The kneeling man noticed the tobacco so lovingly described in rumour and legend, spilled on the wet earth. Sparks flew in his eyes. He said so, and they all turned round.

The crowd ran furiously to the suitcase to tear the villain to pieces and take what they had rebelled for. Like kites they flew down on it, in a minute, before the man could even be let go by his collar. Twenty people tore the foul-smelling, badly over-dried weed out of one another's hands; then the rest came running, climbing on one another's backs, and it turned out that at least forty or fifty were interested. The count was simply appalled, and began to load his rifle again. Others, non-smokers fortunately, backed him. The quickest of the smokers were already amusing themselves by stuffing the stuff up their noses, to gather more, since the secret compartment, which they tore open without the slightest shame and spilled out on the ground, was not small, and there is

not much one can carry in one's hands with no pockets. Oh, misfortune! The first ones went straight under, high as kites.

The count searched his pockets for something. Then he spat, and ran towards the porters with the baggage. He looked as if he were going for an ancient arquebus, to blow on an equally ancient match and fire into the villains on the spot. The crowd quieted down, and even the tobacco fighters, dying of their endless sneezing, were so surprised by his flight that someone said the cigarette dust must have had a laxative effect on the count.

That was nonsense, of course. A brilliant idea had come into the count's head. He was a great connoisseur of spices. He had been many times to India and to the islands mistakenly called the West Indies centuries before, and had made a great fortune from them. At the beginning of the twentieth century the demand for overseas herbs and roots and such stuff was still far from satisfied; how were the poor cooks in the great palaces to manage without? Persia was not enough. People wanted a little saffron, ground pepper, something wildly hot. Prices were undemocratically high, even in Mother Europe. He still had a great deal of stock from South-East Asia, besides bales of tea and other delights, and he could not simply leave it. The Bolsheviks, he thought, could not tell one thing from another and would feed his spices to pigs, or to their prisoners. That was less a thought than an excuse for greed. Part of his stock, and it was a large one, he had spent on bribing port officials for extra space in the hold, where he loaded thirty poods. Another two poods he had spread among five suitcases, even squeezing out his clothes to make room. And now thousands of American dollars had gone to the bottom, packed with such love so as not to lose a scrap of their aroma. But something, with the passion of a man whose hobby ends in *-phile*, he had kept. It was ridiculous, of course. His family could say nothing; it was all they had left. Men are hard to talk round. There was no steak here, no rib-eye, so neither the cardamom nor the pepper nor the nutmeg would be of any use.

He quickly found his precious bundles among all that "luxurious" madness, opened one, took several bricks, and, feeling the astonished eyes of the porters, ran back towards the crowd. The pain in his jaw had eased a little, perhaps in anticipation of his almost sadistic idea. He ordered the crowd to surround the smokers. How he missed the servants who had always obeyed him! Ordinary people who had no wish to serve anyone nevertheless obeyed, perhaps because of his face, twisted into a very aggressive grin. While the smokers noticed nothing, men and some women formed a tight ring round them.

Meanwhile Povarnin went up to Tereshchenko, who was holding the man who had started it all like a dog on a lead. This man, Leonid, was very surprised by the way the count looked at him. He knew him, of course; on the beach he had raised his hand to vote for him. He expected something like a reprimand; one of his teachers used to look at him like that in his youth. But no. The count said not a word. He tore open one of the bricks on the ground, took half a dozen nutmegs, crushed them furiously in his hands, and then, to the silent amazement of his friend the sugar king, forced the man by gestures to open his mouth and began to stuff everything he had into it. The man resisted desperately from the first second.

Nutmeg has a powerful smell and a burning taste that numbs the mouth and turns the stomach inside out, and it is about as easy to swallow as sand. The pain in his mouth, with his jaw held shut by the hands of his furious executioner, was only the beginning. He tried to vomit and could not. Tereshchenko, deeply bewildered, nevertheless held Leonid's arms and legs firmly. The whole business looked like the force-feeding of geese for foie gras, a practice as old as the tombs of Saqqara. But it was not a goose that Povarnin meant to make of the man. It was something more prosaic, though nobody had guessed it yet.

The count calmly prised the jaw open and stuffed in spice after spice, ground pepper, and more nutmeg crushed in his fist, until it seemed enough. He waited three minutes while Leonid swallowed the hellish mixture by reflex. Then he dropped him where he was, and nodded to Povarnin's few witnesses. He still had plenty of the stuff left. With it under his arm, he walked into the crowd.

The smokers were rolling about and fighting over the tobacco. Povarnin did something very simple. He went up to the first of them he met and began to pour into their mouths what he had tried on Leonid, and then, delighted to see how much tobacco was left on the ground, he flung that into their gaping mouths too, with one sentence of pure fury: "You wanted it? Have it." It was not the fight over the tobacco that had maddened him, I think, so much as the fact that it had been hidden from him. His eyes searched for the burgundy coat as he trod on the limbs of the fallen.

Why did they look so strange, when tobacco is supposed to be a mere intoxicant? Because they had been without it for three or four days, and because this tobacco was strong, and because they had not smoked it but stuffed it raw up their noses and into their mouths, which brings on all the poison and none of the pleasure. They had given themselves nicotine poisoning, and badly. Their eyes were not human. Those still on their feet swayed.

Panasevich was lying quietly among them, sober, since he did not care for tobacco himself. But his pink, piggish face shone out among all those faces grey as shadows. *Ah, what a gob. That'll take some work*, Povarnin thought to himself, and he seemed to be out of his mind, far more than anyone around him.

Somehow he had found a helper, one of the onlookers, who seemed to understand what was going to happen and was glad to unload a few tons of resentment on the clown. The "bull-calf" was perplexed when he was asked so sweetly, with a velvet smile, to open his mouth. That was a mistake. He fought, he bristled, he spat, but nothing could be done. Besides the nutmeg trick, they used something no less sadistic: a fiery Indian blend of ground roots and peppers, loved by gourmets. Have you ever had half a pound of it poured over you? Never do it. He could not fight them off, and the crowd watched with interest; nobody had seen such a thing before, except the few who had watched it done a few minutes earlier. His eyes burned. He was in agony, killing himself with a thousand sneezes that only sucked the powder deeper into his throat. And worst of all was the nutmeg forced down him. The artistic intelligentsia sighed, but nobody fainted now, or ran to help. They seemed to enjoy this refined cruelty. Or perhaps not. One could tell from the faces in the front row: some laughed, some could barely look, someone even threw down his cane.

Nobody could believe that some trifle you put in your food could do such things. But Povarnin knew, and knew what would happen next. Taken in quantity, nutmeg brings on, slowly, a poisoning not unlike hashish, and then much worse. Nobody here had ever tried hashish, or would admit it; the velvet age of such drugs had not yet come. Curiosity had brought the count to this knowledge, as it had brought Johann Wilhelm Ritter, the father of electrochemistry, to experiment with high voltages on his own body, until it killed him young. Povarnin had been luckier, though not entirely: his experiments had left him with epilepsy and a darker mind than his contemporaries.

When he had poured the last helping into the "burning cauldron" and waited until the man stopped resisting and swallowed the decisive dose, he calmed down and left the poor devil alone. No, not quite. He saw the tobacco again, and thoroughly stuffed a heaped tablespoon of it up the man's nostrils. Now he was at peace. The others did not interest him. His hands hurt horribly and he kept wanting to sneeze, but through it all he addressed everyone in a clumsy, unprepared speech. He made it clear that anyone who lied, or turned

to vodka, or to that thrice-cursed tobacco, or to anything else, at the expense of the castaways' need for water, food, warmth or anything vital, would be shot or destroyed by other means. Whoever did not like the tone could go where he pleased, on his own. And so on. He looked ridiculous, smeared with turmeric. People laughed and pointed. His gun was no longer in his hands; less heated gentlemen had picked it up. Panasevich and the others who had snorted and smoked were declared outcasts and forbidden to come within three hundred paces of the herd.

Then he begged forgiveness of the wounded father of the dead child, and knelt before him, and said that such swinishness and disrespect for the dead would be strictly put down. That the public approved. Their faces suddenly grew serious; the mischief passed.

"It seems one can still look for salvation with them," said Mrs Tereshchenko.

The most unlucky lay senseless, their bodies splitting under that dreadful "injection." The most talkative of them, the instigator, had it worst: his tongue went numb and his heart raced. Nobody noticed him; he lay apart, near a small cliff. The tobacco men had begun to recover, and some tearfully begged for mercy. They were ignored. The merriest were hit with the handle of a shovel for their villainous behaviour. The public was once more appalled by the violence of its guides. The tobacco riot had given way to something else. Delight had turned into fear. The bourgeoisie, the merchants and tradesmen, whispered loudest.

And when Tereshchenko and Povarnin turned to the crowd and made it clear by gestures that the crossing was cancelled and they must look about them to decide where to go, while the weather was bearable, people were slow to react, and someone almost broke under it. But no one took responsibility for anything. Everyone wanted the quickest possible Moses. Nobody thought of forty years in the wilderness, though there was reason to. The land they faced cared nothing for people. It was the kingdom of nature, utterly without a human face.

The boys, who had the most energy, went to look. And there was nothing to hold on to. Nothing at all.

Worse: while the hysteria went on on the southern slope, some of them had climbed a little higher. And there they were stunned by the majesty of an icy kingdom hidden from below. Snow was much nearer than it had seemed. Barely three kilometres away, a little higher than where these burlesque scouts

stood, lay a realm of snow without any visible sign of life. Behind a low wall of rock, invisible from the shore, the country was more frightening still. Below was no kinder. No palm trees. An endless horizon, broad mountain rivers, what looked like lakes, though mist hid them, and millions of hectares of forest. And where to go? There was no sign of a road. To right and left the same terrible, endless, impassable mountains, higher the further one looked. Only this corridor, wide enough, but with a river, lakes and probably swamps. Impenetrable taiga.

The rebellion did not happen. The urge to tear things up and remake the order of things on this fragile ground gave way to a more pressing urge, to eat. The crossing was over. They had to go on, or rather understand where to go. They resigned themselves. The good gentlemen followed their leaders, whom they plainly no longer liked; but they understood.

The boy was forgotten. They turned their backs and walked off. Nobody even looked at the little grave. The parents did not want to leave, and went on in their understandable hysteria, but they were dragged away and persuaded to go on fighting for their lives. Even that was a great feat.

And the outcasts? Some of them crawled or ran after the column, having finished off, as they went, the last of the tobacco that had been the greasy apple of discord. Only three lay writhing: the two guilty men and one who had been caught up by chance. When someone asked what was to become of them, a hoarse voice answered:

"A bog doesn't need a finishing shot. They'll croak soon. Nothing to be done. Or would you like to share it with them?"

It was, of course, the count, the hero and the villain of the day. His rage came not only from his osteomyelitis. There was another sickness in him, which had brought out this sudden, strange, violent aggression. He told no one he had fought in the war with Japan, and come home with six concussions in a year when he was very young. In 1914 the army turned him down, and he took a terrible revenge on the man who dared to reject a patriot with the manners of a would-be general.

For the first time in three days birds of prey were seen in the sky, eagles probably. Someone proposed shooting them, but a gentleman of a deathly thinness, a hunter by blood, called it a stupid idea: eagle meat, even American eagle, was nothing pleasant; it tasted like sucking someone else's galosh. So far no animal had suffered at the hands of this joyless crowd. That moment would come. What they called food would last one more meal at best.

Nothing could change the leaders' minds about the three poisoned men they had abandoned. On the contrary, they urged everyone on, saying that as soon as they found the way forward they would make a proper halt and have dinner. Besides the porridge, they promised something new: ship's biscuits, broken, two or three apiece. Believe me, after that news the company's spirits rose. It was announced too that a hunt had begun, and anyone who saw any living thing, in the sky or on the ground, must report it at once, so that there would be meat.

Neither Leonid, nor Panasevich, nor the third, the thin one, could cope with the dreadful symptoms of their poisoning. It was a monstrous sight. Their nerves groaned and begged for help. Their whole digestive tract was, quite literally, burned. Their consciousness slipped further away every minute. Too large a dose of what turned out to be a drug was killing their livers. There were hallucinations, surely, and then convulsions. In half an hour they looked like men bitten by a black mamba; worse, in truth, the poison being of a different nature. Fever, and all the other symptoms so well known to the science of poisons. The count knew that a few nuts took three hours to act and then left a man with a day of thirst and a splitting head; but this was a deadly dose. Panasevich had swallowed at least thirteen nuts in one form or another.

Beside Leonid knelt his wife, a nurse by training, already understanding that nothing could be done here. She tried to wash out his stomach, running down to the stream, bringing water in her small palms, cursing everyone who had gone, trying again. Her calling would not let her be selfish, or indifferent to the others, and she dragged them together and did for them what she thought might save them. Meanwhile the two hundred and thirty had gone far enough not to hear her cries. Her face showed a wish for revenge, for killing, which would have been expected in a man. But this fragile woman, hardly more than a girl, fought an invisible enemy on her knees on the stony ground. She fell, she struggled, she poured water and ran, forcing the life-giving water down through their vomit, dozens of times, hundreds. It was not enough. She fought for each of them, though her husband had never liked that upstart Panasevich, and had paid for it, not at his hands, but like a brother, alongside him, and in such a heart-rending way, half laughable and half pitiful.

Tatyana was torn between running after the beasts who had fed her husband this and abandoned him, and the task in front of her. Her legs carried her again and again to that treacherous stream, which reminded her what it was

every time her grey eyes met the cross and the little mound on the slope. Her lightness and her quick feet saved her from another slide; anyone heavier would have brought it down. Part of her mind said she would not save them, and the shovels were gone; a more hopeful part said, catch them, take a gun, and kill. But how? Was it even possible? She had to save the men. She pushed everything else into the future.

Nothing improved. Someone was raving. The wind rose; the sun hid again, with no plans to return; an invisible army was storming the coastal citadel once more. She was alone with the half-dead. Leonid was dying; the tearing pain in his chest was his agony. Plump Mr Panasevich was in rather better shape. The crowd could still be seen, standing as if besieged on that little bare plateau, not knowing what to do.

The third man, the frailest, gave up the ghost at last, frothing at the mouth. Twenty minutes later the wife saw her husband die. Her howl of pain woke the eternally sleeping mountains and echoed round all that greedy land. She screamed until her voice broke, and then grew quiet.

The red one, in his burgundy coat, was still holding on. Should she strangle him? Why sow death? It would come for them all anyway. He might be useful. Let him live. She was alone, after all.

There was a strange, coded silence. And they had to be buried. With what? Ground like that cannot be scraped out with bare hands. And there were two dead now. She could not even look towards the dwindling tribe, which had at last worked out where it could go and where it could not.

The choice was small; the world has only four sides. Behind them was the shore, and the storm that had driven them here was gathering again. They had to decide whether to climb up and suffer near that Olympus, or go down again into the lowland, into those swamps or lakes, whatever they were. Someone insisted the river and the lakes could not be forded, and boats could not be carried. Water was near. It was cold. It would soon be dark. And everything would go round again: a sleepless night, an empty stomach, no will to do anything. That sense of inglorious death is typical of everyone whom fate has not killed in an instant but left to the mercy of such a land.

Panasevich came round, slowly and painfully. It was dark when he came to. He went on vomiting, though there was nothing left but something that could only with difficulty be called stomach juice. His fat little belly had never worked so hard, and in the end it reduced his poisoning to merely serious, unlike the luckless men cooling beside him. It was very cold, close to freezing; in

the mountains night comes early. The pale shadows of the others had dissolved somewhere ahead. The poor girl tried to help the man who was, in a way, the cause of everything that had happened here. His body burned. His breathing steadied. He asked for water. But how to reach it in that darkness? In a starting storm the slope was a death trap; the chance of falling down it to the stream below and sharing the boy's fate had never been greater. She was terribly afraid to go down. The wind blew straight into her face. The rain began. Two corpses and one barely living man.

She did the most rational thing. The rain turned quickly to snow, big flakes falling on that cursed ground. She lay down between the living and the dead. To lie on ground where there was nothing but a little grass and lichen, with the nearest pines three hundred metres off, was enough to drive one mad. But even the dead men she pressed against did not frighten her as much as the sense of death by cold. She began to drift towards sleep. She could not bear even ten minutes of lying still. Only one thing stopped her: beside her lay a man she did not know, but alive, still alive, and she had to warm him somehow, and herself with him, so that he too would not leave the world. Tatyana rubbed his hands and his face, and the snow kept falling. That morning's green landscape was turning to a stern winter one, and it was only the twentieth of October.

Panasevich was still half in a coma. Twelve hours his body had been fighting for its life. The hours dragged for the two of them, alone with themselves. Fear, fear and fear again. And as soon as it was dark the local inhabitants announced themselves, and they were not people. For the first time in three days, they heard a wolf howl. It sounded muffled and far away. But it made Tatyana tense, and Panasevich too, who was beginning to understand.

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At the same time the tribe was sheltering in a grotto three miles to the north-east, a small cave, or rather a cluster of rock formations on the slope of the next mountain. They had spotted it just before sunset, and getting there turned out, luckily, to be easier than they had feared. Strangely, people had already been ready to stay where they were, on the bare plateau, rather than go down into the forest; only the shepherds' persistence saved them. A convenient ridge led across, a continuation of the plateau hidden behind a hump, as if the mountains themselves had not wanted to show their cards. People always look for shelter, and do not always find it. They owed this rocky inn to a gentleman

of about thirty who climbed to the top of the hill and spotted it with his sharp eyes.

Among the rock pillars there was slow, listless talk. Their strength was leaving them. How they wanted to eat, to drink, and to change their wretched clothes at last. Their curls were a pitiful sight. The latrine was wherever one happened to be.

"People are falling ill. We'll all be ill soon. I'm soaked through. Where are we to go? Did you see those endless forests? Shall we go back to the shore? People!"

"My dear sir, whoever you are, I can't see you; would you be quiet? My child is crying. Anechka has a fever. She's caught a bad chill. And now what? Do oxen bellow when the trough is full? I mean we shouldn't sit here burning an empty fire; we should go hunting. Whatever they give us in the morning will be the last. I'm thirsty, and not for fine talk. We must act."

"One moment. Do you understand what you're saying? Put your nose outside. It's snowing. Let's wait until morning."

The mountains resonated, amplifying their whispering. Only one fire caught at the first attempt, with a good old splint of kindling. The damp foreign matches went out the moment they flared. There was not enough brushwood; the little they had gathered before the stream was vanishing as fast as the snowflakes that blew into the shelter. One could not lie down; the wind came in horribly, snow and rain taking turns. Through it all came the muffled sound of some kind of pipe. For a long time no one knew where it came from. It turned out to be in the best place of all, where the first arrivals had settled: inside there was a small hollow, almost a cave, which narrowed to nothing after a dozen metres.

People stood, tried to sit, held on to the walls or leaned against them. Dirty, nervous, without real daylight, hungrier than ever: that was two hundred men and women. They begged for more fires, and soon they got them. Meanwhile the doctors and the more sensible people noticed that the number of those coughing was growing with every hour.

What frightened everyone most, even the unimpressionable, was the waking of some animals, bats or birds, discovered when one of them caught in a boy's hair and set off a dreadful panic. There were only twenty or so, not the hundreds or thousands they had feared; they had been woken by the firelight from little holes in the rock above head height, left there perhaps by migrating birds.

Our famous silent cynic, the owner of the notebook, muttered to himself. By some miracle he had survived, despite his dreadful absent-mindedness and clumsiness. Life had given him new troubles besides his eyesight, his reserve and his oddity. He was one of the few who had not found a place by a fire, too feeble to warm forty or fifty bodies but warming at least their hearts. He no longer cared about anything. He only wanted to write, but the darkness kept bumping him into people, and he had no ink and his notebook was spoiled. He hummed along with the timid sound of the pipe, which was playing, clumsily but persistently, some mountain or shepherd's tune, until even this incurious man went looking for it. As one might expect, it was a child who, for some reason, had decided he had the right to play his music at night among dozens of people dead with fatigue; the march to the grotto had taken three hours. Stranger still, people consumed by thoughts of survival did not mind the sound. If you want to sleep, you sleep. And did they sleep? They tried. They dozed at every halt, and it did not drive them mad, except some, like the recent heroes of the tobacco riot.

The child had dark eyes and was incredibly dirty, like a chimney sweep's boy in Mother England. In truth, all the dirt was the leavings of various living creatures. When day came, many would be amazed at the filthy swamp they had slept in: feathers, fur, old droppings, animal tracks.

Not one pressing problem had been solved. Going back to the start was not even considered at the top of the hastily built hierarchy, which was built, in my opinion, of bird droppings. Tereshchenko was the most dissatisfied man of all. He had thought that as soon as they climbed that hill, a rounded mountain two or two and a half thousand feet high, he would see the glittering spires of local palaces and hotels. How his intuition had failed that most charming man. And he could not give up his post as one of the two high priests, out of fear of the stronger-willed and, as it turned out, very cruel count. He tried to talk to the people, but those he wanted to talk to hardly spoke, saving their strength. Nobody knew how many days, or perhaps years, they would be searching for the humankind that had suddenly become so dear to them. Somewhere deep in their minds were happy memories of conversations on deck and in the saloon of the *Helvetia*, about how *the Magnolian soul yearns for wild nature and the primeval life, and how the bustle of cities and all the deadly sins destroy it*. Now those words were turning out to be prophetic, and false.

CHAPTER TEN

# The Black Swan



Sliding into the sea, they saw the ghostly outline of the *Helvetia* go deeper and deeper. Hissing and spouting, the steel giant sank fast. The Pacific was taking the fine steamer into the depths of eternal cold and darkness. The ship had found her rest for ever.

*They* were the lucky ones who got away: four sailors who had thought up their own salvation a few minutes before what had seemed certain death, out of the ship's own fittings. It tore their hearts to take that chance away from the passengers. But ten minutes earlier everyone had watched the terrible deaths of the people on the flimsy rafts, who had not known how to handle them. So, whatever their consciences said, it was decided to give the youngest sailors their chance. And they were lucky. Their craft did not sink as she went in. As the *Helvetia* slowly went down, the water pushed them gently away, in whatever direction the sea chose; they had no oars, and to flail with their hands would have been fatal. Crammed inside four walls on a simple bottom, a box made of two crates, they were carried at right angles to the shore, with a little help from the wind, with a hope of reaching land in a few hours, or days.

The passengers left on deck watched their lucky start with black envy. They could have done the same, if there had been more time, and more crates, and more skill. The crew had known that the holds where such things were kept had flooded from the first. The coal pen on the deck had split one of its walls into useless splinters as she heeled, and the other walls were too heavy even for so many people.

They were lucky, then, but less so as yet than the crowds who had gone off in proper boats with oars. They drifted further and further. The wood creaked and swelled but held. They did not know where their raft was taking them.

They were Ukrainians from the Green Wedge, the land along the Amur and the Ussuri where their fathers and grandfathers had been settled; where had fate thrown them this time? First their fathers from Ukraine to beyond China, and now themselves to beyond the ocean.

The shore was clearly visible. By four in the afternoon they had reached it; the watch the senior seaman had given them came in useful. Eight hours adrift. Wet, hungry and shattered; their whole crew and many of the passengers had stayed behind, and the *Helvetia* was long gone. Their churning thoughts stopped when they landed. With no food and four pint flasks they found the shore duller than the ocean. The one thing that no longer frightened them was their little boat, which split, as it happened, just where they least expected, so that they had to wade the last thirty paces up to their waists in freezing water.

The four young men had come ashore at the southern end of the low headland near the wreck. The beach where the sixteen boats had landed was at least eleven kilometres away in a straight line, and from that distance they could see nothing but the mountains to the north. They understood that they had been thrown up in the wrong place. A small fire-making kit, carefully kept in a lead box, saved them, and quickly. They could build nothing in the few hours before dark. They leaned against single trees standing round in the shape of a cross, with the fire at the crossing.

In the morning they set out. They soon found a stream, so at least water would be no problem. Under the rain they went inland; here the land was quite flat. But after a few versts they realised they were cut off by a broad, wilful river, and that they were living, if not on an island, then on a peninsula. That had yet to be found out, and whether the river, fifty metres wide, could be crossed.

On the far bank they saw bears, ten of them, though not at first; only when they had gone upstream, where the island was cut off on the slant from the mainland, and where the ground began to rise and a summit appeared, hidden till then by the pines along the river, the continuation of the very plateau their companions had climbed that day. The bears frightened the sailors badly. They were dark brown and black, grizzlies perhaps, and they were idle, and hungry, it seemed; they could find nothing to catch. A hard time was coming, for all the outward kindness of autumn on the Pacific coast. Here by the river it was warmer than on the shore and much warmer than up on the heights, seven or eight degrees, not bad at all for the twentieth of October at about the sixtieth parallel. But the salmon were not as eager as their hunters. The water was colder, there was a light mist with the rain, and no fish came. The boldest bears

sat on boulders, feeling with their paws in the clear water for the red bodies they wanted, and found none.

And then the men came out of the trees, straight into the middle of a big bear family. The animals had noticed them before, and given no sign; but as soon as their eyes met, across twenty or twenty-five metres of water, some of them, the idlers rather than the three who were fishing, waded into the river without a moment's thought and started across, straight towards the gawkers. The men's first stupor turned at once into a wish to run. But where? Five bears were coming fast towards their bank, eyeing the men, so the poor fellows imagined, as prey, their eyes full of blood. That was not so. But they were curious about the men, no doubt of it. It was best to leave, quickly. And they did; they had a minute's start, less the first seconds of paralysis. The kings of the forest had rarely seen people, perhaps never, and treated them as any creature with the burden of being chief must: a stranger had to be identified, and if need be torn to pieces or driven off. The chase, more psychological than real, ended in deathly exhaustion, the loss of a few things, the bears sniffing over the place where the sailors had stood, and the knowledge that on this island of life too, people were not alone.

In fact the bears had only meant to cross to a better fishing place. And so it was. The idlers who stayed behind on the far bank got nothing. The lucky ones were the hunters on the near bank, which we will call the right bank, because a hundred field-mouse paces away there was a fine spot, a little channel where the river narrowed and split into two unequal arms, one large and the other barely two metres wide, divided by a ridge of oddly regular stones, rather like the Giant's Causeway: the remains of a great rock which the water had worn down, all but a broken path of bare stone covered with moss. How could there not be moss?

The four hid wherever they could. One fell into a dry ditch, an old stream bed hidden by brush, which ran alongside the river. They searched the whole course of the river for food and people, but now their steps were careful and quiet. They were lucky enough to find a few mushrooms under the evergreens in a warm, dark clearing, the kindest place in all that country. Neither the deep needles nor the mud underfoot nor their tiredness could stop them looking for more, because mushrooms might keep them alive; besides water and bears, there was nothing to eat. The birds, few as they were, were out of reach. They were in the oldest part of the coastal forest, where some trees, even the rare broadleaves, now almost bare, stood twenty metres high. The phantom sun

came through badly, but the rain did not lash them here as it lashed the others on the plateau. They decided to go back to the shore, fixing the clearing in their memory. They took the mushrooms, nineteen of them, and went back to the coast, where, having understood how hard and dangerous the river was to cross, all that remained was to go the more rational way, along the shore, and follow the first logic of the "big company": find a settlement. They knew rather more than the others about where they might be, but they had no map; nobody had thought to give them one in those terrible minutes of farewell. As it turned out, the later you leave, the harder it is: to get anywhere, and to look the people you leave behind in the face. Some of them had lowered their eyes on purpose; everything was clear enough. Someone had jumped into the water in front of everyone. Those first minutes after six o'clock. They would never forget them.

The mushrooms were wormy through and through, which made them believe they were not poisonous. Their fear of being poisoned was put down by their will to survive and their hunger. One can love people if only for this: a child who falls into a deep storm drain may climb out of it a grown man, if he is lucky. I mean the extraordinary art of adapting, of gathering one's strength when it is needed. These boys of twenty-two, wiry but no more than that, did everything that might help them live, with nothing but their flasks, their knives, their fire kit and their thin torn clothes.

By evening the mushrooms were ready. A small pot, pressed on them by some tender-hearted lady at the last moment and accepted unwillingly, with tears in her eyes, came in very handy. Mushrooms were mushrooms: a stalk, a cap. Not ceps, not chanterelles. Boletus? Who knows. Some autumn or winter kind, and good enough. Hard to notice, though big; if they had not trodden on them and smelled their splendid smell with their sharpened noses, they would still be sitting on the shore watching imaginary steamers on the horizon. They boiled them as one should, not knowing that they were a little above sea level, and that the higher you go the lower the temperature at which water boils. Nobody knew of such hidden reefs. They were hungry. I will write it for the hundredth time, and I will be right a hundred times.

On the second night, branches came crashing down on their heads. The same storm that had caught the others in the forest was raging here.

The gale off the ocean dropped only late in the evening, and only in part. Even in the thickets inside their little island it was frightening; the trees bent and broke and whistled. Their exploration of the coast was put off for almost a day. Their attempts to catch birds came to nothing. The wind kept driving

the waves in, forcing them to walk more often inside the forest than along the easier stony beach.

They decided to go south, away from where they supposed the others to be. Looking for survivors would take time and might come to nothing, and besides, the further south, the warmer, and the warmer, the likelier to find people. The logic was crude but had a right to live. The trouble was fresh water; they had to keep turning off towards the river to fill their flasks, thinking all the while of the bears. Lightly dressed, with empty stomachs, over flat ground, they walked fast and easily, except for one thing: the faces they could not get out of their memory, which burned them from inside.

The forest began to give way, bending lower and lower towards the shore, and soon they saw why. The mountains were advancing. The bare clearings were the snowfields of the weeks to come. For now the weather was kind. Snow fell, but here it turned at once into a fine rain like sea spray.

On the third day a large lake stopped them, fresh water, spread over ground that had once held bushes and small trees, separated from the sea by a narrow bar of bare sand that the waves were storming to get at it. They found what fed it: a high waterfall, which they heard before they saw it, coming down out of tall pines on the slope of a small mountain. "The most beautiful place in all these days," said one of the sailors. They did not go close at first, only looking with their sharp eyes for any sign of a hut. There was none. But one of them wanted so badly to see the waterfall close to that he overcame the fear the river had put into them. There were animals there, something like roe deer, which he saw for a second or two before they fled at the scent of a man. That evening, sitting in the crown of a tree that lightning had brought down in the summer, the sailors worked it out: if the animals here fear people, then people come here. A pity they had no gun to test it.

They decided to go back to the waterfall in the morning and try for fish. They lashed a dirk to a stick with a bootlace, tied with a sailor's trick that even such young men knew, to make a fish spear; or, if it came to it, to throw, at the risk of losing the blade instead of putting it into the fish's belly, and being left even more naked.

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Two days later, further north and higher up, hands were going numb in the frosty wind.

Panasevich had recovered, though he was still weak, weaker than the poor girl who had saved his life. They were dragging her dead husband down the mountain. The views from the plateau had frightened them, and they could not bring themselves to go over the ridge after the crowd that had made them outcasts for nothing. The second body they could not manage, and left it "for later," knowing they would almost certainly never come back for it. Their strength melted like the snowflakes on Mr Panasevich's stubble. He laughed at himself; he could not bear a beard, and preferred a bourgeois moustache and nothing more. They crossed the deadly stream; it slid again, but this time it hurt no one. They drank greedily, and the cold of the water froze their voices so that they hardly spoke all day. Talk was now a costly generosity. The snow came again and again.

As they went down, they felt warmer, in spirit at least; the real difference was a fraction of a degree. Eagles circled overhead. They could smell the dead. Our two had left just in time: the body abandoned to the wolves was torn apart by the middle of the day by those winged killing machines.

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Mountain air purges the body not only of diseases but of lies. For the people who had spent the night in the grotto, it quickly became clear that only sincerity and truth could get them out of this bondage. Their affected way of speaking evaporated. Intellectuals who had once wanted with every fibre to set themselves apart from the common people found the common speech of their childhood rising up in them. How splendidly a Ryazan burr came out, how clearly one heard Oryol in the voices of "Petersburgers," how northern words slipped out of the mouths of men who had boasted like peacocks of being born Muscovites. One does not speak elegantly when every sound must be paid for out of one's own fat.

The night had not passed without incident. Besides the wolves, several people had burned themselves badly, their numbed hands feeling nothing. It was a little below freezing at night there.

That day it was decided to find food by any means. People were starving in earnest, and there was a problem with water too. To solve both at once, they began a difficult descent on the far side of the mountains, inland, towards the bed of the nearest river, which was a broad one. By midday the descent was over. It turned out easy, a long gentle slope, though the other face of the

mountain was sheer. The count and the sugar king had decided to keep a calendar too, so as not to lose that essential sign of a society's life, a point to count from.

Some of them had begun to write again, on whatever they could find.

*My mind needs good thoughts. Annushka cannot walk any more; I carry her. My wife has fallen ill and can barely move. At least a third of the people around me look like those poor Polish children who came out of the cellars where they had hidden for six weeks, in the summer of 1915. I try to remember the past, something to warm me from inside, but our situation grows worse by the hour and I can remember nothing useful. Perhaps it is the lack of sleep. Human voices have begun to irritate me terribly. Theodor told me we are wasting away very fast, that our last day is coming at a cosmic speed. Sometimes I fall into a stupor on purpose and turn into a statue. And this is only five days without food. My feet burn; they are tired, though we have not walked so far. In the night in the rock I found I could not bear the sound of dripping water; it tore me apart, my hands shook. My nerves are not right. I do not recognise Genrikh Vyacheslavovich. He has stopped talking altogether, to save his strength probably, but you should see his face: a pale mask. In the night he said only one thing, that without food he will die soon, much sooner than the rest of us. He has some disease of the blood which he never mentioned before. When we left the grotto he went over to the line of the "goners." That is something new in our lives: those who have lost their strength but whose thread has not yet broken go there, meekly. In the night everyone thought that by morning there would be ice everywhere and we could not get down. Some fools were glad of it. I was not. But in the morning I saw we were lucky; winter has not gathered its strength yet. Today is the twenty-first of October. Annushka needs something warm, but they do not even give boiling water; there are no pots and little water. If there is ever boiling water, I think I will put pine needles in it; perhaps they will help. My wife is sulking. I am writing in signs, on a little board, the way we did at the Greek school, dipping it in the last of the ink mixed with a little earth. I do not remember where this thin board of lime or ash came from.*

*I cannot remember anything useful I was taught as a child, except the rules of that alphabet. I marvel at my memory and its art of forgetting. We have come down now. We searched the whole little level and found nothing but a little salty grass, which was eaten at once without any caution. My friend Afanasy,*

*himself a doctor, is crawling round me muttering. He says the grass is not bad. I cannot eat it; my stomach will not take it. I try chewing pine cones, but it seems a silly way to destroy one's jaws. Though jaws are a vestige now. Good riddance. If we live till the winter on this fodder, scurvy will kill us sooner or later. Or something else, wolves, bears. They were heard yesterday in daylight. I hear only the rain and the scraping of hundreds of feet. Theodor thinks I am lucky, since he lost his wife back there; I told him I would rather my family had not seen this. We stink. We are turning into animals, and this is only the beginning. Every visit to the "lavatory" is a torment, for the children most of all, and for the old people, the women... Never mind. Tomorrow I will try to rub out what I have scratched and, if I live, write something of the same kind. It will be my canvas. God keep us.*

The river let them drink their fill at last, and a roll-call was held. The "stale little count," as people now called him, leaning on a stick three sazhens long, read out his ever more battered notebook in a voice muffled, perhaps, by the cold water. Did it occur to him to burn it instead of carrying it about? A mystery, and one that interested no one. He asked them to crowd close, so that his voice, gone dull and hoarse, would carry over the noise of the river, and he went through them all as fast as he could, so that they could try for fish.

Vladimir Obolensky-Kaspiysky wrote of that halt afterwards: "For the first time since childhood I felt greed and envy for an object, a bottle of some kind of drink. My little daughter Marusya, like all the children, was the first to catch cold, a serious and dangerous one, like everything around us. At the river someone was giving their child some spirit-based brew, so close to me that my nose caught it. I sat with my back to him, holding my daughter and propping up Arisha at the same time. Volodya sat on his own; I could not have carried him in that state. It nearly made me break my neck. And the swinishness of it: the man was my friend, a man who had sat at my table. What happened next I am ashamed to remember. I was quite wrong; sharing was not the custom here; other laws were at work. And the muck that got into my left eye could never have been prescribed as medicine for my little girl."

By the river a new misery appeared: mosquitoes and midges, preparing for winter and saying a long farewell to the year. Winter for them was death or a long sleep, and then such good fortune came their way. The insects crept into people's clothes, and they scratched, thinking it was nerves. In the open, the fires would not even smoulder, and drove nothing off. Who could have known

that the ash left in the grotto would have made a fine mask for the faces of several dozen sweet ladies, so badly bitten by the hungry little beasts?

The roll-call was upsetting. Nine people were missing, and the real reasons were known for only three: an old man who had allowed himself to die alone on the plateau, and the one man who had insisted that it was better to stay high, because, he said, after a brief burst the body's metabolism slowed up there and one stayed afloat longer. Nobody listened; the grotto, their highest point, was no more than seven hundred metres up, which hardly made it a mountain. And a lonely family had stayed in the grotto, broken in spirit; no persuasion would move them. Weakness of that kind is an easy gift to death. Then whoever was helping with the count realised where the gap lay: the three men left on the plateau. That made six. And the other three? Someone remembered the woman who had run off, the wife of one of the poisoned men. The two still missing were put down to errors in the count, or someone's hearsay.

People howled like oxen. The council of elders insisted that the pointless roll-call stop. Everyone was longing to fish.

They imagined that the fish would swim into their hands. So the horde of bipeds went down to the bank and began to churn cubic metres of water with their arms, like mills or oarsmen, showing once again how unfit and foolish they were. The river there was more than forty yards wide, and hundreds of arms did nothing but catch cold. The bravest waded in and peered into the muddy water. A quarter of an hour passed, half an hour, nearly an hour, and they thrashed about as foolishly as at the start. Tereshchenko went down the line telling each "cog" that it was pointless and they must go on and find a narrower place. It was not easy to make them stop.

And then, luck! But what came into a man's hands was not a fish but some small, darting creature, a lemming or a cousin of one, which had come out of its burrow to become the prey of a man who had come thousands of miles. It was frightening to hold it, with two hundred mouths around you ready to tear you apart for it. They looked at him as a hero. But not for long. A fish is not a mouse. People were struck not by him but by two beavers, or muskrats, swimming a little way off. That was more interesting. The din frightened the animals, which made off downstream. And now nothing could stop the people's wish to eat: not the slanting rain, not the current, not the stony bottom. Almost everyone ran. It was an epic scene, with the pain of falls, a crush along fifty metres of river, and the chase. The current was not strong; it was not a mountain river. But the depth was a nasty surprise, up to the

shoulders in places. Why did they run? Some gave up at the first step, knowing that among a herd of hippos one of the leaders would get the prize. The closer they came to the animals, who knew now that they were being hunted, the fewer people stayed on their feet. It was frightening to watch from the bank: nobody helped anybody up. They were mostly men, and they did not care about their neighbours so long as they could bring home to their family that scrap of wet fur swimming for its life.

The lemming meanwhile was shown to the man's little daughter, and made her mother go faint; she was mortally afraid of such creatures, and asked to have no part in its killing and cooking. Then the little beast tried to escape, giving its captor a small bite, and in a rage he caught it and wrung its neck. He was an educated man and knew what diseases rodents carry. Now he did not know what to do. How was he to skin it with his bare hands? A pleasant-looking man of about fifty sitting beside him offered to help, for a share of the contents. The father refused at first: there was hardly anything inside. But a shining knife, displayed with some ceremony against all that matt greyness, was taken as a firm wish to go into partnership. The "old man," who was not old but whose thick beard gave him the look of one, introduced himself as Yakov Mikhailovich. Calmly and easily, with a mocking eye on the father, whom he plainly meant to shame for his squeamishness, he gutted the creature as it should be done, kept what was perhaps the best piece for himself, and handed the father, on a sprig of some conifer, a mash of little bones with flecks of something like meat. The father looked as if he would be sick. Somebody quietly picked up the skin; somebody got the head. I do not know what they did with them, but it is very possible they ate them.

It still had to be cooked, and there the rule of human society came in again. Either wait for a fire in the evening, at the next halt, or have one now, for another share. He did not want to share. He decided to wait. And soon he had a piece of luck. A man he did not know, though from his own "commune," the loose group who walked together in the column and usually shared a fire at the halts, silently handed him some bark. He had gone into the bushes for the most prosaic of reasons and found, hidden behind young growth, a solitary western red cedar with three trunks, rich in hard, good bark; it grows in northern Washington and British Columbia and, it turned out, rarely here too. He was afraid of water and had not joined the hunt, so he had made what passed for dishes. The red-brown bark, with its few small cracks, was a fair alternative to dirty palms.

Meanwhile the unlucky ones, soaked to the head, were still chasing the animals, and the river was punishing the uninvited guests and favouring the nimble little water dogs. But the people were more persistent. Up to their necks in the water, near the far bank now, four of the most successful at last caught up with them and passed them. The animals tried to hide underwater, but the water was clear where the crowd had not stirred it, and the bottom was firm and bare, without burrows; further down, on the far side, were their feeding platforms, and a lodge in a little teardrop-shaped bay.

Then came the touch. A grab; a miss; it goes under; fools tread on your feet; everyone goes down. But the man smells blood, his own, and stops for nothing, goes under, catches up with the animal again, clutches it to his chest, and comes out of the water on the right bank. He looked rather like the creature he was holding with such careful delight. It fought, but he was stronger. He picked up a stone and smashed its head, and in a burst of ecstasy he threw the bloody stone into the river, where two dozen men were still fighting over the creature's brother or sister.

"Looks like we'll have a feast today," shouted the happy hunter. "Only a tooth each, if it's for everyone, but still. They're getting the second one now."

"That's not the point. Damn it, look for anything that'll do for firewood," Povarnin shouted back from the bank. "We have to warm them, not just cook, or we'll lose those knights who are wearing themselves out for their families, and for us too."

People cheered, and the children, who had watched this wild chase, the first bright sight they had seen that was not entirely terrible, cheered with them. It was a desperate fight of amateurs against something near the bottom of the food chain. The lemming's ten-minute glory faded; the heroes now were those who had caught something bigger.

"Here, here, and there too. Into the woods, more wood, we need more heat. While the weather holds, drag everything you can, and look at your feet, there may be plants, mushrooms, something," said one of Tereshchenko's unofficial assistants, who had earned people's respect for organising skills he had only just discovered in himself. Smaller fry shouted too, hauling branches, eager to raise their own song of praise and to give a few orders, to show their importance and their joy at being part of a system that was doing something useful. So many fine words, and so little done.

On the cliffs above the right bank sat a good many birds, something like petrels, useless as food, but food all the same. Some of them could be shot, if

the men in the water could be made to stay on the right bank while the riflemen fired from the left. But the men in the water could not understand the frantic gestures telling them not to come back. The second animal was caught with great difficulty, and nearly cost a man his life when he struck his face against a boulder in the crush. No: it got away. Only its tail flashed for a second, and it was gone, into its lodge or under the mud. The men's rage was enormous: anger, spite, a sense of their own worthlessness. They looked at the winner as if he too might become their prey. *Why should he be happy, when I am a nobody whom a river rat escaped?* Then the first outburst sank into sullen gloom, and they waded back, clinging to the roots of the hundred-year-old pines that overhung the water on the left like mangroves, gnawed by the animals and undercut by the river.

A zoologist who had been watching the birds glanced at the dead animal and declared it a muskrat, a creature then hardly known in Europe or Asia, which most of them took for some mangy beaver. It weighs perhaps three pounds, and its tail is as long as its body.

The wet hunters waited for the fire, but it was too feeble for them. Five-degree water, for people not used to it, was a great shock, and it would cost them dearly soon, and in the saddest way. The hunt had been born of competition and had nothing to do with foresight and calculation, the conditions of success. That chance catch, like grabbing a departing tram, gave them false ideas about hunting. And they had learned something even more important. There were no fish. There were, of course, but in all the confusion nobody had seen the few that swam past. Raised on novels, they had imagined that salmon and trout would leap into their hands in such a land. But the spawning was long over. They had to face reality, not fantasy. They were not Siberian settlers; the Kamchatka sailors who might have known these things had died with the ship.

The narrow path along the river was the only way they could take. But further on, the kindly path thickened into those same undercut trees.

The meat had to be cooked and shared with whoever the hunter chose as his friends. It was a nasty new rule of life, but it would have been foolish to do otherwise. To divide less than a kilogram of meat among two hundred people was absurd. The count tried to keep this small victory from causing fights, because tension was rising again, thanks to the children, who would not understand simple rules. Instead of lying low, head in the ground like that African bird, and mastering their hunger, they whined and pestered the good man, who stood firm, since he could do nothing for them. There was hardly

more meat on the muskrat than on the mouse; the little body had been mostly fine fur. And nobody knew to remove certain glands, whose secretion spoiled the taste.

The pot that had been meant for broth for the sickest children was lent for it, and the meat was ladled out with a small Danish entrenching spade onto the lucky ones' bark plates. Nineteen people got a scrap each, a bit of leg, a bit of rib, about seven zolotniks, an ounce, and were endlessly grateful to their provider, though they did not even know his name. He had been sensible and not greedy. Yes, he kept a slightly better piece for himself and his family. But to be handed a morsel of red meat on a little spade by an officer and a hero of the Great War was an occasion. And the children, ten boys and girls from four to nine, who swallowed with their eyes that not very tasty but most longed-for morsel, gave him a gratitude that was not put on, almost worship. They even tried to hang the skin round his neck. The hunter was touched to the heart. Only the sinews stuck in his teeth kept him from answering.

Then three marksmen took up rifles and asked those sitting nearby to make room, so as not to get powder or a cartridge case in the eye, God forbid. The shots rang out, out of time and out of step. Two hundred souls held their breath. The birds took off at once, but the distance was short, seventy or eighty yards, nothing for a rifle. Two shots out of three hit. They might have used the fourth rifle, which had turned up lying in the middle of the crowd, abandoned by somebody, one of the swimmers probably; but the count's scruples about property cost them another bird. The dead birds fell, as in a fairy tale, exactly where they were wanted, on the right bank. Now someone had to put down a rifle and run for them.

"Ah, if only we were thirty, or twenty. We'd manage. But such a horde... When I look back I'm horrified that we may become the gravediggers of all these people."

"Or they ours. We'll think of something. Don't fall into the blues. We must go on. A day ago we could afford nothing at all, and now we have some skills. If only we can use them sensibly, and be ready for winter. It'll soon be tickling our noses. In the mountains it's here already. The peaks frighten me."

"If fate drives us into the mountains, we may become Hannibal's elephants. Yes, the crossing of the Alps."

"But as I recall, most of them came through."

"You're wrong. In fifteen days, from fighting with the mountain tribes, from cold, hunger and falls, Hannibal lost half his infantry, of forty thousand

or so, and some of his nine thousand horse; and of thirty-seven elephants about fifteen survived."

"Ah, you heard that in lectures in Moscow too? It's the first time I've heard anyone here talk about such things. But as I remember, that was enough to terrify the Romans. And many who survived, Polybius writes, lost their minds from hunger and exhaustion and could no longer fight."

"Exactly right. Yes, in Moscow. He lost half his men, but the door to northern Italy was open, and he made up his losses from the Gauls, who hated Rome. But we are not elephants, and we have no enemy. And our march will last God knows how long. And there'll be no Italian vineyards and warmth beyond these mountains."

"And no bold general. Perhaps the trouble is that we didn't come here to make war, so our efforts are laughable, like those little hens our gentlemen are running after. They did well, of course. With my eyes and my inability to shoot I couldn't have done it. But it seems we need an enemy, and the wish for revenge, to show what we're made of."

"I don't share your philosophy. We are not Carthage. We were simply unlucky. Like our whole country. But we're alive. And perhaps this is a test from above of our strength, so that afterwards we can go back and kill that snake, that python, that is strangling our brothers in the Maritime Province now, if it hasn't strangled them already. We must come through this, because then nothing will be able to hurt us."

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That same October day, worn out by the weight of the dead husband of fragile little Tanya, Panasevich and Tatyana at last reached the shore. For the last few feet the body moved not by Panasevich's strength but of its own accord, pushed by the wind, which had suddenly changed direction, and by other unknown forces. To have carried a dead man for several miles made him curse everything, his own hands included. Even in such cold, life after death had made itself felt in the plainest way, and on the third day their sense of smell had simply given out. Their bodies could not bear what they sensed. Their muscles twitched; their legs would not obey. Tanya tried to find some edible herbs. Now all three of them, one for good, lay exhausted on that wretched shore. Their eyes turned towards the place where the *Helvetia* had stayed for ever. Fine sand, in their

fury, had got under their nails and into their eyes, and the grit had scraped the faces of those who fell on them.

They had not even the strength to turn over, everything hurt so much. It was good that it hurt. Better torment than the deadly numbness of the body and the soul. Panasevich's gloss had given way to the face of a ploughman worn out with work, drenched in sweat inside that thick warm cloth: heat and cold at once, the labour of muscles that had never laboured before, the cold outside, and the first signs of another storm, or a fever. Tanya was turning into a mummy, or rather into the skeleton of one of the creatures in Conan Doyle's *Lost World*. Her bones showed through even her warm clothes. Only here it was the other way round from Professor Challenger's expedition: the explorers themselves had become the ones lost between the ages.

It was a wonder they had reached the shore at all without meeting wolves or bears. Perhaps the animals had been frightened off by people, now or in the past. Man, with the right tools, can frighten anything for life.

Soon after their "pleasant" rest on the beach, they found food, by chance, thanks to the ebb tide and to somebody's sharp brown eyes. Tatyana, a sailor's granddaughter, choking with joy, made a sound like an animal, which brought the sea elephant Panasevich to his feet faster than any word could have. A few creatures of the sea she had stumbled on became a victory over hunger: mussels or oysters and some other strange inhabitants of the shallows. Seventy in all. For two hundred people it would have been little; for two it was a feast. And the same picture was repeated here every day. On the first day, in their stupor, nobody had noticed the shells scattered along the shore. It seemed one had to go through the whole palette of pain of those five days to feel happier than one had ever felt before.

The distance between these outcasts and "society" was great. But the feeling of a morsel of flesh in the mouth, whether muskrat or mussel, was the same, like twins.

Raw shellfish are dangerous. But the cold Gulf of Alaska and the cold weather, unlike the shores where Defoe settled his Crusoe, kept them fresh. Opening them was harder than expected; a crooked knife that someone had dropped in the tobacco disgrace helped. Cooking them was impossible. Fire was still a luxury they could not keep, like a pet. There was no lemon either, that indispensable companion of oysters. And no chest of guilders washed up for our Robinsons, nor anything more useful, a spyglass, say. In five days of

storm something ought to have come ashore. But the ocean, that Scrooge, had not yet repented. Christmas would come here too one day.

Neither of them had ever eaten such things before, and the look of them, these little filters of the sea, was not appetising. But the brain had decided they were food, so food they were.

"Not bad," pronounced the "mute" Panasevich later, and kissed his rescuer, and got his face slapped at once. The joy had to be turned to work, and there was work enough. The day was so short.

After a little half-whispered talk, sitting by the dead man, they decided to use the boats to build a hut. Nothing else came to mind. One of the boats, the lightest, would be a coffin. It was comic to watch them try to shift the boats by even an inch. The tides had undone what the survivors had done, hauling them up the narrow beach. There were tracks here of birds and small animals, so there might be something better to eat than shellfish. The shelter would be at the edge of the trees, where the water could not reach and the "material" would not have to be dragged far. Going back into the forest was neither sensible nor safe; they remembered the wolves howling on the plateau. The shore seemed kinder. And Tatyana and Panasevich hoped the shellfish would not be a single gift but a regular one. They would find out in a day.

Two people as unlike as could be decided to forget everything that had happened, and why they were here alone. With their bare hands, since every shovel and tool had gone with those who had thrown them out of their insect-colony of a society, they pushed at the boats. One began to move, and after a while, with strength they had hardened only lately, it even slid over the shell gravel. The second had sunk deep, and very nearly buried them. Instead of giving up and going to the next, the gentleman, who still smelled faintly, as the rain washed it away, of spices and that ill-starred nutmeg (though he himself could smell nothing now but the corpse he had carried in his arms for all those hours), went at it until the boat was ploughing its keel through the sand towards the campsite. They used fallen branches as jacks.

Who could have known that three groups of castaways were now wandering this kingdom of nature? Besides the two hundred, and the two who had been buried alive by society, there was a party of sailors a few miles to the south. They should have joined forces. But the sailors were cut off by an island that was, for them, very real, and had turned in the opposite direction.

The wet boats were enormously heavy, and every push cost strength they did not have. They had to rest a long time after each heave. And while they

worked they had to think how to use them: two for beds, the rest set on edge as a kind of palisade, leaning on one another and on the trees. Laying them flat was easy; standing them up was a skill they would have to learn, by trial and error. By the third hour, only the third boat was in their "dry dock."

The wind cut their faces like thistles. All they had was the seven shellfish they had kept back, which they now wanted to eat, with disgust, fingers and all. And thirst. They had nothing to carry water in from the stream. Panasevich's right foot, crushed by a keel when he overrated his strength, was killing him. And this was the third day without sleep, a rare effect of nutmeg poisoning. The girl had lost her spark too.

The only comfort, if one can call it that, was that the dead husband, who had been lying here for four hours, was now covered by a wooden sarcophagus, an upturned boat thirty paces from where they would sleep. It had hardly any gaps, and for a while, in this climate, it might really serve as a grave. Sooner or later, of course, the wood and the flesh would rot and the horror would be uncovered. But there was no choice. There was no spade, and no ground to dig. No Zeppelins flew here. The sky was utterly empty and grey.

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On their fourth day, driven by their fear of the brown bears, the four sailors came, without knowing it, out of the trap of mountain streams, which were more numerous here than lakes in Finland. Their fishing had come to nothing, except that they now had something to defend themselves with, their makeshift spears, though as missiles they were useless. Nothing else happened. No mushrooms, no berries. Only late the next evening, in the most frightening hour of dusk, when the animals are busiest, they saw at three hundred paces some small predator, a fox perhaps, fighting with a fast-moving scrap of fur. The chase turned away towards the slopes of the same mountain they kept running into.

The Alaska Panhandle is everything one dislikes in mountains: broken ground, steep first slopes, countless fast streams, and on top of all that, low marshes. For the whole of the fourth day the sailors were hemmed in by bog. Without turning back, they made for the shore again, and once more the long, bare strip of beach saved them. What astonished them was that in all those bogs there were none of the berries every Magnolian expects; these were young men who knew peat bogs and blueberries and bilberries. Once they met a strange plant of a faded red colour and thought it too dangerous to try.

The night birds, and strange tremors that seemed to come from the depths of the earth or of the forest, turned yesterday's warriors with spears into neurasthenics who stared at every bush. On the beach they came on birds tearing at something stinking that the sea had thrown up with the weed, and the four red-eyed creatures, more like the goblins and water spirits of Magnolian tales than men, went closer hoping for a share. And then they heard a horse neigh.

It struck them harder than the shock that had gone through the *Helvetia* when lightning hit her mast. The men shouted something in Magnolian. The riders behind the low rise, to whom it was addressed, understood nothing. They rode up onto the rise and looked down at whoever had broken the blissful silence. Strange that neither party had sensed the other before, so close; the surf, perhaps, or the lie of the land, swallowed the sound. There were five horsemen, on fine horses, and they were astonished. The sailors shouted joyfully, and that astonished them more. Any trace of the Magnolian tongue on this coast had long since been buried under English and French.

The sailors had heard English now and then and knew it when they heard it. The strangers had never heard a Slavonic language in their lives. An experienced anthropologist could have told at once that the boys were western Magnolians with a touch of the Mongol, but there were no such experts here, only ordinary American fellows, keepers of the peace in a land without lawbreakers. Anyone looking closely could have seen they were seamen; but they were muffled in the coats and furs that the doomed passengers had thrown over them as they left the ship, knowing they would meet death naked anyway. One of the four, a narrow-shouldered youth, wore three coats at once, and looked like a fat country squire who loved riding in a carriage and had been terrified of catching cold ever since his mother wrapped her treasure in several sheepskins at once.

Nearby lay what the birds were eating: the body of a cat, unmistakably a house cat by its fine markings, one of those that had drowned on the *Helvetia*, the first sign that the ocean would sooner or later give back to the land everything it did not consider its own.

The monsters, which no longer much resembled men, mud to the waist, covered in burrs and grass, made the riders raise their rifles. The situation called for a white flag. Any creature that looks like the wild man of the woods makes a man shoot first. That is an exaggeration, of course; the sailors had not yet grown hair like storks' nests or beards to their feet. But five days had left them looking very bad. And these simple, hungry Magnolian sailors did not understand what was wanted of them. After a short pause they calmly began to walk towards the

Winchesters and Marlins aimed at them. Their impudence was answered with a shot, and not into the air but in their direction.

That decided it. They put their hands up. English and broken French had been tried on them and failed, so they were not Canadians or Frenchmen. Not Indians either, though there were still some here, by their European faces. The leader of the hunters, whom the other four had been assigned to guide, was disappointed to have his hunt interrupted, but he was a police officer of fairly high rank, and could not ignore such people. And a small curiosity had woken in him. In his head swam fairy-tale guesses: criminals, or better still foreigners, dumb ones, with pockets stuffed with gold. The gold rush was over, but this coast was still a road for it. Or spies? Whose? In the end, the thought that these strange men might bring in more than a dead bear made him order them arrested and taken back to a small settlement five hours' walk away on Lituya Bay.

One of the riders, dressed like a man of importance, remarked that these were not prospectors and there was nothing to be had from them, but that leaving them would be odd; and what was really interesting was a house cat where no house cat should be. That alone was worth putting off the hunt.

So the chance-met strangers became escorts. After that deafening shot the sailors understood that they had found the very people they needed. Sign language achieved nothing and annoyed more than it explained. But they surrendered peacefully, expecting to be led somewhere and everything to come right. They were content to be led, like obedient sheep. Their working clothes would have told their story without words: the light-grey canvas shirt and trousers worn over the white shirt with its blue collar outside, laid down for the ratings of the imperial navy in 1874. Any thinking man would see that these strangers had not fallen out of the sky, but had come by sea, and lawfully. The gears of deduction would do the rest.

They walked round the dead cat three times, out of superstition perhaps, left it to the scavengers, and set off, south again.

The Americans were sorry to lose their outing, especially the man who had arranged it. His name was Hazen Odell. He had grown up near Springfield, Illinois, in the years after the Civil War, the son of a war hero, and had hunted buffalo as a boy, and caught then for ever the passion for hunting and travel. He was getting on in years now, though he looked much younger; the Indians of the Northwest, some said, believed that killing animals slows a man's ageing. He chewed over his anger at the spoiled hunt and his boyish curiosity, and he

regretted that he would never again feel what he had felt as a boy among the buffalo.

He had seen the end of the buffalo. In 1887 an English naturalist crossing the prairies wrote that there were buffalo trails everywhere, but no buffalo, only skulls and bones bleaching in the sun. Their hides went to Europe for robes and rugs and drive belts for factory machines; their bones went to the fertiliser works; their meat rotted where they fell, except the tongues, which went to the best restaurants of the East. The railways fed their navvies on buffalo, and sold tickets for shooting them from the carriage windows. Buffalo Bill Cody, who killed more than four thousand in seventeen months to feed the men building the Kansas Pacific, and who in 1872 guided the Magnolian Grand Duke Alexei on a buffalo hunt, made a famous show of it all. And in 1875 General Sheridan told Congress that the buffalo hunters had done more in two years to settle the Indian question than the whole regular army in thirty: "Send them powder and lead, if you will; and let them kill, skin, and sell until the buffaloes are exterminated." "Every buffalo dead," said Colonel Dodge, "is an Indian gone." The Americans had their own empire to build, and they built it as empires are built. On this coast they had not yet got round to it; Alaska was far away, and its south-eastern tail further still.

Hazen envied those who had had their fill of buffalo, and made up for it on whatever was left: bears, wolves, coyotes, badgers, raccoons, and once an alligator, which took the little finger of his right hand in revenge. Even such losses do not stop the wish to kill that lives in many of our species. Culture has driven it down into the oldest parts of the brain, but not for everyone, and not entirely.

The St Elias Mountains shone out for the first time, or rather for the first time the sailors raised their eyes to see them, after five days of looking at their feet in the forest. The "locals" had given them no food, but they had given them a direction, along the same shore, which showed no sign of ending. The sailors, a little drunk on the feeling that their fate was now in other, cleverer hands, were secretly blissful, especially when the sunset made it seem that every step took them further from one of the highest mountain systems on earth. They were wrong. The peaks ran on to the east as well, still white, under ice so thick it could hardly be called a cap.

And somewhere far off, behind one of the lower ridges, two hundred and twenty-five living souls were leading themselves by the nose. There had been more at the start, but some had judged themselves too weak and given

up quickly. Some pets had survived too, nobody knew how many; nobody counted, yet. But certain gentlemen were carefully nursing seditious thoughts about the meat on those few dogs and cats. The dead cat on the beach would not be the last. Luckily the four sailors had no such worries.

It was growing dark and cold. The sixth day since the wreck was ending. At last they came to a place where the coast truly broke, not in play as before, and opened onto a bay hemmed in by mountains: Lituya. Here a large temporary camp had been set up by the hunters' friends, who were waiting for the advance party to come back in two days' time, so they could all leave together. There were four huts close together, and another across the bay, plainly built much earlier, and in the pinewood another dwelling, built not at all in the Magnolian way. There were at least thirty men there, well dressed, with everything they needed, run in a military fashion, and a corral for fifteen horses or more, one for each man, which spoke of their standing. They were falconers, among other things.

The talk between the hosts and the newcomers was lively and emotional and on the whole unfriendly. Nobody could explain anything. They roughly made the sailors take off their coats, and found the naval working dress underneath, which puzzled them even more, and changed their thinking. The first idea, to turn the strangers into porters, gave way to what the general council decided. They tried to talk to them. One heavy man brought out a map of the region to find where they had come from. It was no use. The boys could not read a map. In better times such men would not have been taken on such a ship. Two of the four were stokers, who needed nothing but strength and endurance, and two could not read at all; they had been street children whom the empire's literacy campaigns had somehow missed. In another country, with another name, they would later take up that task with tremendous energy, and even so there would always be people in that vast and varied land who could not write. The only thing the sailors understood from the map was where the sea was, and they pointed at it, and that convinced the Americans that they had come by sea.

The night by the great fire, that essential of success in this new world, passed quietly, despite strange sounds of the mountain night, perhaps because of the bay's odd shape among the slopes and glaciers. The sea was restless. The sailors waited quietly to learn what would become of them.

Their fate was decided. In the morning they would be sent, quite simply, if reluctantly, to Juneau, for "further inquiries," more than two hundred kilo-

metres by sea, through gulfs and channels and inlets. The hunters grumbled about having to haul useless men all that way. But neither curiosity nor the sailors' fate was the real reason. Hazen did not regret finding them, and he had persuaded his friends that they could be "sold." He knew what the trade in men was, slavery or no slavery. Officially it was not slavery; in reality it was work for next to nothing under guard. There was plenty of work in Alaska, mostly sawing and felling, for pennies. A couple of his comrades did the same. That was his plan B. But he was genuinely curious where these men had come from, so different from anyone he had seen in his long life. They were certainly from some ship's crew, and by their dress a big ship, everything according to regulations. That too might be sold. To whom? Money loves silence. He left the question to an associate in Juneau.

It was remarkable, by the way, that so large a party of hunters was camped in one of the most dangerous places in the world. Lituya Bay is a fjord seven miles long and two wide, with a narrow mouth over a sandbar, where the tides run at five knots. Again and again, in 1854, in 1899, and later in 1936, landslides into the head of the bay had raised waves of fifty metres and more. On the ninth of July 1958, an earthquake would bring down thirty million cubic metres of rock into the inlet, and the wave would strip the forest off the opposite mountainside to a height of five hundred metres and sweep out over the bar to sea. If that had happened on that October night of 1922, there would have been no story.

The watches had run down long ago. What did the time matter, when the only light was the moon on the glaciers and the yellow fire? The uninvited guests were not allowed near the fire, which was fair enough. Dawn came late here, and the light was dim.

Seven bearded men who looked like brothers herded our unfortunates into a boat. It wounded someone's pride, but the sailors still obeyed. Neck or nothing. They were allowed to put their coats back on and given some soup with bits of fish in it. The small half-decked boat, with a tiny wheelhouse, built for ten or twelve, ran south and soon left the bay behind. The hunters said goodbye without emotion and went back to their horses.

Talking among themselves, until a raw, freezing wind cut them off, the sailors agreed that their road south had been doomed anyway, and that meeting these "trappers," as they thought them, had been their salvation. Nobody wanted to go into the mountains, and the bay had shown that the way south along the coast was closed. Beyond it the gentle shore gave way to fjords and worse, where sooner or later you would fall off a cliff.

The boat went surprisingly fast. Later the wind let them set a small grey sail. The Americans talked without stopping, as if let off the chain, so expressively that it did not fit their gloomy, unsmiling, northern faces. The wind was exactly right, and the little boat galloped over the waves of the Gulf of Alaska, until the shore that had seemed all of a piece the day before broke open, and they made the turn. The boat went on through the night, as if to hide from her guests the treachery of a coast strewn with islets, narrow channels and great islands. At last the sailors slept from exhaustion, however cramped they were. The men sailing her did not; they took turns. On the night of the twenty-third of October the moon was the best of pilots.

The stokers suffered most from the cold and the wet. These two, at twenty-seven the oldest of the four, had worked for years in an everlasting tropic, and now they missed the heat they used to curse as the sweat poured off them. Nothing had changed, as it happened: they were sweating just the same, even in this cold.

These fits of a strange fever had first come on the third day of their misfortunes, and now they returned every night when the cold was at its worst. I do not know if there is such a thing as stoker's syndrome, but there was something one could call that.

It took a full day to pass among the islands of the Alexander Archipelago, all of them under ice and snow: a terrible, primeval place, whose cold the sailors felt in their skins, and which the local pilots threaded with mastery. It was frightening to imagine the *Helvetia* thrown up here. It was further south, not so far from the Queen Charlotte Islands, where she had meant to run down the broad, safe Hecate Strait to Vancouver; but it was better as it had happened, for behind the apparent kindness of a "better" place for a shipwreck (as if one chooses) lay a quiet madness. Without kayaks or canoes one could wander among these islands for ever. There was life here, though, that the others in their mountains had not seen: they spotted three sea otters near the northern shore of Chichagof Island, and near Baranof Island, another island with a Magnolian name, a colony of sea birds they could not name. The archipelago had been sighted in 1741 by Bering and Chirikov, and from 1802 to 1867 Novo-Arkhangelsk on Baranof Island had been the capital of Magnolian America.

Listening to the strangers, the Americans began to suspect that their "guests" were Magnolians: the Magnolian names of the islands, the sounds of their speech, so hard for English mouths. One of Hazen's men had suggested it back at Lituya and been laughed at. Magnolians, here? This was not the Bering

Strait, nor even the Aleutians. And everyone in the world knew what was happening in that strange country; the West Coast newspapers reached even here and were eagerly bought, at a time when America was only just beginning to come out of its long, comfortable isolation. Apart from their own civil war, the Americans had little to remember. Everything had always gone so nicely for them. Victories everywhere.

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The meagre bag, two tiny birds like grouse or partridges, deflated the first excitement as fast as the smoke of the shots blew away. And yet the hungry people did not care how these birds of the tundra had come to live in the forest and the mountains. The answer was simple. When the hunters crossed the river to fetch the bird that had not fallen all the way down, they climbed a little up the steep slope and found, hidden from below, a little clearing of yellowing grass, a tiny oasis of a different world, walled off by nature, where these crested birds lived. Further up there were more such ledges, like scraps of Australian bush, and higher still, fifty feet up the cliff, holes like an ordinary colony of mountain birds. One of the hunters came back, frozen, having hurt his leg, and announced that this was only the beginning, and volunteers were needed to drive and catch by hand the birds that had huddled in a hiding place.

Several dozen men and women started across, and the water rose and grew muddy. A slide upstream, perhaps; they had seen one already. Most of them were back in five minutes, having "tasted" the weeds and the muddy water. But the rest, organised once more, did partly succeed. The cogs of this tribal machine, taken one by one, were worth nothing; that is cynical, but true. Ancient laziness.

That day gave people what they had prayed for. Seventeen carcasses of various creatures, mostly birds, were cooked and presented by various people who thought themselves heroes and needed to express themselves, with such pomp that even the mountains could not stand the flattery and thundered rapturously in the distance with another fall of stones. There was a bone for everyone, and for the most distinguished, two. That is a cruel irony. The hunt that wiped out these peaceable birds, which had hidden from eagles and foxes for years, did not give back the strength it had cost. Two hundred and twenty-five people were hard to seat, let alone feed. The grass was inedible. There were no mushrooms. And overhead, always, the eagles circled, waiting for whatever

they could snatch. They were cleverer than the people. They flew very high, not because they feared the rifles but because their eyes did not need to come lower. About ten of the great birds patrolled that narrow strip between forest, river and mountains where the human race was playing its strange collective game, and the feeling that their feast would come soon grew stronger in their heads.

That first wretched supper in five days was a disappointment. Those who had been in the water had it worst. Fever gripped many who were already ill. The doctors' council, twenty-seven of them, could do nothing; the time had been lost and every remedy ran into the lack of means. On the night of the twenty-third the cold deepened; the river water froze in the few vessels they had. Sanitation was ripening like an abscess. Organised life for so many proved, predictably, mediocre. Fights went on. Several men complained of a great weakness, the mark of those soon to be left behind. They could not wait for water to boil, for lack of pots and fuel. A big river is not a mountain spring; it carries hidden dangers. Every attempt to barter was stopped; three cotton and linen kerchiefs that women meant to trade for a ration were confiscated. Raw water and portions of "meat" that in better days would have seemed a mockery did not lift anyone's spirits. They lay less than an arm's length apart. Those in the forest complained that it was unbearable; the trees, pines and hemlocks, swallowed what little air came in, and the further from the river, the thicker and less passable the wood, which gave some protection from the predators whose tracks they had seen that morning, but made it a close, unventilated place where sickness spread.

The quick sunset left no time to study the way ahead: a rise, and beyond it a dip, and beyond that, apparently, an overgrown cascade of slopes leading nowhere. Remembering the view from the grotto, they chose the way that should, sooner or later, bring them down to level taiga; but one had to live that long. Professor Sadalsky announced that if nothing changed within a week, ten days at most, the survivors of the wreck would begin to die off fast, and the first victims would come very soon. He advised that the guns be kept under strict control, since the state of many people's minds could lead to sad accidents.

At least six people were tearing their hair, among them Semyon Semyonovich's "subordinate." He did not want to die, more than anyone, it seemed. The undercover Bolshevik's wish to be rid of his tiresome junior partner was as strong as ever, but impossible here; he resigned himself to the thought that one never knows what one will become oneself. Neuter irritated so many people that others had to step in to protect him. There were fits of

madness among the women too, and the children, even the adolescents, lately the steadiest of all, were becoming a problem. Here one had to keep busy, and some did so by instinct, carefully sewing buttons onto their coats without a needle. Some children played with whatever was on the ground, straps, odd things, the rare insect, which took their minds off the present.

Snow fell. All night people told themselves that tomorrow it would all suddenly end, and it was a lie. Fewer slept that night than any before. A fifth of them were busy keeping the fires going; others nursed their families, who had fallen to the red fever. They waited impatiently for dawn. The Panhandle was in no hurry to let the light in, leaving the sun only a narrow loophole from which to fight its endless war.

Povarnin, sick with something, was slipping out of the ranks of the rulers of fate, handing his share to the sugar king. But Tereshchenko's own world had shrunk to his wife and daughter, who seemed to have pneumonia. In the night their lungs began to hurt, and he tried to think of anything to ease them.

The night took seven souls with it, little-known people, three of them alone in the world. It came out later that only two had died in the night; five had died the day before, and nobody had noticed, so loosely were people bound together.

Remarkably, the craving of those who had lain stupefied with nicotine on the plateau a few days earlier seemed to have vanished. Silence, as if nothing had happened. They did not even chew what was left in Panasevich's abandoned suitcase. Was it the mountain air? I do not believe it. It was fear, felt once and in a good dose. And the simple lack of tobacco.

Was our herd becoming Panurge's sheep, following one another over the cliff? Not yet; but it was on the way. The trouble was that there was no clear leader. There was a centre, and it kept control of people of very different views; at least the talk of splitting off had died down, except for the few outcasts. Inequality, a Magnolian writer once said, is a law of nature: men differ in talents, even in strength, and so there is no equality among them; every change for good or ill has been started by a minority, and the crowd has followed it like Panurge's flock. That is neither good nor bad. It is a fact of existence, cunning existence, which longs to tear a community apart and finish it off without effort. So dreamed the eagles, and the wolves prowling half a kilometre from the camp.

The discovery of the dead coincided with the general muster. And for the first time a vile rumour was born in some living but diseased head: that *there is*

*a murderer among us, who walks at night and kills whoever he meets, by various means*. The idiocy spread faster than the order to put out the fires and take the remaining firewood. One man's ravings go unnoticed; when several repeat them, they become the truth. That rumour, and others like it, was another hidden sign of a growing collective madness, which could turn these people's lives upside down, leaving them alive but mad for ever.

The dead looked peaceful; there was no mark of violence on them. While the mob sucked conspiracies out of its fingers, the sensible thought about why these people had died and how to bury them. The second question needed only strength and volunteers. The first needed thought. The rest drew away from those who had gone cold for ever, towards the way out they had been shown, up into the hills. A few remained with the dead to find out what had killed them, though standing still meant hunger and thirst and, if it went on, simply counting the hours of death. They soon gave a short answer: cold, and acute pneumonia, the black swallows that had crept in so quietly and taken those sons and daughters of the fatherland.

It was harder to find anyone to dig the graves. Altruism dissolved in a sea of selfishness. In the end the leaders of the expedition took up the shovels themselves, the very sick count barely on his feet, the pale Povarnin, and a few sound men, though they had pleaded and even offered food to anyone who would help. One does not abandon people like oneself, with whom one chatted pleasantly on the ship not long ago. The dead do not ask. One has to understand for oneself what separates a man from an animal. And it was sad that among so many people, not counting women and children and the sick, so few were noble. Honour was disappearing day by day. Compare the showy first day ashore with this, only six days later, and you wonder how it was possible, and why they had been given their lives at the cost of others'. Other people's kindness teaches nobody anything. A great pity.

Someone wrote:

> *The sacred number seven turned out not so sacred. The seventh day of our wandering through these thickets and rocks was defiled by the quiet death of seven people. By elimination we found out their names, though it no longer meant anything. Great trouble is coming. Burying them was very hard; the ground is a wild mixture of stones and sand that will not let you dig. Perhaps it is also our great weakness. It is hard to find a healthy person, and impossible to find a fed one. We made a sort of hollow, bent the stiff bodies, rather like a*

*Tatar burial, checked three times that there was no life in them, as if we did not believe ourselves, and buried them. Three feet deep, reached in about three hours by men who had never dug a grave before. No mound. We covered the place with branches of a weeping spruce the river had broken. We left, hiding our shame behind that rise, into the unknown.*

And the day was only beginning: a short day, nine hours long, two of them twilight. Moving at night was out of the question. Our eyes are not made like those of the creatures that were carefully following the herd of elephants teleported into this grim, dead land. No birds could be shot that morning; either all the partridges had been caught, or the stink of burnt feathers had taught them to stay hidden. The eagles hung on high, like angels, fallen angels, knowing that they would soon be sick of these unlovely, dirty faces of their future victims.

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The doctors did not indulge the sick. They were sick and battered themselves. Some kept dry statistics in their heads; some said nothing and waited for new victims. A small store of spirit was poured down children's throats as medicine. It was on the edge of madness. A young doctor in my youth, I remember, used to prescribe castor oil for heart disease with a clever face and complete conviction.

The children, some forty of them, thin as rakes, were made drunk by even these small doses, and grew more tearful and listless, which was foolish thrice over. Spirit on an empty stomach, for the starving, is unforgivable. But there was worse. The doctor who gave it out was terrified that the precious bottles would be stolen by those who looked on them with a hungry eye, and that the count or someone else would hang him for it; and he managed it all so "successfully," to ease his own trembling little soul, that hardly anyone noticed the grown-up medicine being handed round.

The seventh day brought what nobody expected. For many people the unhappiest day of their lives was only beginning. Mercifully, not every child got a dose of that liquid placebo. The spirit was not ethyl alcohol. It was methyl alcohol, wood spirit, which someone had thrown into a sack at the last moment from the instrument rack in the wheelhouse, meant for some technical purpose. It had been the dead bosun's, and now, after his death, through

someone's anonymous stupidity or ignorance, it became a catastrophe. The label was small but clear, on the bottom of the bottle. Nobody read it. Three bottles were emptied almost to the last drop among twenty-eight children aged three to nine. Fortunately there was not enough for all of them.

The poisoning showed itself quickly. They had gone no more than three hundred and fifty paces when the living organism faltered. The centipede had been limping already, its legs dying off one by one, holding on through its few heroes. And now this.

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A cross made by hand, cleverly put together in the thicket from the branches of a broadleaf tree surrounded on every side by conifers, became a silent obituary for Tatyana's husband. It was a temporary thing, which would not outlast the wooden sarcophagus and would probably fall in the first strong gale. But it gave the woman a little peace to know that her husband would not be torn apart by birds and beasts. And the cross became an amulet too, and a hope of rescue.

It was easier for these two little flames than for those who were only now feeling their first losses on land. For Tatyana and the man she had forgiven, Mr Panasevich, all that was behind them. They had felt it as sharply and as painfully as possible, and now they were not in hysterics or convulsions like their kin. The two strangers who were no longer strangers roamed the shore at the new ebb, which had become a sacred hour, when the Gulf of Alaska laid out its gifts along the beach. Never mind that those creatures of the sea had lately been filtering, perhaps even feeding on, what remained of the people now fixed for ever to one hidden mooring on the bottom. That is how nature is arranged. We are all bound into the vicious circle of the food chain, which makes us killers and victims at once.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

# Landfall



The launch, which had acquired a sail, began without meaning to to think of herself as a great and noble schooner. Self-deception is dangerous but pleasant, even for an inanimate object such as this tub.

She was coming into the capital of the land of the midnight sun. The town lay between Gastineau Channel and the slopes of the mountain of the same name, in the Coast Range, in the taiga. Long before any Europeans came to America, the channel had been a favourite fishing ground of the Tlingit, who had lived here for thousands of years, with their carving and weaving, their songs and dances; it had been a place of meeting and trade, and sometimes of war, for the Tlingit, the Haida and the Tsimshian. The first European to see it was Joseph Whidbey, master of HMS *Discovery* on George Vancouver's voyage, in 1794, who wrote in his log that the channel was not navigable and froze. In 1880 a mining engineer in Sitka named George Pilz offered a reward to any native who could lead him to gold, and a Tlingit chief named Kowee did; Pilz sent two prospectors, Joe Juneau and Richard Harris, who found nuggets along the channel, and within a year the camp was a town, the first founded in Alaska after it became American. It was named Harrisburg, then Rockwell, and then, by the miners in 1881, Juneau. When whaling and the fur trade declined and Sitka emptied, the government moved here in 1906.

At four in the afternoon, an hour before sunset, at the mouth of Gastineau Channel, the boat ran into thick smoke. It was not fog. When she came out of it, they saw the town, rather like Petropavlovsk at a distance, and the cause: a forest fire on its outskirts. The burning trees made a torch, a beacon for the boat coming in, and lit up the part of town that was busy putting it out. Nobody met them; how could anyone have wired from Lituya Bay or

the fjords? From the water the fire did not look so very terrible, nothing like London in 1666 or Moscow in 1812. No houses were burning, only a square of what had been green life yesterday and today was hot ash, stumps, flaring resin and burning cones. The whole business turned out to be a "small" piece of negligence: instead of hiring lumberjacks, of whom there were plenty, many of them failed prospectors, the town administration had decided to clear the land for new buildings by a controlled burn, to save money, and the wind had changed. Alaska was poor. It was not a state but a territory, and had been one only since 1912. In 1916 it had fifty-eight thousand people, and the government could hardly afford to keep them.

The sailors, who knew Magnolian ingenuity, were surprised at how much better their launch was than the makeshift boats at the quay. In the Land of Magnolias, they thought, people tighten their belts only when ordered from above or when they can bear it no longer; here they did it in advance. Those first impressions came to them even in the dark.

The prisoners in their invisible chains were marched down a street paved entirely with planks, the building material of every northern town. Two-storey wooden houses with lamps in most of the windows flashed past as fast as their guide, an energetic, dishevelled bearded man exactly like the brothers trotting after him, and the sailors limped behind, taken by surprise. A turn, straight on. The streets were unlit, perhaps always, perhaps because of the fire, and the smoke made their lungs ache at that pace. They passed a few shadows. And they came to a house in the fourth street back from the waterfront. Juneau then was an outpost of the American nation with three thousand people.

They were put in a dark shed at the back of the yard, stinking of rat urine. The sailors, who by now looked like worn-out wax teddy bears (an awkward oxymoron, forgive me), had expected something warmer, more like Magnolian hospitality. It was nothing of the kind.

They goggled and frowned, and very nearly tried a hopeless little rebellion against the escorts into whose hands they had walked of their own accord. Their ignorance of English was no excuse for the way they had hung their heads and given themselves up to the first men they met. I have said more than once that the people of the *Helvetia*, not all of them, of course, showed a strange meekness exactly when it was least useful, and it turned them into rags. And now the rags, tumbling down a short, steep flight of steps into a cellar, calmed down, with a couple of nice grazes for their trouble.

The Americans had no wish to oppress anybody. They wanted to be rid of a burden for one night, so as to give it to a less respectable trade that still flourished here, though less openly than twenty years before, when every unrestrained prospector who walked, sailed or crawled north was drawn to the Sodoms of Dawson, Circle City and Forty Mile. Even in Juneau, which had never been the brightest star of that time, the fever could still be felt. The spirit of Magnolian Alaska had long since dissolved in that aqua regia, and left behind not a single grain of gold.

Left there without a word of explanation, the sailors stopped being sheep and tried to break the door down, knocking and pounding, to no effect. The door was like something from the Middle Ages, clad in iron plates with studs, and in the dark some of them hurt themselves on it.

The next day, which was no more cheerful, they were led out, more gently, into a good building in which lived the spirit of a pedant and a formalist. At last they could look about them at a little of this small town tucked between the islands and the mainland, and on the whole they liked what they saw on the way. It was better than lonely glaciers, a bare, almost Arctic shore and the cursed sea, which now made them afraid. Every shipwreck you live through leaves the print of a death that failed to beat you, and afterwards calm waiting for the end gives way to waiting for death's return match. The tension they had hidden behind stony faces in the launch had to break against something.

The escorts knocked, said something, and three of them pointed to the open door. The interior made the sailors envious, though they were not allowed far into it. A man came out in a splendid uniform, beside whom everyone looked shabby: a typical European face, a magnificent head of hair, a little cross, perhaps from distaste at his visitors. But the talk calmed him, and he even smiled, and with a gesture that meant *oh, very well* he invited them upstairs, to a floor that seemed still under repair. His private office, with broad shutters and a view of the hills and pines round Juneau, was spacious and grand. Nothing much, really: a desk, caribou antlers, a flag, an inkstand on an enormous empty table, a map on the wall behind it, a varnished parquet floor, and one chair, for him, the egoist. A few pleasant paintings of nature, three of them a little smoked along the edges by a badly drawing fireplace at the far end. Between the cold of reason and the warmth of the hearth there was room to dance. Stools were brought later.

Adam Smith, yet another figure in this endless story, was fairly new to these parts. He had come, it seemed, from some Ruritania, made his name in Seattle as a businessman and almost made a political career there. In America people

had not been the first to notice that trade and politics share a root, but they had been the first to make a living from the fact. Then something went wrong, and, as on a chessboard, from a major piece he was reduced, if not to a pawn, then to a bishop. That is familiar in every big country, which always has somewhere far away to send people. He had tried to be an optimist, and had not drunk himself to death, and in seven quiet years he had become one of those who decided things here. He loved interesting books and people, unlike his misanthropic friends, the way a queen bee loves her workers: each one separately, but not the mass. And now here were some foreigners on his land; not entirely his, he shared it with two "comrades." Naturally he must find out, by playing at an English detective, who these ragamuffins were, and then, once His Quiet Majesty had solved the puzzle, sell them profitably, let them rot, or at best, for the statistics, make criminals of them and put them on the government's rations. Washington complained that there were not enough arrests. That too had happened here.

And you say people differ greatly? Separated by a great ocean, they thought in much the same way.

The conversation went rather well. Adam unravelled the gentlemen's origin. A remark from the bearded hunter set him on the track, and it was confirmed by an enormous map, on which even these illiterate fellows, with some help in pronouncing the names of cities on both sides of the Pacific, found that dear, familiar Vladivostok. Smith was good at riddles, and the first of the morning was solved, and his interest began to fade. The trouble was that nobody here knew Magnolian, not even he, almost a genius of deduction, and every further conversation ran into the foundations of the ruined Tower of Babel. Why are there no dialogues here? How do you imagine them?

The hunters left the puppies with him and, after a short argument, by the sound of it, went off, back to Lituya probably. Adam rang a little bell, a strange relic of the sea, and five clean-shaven, well-dressed men came in: policemen. They worked in the next office; this was not a house but some department responsible for the borough. What exactly this Ruritanian boy, long since a man, did for a living, I never found out. Adam nodded, and the four were led away again, to the back yard, where there stood a strange building with no windows and one door; along a dark narrow corridor; and out onto a yard.

Adam sat alone, thinking of the ashen palms of two of the sailors, the stokers. He was a little puzzled. Their hands were darker, it amused him to note, than any he had seen. And he was consumed by curiosity, which now took a more practical form. Two searches of the strangers' things had proved

beyond doubt that they had been shipwrecked, off the coast of Alaska, near where his friend Hazen Odell had found them. If a ship had gone down and sailors had been saved, then somewhere passengers might be wandering too; and even if not, an empty coast always has something valuable thrown up by the sea. Why not take obedient slaves, buried alive by their own people, or better still, missing without trace? His imagination took flight. He already saw his small colony receiving what would make him a magnate. Cheap labour has always been half of success. He had already put together almost a million dollars, to build something that mattered and justify himself back in the Emerald City; more than a million, in truth, since men connected with him paid him a tribute for express trains robbed in neighbouring states, thanks to information supplied by a young and very ambitious railway inspector named Adam Worrell. But that was in the past. He had changed his name and altered his looks a little. Now he made no mistakes, trusted no "large circle," and did business only with his wife and the friends I have mentioned. Alaska was full of rumours that it would soon become a state, and he was already thinking of becoming lieutenant governor, if not governor.

In his diary he wrote:

> *An interesting day. A little puzzle knocked me off balance and took me out of the routine. I don't know whether to tell Donald or Ronald; not yet; they would laugh. Tomorrow, unfortunately, I leave, and Victoria is just back from Ship Creek (Anchorage), where she has been seeing to the railway business. When I come back I must summon these foreigners for "questioning." I studied the map and made calculations with calipers. But damn it, that town with the strange name is so far from us. I think they are lying. But I will outplay them. Give them a pencil or a pen and paper, and let them draw what they were doing here and how they came. If only I can make them understand, or they will look at me as if I were an idiot. Strange little people. If nothing comes of it, when the provisions run out, we will send them away somewhere as spies of that country, or feed them to the worms, or the usual: the woods. If only Hazen were back; he has gone for a long time; perhaps he will find something. I am getting old. A simple story, and yet I cannot sleep. And those blockheads are still putting out the forest. Soon everyone will know what idiots we are.*

The Magnolian boys were taken to a prison hidden on all four sides by brick and wooden buildings. Have you ever smelled the stench of half-rotten bodies

of living creatures sitting in the pits of Adam Smith's private shop? Their limited welcome turned very quickly into ordinary imprisonment in inhuman holes made for animals. Before the sailors could gasp, the obedient Cerberuses had tipped them into one of the pits with a trip and a push. So much for the Protestant ethic. Though why be surprised? Every church that came to America in the train of a conqueror has blood on it: the Spanish in the south, the Protestants in the north, and the Orthodox, for their part, in the Aleutians.

"We're used to it."

"Why did we go with them..."

"Did we have a choice? Wait. Of course they don't understand us and they've taken us for criminals. I think they're looking for an interpreter. Not that it helps us... The ground's frozen here. It's horrible. Will they feed us?"

"Judging by what I saw on the way here, by the shouts and groans, no."

"Let's try to 'talk' to them. Only what can we bang on? It's dug earth, that's all."

"This is the end, my friends. If they'd wanted to talk to us seriously, not like that odd fellow did, we wouldn't be sitting in the local cesspit."

"Stop talking. What's the use? You're only losing water. Look at the steam coming out of your mouths. It's not certain they'll give us any water. If we can just get through the night without freezing."

"And why the devil did I go on that ship? Not drowned, not torn up by bears, but left to rot in a dung pit?"

"But it's interesting, what will happen. Remember the ones who stayed on the ship. Do you understand?"

"Not at all. Better there than God knows where with beasts in human shape."

"You're saying that because you got kicked in the backside. You went in, you got it. I'd have treated strangers the same. You can understand them."

"You can't, burst or split, it's wrong, damned wrong, to throw us in a pit. I'd like to get out. Let them look for me. If I can't turn back time, at least I'll try to change my fate at the end."

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The sixth and seventh days of the new life brought Tatyana and Panasevich not one shellfish, nor even a scrap of weed. The ebb was weak, the sea almost calm. By the end of the sixth day their little fort was nearly built, though their

strength gave out and they had to move the whole shack five metres closer to the shore, partly. Not the best choice; it lost some of the shelter of the trees, but it was more finished. Eight boats, four of them set on edge in a diamond and braced with stones as big as they could lift, with the smallest inside, upside down on the cold beach. A little under five feet high. The work was done soon after sunset. They still had no fire. They had to drink salt water; nobody would go to the distant stream at night.

The night before the seventh day was quiet, the last quiet night of autumn. No rain, no surf. And then a scream, heart-rending and short. And silence again. And that was all. Much later they would learn the cause: it was the last second of life of one of the free outcasts, who could not keep up with the *largo* of the common life. He had been coming back towards the shore, following the same logic as our two, and death caught him at the very place that had become the grave of the first loss on that cursed land, the little boy. At two miles they heard the scream, which was certainly human. They did not hear the snapping of the jaws that soon fed two wolves. Perhaps it was better that the most terrible sound in the world did not reach them.

Over the ages wolves have learned to fear man and to leave places where he begins to appear. But how strong that fear is depends on hunger, the season, the place, and each wolf's experience. A wolf that has once tasted human flesh easily becomes a man-eater. A mother and her son had crossed that Rubicon, while the father, probably, was dealing with another lost soul, the one left behind in the grotto. They were driven to it by a terrible hunger after what had seemed a recent summer. Wolves cannot store fat as seals or bears do; they must eat regularly, and here that was hard. The forests were poor in game. Most of the animals lived on the islands, away from the predators, and now away from the new men with their stink of gunpowder. When only the native peoples lived here, nobody had been afraid; but since the white men began shooting the deer by the hundred, the animals had been driven ever higher into the mountains, where there were plenty of peaks of three thousand metres, and the lazy wolves had followed them more slowly, and grown hungrier, and bolder, generation by generation.

The scavengers, oddly, did not come to that feast that long night. They would come the next day. There was enough flesh. Those three wolves were by no means the only ones; that wide country was held by several loners and packs. And it was lucky for the two people sleeping peacefully in their absurd boat-house that they had not yet met anything more dangerous than hunger

and thirst, because they had no fire, the one sure weapon against beasts, except against their own kind.

The morning of the twenty-fourth of October began with luck. The ocean gave alms again, through its obedient slaves, as if to justify itself for what had been done with its help. A humanist philosopher, the ocean.

Pacific: a liar to the root of its name. The first European to see it, Balboa, called it the South Sea. It was Magellan's expedition that named it Pacific, because after the storms of the straits it found itself becalmed for weeks in the middle of it, on stinking water and rotten biscuit, hunting rats and chewing the leather off the yards, while men died of scurvy. Of the two hundred and sixty men who sailed with Magellan, eighteen came home. The quiet ocean had been the quiet killer. Our castaways stood on solid ground, and it did not help them either way. And yet was the ocean to blame? The rock had not come out of nowhere. It is men's vile habit to blame anyone but themselves for their own negligence. But who of those looking up at that strange sky knew the details of the *Helvetia*'s last day? They had no time to wonder. They were not recovering from a catastrophe in some café with a glass of wine; they were in a bog where every step might be death. Life does not leave room for reflection.

CHAPTER TWELVE

# Cancelled Sunrise



At four in the afternoon of the twenty-fifth of October 1922, units of the People's Revolutionary Army of the Far Eastern Republic under Ieronim Uborevich entered Vladivostok. Ships carrying the last of the Japanese and White troops had left the city two hours earlier. The last interventionists had left Soviet Magnolia, and the civil war was over. Three weeks later the Far East became part of the Soviet republic.

After Spassk, things went from bad to worse for the Whites. A hundred and fifty versts were covered in ten days, and on the nineteenth of October the Reds came up to Vladivostok, where twenty thousand Japanese soldiers still remained. The Japanese threatened to halt the evacuation if their troops were attacked; the American consul announced in the White press that American forces would take "the most decisive measures" if there was danger. The Reds withdrew a few versts from the city and waited. In those last days, with Diterikhs already gone on a Japanese steamer, a group of Siberian regionalists under one Sazonov declared yet another government, whose activity consisted of pasting handwritten posters about the town, which earned it the name of "the Poster Government," and of raiding the town council for its cash box, which had already been looted. On the twenty-fourth, at the Sedanka halt, the Japanese signed an agreement to leave by four o'clock the next day, and they did. The next day Lenin sent his greetings to the workers and peasants of the liberated territories, freed, as he put it, from the heavy yoke of Japanese imperialism.

Forty years later the communists put up a monument in the central square of Vladivostok to the Fighters for Soviet Power in the Far East: a Red Army man gazing out to sea, watching, in plain proletarian symbolism, the enemy flee to

Japan. Today, when the Land of Magnolias has left its Soviet past behind, most of the townspeople pass it without a glance. Perhaps because the city keeps its own truth about those days. It was, after all, one of the last cities to say goodbye to the old country, holding out, even with foreign help, until October 1922.

Remembering those days, I cannot leave out the others, those who did not sail on the *Helvetia*, who were perhaps luckier. In the civil war the Maritime Province was the last refuge of many great figures of Magnolian culture. From Vladivostok the composer Sergei Prokofiev set out into emigration, and the Futurist painter David Burlyuk, Mayakovsky's friend, and the poet Arseny Nesmelov; and a little later Tolstoy's favourite daughter, Alexandra, left for the United States. Army and Cossack units, with civilians following them, crossed into China and Korea; ship after ship, overloaded with soldiers and civilians, left for China, Korea, Japan and America. Most of the émigrés from the Far East, some hundred and fifty thousand people, ended up in China, mainly in Manchuria, along the Chinese Eastern Railway, above all in Harbin, and then in Shanghai: Cossacks, officers, generals, merchants, intellectuals, priests, peasants and workers, with Ukrainian, Georgian, Armenian, Polish, Tatar and Jewish societies of their own. They had no papers and no money, could not learn the languages of the East, and could not compete with the local people for work. Some reached America, Canada, Australia. For most, China became a second home for many years.

Diterikhs remembered the last days: "On the sixteenth of October 1922 we returned to Vladivostok and found terrible confusion. Order was kept by an officers' battalion; the police had already collapsed. All the rear services had stopped work; sabotage began, and then strikes. People thought only of how to get out, or how to get ready to meet the Reds. And we had to get out all the soldiers' families, the refugees, part of the stores, move the troops to Posyet, evacuate the military schools, the sick, the wounded. It seemed impossible, there were so few means of transport. The Japanese command had ships, but would not give them without Tokyo's permission. In the end it gave in, and on about the twentieth the families began to be taken to Posyet on a Japanese transport. The Reds followed on our heels, but did not press us hard."

And a journalist named Shcherbakov, who lived in Vladivostok through the civil war, wrote: "What wasn't there! Parliaments with factions, and an army, and magazines, and universities, and congresses, and even, oh archaism, a Land Assembly. As if the whole of the old Land of Magnolias, given a three-year reprieve, had shrunk microscopically into that stone cauldron, so as to crawl

out again along all the shores of the Pacific, frightening the colonial misses with shaggy forelocks and sun-bleached tunics." And: "A strange life flowed in Vladivostok then: anxious, sharp, absurd, upside down. And what people washed up there! A man bearded to the eyes sells a Chinese a bag of gold dust panned near Okhotsk. Beside him a lean olive-skinned Italian changes his lire, and a square-hewn Yankee sailor chews rhythmically, like an axe. And everywhere, the unsleeping eye, scurry the short-legged Japanese, swarming in every corner of the city and over all the forts of the once-mighty fortress, like ants on the cooling paw of a beast not quite dead."

When a new power comes into your house, repression is inevitable. The civil war proved that as nothing else had, humiliating and killing on every side of the conflict: not both sides, every side, for there were always more than two. One of the first victims was that poor simpleton, the watchman in the port who had turned on the two strangers. On the night of the twenty-seventh of October he was killed with a bayonet by a gallant soldier of the People's Army. Was his death justified? He was ill, after all. There is no answer. But it was thanks to his illness that two perfectly healthy boys, Vanya and Sasha, had lost their lives.

And in those days, when the white sunrise never came and the sun turned red, like Proxima, the crimson dwarf of Alpha Centauri, their countrymen four thousand miles from dying Vladivostok were perishing in a struggle with an invisible enemy on a land that was no longer theirs, as if repeating the fate of everything they had believed in and lived by.

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On the last day that was entirely the Whites' in Vladivostok, something happened by the river that split and killed the society which for several days had more or less fought together for its right to live.

The methanol did not take long. Since the "medicine" had been given almost all at once, thanks to that idiotic Magnolian saying that *if you give a dog vodka it'll stand up again*, or something of the kind, the murder happened almost at once, before their parents' eyes. Five millilitres of that stuff is enough to destroy the sight; thirty, a hundred at most, is fatal. And these were thin children. Almost instant blindness. They fell, one after another, to the ground, and without a word, almost, they died. Very fast. One cannot call the effect of falling dominoes fascinating. It was the most terrible thing any of them had ever seen.

Who had laid this curse on them? People who had barely gone a few steps threw themselves on the ground, trying to bring the lifeless bodies of their children round. Chaos, hysteria, panic, horror, a growing madness in the eyes. What could have happened in those minutes? The children showed no sign of life: one, two, five, seven. All poisoned. The parents wept; no one was left unmoved, no one at all. Overhead, the old friends, the eagles. Their time was coming. But nobody looked at the sky. Everyone was saying *what's wrong with you*, *live*, shaking the dying and the dead. Too large a dose for such small bodies. Grown men, healthy ones, would have gone blind as quickly, but would most likely have lived.

The "doctor of death" was bewildered. Nobody was looking at him yet. He did not understand what had happened himself. The mortally sick Povarnin lost his self-control and fainted at the sight of the bodies laid out in rows. Tereshchenko was swallowed by the crowd trying to revive the children. The powerful became what they really were: lost sheep, their minds disordered by hunger.

The bacchanal went on a long time. Reason did not return. They blamed someone. They tore their hair. They tried hundreds of times to bring back the souls of the dead. Nothing helped. The rain began again, timidly mourning them. Never before had this corner of Alaska borne such a weight. This was not Dawson, not Nome. People were not used to dying here, still less in such a strange way. In this story everything comes so fast, so suddenly, so mercilessly. You are used to reading of death as if it were a concert. I want you to see that it is a flash. And again and again, the same thing, death, a word repeated for the three-thousandth time. Be damned, go away.

Even the animals hid, sensing that something was wrong. Anyone who had cared nothing for what had fallen on them from the sky might have tried his luck catching birds at the edge of a little oval lake beside the river, a glacier pool perhaps. But who was looking at that now? Hunger was not a disaster. This was a tragedy, which had taken the best of them again. Lose the purpose of your life and you lose your mind, very quickly, even if they were not your children.

Did the people who loaded the boats with shovels know why they were burdening the survivors with them? Nobody had thought about it then. Now, eight or nine days later (counting the days had become the last thing anyone thought about there, on the slope of a low ridge of the same Cordilleras, by a stream and a little lake), the tool invented by the Dane Linnemann was the

most needed thing of that day. The ground was soft for once, and digging was fairly easy. The parents did not dig; they could not leave what had happened. Anyone with strength left dug. The dead could help no one. Fifty or sixty people collapsed on the ground, feeling they could go no further, not yet, and the doubt whether they would ever go on made their exhaustion worse. The surviving children crossed themselves as never before.

Someone suggested at first that it had been gas, a breath of methane from the mountains, the canary-killer every miner knows. But there was nothing around that could have been its source, and it would have struck everyone, not only the children, who had walked mixed in with the rest. After several agonising hours the answer came. The crowd's fury turned on the young doctor. After their first stupor and a spell of amnesia, they remembered him.

Their lives had stopped at the moment their children lost their balance. But we are changeable creatures, and one reaction to shock gave way to another, more active one. Those who saw the frenzy growing and did not think to protect the lost young doctor acted very wrongly. He was an honest man and did not mean to run. He just sat there, understanding nothing, like everyone else. He still had the bottles with him; for some reason he had not thrown them away. The inflamed mind of the crowd found its answer at once: he had poisoned their children, since he was the last to give them anything, the stuff he took for medicinal spirit. People knew, of course, that there are different kinds of spirit, and everyone had heard horror stories of poisoning by bad liquor.

What happened next split the people for ever into several groups. There was no real organiser among them, no Cromwell. The count had lost all his strength and looked like a corpse; his pneumonia was getting worse. Few knew that he had only just recovered from tuberculosis, and although he had taken charge so briskly on the first day, he could only ever have lasted a little while, and here every day counted for three. Tereshchenko too could barely stand; he had fallen badly two days before, and had lost his voice, speaking only in a whisper since the evening before. There was no thought of another assembly. The handful of wise men could find no one to carry out their ideas. There was no good manager among them, as the whole week had shown. The first orders and divisions of duty had never grown beyond the seed. By the fifth day the organisation of their life had fallen apart, and nothing remained of its early successes. Everything cannot rest on two men, especially when both are sick. Who was healthy here? It was endurance that counted, and the leaders'

was mediocre. It was remarkable that the crowd had not yet dissolved into Brownian motion. A society keeps its reflexes for a while even when its head is cut off; but not always, and not for long.

They began to tear at the young doctor, to beat him, to torment him. If they had been able to think as they should, it would not have happened. What was strange was not that in the end he was beaten nearly to death (he died anyway, afterwards, of internal bleeding), but the pleasure, the predatory grin, with which people who had just been sitting over the warm bodies of their children finished off the man they believed had poisoned them. Not everyone believed it. But many beat him, with a good appetite. His father and mother were sitting beside him, and they were beaten too, defending their son. When the forces are unequal, you get what was seen there: a pool of blood, skinned knuckles on dirty hands, panic and voluptuousness together. And it was all done so fast that no one could have stepped in to mediate, or even to stand guard like a legionary in front of the victim.

From that moment the society began to come apart. It was not only what had happened. The human beings there had reached something like a split personality: indifference on one side, struggling with a selfishness that was not quite its opposite; and on the other something no single word describes, heavy, strange, vile, made worse by the nearness of death, which a man begins to wait for, and which does not come, and does not relieve him of his troubles.

And again the inner storm, which touched even those who pressed themselves to the earth and prayed not to be touched, demanded more. The enemy lay lifeless now, and his parents, beaten as cruelly, mourned him by the same simple script. And then the urge to throw off that black energy turned inwards, and disfigured still further people who had received a second helping of evil that day. Was it like the Battle of Fallen Timbers? There were a couple of fallen trees, but no horses, and no Indians. It was more like a mass self-immolation without fire. Thank God there was no fire in those hours, or someone, as always in such roaring minutes, would have been thrown into it.

Then came the slump that the body demands, a vicious apathy. Vicious, because there was no one left to vent the bitterness on. But, as always, the need was soon met. The tension in that company, surrounded by twenty corpses, passed the point of no return. On the most foolish pretext, what they had all been heading towards for days began. Everyone knows that weariness with the people one lives beside for a while, by choice or not, when everything one has noticed and resented comes out at last in ugly words. That was the second, final

stage. They wanted to escape the reality of the wet earth and the dead, and they did.

What happened next is a dark place in this story. Nobody knows what set off the storm. Someone broke his chain and began to beat whoever was near him, with incredible force, and for some strange reason the relay passed from the mourners to everyone else. Was it like a painting by Bosch? Or Bruegel's *Triumph of Death*? We can only judge by what it left behind.

The one person in a relatively sound state of body and mind who lived through it was a little girl, who fell asleep despite all the dreadful flickering. Her father had been secretly feeding her edible plants; like any man from Perm, he knew the forest. Asleep on the bare ground, she dreamed lovely dreams of the past, lost for ever, of a table laid with little Perm dumplings and fried burbot and chanterelles: everything she lacked in that terrible reality, where she held on steadily while the grown-ups nearly killed one another for nothing, losing the last rim of their reason.

The ground was trampled. One cannot call it a battle; what battle is it when the enemy is yourself? The bodies of the dead still lay there, partly trodden now. The madness reached its height after an hour and ended in bloodshed, and even in deaths. One thing was clear: with so many people, there was no future. One could not be one of many in such a situation. One had to be alone. But that was still to come.

The birds of prey, smelling blood, began quite calmly to make their way to the bodies and peck at them, regardless. Their patience too had snapped after three days of waiting.

A few understood that from now on they must keep together, but in small groups. And since at least half had disgraced themselves in the bacchanal on the bones, there was no point in talking to those half-wits. One of the first to understand this was Prince Vladimir Vsevolodovich Obolensky-Kaspiysky. As soon as the fighting died down, not because anyone stopped it, for no one could, but simply from exhaustion, he began to run about looking for people he knew, and people who were, as he saw it, still human. While the most violent were busy with the burials, he found his allies. He picked them out with his eyes, and they answered, understanding at once in the language of looks what must be done. They were mostly those who had been at the professor's evening and had lived to this day. It was hard to find them; some were face down, holding their heads, bloody, beaten, sick, overgrown, filthy, nothing like the sweet-smelling, handsome people of that August night. The ladies looked

worst of all, of every age, like the beggars and servants of the stale, unfunded almshouses of the provinces, where a servant's wage was thirty roubles a year, below any limit; he knew what he was thinking of. Total poverty, in the Kazakh steppe, on the Volga.

For Pavel Kurbatov, another of those who had escaped in the very last boat from the sinking *Helvetia*, and who wandered over the "battlefield" not knowing what he was looking for, over the grey, cold, sticky clay that showed through a thin sprinkling of soil, it was like the trenches of the Eastern Front, the horror of 1914 and 1915, the Great Retreat, which he had lived through after the mobilisation, far as his home was from the western border; the loss of Galicia and Poland, and the dead and half-dead lying in the same frozen poses on different earth. What disgrace that had been, and what shame now. It was a time of inglorious things linked one to another, without end.

The cursed day ended. It had taken at least thirty lives, most of them by the methanol, but ten or so for nothing at all. Though what am I saying? Everyone here, from the street boys onward, had died as inglorious a death as their whole age, like most violent deaths in this unjust world.

The coming evening was the quietest of all. Vladimir found thirty or forty people who were ashamed of what had happened. They honestly took their share of what could be called property, which was lying about unguarded, and went off, silently, along that invisible road into nothing. A few more joined them later, quietly, ashamed before the others. The living links of the Colossus began to drift apart, dissolving shamefacedly in the last rays of a sun which, for the first time and surprisingly for autumn, gave them a beautiful clear evening, breaking its oath to the grey sheet that always hid it. The Colossus hardly noticed. It had lost fifty living, and kept its majority, together with the dead, and did not condemn them. On the hill remained the weakest and the most aggressive. A fine symbiosis. Why was the split bloodless? Because the disgrace that had happened could not be justified, and they all knew it.

Mr Krusenstern remembered afterwards: "The ice cliff, scarred by quarrels and clouded minds in a lost world, cracked when no one expected it. A man I knew came up to me and whispered that we must get ready and follow him. I was surprised when he went on and repeated the same words to some people and not to others. I did not know then who he was or why he was doing it. Around me lay three wounded men, moaning, and further off the dead, the murdered, the dying, the barely twitching. The ring of shovels on the earth told me that we were still alive, or rather that I was, among a great human family

living out its last days. And among those intangible wooden crosses, his words gave me a small hope that he would save me. It was hard to get up. The cold ground seemed to have nailed me down. The fire had warmed us a little before; now the frozen earth, as the frosty night came on, held my clothes like a magnet. But I overcame it. Rising half upright for the first time in six or seven hours, my stomach nearly had a heart attack; I felt all the greatness of its poison, devouring itself. I went, slowly, stumbling, kicking people who sat and lay everywhere. Only a few were upright, like the boys of the burial details of the old wars, going over everyone left on the field. When I looked at them for the last time I saw only eyes full of tears. It was hard to look at faces. The roses withered too fast. The eagles' attacks grew bolder. One could not fight them off alone. They went for those who showed no sign of life, and the living fought for the dead. That could not go on for ever. Even three shots from one rifle did not frighten them. We left when it was almost completely dark. Only the clear evening, the sun's gift, let us find our way by the moon, though the mountains hid it. High mountains. We walked badly, slowly, teeth clenched, in silence. Now and then we heard footsteps behind us. People were joining us. That night walk will stay with me for the rest of my life."

The mountains hid from them one of the great sights of that country, Alsek Lake. Wandering along a "young" river, they lost sight of it. Even with maps one can lose one's way here, so changeable is a nature that seems unchanging. The river they followed was something of a mirage: a few years later it dried up and stopped feeding the lake seven kilometres to the north. Their exact route has never been traced.

Not everyone lived through the night before the ninth day. Who looted those empty suitcases nobody knows, but besides the rifle the departing group had taken, the other three were lost for good, probably because yet another group had formed, which could think of nothing cleverer than to go back to the shore. It was twenty miles away now, or fifteen, uphill and down, round and across rivers, a distance they had covered in a whole week in a slow party of two hundred, with halts by day and night, less hungry and less weak than now.

Their great mistake had been to walk as a single crowd, inventing their way as they went. They should have split up much earlier and gone in different directions. And the boats, and the storm of the first three or four days, had played a great part in what happened. The boats, in which they could and should have followed the coast looking for signs of people, would have been the simplest way out. Yakutat was seventy or eighty versts to the north, or less,

though reachable only by sea, because a great river, the Alsek, flowing into the gulf just north of where they had landed, cut the thin coastal strip, and could not be forded. To the south, by boat, it was hundreds of miles through the archipelago. They knew none of this. Nothing they had been given, except the shovels and the lamps, could have helped them decide.

And they had no idea that they were a mile from the international border. A notional border, unfortunately. Of course the Canadians would not have let them in if there had been a post on the left bank of that nameless river. There was none, and there could not be. If Canada had put a platoon on every twenty miles of its frontier, there would not have been enough Canadians to man it. They had reached the narrowest part of the United States, won with such difficulty in that arbitration, and sooner or later they would have met the land of the maple leaf and the beaver, the moose and the Mounted Police, those very necessary Mounted Police.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

# Crossed Out

VLADIVOSTOK, 20 OCTOBER 1922

The Admiralty, the government and the port authority had practically ceased to function. Everyone was running, as far from the city as possible. Ivan Savelyevich Frolov, formerly a captain of the second rank, now the "Captain of the Port," was tormented by the fact that a ship put under his authority had neither made contact nor arrived at Vancouver, let alone at her destination. The steamer *Helvetia*, with four hundred souls, was missing. Since the fourteenth of October he had been sounding the alarm and reporting to his superiors that after her last contact from Petropavlovsk she had not called Anchorage or any other station. His work left him little time for it, but in his sleepless nights (and he had many, like everyone who was saying goodbye to Vladivostok and knew he would never return) he tried to work out what had happened to the ship and her people and how to find them. Time was against him.

He was not, in fact, the Captain of the Port. That old title, long abolished in all but name, was simply a fine-sounding label for a nameless post, a sort of last commandant and quartermaster of the old harbour, responsible for everything that happened in it. Vladivostok in those last months was saturated with such titles and ranks, drawn from different eras, from reforms and the counter-reforms that cancelled them; people called each other by the old names, if they knew each other. Until August the Japanese had run the port. When the work of the evacuation began, they put a Magnolian in charge, a tired man who did not know how to say no. Ivan Savelyevich was a man of enormous generosity of spirit, and he did calculations round the clock, shouted at the workers, drove

them, hiding a serious illness that had come back the moment he returned to work, doing a job that in peacetime would have needed several young men. There was a shortage of people everywhere. Behind them lay four years of war and millions of crosses and émigrés who would never come back. As always, only the very old and the very young were left. Diterikhs's "elderly republic" was coming apart at the seams for that reason too. Clever people did not want to run a ball in a looted harbour; it was more interesting to wave a handkerchief once and sail away somewhere, or else die in the last days of the war near Spassk.

Mr Frolov tried with all his strength to make someone take up the matter of the missing ship. In a government that was being hurriedly evacuated, he got only brief excuses: there were more pressing problems; it might all be fine; one must wait; there was no point raising the alarm. He could not stand such unconvincing indifference, and four days before Vladivostok fell, feeling with every fibre what any city feels under siege, he set out to see his superiors in person. And he discovered what no one was supposed to know: none of them were there. Only nervous little secretaries, scurrying out of the building with small boxes. In front of the temporary "Admiralty" documents were burning. The government building was fenced off. One could still get in with a pass, and, by the bureaucratic principle that still somehow worked, he had to walk some distance and go through a heap of pointless formalities to get one. He got it, despite the glassy eyes of the sweet girls who issued them, who were also planning to run and were working their last day. He was the first and the last man to come to them for "permission" that day: a grey-haired old man in footcloths, dishevelled, red-eyed from two months of reckoning almost alone, with only the help, now and then, of a local bookkeeper. He had worked out provisions for sixteen steamers in that short time, without any calculating machines, and he was crushed by it, above all in his mind. For two months he had worked fifteen hours a day, on maps as well.

He was on his way back to the government building when he realised he had forgotten what he had written the night before: a long letter, a reflection and an appeal for action about the fate of the ship. He had to go back for it. Vladivostok was flooding. He walked, barely, over the empty cobbles of one of the central streets in his simple clothes. His heart hurt badly. But he walked on, wanting to help. He was the only one who remembered the ship. By the worst reckoning she should have been in Vancouver by now, and even in these times, by roundabout ways, they should have heard of it here and sighed with relief. The route was an experiment; only three ships had taken it, one of them

slightly differently. As a former cartographer Frolov had been against it. But, as usual, someone thought it interesting to try. He worried not only about the *Helvetia* but about two later ships of the same class, whose fate was also still unknown in Vladivostok. Soon there would be no one here to report to. Ships leaving the Golden Horn after the fourth of October had been told that if they could not raise Vladivostok they should report to Harbin or to the Japanese ports. Petropavlovsk could not help either. It was still holding out, in its last days too. On the second of November the White detachments would leave it on the steamers *Sishan* and *Magnit*, and on the tenth the partisans would come in. And then it would all end. Or begin. Depending on who you were.

He went home, almost to the edge of the city as it was then, sat down at the table, took the letter out of the drawer and put it in an old, old envelope. He changed his foot-cloths and pulled on the boots of his youth, which he thought were waterproof, ignoring the pain of his badly swollen feet. He fed his tame talking parrot, which, instead of falling on its food (the lonely old man had not been home for two days), threw itself onto his shoulder so that he could not pull it off.

It was a splendid parrot, brought by a friend of German origin from the former German islands of Micronesia, a colony of a vanished empire, seized by the Japanese at the start of the Great War. The friend had been a war correspondent, a man of two languages, who had been at Tsushima and was one of those who got away, all the way to Madagascar, where, being free of military orders, since he had been there almost by chance, he lived for several years; and then, travelling back to Vladivostok with a mass of notes, a Magnolian subject, he had managed to reach German Samoa, which was just like him, where he was given this clever bird. In 1918 Hans Hermann Höpfner died, never having recovered from a misfortune on one of his journeys through Manchuria; a few weeks before his death both his legs were amputated for gangrene. Knowing he could not care for the bird, he forced it, against its fierce resistance, on his only friend in this city; he himself had lived nearly all his life in Harbin. The bird took the loss of its master hard and almost died of grief, so perceptive was its soul, like that of some dogs and cats. But in a few years it had got used to Ivan Savelyevich, and became his family, and eased his loneliness.

Now the parrot behaved like a mad crow. It even pecked its master when he started to go out. Brushing it off, he tried to shut the door so that it would not get out into the street, which would kill a tropical bird. He could not. Orion, for that was its name, insisted with everything it had that Mr Frolov

should go back. But a sense of duty, hardened by years of service, came first. He trudged through the puddles of his poor muddy suburb. He met only one person, a woman whom people still called "Madame Fontaine," the widow of some general, who had taken to drink. She was walking with empty buckets to a nearby tavern, not for water but for scraps to feed her animals. Strange: a peasant woman in fact now, she had not lost those bourgeois habits that were vanishing with people like her. He greeted her with restraint, barely seeing her through the dense, slanting, cold autumn rain, and cut short the conversation she began by remarking that her buckets would fill up with water very quickly that way, and what did she want water for, that wasn't what she was going for, was it?

The parrot was soon soaked and could barely stay in the air. The old man was furious with it, but could do nothing. Three hundred paces on, as he went down towards the centre, he was seized by a terrible pain in his heart. He could not stop now. He had had such pains in recent months and had saved himself by lying down. But he could not allow himself to go home a third time. There was the water tower, the saviour of the people of the suburb on the hill in the dry spells when their shallow wells ran dry. Beyond it the road grew treacherous; the ground was sinking, little mudslides ran down the hill and flooded the houses below. There were no proper drains then. Orion pecked again and again at the peak of his cap and screamed, feeling that soon it would fall to the ground; every bird knows what flying in weather like this leads to. There were no palms here, only bare single trees, and its devotion to its master would not let it go. His legs went numb and would not obey him. He leaned against the rough, cold wall of the water tower and felt the full force of the attack, trying to knock his heart out of his chest. He fell.

The parrot screamed, as if begging for help. The rain grew so heavy that the streets turned milky and the sky became thick and impenetrable. The man was dying. He lost consciousness from the pain and fell into a small trench along the wall, which soon killed him. There was water enough in it to drown a child, and as the rain went on, as it had for two days, like a monsoon, the water rose to the level that was needed, and he drowned. No one would envy such an inglorious death. But he never knew it. He had closed his eyes in time and left his shell.

Orion was lost. It sat on its master's body, unable to bear the rain, and that night it died, of the cold most likely, like a faithful dog. The envelope with the long letter lay in the water, and the cheap ink did what cheap ink does.

Ivan Savelyevich was found four days later by two soldiers of the People's Army who had just entered the city. The locals had either left or did not come out of their houses. The rain went on for two more days and brought landslides and ruin, and if anyone was still living on the slopes of that hilly city, it was mostly the poorest, indifferent to politics, abandoned by both sides, and nobody noticed the figure of a man two-thirds hidden in a gutter beside a water tower shut for the winter, in a quiet lane. The soldiers were sorry they had looked.

So ended, without glory, the operation, never even begun, to find out what had become of the passengers of the *Helvetia*. Everyone forgot about her while the city was still in White hands, and she dissolved entirely, like those lines in the puddle, when the people we call the Reds came in. The new power had no interest in traitors who had fled, and no means of finding a former Japanese ship with a European name and a Magnolian crowd aboard, even if it had wanted to; it did not even have a state yet. The Soviet Union would begin two months later. And for at least a decade the West, the only civilisation of the time, which had enslaved almost every continent by the old colonial method, except for one great red patch where Europe meets Asia, would not even talk to it.

The story of Ivan Savelyevich is in this book as a tribute to the one great-hearted man who left behind him a timid attempt to find out what had happened to the ship. Sixty-seven years later it came to light that the letter he had been carrying to the burning, fleeing government of the Black Buffer was one of three copies, and that one of them survived to our day, instead of becoming paper for some proletarian's cigarette, or for something more practical. You understand me. He never managed to wire it where he had meant to, to a little-known intergovernmental organisation abroad; that was learned from the last page of his diary, which was seized with his papers, since it held all those interesting calculations and figures over which various "investigators" would sweat later, once things settled down, and thanks to which the heads would roll of everyone who had stayed behind and appeared in them in any capacity. His papers were found quickly. By then the agents planted in September had learned everything they needed, including the address of one of the men they thought most important in the city.

He had all but foreseen what had happened to the ship, and wanted to make sure. His instinct was right. But his thought never arrived. And even if it had, no one could have reached that coast and got an answer in time. Every last

evacuation is a one-way road; there is no one left to keep the lighthouse at the port of departure. Those few relatives and friends left ashore never suspected anything had happened. In those days the world was not yet connected so that everyone could speak to everyone. Those who had gone to China and Korea dropped out of one another's lives for years. Once again, as at the other end of that vast country, families lost one another, and people became for each other missing without trace, and most of that disorder was never undone. The governments in exile, of which there were several, as is usual in such foolish times, did nothing so centralised and important as checking lists of arrivals at particular ports. The most they did was help themselves to what was left of the money, print anti-communist newssheets, and give some charity to the needy.

One can only compare Mr Frolov, fallen dead, and his faithful feathered friend. Ivan Savelyevich was the city of Vladivostok, it seems to me, and the parrot, with all respect, its remaining people: the broken stone heart of the city, bursting out of its chest with the heat of a blast furnace, cooled against its will by the rainwater, by the ocean that surrounded it on every side; and the clever little creature, faithful and honest to its master to the end. We are all the vassals and servants, the footmen and younger brothers, of our towns and villages. Vladivostok had ceased to be the last frontier. The White past had gone over the horizon, weeping at the last for its heroes, those few, and somehow forgotten, people with a capital letter.

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Here too, on the edge of the Canadian territory of the Yukon, enormous and almost empty even a century later, the wolves were losing their patience. A small pack, fewer than ten, could not go on circling the people for ever, and seeing through the trees that something was happening on the slope, a convenient place to attack, they began to stir. People had never been their prey before. But hunger, which ruled this fine family too, forced them to do something.

The crowd went on burying its dead in the night, breaking every Christian custom, and that made those still in their senses set right the one weapon against predators they had lacked: fire. Digging in pitch darkness was not only awkward but frightening. The hungry people, praying to live till morning, when they would drink the river dry and look for anything to eat, were losing their coordination. They took turns at the hard work, but they had not the strength, and it went very slowly. Still, they got a fire going, and luckily it drove

off the birds and the timid wolves, for that night at least. The company, reduced by a third, forced itself to fight on. The night seemed to tell them: do not die; keep hold of yourselves.

The limit of their strength, reached that afternoon, turned out to be a lie. Astonishingly, they still had not frozen or stopped. The evening had to be forgotten, nailed down in their heads with an iron nail meaning *a sin in a fit of passion*, or something of the kind. Their minds had given their first and last warning. Their movements grew worse and worse. In the dark someone accidentally chopped off a dead man's fingers. That was a trifle beside the beaten, the sick, those slowly freezing to death and losing their fingers and toes to frostbite. The morning would show what not every eye had seen in the evening. Those who had seen it had gone on ahead.

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Despite the darkness, the moonlight showed the departing group that ahead of them the vegetation thinned: bare mountain slopes, a broader riverbank, a level, open stretch, and a freezing wind coming down from the peaks on both sides. The open ground had one advantage that outweighed all its faults. There was no fear, the fear that comes to so many in great dark forests. Nothing hindered them in crossing that six-verst stretch and reaching a place where two rivers met crosswise. One of them, their old companion, turned out later to have a strange name: the Tatshenshini. Here it was at least a hundred and fifty metres wide; from the fatal hill they had mistaken it for a lake. The ground here was like the beach on the gulf, which explained the lack of trees; the river had covered it a few hundred years before. They walked easily to where the ground dropped and the smaller river crossed in front of them. It was wide too, and impassable. The risk of deep water, a false bottom, or the other tricks of rivers, at night, stopped them. They made camp, meaning at dawn to go downstream and find a crossing. The one good thing was that across that mountain stream the same easy ground went on, with few trees, which kept close to the slopes of a high but gentle ridge.

Someone dared to go to the slope, and soon the most important thing for survival, after water and the food they still lacked, was found and brought: brushwood, from a grove five hundred paces from the camp, though the tall pines "bit" the intruders and gave the people on the bank a fright. Sounds from the mountain told them there were animals here. Someone thought he heard a

moose. They decided not to hunt in the dark but to wait for morning and the river crossing, if it was possible at all. There was always plan B: go up into the mountains and do the main thing, hunt anything at all. That logic was rather like the wolves', who had stayed on the other side of the hill, besieging the main rabble at middle distance and not yet taking their chance.

Afterwards, some of them wrote about that night.

> *I always wanted a house in the forest, far from everything, a place to be alone, to be myself, to enjoy the beauty of nature, listen to the birds, become part of the rain, feel that incredible sense of life when happiness fills you and you want to run like a child. But after those events I never remember my dream. It became a terror for me. I never want to see a forest or mountains again. I hate silence. And, of course, hunger.*

> *Eight days into our "walk," we were going nowhere for no reason. I had seen a broken compass and some sea chart on the first day ashore, and I never understood why none of it was used. We walked because we walked, not towards anything. It seemed to me quite clearly that we could walk a thousand versts and find no one. Alaska, we knew, is the sister of our Siberia, an empty, wild land, where it is not man who rules but nature and other unknown things. River after river, the sickening outlines of the mountains. The one thing we did not feel was that we were going in circles. With every step we went further from the shore, trusting to the Magnolian* maybe. *And no one could object. There were no choices. We could not think.*

> *For the first time in all that time I heard something like a moose calling. That night, when we left the others for reasons I did not understand, we had one rifle, which soon became two: early in the morning a frightened young man caught up with us, with a rifle and a suitcase, running after us, and so at last we could hunt. The ridiculous little animals we had caught before were a disgrace in a country so plainly rich in game. And we had to try our luck on the river. Surely, even in October, there would be a salmon or two? Is Alaska so dull? Or had we wandered into some black zone that blinded our eyes?*

Vladimir Obolensky-Kaspiysky remembered: "I did not know then why I left the group either. But something led me, without a word of explanation. I walked, and shadows moved after me. It was like what we had seen before with

the two 'little princes' who had burned out so quickly. I did not want their fate, to lie in filth and blood waiting for manna from heaven, and for the eagles, who would gladly have torn my eyes out while I lived. After about two hours we came up against water. I had noticed that the river's width varied a great deal, so I was sure we would find a crossing quickly. That night I managed to sleep. My wife woke me at dawn, slow, unhurried dawn, and barely overcoming our weakness, not expecting a hearty breakfast, we set off at once along the river. I did not understand how she stayed on her feet. But I knew that today, at last, we had to find food."

The keeping of the calendar, that relic of the past, had been kept up by a few people, above all by one man who carried it all in his head and had stayed behind on the hill, losing strength fast. Kharitton, as this keeper of the hours was called, had been looking for someone to take it on. Nobody cared; some thought it was November already; others did not mind. He was abandoned on the hill that evening, like so many, and soon died of exhaustion. But his work was carried on by the owner of the famous notebook, the last man Kharitton had spoken to, Dr Brzezinski, who made notches with the last of his ink on his own shoulder, since the paper was still damp and he would not risk the thin pages that held his drawings and his reflections from the ship. It is to him alone that we owe the chronology of this whole story.

They went downstream; there was nothing else to try. They were nearly on all fours, so tired were they, and their wet, filthy clothes weighed them down. At least it did not rain that morning; the rain had stuck somewhere behind them in the mountains. On the bank they found three big white birds whose name nobody knew. One was brought down by a good shot; the others flew off before anyone could fire again. A fallen branch of Jeffrey pine, borrowed from nature in the night, had become a smouldering torch, carrying the flame on from the big fire at the last camp, and the bundles of small hemlock branches five men had carried with them came in very useful. The bird, the size of a Christmas turkey, was gutted with two knives in a frenzy of hunger and cooked, half raw, still needing more cooking: the first real comfort the group had known. It was tough and tasted of the river, and there was not enough for everyone; but it was better than the muskrat and the partridges. How much better? Twice: a hundred grams instead of fifty. The bones were wrapped in a woman's wet kerchief "for the evening."

By midday they found a narrow place, beyond which the river forked and then ran over rapids. It was the rapids that drew them. That was where one

might fish, and in all those agonising days not one of them had caught a single salmon. Heartened by the morning's bird, they went into the river, bodies and all. The three lucky children in the group were carried, for fear of the cold. The rest had their hands free, except a dozen who carried their few belongings: rags, the two "guns," a box with their most precious and water-shy possession, twenty cartridges, knives, small vessels and other rubbish.

This river was much faster than the Tatshenshini, and it was fruitful! The shout when a silver fish slid between someone's legs must have been heard even on that cursed hill. Much more frightening were the grizzlies downstream, fighting over some strange animal on the bank, who did not notice the people for a while. Falling was the custom here, finishing off fragile bones and tendons. But it was worth it, worth it. A great shout and applause marked the crossing, and a single big king salmon, lost out of its season, barely held in a man's arms, raised everyone's spirits to a quite different level. Everyone began hunting for fish. Something did shoot past at incredible speed and even struck their boots with heavy heads. The thrill of the chase is the last thing a starving man is capable of.

*The morning of the twenty-fifth of October was the happiest of my life. Never before had I, or anyone, felt something so bright, which warmed the body so that one did not feel the cold at all. We were so happy we wanted to jump and swim and gallop and sing. There were not many fish, but you could feel them and see them, really see them! I managed to pin one to the bottom with my fingers, but it was so strong that I stood like that for a quarter of an hour, barely feeling my fingertips in the water.*

*They helped me catch it, at a price that was dear to me. But I was so glad that, having caught a ten-pound fish, as they told me later, barely keeping my feet, I could feed myself and the people who were in the same plight as me. People stood in the water stunned that at last they could catch something to eat on the bank. They could not believe it. Bewitched by the fishing, we did not notice the small dark bears coming towards us. It was they who cried out the warning. That morning I became one of the two lucky ones who fed everyone, and the only woman to catch a fish! What a pity the current was so strong. I cannot explain how I survived it.*

Theodor Abalagov remembered: "The fish were so slippery that you could not hold them with your hands. You had to fall, to go under completely, to put your arms round them, and then dive head first ahead of them, guessing where the current would carry them. Under the water the river opened up: a little muddy at the bottom, quite clear near the top, all its little hollows and stones. There were not many fish, but their reddish sides gave them away and you could try your luck. I seriously thought of taking off my torn autumn coat to use as a net. But the bears changed all my plans."

The bears were moving upstream, driven by the same hunger. The summer had given them fat for the winter, and they did not want to spend it early. The salmon were finishing their spawning. Here in Alaska the king salmon spawn later than in Kamchatka, sometimes almost into winter, though their timing is inherited and rarely changes; something had disturbed these, and on their way back they had simply given up their spirit in this river, shallow and stony and well suited to it. What was dessert for the bears was a festival of life for the people.

Luckily the grizzlies were not hostile, but their surprise could be read even by people, as people's could by them. They came within a hundred and twenty paces of each other and stopped. Some of the people grew nervous, which is a bad idea, but the current swallowed their movements.

Only two fish were caught. But what fish! What is a big salmon to you? Ten, twenty pounds? Much more. One was killed with a stone from the riverbed, after it had knocked a young man off his feet into the water, and it took three men to get it ashore, one of them watching the current and holding the two "porters" with both hands as they edged sideways. It was thirty inches round, and not even a queen; some grow longer than a metre. Its name, *chavycha*, comes from the Itelmen of Kamchatka; the Americans call it Chinook, or king salmon, after the people of the Columbia River, and the Japanese call it the prince of salmon. The second, much smaller and different to look at, like a char, was the "guest" of the feast, and it was caught by the woman, who tore her hands to pieces doing it and nearly lost her catch from the pain and the sight of her own blood.

They had to come out. Nobody had dreamed of such a catch. But there were the bears. They had to show firmness, though some of the more impressionable, frightened as they were, showed it in a more piquant way, and wade across. The catch was shown to everyone from the bank and saluted a second time.

The cold river did not want to let them go. Few of them had ever seen bears, even in books or travelling circuses. The bears had left on the bank the body of a porcupine, ripped open by one of them and thrown aside; perhaps it had offended them, or perhaps the ones left on the bank were bored. Bears, too, have their punishments: whoever misbehaves is not allowed to join in the fun of bathing or of trying to rip open the belly of a trout flying past. The king salmon was a hard catch even for animals weighing several hundredweight. The bears played with the shadows of the red-brown monsters like children in a pond with tadpoles, catching them with their claws, so that the fish died soon after without leaving any young. They glanced at the people, saw nothing worth a feeling, and went on with their simple trade.

It was strange that the great salmon river was not this side-stream but the one they had been following, the Tatshenshini, the old trading road of the coastal Tlingit. The first white men to describe it, in 1890, were Jack Dalton and Edward Glave, who went up it with two Indian guides. The world had known of it for only thirty years. Its name in Tlingit is a whole sentence: *the river at whose head the king salmon stink*, because the salmon go up the Tatshenshini and turn into the Blanchard and spawn at its head and die there, and their bodies rot in the water.

"Sitting by the fire," Obolensky wrote, "as one of the two 'respected persons,' I wondered why we still had not met a single local. Wild nature, lonely birds, animals, fish, and that was all. Does no one here love company? Or is it so crowded and so well-fed here?"

The bears stopped at the rapids and came no further, towards the people. Everyone sighed with relief. The rifles were ready, but no one wanted to waste bullets on them, for two reasons: why kill the king of the forest, and why waste cartridges, which were few? Mutual condescension avoided trouble.

They did not go back to their last camp; who knew whether bears or something worse were there now? Animals always come to places where people have been, to sniff. They carried the two fish onto the rocky bank and jostled to see them close, as if they were rare museum pieces. The woman's fish was a good ordinary fish. The young man's fish earned him something like reverence.

They did not dare gut the fish right by the river, because of the bears. They lifted them like wounded men carried off the field and carried them a long way back up to the Tatshenshini. On the way they found a little green oasis, though the spruces were ancient, and it took nearly a dozen people to break off the

branches they needed. There was nothing to saw with. But at last, from the very last of their strength, they won a victory over part of a tree fifty feet high, and that the smallest and youngest there. Even that would not have been enough to cook the fish, and while the wood was to hand they took more, and spent another couple of hours stripping the trees, wounding them but not killing them. At last nearly everyone, however they felt, had full arms: four poods of wood, almost perfectly dry.

They reached the place, on a lonely stony bank with a fine view all round. A few men found a flat stone for a board and set about the fish with their knives. Luckily the rain still did not fall. The little knives were no match for the great body of the king salmon. They hacked at it, spoiling the lovely shape of that creature born of nature's majesty. The grim head with its predator's face came off first and fell between the stones. Everyone was hypnotised. They split it along the spine into two slabs, then did the smaller fish, more expertly now. The beautiful red flesh lay open, and appetite rose beyond words. Piece after piece was laid on the stone.

The cooking pot was a suitcase: a single-use vessel, used like that, but nothing better could be thought of. On four poles set in a square they laid a thin iron sheet, the lid of one of the crates from the ship, and on that the plain, clumsy suitcase, a proper Chekhov suitcase, stolen from themselves for "possible use." They brought water from the river in their palms and small vessels, foolishly, instead of filling the case at the river and carrying it up; then they lit the fire with the last of the resinous pine "sceptre." The women tried to pull off the scales and skin with their hands, and did it badly, until the men finished it with knives, though someone said he would take it as it was; it hardly mattered. They burned a great deal of wood, but the "water in the suitcase" boiled, and the fish was cooked. Someone even managed to fry what was left.

A doctor warned them not to gorge, or it would do them harm. To everyone's surprise, they listened. Perhaps it was his baritone. The fish was eaten with tremendous appetite, and the water drunk after it in turns from little wooden cups. It tasted bitter and a little salt, strange in a fresh river; that was why it had taken so long to boil. Salmon do not mind; the king salmon can live in water of any saltiness, in estuaries and in the open Pacific thousands of kilometres from shore. Before they spawn, Pacific salmon lose their gut entirely, and the room is taken by roe and milt, so as not to compete for food with their young. There was roe, too, and nobody paid it any attention; they threw it away with the entrails. Red caviar would become a delicacy only later, and one

needed to know how to prepare it. Nobody dared eat it raw, and several pounds of it were left to rot. So the mother died, and her children with her, for these people, brown-eyed, blue-eyed, grey-eyed. She would have died anyway. Every king salmon that spawns dies within two weeks, at four or eight years old.

Nobody thought of going back to tell the people on the hill. Intoxicated by the smell of boiled king salmon, they forgot that there were another hundred like them. No, someone did think of it, but it moved no one to act.

The tail, nearly half a pood, and as much again in slabs, was left, and the head, which they decided to take with them. A fish of thirty or thirty-five kilograms had saved fifty people from burning hunger, as if it were a boar or a bison.

> *We had all lived our own lives, for ourselves, for decades, and we could not entirely change in those days. The salmon we ate on that bank had more effect on us, I think, than the tobacco had on those "merry fellows" who were now rotting somewhere on the far bank. I could not find a single one of them among us. I did not think about it then. I was warm and cosy on those stones, and I believed we had beaten our chief enemy, hunger.*
>
> *I will always remember that piece of fish. I only marvelled at how the one who gave us such happiness had managed to catch it. It was truly magic, a mystery.*

They had to pack up. The full day was ending; night here falls suddenly, asking no one, and the sun had to be found first. They put the remains of the fish in the suitcase, now emptied of water, took some ash along at last against the insects, threw the entrails to the little thin-legged birds that came running to the smell, and walked on without looking back, hoping to repeat their luck, by the same guide, the Tatshenshini. The big river had become a philosophy. Mankind has always found its way by rivers.

And three hours later, a little before sunset, which they sensed by their inner clocks more than saw, two shadows appeared behind a boulder. Two moose! One small, one larger, a little more than half a kilometre away. Strangely, the moose did not notice the people. They were busy with something more important: licking the salty stones, which they lacked up in the mountains they had come down from. A low spur of the mountain, the only one that reached into that kingdom of boulders, hid them partly, and to see them properly one had to go round it, close to the river.

Vladimir Obolensky-Kaspiysky snatched a rifle from his "squire," a sweet old man, signalled everyone to stop, and, with a wave and a word, made the other rifleman climb the rise with him. Not everyone had seen the moose. Most people's gaze stopped at the ground or the sides. Their stomachs, given food at last, wanted more.

"Lions and panthers and hippos are ruled out," someone joked in the crowd.

"And witches and wood goblins too, I hope. This isn't the Magnolian taiga," someone whispered back.

"In this world anything is possible."

The two riflemen began to prepare to fire. The distance was fine, and the Mosin rifle was the simplest of weapons, known to anyone who had served; both men had.

Then one of the women, for reasons nobody understood, ran towards the rise as if to get ahead of everyone. Being tall, she had seen the animals, and when she saw the men preparing to shoot she understood, and threw herself at them to stop them. She did not see why one should kill something she could not even name, some creature on four legs, which meant food. *But why?* thought her sweet heart.

She half succeeded. Two shots; one, thanks to her, went wild. But one hit: the smaller animal fell, and the stones gave back a faint echo. The other leapt away, ran, came back, to its calf probably, and tried to rouse it, as far as they could see from there; then understood there was no point, and ran, saying goodbye in its mind, not wanting to share its fate.

The second rifleman's bullet had gone much higher than he meant. And who could have known that this little incident would in the end weigh terribly on all of them? Hardly anyone knew those odd "comrades," one of whom had brought a rifle when he caught up with the group that night. They were our Bolsheviks. And their plans had changed completely; or rather, in the head of one of them. Semyon Semyonovich Neglasov-Bobrov, in his ageing naivety, was counting on a quick way out. But Neuter, who had behaved so disgracefully before, had been rethinking his conduct, and forming his whole being anew for this place. And the spoiled shot, an interrupted attempt to take revenge on everything he had fallen into, broke something in his soul, and left him nursing a wish for vengeance, not on nature now, not on the animals, not on himself, but on the woman in particular, and on all of them in general. Unfortunately, as always, the truth came out too late. For now it looked quiet

enough, despite Neuter's half-mad reaction; she deserved a slap, but she did not get one. They exchanged looks, measured each other, and parted. He threw down the rifle, and it was picked up by Roman Mikhailovich Morozov, the quietest, dullest, least colourful of the three.

The noise went on for a long time, until Vladimir Obolensky, who had shot the moose, cut short the moral and ethical debate. He was irritated too by the woman, who had tried to stop him with one hand as well, but he had been quicker. She was sworn at, publicly, and shamed. They walked on to the place of the killing.

> *The defenceless moose lay like a dead weight on that sad bank of the great river. Barely out of youth, quite young. It should have lived a long time yet. Hit in the heart; the man who fired still had a fine hand, not lost to time or age. The killer, the slightly melancholy Mr Obolensky, walked round his victim, and so did the onlookers. I stayed some way off. The young antlers shone in the setting sun. Frosty air and calm. Some saddest of tunes was playing in my head. I have never felt so ashamed, so heavy at heart, as when I looked into the eyes of the dead animal. They were open. It was like being burned.*
>
> *The beast lay in a position that gave off one silent, clear thought: Why?*

People who had not wept "for a long time" suddenly began to mourn the animal, much more sincerely and more expressively, and, to look at, more heart-rendingly, than they had mourned the dead before. Man is a strange creature. He loves animals more than his own kind. He feels injustice keenly, and rarely acts honestly. He abandons and betrays, and moralises. He is endlessly sentimental, and shoots in the back. He goes to success over other people's failures. He dislikes clotted blood, and drinks fresh blood without a qualm. Dying, he tries to take as many lives with him as he can. He is utterly subjective and unprincipled, and thinks himself rational. He changes what he means by good and evil more often than his gloves. He drinks to feel merry and calm at once. He loves to feel, and always relies on what does not feel. He thinks himself great, and cannot master anything without a weapon. He is perfect in the art of deception, above all of self-deception. To him a king salmon is food honestly earned, and a moose is food got by foul means. There is no difference.

Nobody noticed the long strings of white-headed eagles across the sky, dozens of them. They cared nothing for the lone moose. They were flying west,

to the hill. Far worse things were happening there than this sentimental tale of a moose shot to no purpose.

Later, when they settled for the night round the body, they found a use for it. None of them had eaten moose before, but they decided to butcher it, which was much harder than a salmon. With no proper tools, several enthusiasts worked almost all night to open it and cut it up by the light of a feeble fire, which lit their work more than it warmed anyone. Someone suggested taking off the hide carefully, with no idea how, to wrap the rest of the fish and the meat to come. An animal weighing many poods was a hard test for small knives and the strange contraptions made on the way by local inventors. The frost hardened, and the only way to save one's hands and feet and oneself from sudden cold, in wet clothes with a light crust of rime, was to keep waking up; luckily the sound of the work and the howl of the wind made good irritants against that dangerous sleep. They put off eating till the next day, and everyone understood, though the stomach, after one nearly proper meal, wanted more.

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The eagles flew on and on. The ancient pines bent. The river rippled in the wind. Ten kilometres to the south-west a bloody feast was going on. Whoever had managed had gone. Whoever could not find the strength to get up, only a day later, had become part of the food chain. The boldest of the hunters of the air overwhelmed the poor wretches by numbers and began to peck at them while they still lived. The exhausted fell, or did not try to rise, and stopped fighting. On the eve of the full moon the hunger of the hunters on the ground reached its limit, and they stopped being afraid of people and came up to them.

That night, the first night after Vladivostok threw its white handkerchief into the ocean and said goodbye to the old times for ever, more than forty of those saved from the sinking ship were torn apart by wolves and birds before dawn. The rest would walk back to the shore, barely moving their feet, hoping for nothing now, gnawing tasteless plants as they went, even eating needles and fallen leaves from the few half-rotten trees, like a boar after truffles, crawling like legless cripples. Those they had abandoned, for one reason or another, had saved them once again, by making their number smaller. Those who had gone off in the morning, in the day, in the evening before, never knew what happened that night. They dissolved into the forests, and most likely lost their way later and died alone. It only needed one group to declare itself independent

and leave, in silent protest, for everything to fall apart. It took a little more than a day, with circumstances to help.

No fire shone on the hill any more.

The night of the twenty-sixth of October was the last for Émile, a Frenchman who had once stayed on in the Land of Magnolias and lived through in his own body everything his second country had suffered for five years. The romantics died, struck down by the birds' sharp blows, and then by the ancestors of dogs, which found it hard to overcome themselves, and did. On their sharp fangs appeared the blood and flesh of people who had died earlier of their illnesses and had not been buried. A wolf is like a shark; if it needed to, it would tear open the earth to get what it wanted.

Several people drowned themselves in the river, with nothing left in their heads. In the night of the bloody feast an old man shot himself with the one remaining rifle and its single cartridge. He had a broken leg and a raging fever, and was waiting for death from pneumonia in both lungs, the unspoken diagnosis that had killed at least fifteen people. He put the barrel in his mouth and fired, not wanting to see the horror any more. On some of the children's graves dug the day before stood those little shovels. Had they been forgotten in the confusion, or were they meant as crosses? How can a shovel be a cross? Round the low, barely visible mounds people were dying, giving their last care to those who had just left the world, wanting only to meet their sons and daughters as soon as they could. Wolves tore off ears and noses and raised a delighted howl. They had taken to human flesh. Someone tried to crawl away and got painful, gripping bites in the back. Someone stripped naked, hoping to freeze quickly, the simplest death, in sleep. The wolves walked their own land without any of yesterday's shame. Their winged accomplices had given them their courage.

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Adam could not sleep. The insomnia that came to him at a certain phase of the moon, the legacy of a childhood illness he had barely survived as a youth, was back, along with a few old stab wounds and the single gunshot wound of his eventful life. He turned on the light and sat in his armchair, looking out of the window; but the moon, almost full, came out of the eternal cloud and spoiled his mood so badly that he had to close the shutters. He hated moonlight with every fibre. And his departure had been put off by small problems in Juneau that damaged his reputation as a manager. He had forgotten all about the

strange foreigners. He was waiting for his wife, who should have come back from Sitka the day before. By his reckoning they should have met. Like any man in his state, made worse by a quantity of Canadian brandy, which only he liked, he began to imagine things, each worse than the last: that his wife, knowing he would be away, had stayed with a lover in that town; or that she was running some business behind his back; or, the saddest and no less real in this dark country, something else.

And strange things were indeed happening in Sitka: a small coup, with a hostage. The bandits of Novo-Arkhangelsk, a gang of former whalers and sealers from the archipelago, were tired of watching their town lose its money and its people. When Juneau began to talk again of money for new houses and government buildings, Sitka's house of cards began to come down even faster. Their once well-paid trade was now worth little more than lumbering, and it was foolish to risk your life in the ocean hunting leviathans when there were silent, peaceful trees and the machinery to fell them, all of it controlled by Adam Smith, who gave work with one hand and ruined one place for the sake of another, no better, with the other. A few men endowed with nothing but a set of well-working instincts, and the full approval of the Old Testament, managed to seize Adam's wife in Sitka itself: Victoria, a simple girl once, now almost a northern queen, who liked to be called by her full name, which linked her to the ancestors whom fate had carried west. She was snatched crudely from what passed for a hotel, a house of local cedar logs, and taken bound first to a sawmill and then to a more interesting place. Human idiocy has no limits: the dolts did not blindfold her, and the gag was poor. Not wanting to kill a woman, they found themselves drawn deeper in, first two of them and then two dozen men of every kind and rank, with the clever idea of one of them, a man she recognised, even knew. In a country like this, everyone is brother and sister if you travel at all. They made a deal with the locals, stirred up a controlled outburst of the townspeople's discontent, untied the woman for a while, and asked her a great many awkward questions.

She was certainly not without sin herself, and her answers, built on counter-arguments, which rarely work in such a position, sounded thoroughly unconvincing. The few active citizens who were loyal to that little town lost among the islands and fjords caught the rebels' fever without understanding it. Many decided to go to Juneau. But, as usual, the night sifted out those whose rebel masks hid plain, swollen laziness. These were not the wild years of the Middle West, nor even the first years of Alaska. One could not charge in and

knock over the local bigwig. This was not Europe or the Land of Magnolias, so easily seized by a youthful urge to smash everything. An inherited stiffness, together with the extremes of the climate, made for a different outlook. The question had to be settled somehow, but not by bursting into the "capital," which some did not even count as one, and killing Smith, a man few knew by sight and many condemned at a distance for his love of profit.

The "mutiny" ripened for two days, over a good deal of brandy and rum, and tea, and even coffee, in the poorer shacks on the edge of town and in the houses that stood in the invisible shadow of the one building there worth looking at: the Orthodox cathedral of St Michael the Archangel, the last great monument of the Magnolian presence in Alaska. Baranov had wanted a church at Novo-Arkhangelsk to rival the mission on Kodiak; the plate and icons sent for it went down in 1813 with the ship *Neva* off Baranof Island, all but an icon of the Archangel in a silver frame. In the 1840s Bishop Innokenty, the former Father Ioann Veniaminov, a priest who had learned the Aleut language and given it an alphabet, built the cathedral with the Magnolian-American Company's money, cast its bells in the local foundry and assembled its clock with his own hands, and founded a seminary to train priests from among the native peoples. It was the gentlest face the Magnolian empire ever showed in America, and it stood on land the empire had taken by cannon. When the Americans came in 1867, their soldiers looted it along with the shops and houses of the town. In the years of our story it was a shabby, beloved old building; in 1966 a fire would destroy it, and it would be rebuilt from photographs, and Solzhenitsyn would come to its consecration.

The plotters had chosen their moment well. The full moon is the treacherous time, when your enemies find their strength and can put you to flight even if you are a proud wolf and they are mongrels. And Adam, who was not really an Adam, having sins in his past, now had a surname that stuck in the memory for all the wrong reasons: Smith. And that was the reason for what happened to him a few days later.

It was seriously, absurdly, suggested that he was really a reincarnation of Soapy Smith, the confidence man of the Wild West, who had died twenty years earlier at Skagway, not far from here. Jefferson Randolph Smith II had made his name selling bars of soap for a dollar apiece on street corners, wrapping a hundred-dollar bill round one of them before the crowd's eyes; the lucky buyer was always one of his own men. He built criminal empires in Denver and Creede and finally in Skagway, the gateway to the Klondike, where he ran a

telegraph office whose wires ended at the back wall and a saloon and gambling hall behind it, bought marshals and politicians, gave generously to churches and the poor, and even raised a volunteer company for the Spanish War and called himself Colonel. On the eighth of July 1898, after his men had robbed a miner of his gold, he went drunk and armed to a meeting of the vigilantes on Juneau Wharf in Skagway, and was shot dead there by Frank Reid, who died of his own wounds twelve days later. Reid's gravestone says he gave his life for the honour of Skagway. Soapy left a wife and three children in St Louis, to whom he had written more than a thousand letters. Sitka remembered his gang, who were tried there and died in its gaol like rats. And there had always been rumours that the death of so slippery a man had been too simple, as if staged.

That was the gossip. Behind it were harder men: the former whalers and sealers, the "men of standing" who sat out a grey day gnawing halibut bones and aching in their joints, longing for better times. Something had to be done before the snows of early November.

Nobody quite knows what made them decide on so bold a thing, a coup or a feeble riot, by the people of the old capital. Quiet anger was not enough. But on the evening of the twenty-seventh of October more than thirty men set off in five boats for Juneau, armed, in warm, nearly waterproof clothes, in the usual rain, through the small waves. A remarkable number for such a desperate raid; there would have been more, but for the cursed work that nobody could leave even for this. The spire of the cathedral saluted the departing Varangians for the last time. They meant to settle the question of the total dominance of another little town, no better than theirs, and above all of the source of all evil as they saw it: a gang of officials from somewhere else. And it was true that every official of the Territory of any rank had come in the last eight years or less from kinder parts of the country. No local white Alaskan could be one of them. And they had a trump card: the unfortunate Victoria.

A little more than a day later the flotilla came in to the slightly balding town; the burned patch of forest was easy to spot, and so was Adam's house, where he was pouring down his second full glass of brandy, worrying more and more about the woman he loved. Thirty northern cowboys, each looking like an ordinary hand in any Western gang, burst into the spacious wooden house, knocking down a thin messenger who was at that moment bringing Smith or his police friends an important dispatch, not one of the trifling telegrams that took ten days to be read. Muddy boots, and not only boots, swept up the stairs,

knocking aside a chair, a table, a secretary who shouted something like *Help!*, and three rather solid "policemen" on the stairs, who could not even get their pistols out of their holsters, with eight barrels pointed at them, two to a man. The master of the house was so deep in his gloom that he did not even hear what was happening behind his stout oak doors.

He had quite forgotten that important guests were expected that very day. Grey routine always gives way to the extraordinary in the end.

They led him out of his wooden castle with great distaste, his own. He would never have left it if it had not been for a delegation, which turned out to be no friendlier towards him: stern men in black coats, standing in the lane opposite, watching with amazement through the house's great windows what was going on inside. The commission had arrived at exactly the right moment, and it made the most of it, swallowing every scrap of nonsense with the appetite of a bureaucratic machine. The plainly absurd, unsupported claims of the loud fishermen and hunters went down on paper. It nearly became a shoot-out first, which would have cost lives and left Adam's office bloody for a fortnight's scrubbing. Then Smith saw his wife, downstairs, with two guards, and the visitors had to think again: this was not an ordinary riot of the offended but something criminal. Five against several dozen was a poor bet. They calmed everyone down, "evacuated" Smith, and agreed to sort out this deadlock somewhere more suitable, which meant the police station, still being built.

It was not easy to take the rifle away from Smith's temple. He was no coward, but if a monkey has a gun and you have not, it is better to talk. He walked, glumly, to the old two-storey building next to the new police station. It was decided to push him aside for a while, a week at least. He had protectors in Portland and Seattle, who might remember him later, or might just as easily forget him. His closest friends were rather glad to have him out of the way for a bit. Nobody spoke of a conspiracy. One important figure was missing, the chief of police, away hunting, who was close to Adam; without him no one could move against either of them, and there was no real reason to. They could take the shine off Adam and his wife, who annoyed everyone with her appetite for money. Even men envied how well she struck a deal. So everyone, the Sitka men included, was to be held for a week, until time showed whether to show their cards.

By evening Adam and his colleagues understood that for the first time in all their dealings someone had struck at them, absurdly, not seriously, and yet

seriously, because he was part of their system, a system that lived well enough, if not as well as some record-breakers of New York's Tammany Hall in their day. The syndicate had to go on working, and those who had disturbed it had to be punished, or bought off with a rotten carrot. That was what Adam was waiting for now, in the arms of his wife, who had come through the whole primitive kidnapping with dignity.

They were hungry. The only light came from the little room of the watchman, the chief guardian of this fine establishment. Somewhere in the depths of the small building sat and lay, almost silent, those who were apparently real criminals. Supper was long over, and despite the couple's protests they had to spend the night there, in a half-shut room that looked like a guardhouse. Victoria must not go hungry. Swallowing his pride and his resentment, with a phantom pain at his temple from the cold barrel of the strange visitors' gun, he quietly asked the shadow guarding the place for something. The shadow found nothing fit for such high-ranking prisoners (the gaol's slop, made of rotten coarse grain bought at less than the price of air and entered in the books at a good price, as usual, would not do), and handed him instead a little cloth bundle with something hard and light in it.

Victoria had diabetes, "insulin deficiency" in the new language of the time. In those days only Toronto knew about insulin, where they were about to make it in their laboratories; they would succeed, and a year later win the Nobel Prize. But that was tomorrow, and in a backwater like Juneau, the day after. Her illness had been diagnosed a couple of years before, and it was quietly going its own way. She had eaten nothing for two days and had been through a shock, however coolly she bore it. She had to put something in her mouth. Her kidnappers had ignored her single request, made with all the pride she had learned in her marriage to Adam, whom she imitated in everything.

It was halva: a rare and rather costly sweet in Alaska, like chocolates. A strange substance, like nothing else, oily and sweet, with nuts or seeds in it, flaky and fibrous like felt, and melting in the mouth. The writer Stanisław Lem, when he was found to be diabetic, joked that locking oneself in with a big tin of Turkish halva would not be the worst way to die.

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To die of thirst on the shore of the Gulf of Alaska? It sounds absurd. This was not some warm island in the Indian or Pacific Ocean without a spring, let alone

a drifting atoll; it was a continent, in the north, and the saving stream was a mere four hundred paces away, uphill, through thick undergrowth. And yet three days after the events I described, Panasevich and Tatyana faced a simple choice: to die of thirst, or in the jaws of predators.

The hungry wolves roamed their lands, disputed only by people and by the bears, who were lazily going off to their winter rest. The shellfish at low tide barely fed them, and they did not always find any. On the last day they had found eight, fresh only to the thirsty, and suffered for it with a short but unpleasant poisoning. Another wave of endless rain had come in from the central Pacific, driven by a needle-sharp wind that threw dark-brown kelp onto the empty shore. In the evening heavy snow fell, and they still had no fire. Their shoes were falling to pieces with every trip to the stream: Panasevich's fine boots, bought in Florence, had almost no soles left, and Tatyana's simple autumn boots had rotted years before their time. The man who had survived the nutmeg was holding up better than fragile Tatyana. Her breathing was difficult; something like asthma was developing in her.

Panasevich had given up trying to make a fire; the last hours had soaked anything that might have stayed dry. He sat on the ground, leaning against one of the boats, on earth that was turning into a little bog.

And yet the sky, for once not entirely leaden, gave them a beautiful evening, the first since the day of the tragedy that had changed their lives beyond recognition. Far out over the sea in the west the evening was lit by red feathery clouds, the sure sign of a change in the weather: the sky competing with itself, May reds against September reds, against clean pale blue, with cruelty hanging over the harsh, entirely wintry Cordilleras, just as it does far to the south in the Andes, where llamas graze instead of musk oxen, but the same storms come in from the same great ocean and break against the same kind of mountains.

In such October days, for a man unused to it, the head splits; the older you are, the worse your bones behave; your blood seems to press on your neck with a bull's strength, choking you, not hard, but all the time. You look at a little strip of open sky, which an hour ago was pouring water over you as if a kind farmer outside your bungalow were emptying his milk pail into a vat, and you are glad of that little piece of beauty, and then you understand that tomorrow will be "merrier" still. But why think of tomorrow, when, lying feverish on the ground inside those squares of boats, you suddenly find that you are not so badly off, and the water from the sky is something great and sweet, compared with the salty "spring water" you had to drink the day before yesterday when

you could not reach the stream? It is a strange feeling, when wet clothes warm you through. You begin to believe the illusion. And it saves you.

Night came quickly, more decidedly than ever, and with it more gloom. But gloom cannot last for ever; felt so often, it stops being something unusual and becomes part of how things are. Silence gives way to short phrases, which are not messages or questions but a way of warming the jaw, because one tires of the chattering of teeth, which turns into a dreadful rattle, as if the two of them were telegraphists. Their fingers were raw from rubbing, the last pastime, the unfulfilled dream of a tame, warm little sun of their own.

Tatyana wept again for her husband. She was drawn to him and could not hold back, breaking open for a while the structure of their rotten little house, whose only way out was its door, a boat set on edge. Panasevich, with his bad head, had passed out, curled up like a kitten in a wet cupboard. He had been like that for two hours. Something similar had happened to her the day before, when she burned with fever. She leaned against him quietly to make sure he was alive. If you have never done that for each other, by turns, you do not know life. Every misfortune is a trifle beside it. To wonder every hour whether he, or she, has died, within plain sight: that is a terrible thing, which leaves a deep scratch on the heart for ever. Lovers and close relations feel something like it, in a more romantic and so more distant form. Tatyana and Panasevich had no feelings for each other at all; they could not make feelings even for themselves. It was simple fear of being left alone in the face of death.

That night the moon was full. The wind dropped, as usual before a rising storm. The wolves, having tasted success, came out to hunt again. Full moons quicken their blood. The last high tide of the evening came several metres further up the beach than before. On such nights one must be on one's guard. Tatyana did not understand that. To her the moon was only a guiding star to light her short way to her husband's grave. She sank to her knees in the sticky mush of the "second shore" and tapped gently on the coffin, the upturned boat, as if waiting for someone to answer. The night was far colder than the short day. She saw nothing, sunk in her own grief, wishing to stay there for ever, tied by invisible bonds. Panasevich lay meekly and did nothing. His mind did not want to wake, but something was telling it to come back to the world.

And the wolves had already smelled the people, and were coming closer, step by step, towards that unhappy pair. There were several, at least four grown males, which was strange for wolves. The full moon had changed them, and made them band together, as had their endless hunger. Some were only a little

hungry, and could not resist the clear marks, understood only by hunters, by which they practise their chief art, the art of killing.

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We are all wise after the event. And it makes all of us criminally vulnerable, as had been shown behind them on the hill of discord, where there had been no words, only quiet flight and agony.

The moose's warm blood, of which there was plenty, warmed the hands of the butchers, but nobody dared to drink it, or even taste it. The hands of those not taking part stayed clean, which felt better ethically, but in that frosty night they could not feel them at all. They had to hide them in rags and warm one another, burning up their last strength. It was good that they had met those salmon, which kept them afloat. But that was not enough.

The fresh moose hide smelled foul, and gave off its own spell of disgust. To any sensible man it was a great prize. Its coarse coat, with thick guard hairs and sparse, harsh, curly underfur, was hard to cut. Here, behind the ridge, the moon could hardly be seen, and only the glints of the fire showed what colour the creature was: brown, ash-grey on the belly and legs. The three most experienced, who had dealt only with sheep and pigs, tried with all their strength to open it, pushing blunt knives against the resistance of the fat the summer had put on. A moose's hide lies tight against the body, and a careless cut pierces the belly wall and the gut, and the contents spoil the meat. That is what happened. The participants in the bacchanal struck their knives exactly where a real hunter would never have struck. Confusion, inexperience, poor light.

The unpleasant work took the whole long night. On their side was the fact that such a large animal cools very slowly. Against them was the frost. By the second hour fifteen people were gathered round the "hero" of the evening, the moose, not the hunter. Sleep would not come anyway, on sharp gravel and stones that the river had not yet worn smooth. By dawn they had torn and hacked the carcass apart, with no wish to desecrate it. They got part of the hide; the legs and neck would not come off. The head they cut off with a shovel, or several, since one broke. Then they stood in silence, giving thanks to nature and to God for so great a creature, and for another, which everyone already knew of: a creature great in mind and cunning, which, weak in body, had learned to conquer much.

They cut the hide into strips and wrapped in them, after breakfast, what was left of the fish and the best pieces of the moose. The meat was far from perfect; they could not drain the blood, and some of it was too close to what had been going on in the animal's gut and had to be left. But they gathered two poods or so of what could be called meat, and as much again on the bones, with tendons and clotted blood and scraps of flesh. To leave that would have been foolish greed, and there were plenty who wanted it.

In the end the upright society lost an undeclared contest to the wolves, who had lately feasted on their friends and strangers a few miles away. The moose was torn apart, but not as "well" as those nameless people who had tried the terrible game of the loner in that terrible land. In the night a bold creature the size of a fox, which nobody could name, smelling blood and flesh and something strange, tried to get at the carcass, unafraid of people and fire, pushing through the ragged ranks to snatch a piece and carry it off in triumph to the bluish-green spruces half a kilometre downstream, at the foot of the rising mountain, where the poor people would soon have to go, trusting to the river, which, they believed, must lead them, if not to Chicago, then at least to some centre of civilisation. The new leader followed the faith of the lost and forgotten "chiefs" of the first nine days. No alternative had yet been born.

Ten litres of blood or more was smeared over the faces and hands and even the legs of those who had worked on it. For the first time they went into the water without needing to, and their silly efforts to catch a stray fish near the bank, a sign more of greed than need, brought nothing but a little rinsing off of the blood. At least their hands lost the look of a butcher's. That dip, for some the third, was fatal for two men already suffering from some sickness, infectious or brought on by the cold. They went against common sense and their own health for the sake of a "spiritual cleansing" in the dreadful water. By the evening of the next day both were coughing up their own blood, and both died: strong, clever, capable men, cells of what remained of the society. The women had the same troubles. Colds were spreading through more and more of the still-warm bodies, not only the throat and chest but the bones of the pelvis, the inner organs. And there was no ice or snow yet; that was still to come.

The last hope of a quick deliverance was dying. Faith fluttered, but not so naively now. People hardly spoke, sunk in silence, simple gestures, weariness. Someone seemed to have scabies, or something else; but since nothing could

be done, nobody paid it any attention. The fire went out; there was nothing left to burn. Overcoming their sickness, they walked on, towards hope.

Victoria had never eaten halva before. She ate it greedily, very fast, which in her state was strictly forbidden. A sudden swing in the sugar in her blood after two days of hunger, without even water at first, bound tight with rags, could lead to anything.

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The shears of Morta, the Fate who cuts the thread, nearly closed on the threads of Tatyana and Panasevich. But let me tell it in order.

Hazen Odell did not suspect that his ordinary outing "for a rest" was only beginning to surprise him. Having sent his men off to Juneau and waited for them to come back, shooting a little game in the meantime, more for the pot than for trophies, the hunting party set off north along the coast in boats, to Yakutat Bay or the first good place on the way, their heavy boats piled with gear, much better boats than the *Helvetia*'s. Only thirty miles north lay our ragged pair. Some of the hunters went ahead to Yakutat by water; seven rode along the shore, keeping the boats in sight, unhurriedly, as if putting off their return to Juneau, which they thought a dreary hole, though it was not. It was only poor in entertainment. Its "saloons," more practical than the classic article, did little for the gentlemen of law and order; the country round it they had long since explored; there was no proper casino, no outlet for a man's feelings. And who would a casino be for? These bearded men could hardly be called the cream of society; there was no such thing here. Yet it was they who kept Washington's power in balance in this strange territory, where the districts are called boroughs and seals outnumber people. Hazen had chosen the worst of the two ways for himself, loading his horse, which for four days had done nothing but chew grass and miss exercise, with his iron gear and his own weight.

The party of bear hunters was coming near the place where the Magnolian host had landed and become, in a moment, a ragged rabble. And those two left on the shore were living through the most terrible hour of their lives. The wolves had come.

Tatyana had just begun to recover from another fit of grief when she heard a rustle from the trees. Her tears blurred eyes already dimmed by the dark, and only the moonlight on the leaves showed that something was there. In the deep of the night the calm was absolute. Before she could think, she turned her back

to the forest and felt the heavy, gnawing stare of more than one pair of eyes. Not fire, of course: only the mirror behind the retina that lights a hunter's eyes in the dark, green or red or orange. These were all three.

Then the attack came, from fifty feet away. There were three of them, and at least one had already tasted human flesh. Alone, these careful hunters might have been more cautious, more lenient, if the word is allowed. But hunger had made them savage in a few days, and the last and only prey that had satisfied them was man. None of them would miss the chance of such easy slaughter and such bliss again.

Two hundred paces off, the riders' five horses, as if passing a signal along, neighed at once, long and pitifully, swished their tails like wings, and tried to throw off their loads and their riders and leave that dangerous place. Their instinct did not fail them. But men, those relentless, unfeeling creatures who rarely listen to their own inner voice, still less to their smaller brothers, drove them on along the ghostly beach. The wolves had not yet come out of the shadow of the trees, so the riders could not see them from their saddles.

Panasevich was lying peacefully inside his "wooden Stonehenge," steeped in the smell of wet wood, leather and earth. It was the cramp in his body, folded nearly in three, that woke him, not the close air, and just in time. When he opened his eyes, the only movement that did not hurt, he heard a scream. Tatyana was running towards the shelter at great speed; he felt it even inside, through the shaky walls of boats balanced on uneven ground. The whole hut swayed. Fragile as she was, with the wolves at her heels (they had not wasted a moment), she leapt over the wall of the shelter from the top, without meaning to; she did not get inside properly. That pitiful architectural wonder of boat timbers could not stop the wolves, who were breathing down her neck. She had given way to the oldest instinct, *run or die*, instead of meeting fate calmly. But who could blame her, starving, after all she had been through?

She fell, striking her face on something hard, the ground of the inner ring. She was glad for a second, and then the pain came. Her nose was smashed and gushed blood; her arms were flung out like a swallow's wings from trying to break her fall. And she had landed in the wrong part of the shelter, away from her only companion, her brother in misfortune. The wolves were already storming the walls, scratching, trying to leap over, their sinews trembling in anticipation of prey. The blood covered her whole face, though it could not be seen, and she tasted iron in her mouth, open from pain and from the scream that the jump had cut short.

Panasevich felt not only her landing but the wall he leaned on shake. The shelter was like a little fortress, in a very distant way: an outer ring of boats, longer and less sturdy, and a small, half-roofed inner one, covered with brushwood for beams. Both had a gap for a door, facing the ocean, away from the forest. Stood on edge and wedged with mud and small stones, more for show than strength, the boats had stayed up only because they leaned on one another, like dominoes holding hands. Now the dominoes shook.

The wolves' claws looked for a gap and found none, so they decided to jump. That was the worst. A lean, fit animal (wolves are always lean, except the ones going off to die of their own accord rather than by the tusks of a boar or the horns of a bison) began to storm the little fort, with no intention of besieging it. The blood had turned these careful creatures into something with the habits of a young lion, for whom everything is *here and now*.

Tatyana had lost a great deal of blood; a few more minutes and she would faint. Sensing death climbing up the shaky wall, which was light for the weight even of a starved grown wolf, she pressed her hand to her nose, pinching it with shaking fingers, and tried to get up and reach the inner hut, hoping in her simplicity that the jackals would get lost in the maze. But as soon as she stood, the blood rushed from her head and the bleeding came with terrible force, filling her mouth, salty, like an iron rod dipped in brine and licked.

That sound of wild fear could not be mistaken for anything. The horses had only been the prelude.

The riders, startled and newly curious, forced their horses on despite their wild resistance. Not for long: snorting, kicking wet sand into their faces, the horses stopped dead. The men's guns were loaded, and Hazen, the oldest of them, though not by much, led them forward on foot. A low rise, ten feet high, hid what was happening ahead. Again the woman's scream, full of pain. They ran. The full moon came out at last from under its cloudy blanket; the heavy cloud front shifted south instead of bringing the storm from the west, and left her bare, at her loveliest.

The terrible scene went on. One wolf cleared the barrier like a horse in a show ring; the one with the sharpest need is always first. Barely a yard away a second was climbing, clinging to his brother. And behind them, not counting on victory, meek as only wild wolves can be, the others waited their turn, either because of their place in the pack, as among men, or because of a laziness that comes before the kill: to get to the feast without dirtying their paws. They were

the first the hunters would see. But first came several terrible minutes for the defenders.

Panasevich crawled out of his "shell" to see what was happening. As he came out (the opening was low for his height) he saw a great shadow, which his right eye at first took for an illusion, fall right in front of him: a grey mass of fur. The wolf had seen the woman, in shock now, crawling, trying to reach the inner door or get out of the fort altogether, too far away. It leapt on her back and ended her efforts. Panasevich saw it all and could not believe his eyes. Another monster was coming over the wall. On his knees, rubbed raw, he reached for whatever came to hand. The woman screamed for the last time.

Shots rang out, from five guns.

The men who came running were horrified. The little fort was half down; they heard all the boats fall at once with a single ringing crash on the wet sand. The devilish fight went on under the wreckage, which had fallen on the shoulders of the two people and the two monsters. Tatyana was worst off. They did not find her at once; they had to piece together, out of the wreck, her legs and arms and then her head. Her whole back was torn. Two wolves were killed, not with the first shots; the shock and the dazzle of the moon spoiled their aim. One ran off, whining, perhaps wounded, and there was a crashing in the scrub as if there were several more. Some of their shots only holed the bottom of a boat. The beasts went on mauling both people.

The creature was gnawing at whatever covered Panasevich's flesh. He had thrown himself on the first wolf and got a knife in the back for his pains. Another shot; a piercing ring in the ears.

From the recollections of Fid Rogers and Hazen Odell: "A bright beach in the middle of a frosty autumn night, the only vague anaesthetic for those victims of fate. Their bodies were literally burning when the attackers were killed. We got the man out first, torn to pieces to the waist, bleeding all over. He was alive but did not respond to anything. A bullet had gone through a boat and killed a wolf, which we could not see except for its tail showing through the planks, and had not passed through but lodged in the man, because Mike, who was first there and was not afraid to do that heroic thing, fired at point-blank range. The man was hit in the soft part of the shoulder. A few minutes later he lost consciousness. We never imagined there was another animal on top of the man, still alive. It was killed with my knife. We saw the woman almost at once, when we dragged aside the dead wolf and the man. The moonlight showed us all the horror of it. The woman showed no sign

of life. She had been savaged many times by the grey killer; her bare skin, her back above all and her right arm, was covered in blood, fur and earth. Her hair was torn, and she seemed to have stumbled and broken a leg. We got them all out of that very strange shelter, like nothing I have ever seen, and while we waited for our brothers in the boats, we tried to help them. Slowly we began to understand. The man and the woman were the only people on that empty shore. Nobody else. There was no time for a careful look; we had to save them. *O Mary, Mother of God!* I cried when I found that the woman, who was plainly doomed, was alive. Her pulse was shallow, uneven, barely felt under my rough fingers on her young throat. We had to tear our own clothes to stop the bleeding. The cuts were an inch deep. There was light enough to see that hell. The boats did not come along the shore for twenty minutes. In that time we managed to bind most of the wounds we could see with bits of Fid's light coat. But the bleeding would not stop. These people won't live till morning in this wilderness, I thought. But none of us dared leave them. We had to wait for the others and think what to do. What I had seen stuck in my mind so that I could hardly see anything else. A little spirit we had left in the packs on the horses, which stood there like lonely cedars, we used as a disinfectant; I am ashamed to say I did not know that word then. Who are these people, and what are they doing here?"

The others, travelling unhurriedly along the coast in the calm, which did not help their speed (and why hurry, when there were naive fools to do the work, even one as important as Odell?), with drinks aboard and comfortable bunks in their little yachts, were "delighted" by the news, sobered up at once, turned savage, and began to think. A second incident with strange people put an end to the hunt in that excellent season. They would not repeat the Juneau trip; the wounded would never reach it alive. They decided to go to Yakutat, which was close, if one had boats and knew the way, and they had both.

If the survivors of the *Helvetia* had not met that storm on the water, and had gone north instead, they would have found it: seventy miles, and you are on a scrap of civilisation, whose name in Tlingit means *the place where canoes rest*. The story would probably have ended there, with the fewest deaths. But what is the use of regrets, when only two of them were now being rushed to that outpost, and for so unhappy a reason? Yakutat is a symbolic place for a geographer. There the tail of the Land of the Midnight Sun ends, or rather begins, and to the north lies the other, greater Alaska: lichen for the caribou, prey for the white bears, the coldest climate, chance nuggets for men, polar skies

beyond words, fierce frosts, cruel tundra, the great Mackenzie, and the Yukon in all its glory, not glimpsed jealously through fog and cloud as it is here in the "south," which is no south at all.

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When armour rusts and the heart is heavy, one does not much want to walk. They had come many versts, and had nothing to show for it but worn-out shoes and aching legs. Instead of the river's monotonous banks the forest began again, taiga, broken by hills that made them climb and descend or go round. Not looking back, because it hurt to, the group following the Tatshenshini went deeper into the forest's kingdom, pilgrims in search of the sun. There was no sun. The mountains were giving way to level country, the very plain they had seen from the plateau. Hemmed in among endless, monotonous dark forests, they simply walked, finding their way as they went. They had no choice. A fish caught in the night was a joy. A ban on using the rifles had lately cut their small chance of easy game.

Time had changed its count, as if the clock were a living character, an old man in a silent hut waiting for death and pottering with nonsense to pass the time. It is unthinkable now to find a person who does not know that death exists and may come for him; and here everyone, without exception, was in its cold, unpleasant embrace. It breathed on the backs of their necks, which were growing shaggy; even hunger and fear did not stop hair from growing. The last gleam of the empire's colours had worn off on the clay and stuck under their nails. Death stopped being extraordinary. They lost six people in four short days, and most of them no longer reacted at all. An extraordinary calm replaced the long season of compassion, struggle and rage. None of that turned out to be needed. What was needed were hands, if they could still feel anything, and eyes, and brains, and above all ideas that could be put into practice.

The halts came more often, and the days grew shorter. Their clothes could not take it, and one could see strange constructions made of anything to hand. Only one feeling grew, and that was greed, a greed none of them had ever shown in their real lives, in town or in the warm country. A veil lost on some climb or descent, like the web of a dying spider spun on the last day of an Indian summer, was found with furious greed by a woman who now looked like a spiteful old crone rather than the pretty lady she had lately been, snatched back from herself and hidden under her arm, though nobody wanted it. It was quiet

nerves: you no longer needed a living enemy; it was a state of the body, the fear of losing everything you had already lost.

And yet the most intriguing thing was still ahead. On the last day of October, by their own reckoning, a pale ghost of a calendar that survived only in scraps of memory, they came to the top of a bald hill, lonely and like a great stone, the stump of an old mountain or the seed of a new one; and it set them on the right road. Not by itself, but by chance, and a spark of curiosity, which lit their guiding star. There was no end to their joy. But it was a long time coming.

It was the eve of All Saints, the feast so honoured here by the descendants of Irish and English emigrants, or the devil's own temptation, depending how you look at it: Halloween, a feast unknown to Magnolian literature, the evening before. Two young men, nearly the last of the geologists, scratched their heads at a patch of ice that had survived the summer near the top of that hill, and decided to climb it. They needed ice to keep the fish, and more than the fish, what remained of the moose, which they still had not dealt with properly, having taken the choicest parts and left what was a pity to throw away and hard to carry. On the bare rock grew one great weeping tree, almost the only living thing there. With God's guidance and courage, backed by yesterday's decent dinner, they reached the very top and threw down a slab of dirty snow, and then, with more effort, some ice.

Below, people were getting ready for the night again, on that Magnolian-looking field ringed by oaks, it seemed, except where the cliff was, and their hearts beat strangely, anxious not for themselves but for others. The young men clung to the rock by little islands of hair moss, not the usual green or yellow but the colour of sulphur that some factory owner had dipped in water and thrown out for the boys. The rock had a white crust like salt, but nobody dared taste it, much as they needed salt. Everyone was sweating, God knows why in such weather, from the fever burning in them. Their bent shovels could do nothing with the frozen ground, and still they had to carry their dead further, and the dead kept increasing. Two more were close to it.

Hardly anyone looked up at the cliff any more, except to glance at the brave ones shouting and pointing from above. Their voices broke against invisible barriers and came down as comic fragments. Going down was much harder than going up.

While the others busied themselves below, the two lookouts sat at the very top, holding on to the highest branch of the tree, freezing in their poor clothes

(they were of "lower rank"), recovering from their little feat and looking about them with a clearer eye now. And they saw, quite plainly and not in fragments any more, clearings in the forest that were not natural, full of low dying growth from last summer, across the river, and further off, where the queen of rivers, which had saved them from hunger and must lead them to a warm house and tea and salvation, turned sharply, north or south or east or west, they could not tell. Squinting, balancing on the spire of that stone cathedral, they made out at the edge of the horizon, where fog and trees hid it, something strange behind a rock: a shape that was not a rock, nor a den, but most like a dugout, barely rising from the ground, something made by human hands.

Shouting was pointless, and waving had grown tiresome. Below, seventy metres down, their comrades no longer looked up at their mountain eagles with the respect of a little while before. The two climbed down, without fanfare, looking at the fires lit to soften the frozen ground for the graves.

The people still buried their dead by the rules, not leaving their own behind; but the rules themselves were wearing thin. Someone wrote: "The clearing in the forest seemed very strange to us. We had grown used to the endless rule of stone and tree and resigned ourselves to the endless search for signs of real life, and we noticed a broad, long strip of open ground cutting through the great forest, with bushes already dead for the year and rotted grass, which was not the path we had meant to take. My mind began inventing excuses for curiosity: what was there, further on? The strip ran on as far as the eye could see, nothing but a 'road' cut by someone or something through the forest."

Everyone waited for the two young men, whose descent dragged on and on. Their hands were torn on the rock; they slipped on wet patches and caught their breath on the lichen, crying down to the others what they had seen. The slabs of ice they had knocked down puzzled the people they fell on, until they understood; and many who burned inside with fever in that late-autumn waste would try that remedy, perhaps for the last time, and some would save their last food with it from rot. Not much was left: two hind legs and a few ribs. And ahead was supper, and another wake for those who had gone on without saying goodbye.

The tough moose meat, wound with sinews, did not even smell good to these people who were always hungry now. The bitter grass that grew there spoiled the broth. The meadow by the river turned out to be no shelter; the cliff was on the wrong side for that day's wind and did not cover their backs. They buried the dead almost at the surface now, too weak to make mounds,

and close by the camp, no longer at a distance. The fog crept in and swallowed the top of the hill, following the boys who were still up there. It was not the warm fog it seemed. It was a blizzard, and they could see it more clearly every minute, though strangely hardly a flake came down to them yet. Nobody felt like natural philosophy. They only wanted to be silent and weep, waiting for the end, chewing that vile grass, like wormwood, so as to suffer no more.

The sun had gone, it seemed for ever, and with it the crumbs of optimism it threw them now and then like amber on the beach. All the watches had stopped, those of their owners and of the new owners who had taken them from the warm hands of the dying, willingly or by quiet looting. Time ticked only in their hearts.

The boys came down, almost falling, out of the milk of the fog, found their friends by ear, and told them everything they had seen in the last clear minutes of the last day of October. People were glad of them, and of what they heard. Hope did not die last; there was still plenty of imagination left.

The strip of open ground ran away into the distance right in front of them, but they could not go, for it might be bog. They did the wise thing and waited for morning. And then they went. Soon they came out onto a road, and left the river's rule over their minds.

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NEAR YAKUTAT, 30 OCTOBER 1922

Everyone took a turn carrying the torn bodies to which life still clung with such reckless courage. The blood, first flowing and then dried and crusted in the wind, weighed heavily on the men, who were straining every nerve to reach Yakutat, a devil's lagoon where only the most desperate stopped. The sky was clearing, moving off towards the mountains in the west, and the wind did not come. The sail on the leading boat hindered more than it helped; there was no time to lower or trim it. They rowed, watching over the two lying on a board laid with sailcloth. The woman's burning body and Panasevich's deathly face made them strain every muscle to reach any hut, any shack, where there were people who knew how to treat wounds. The dead wolves had been thrown into a launch at the last moment. Not all the hunters knew where they were going. Remote Yakutat was known to few, except gold hunters, and unlucky ones at that, who had not made it to the gold districts.

Nobody met them. No sign at all. The moon was already giving way to the meek autumn sun, and still no one answered. Shut huts, rotten posts, five lopsided hulls of ships and the skeleton of a boat being built. They had landed at the abandoned southern end of the little town, and it looked deserted. Not daring to leave the dying mummies, the hunters shouted, and then fired. Only the shot woke anyone. Shadows cried and moaned in the quiet street, caught off guard; there was an answering shot and cries from every side. The little houses seemed to stir, and the shadows of ancestors came out of the eternal dark.

They were not ghosts. They were strange people, afraid of everything, who had seen the strangers long before from the high ground and had decided, after all, to show themselves. Hazen, leading his men into the frozen town, might not have come out of it alive. But the gooseflesh passed as quickly as it came. The people who came out looked downtrodden; perhaps because of the visitors' rough manners. But at the gate of the real Alaska that sounded naive. Here people had always come for help, and always taken the best sons away to better lands, north and south.

Hazen was standing by a stone well with a cross beside it, the familiar ghost of the ever-present Christian mission, when a small man came straight towards him, as if out of the ground, walking freely and boldly, with none of the cringing the others showed, stopped right in front of him, folded his arms, and stared at the uninvited guests, waiting for them to explain themselves. His face could not be seen; he had his back to the stars and the moon. Hazen, surprised that he had been picked out at once as the leader on his side, lost for a moment his gift of persuasion. Then he found his tongue and asked for help, and waited.

The people gathered round their elder and whispered, softly as the last leaf falling from a northern birch. And then it began.

He was a Tlingit, a Christian like most of them here, living under American law: peaceful people, good hunters, but above all fishermen. All this came out later, in quiet talk in the little harbour where, hidden from envious eyes, they were building a whaling boat to a design of the last century, their pride, the last flowering of their old ways. That Hazen, a good-natured man, was somehow let into this secret disposed them to take in all of them, who had sailed into a place no ships had called at for twenty years.

There were poor prospectors too, ruined after the short summer of the gold rush, a listless lot, but most of the people had the round faces of those who had lived here for centuries. Not all spoke English, but many understood it. This was the southernmost "monastery" of their people; beyond the snowy caps of

Logan and Steele and Bona lived their kin, harsher and less sociable in a harder climate, and perhaps freer. Here they carried Tatyana and Panasevich ashore and into a hut that smelled of whale oil and fish fat, and handed them over to the dark shapes of women and men nobody could make out.

Dawn was a long way off, and the talk went on. The visitors, used to everything, grey skies and heat and fires and ghost towns, were shocked by the poverty, the desolation, the struggle to survive. The sun, showing a rim at last in the morning, with high clouds coming from the north, promised a meeting in the sky and much worse weather soon.

Sitting on a bench by the jetty, Hazen turned over the quiet, frank conversation of the night, and one guess after another came to him, each more monstrous than the last. The silence at the landing had not been chance, nor a lack of the hospitality of seafaring people. It had nothing to do with sleep. It was fear. The town was in the grip of a gang of bandits, who raided it suddenly and savagely, "like a fire beast," as the locals put it in a strange phrase of their own. There was no government here; there were not enough petty officers of the law, who, like all simple men, wanted money and a warm berth, and there were neither here, so they never came to Yakutat or places more remote. Only priests came, and strangers like these. Big steamers sometimes passed far out, ignoring this coast.

The sick were treated in some strange way, which, despite heart-rending sobs, at least showed that the two had come to, though it would have been better for them not to. The hut was perhaps the most dilapidated on the waterfront, a third sunk in the ground, almost the only one not raised on stilts, though here even a dog kennel was raised on stilts. And there was not a single dog to be seen. The questions multiplied, and it was awkward to ask them.

Hazen, who had nothing to do, took ink and paper from one of the boats, the things that went with him even on that spoiled hunt, and began to draw crosses and noughts and then words, trying to set down his guesses: the sailors, then this. In his rage he spilled the ink, tried to gather the sticky stuff with his fingers, smeared himself and his beard black, threw the paper down under a stone and went for a walk.

The few streets, sunk in mud and stench and that strange persistent taste of burning, gave him no pleasure. The few people he met swayed and staggered, and, seeing a new face, bent down and coiled up like a cat or a snake, a pose that in a man meant extraordinary submission, with wide, astonished eyes and the same blank expression on every face, as if he were some monster they

had known from the cradle and knew could not really exist here. The white faces were worst of all, outcasts, broken men. The natives at least had some skins over their layers of ancient rags. The whites had not even that; only years of unshaven beard hid their shame. Nobody came close to him. And the dwellings! One would have had to look hard for anything more monstrous and foul. Neither Sitka nor Juneau nor much smaller places were beautiful, but none had such dark misery for no reason one could see. There was forest close by, and stone, and yet the eye had nothing to rest on.

He walked until he was walking in his sleep; three nights without sleep. The open sewer seemed a pleasant bed, his boots a warm tartan rug from an aunt on his twentieth birthday, the ache in his neck almost sweet. Something was circling far off, coming towards that bare bay, open to every wind, to cover the mud with snow at last. On his fourth round he almost fell, caught at some invisible altar with a tired hand, and the people he met stopped seeming frightening and rough, and their silent mourning eyes seemed ordinary. More than two hundred people living there had passed under Hazen's eyes, and he had found no answer to anything.

His men's sour faces did not keep him aboard. His cabin on the largest boat had not been cleaned of the blood and rags and suffering of the night; the little window had been shut. He drank a pint of some swill, thinned with sea water, and had to spit. And since he could find nothing to do, and absurdly, no place to be, he decided to spend the evening with the elder, the only man who spoke English, the only local he had really talked to. The day was ending, and his nameless "friend" had less and less to do.

Somehow Odell caught him among a crowd of people who looked very much alike, and made him talk. And this time the talk went well, unlike the careful, extremely guarded conversation of the morning. In a little room with one window, eating salted fish off wooden boards, Aiya, for that was his name, told him about himself, and why life in Yakutat was so dismal and so silent. Every so often people ran in, asking and demanding, and he answered them all; he was at once one of the two priests, the master of the fishing, the chief judge, the best friend, the faithful comrade and the most honoured citizen. He did not say so. It was obvious from those three or four late hours.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

# Greek Fire

*In this small, physically weak man there was something hard as steel, unbreakable as rock, something no physical force, however great, could master... He walked the winding paths of life fearlessly, with a firm step.*

— Written of Mahatma Gandhi

"I felt terribly low when I got here," said Hazen. "Today I walked your two streets all day, and I could not make out what your trouble is. It's a depressing sight, forgive me for saying so plainly. It's made me gloomy, and I keep thinking about it, because I don't know the answer. Do you understand me?"

"Yes. You speak well; nobody else here speaks like that. I'll try to answer you, though I don't think it will please you, any more than it pleases us. And then I'll ask you something in return, about the poor people you brought us. I saw how worried you were last night; your eyes were shining. Did a sea monster attack you? But first my answer. No. You should not know."

"Why not? Do you know who I am? Or would you like your damned village to burn down one fine day? If we're talking..."

"I don't know, and I don't want to know. You are our guest, and you are not behaving as a guest should. Or is that all you foreigners ever think of? Some have done it already. Thank you."

"What? What foreigners? Have you lost your mind? This is my land, and you talk as if you were a hundred per cent native, though I don't hear any broken English or put-on accent from you. Come on, damn it, tell me."

"All right, all right. If I tell you, it must not lead you to do anything. We have been made slaves, and we cannot help ourselves. For four winters now we

have been held hostage by bad men, who always come by sea, from different directions, and always take the best of everything, the whole catch, killing and raping our women. We ran out of cartridges long ago, and our friends, rare as hot days here, have turned their backs on us. They seem to watch us even at sea; they always turn up for the fresh catch and throw us a few coins, to mock us, for full nets. These men look very much like you. A week ago they threw something from the sea onto some huts by the second cove."

"Wait, wait. You're serious?"

"I suppose I shouldn't have told you. I can see through the dark that you're interested, and you'll try to do something... Don't count on anything. It is all settled here. But we can no longer satisfy the wants of these bastards, which keep growing. And it's all revenge for one of them, whom our young men killed half a year ago for his tricks. They are looters, bandits and villains, and there are very many of them. I asked for help in Juneau, and in Anchorage, which has only just been built, but nobody believed me. I am the grandson of the clan of the Nenkin, the son of a keeper of the fire and of an American woman who doctored animals. I can do nothing, and condemn myself to heavy labour every day. Now we are building them a big boat, the one you saw, for wormy biscuits. Here is my arm: a wound from buckshot, not a year old. That is how they tried..."

"Aiya, they're attacking again! People are running from the white rock, and somebody has just started shooting at them!"

"Zershey, ring the bell and tell everyone to bar themselves in. We have no guns. Our only hope is God and hiding. We can't get away by boat. It's too late..."

"Good Lord! What's going on here? Seven years I've been in Alaska, and never anything like this."

"I think it's because of you. Nobody visits us except those mangy ones. All decent visitors vanished three years ago. Come with me."

Hazen, who had drunk a good deal, not knowing his limit, was thoroughly shaken. Bandits on his land, where he was the prefect, the consul! Less than a mile from the town, by a great white rock that stuck up out of the earth, the locals were forced at night in autumn to dig for minerals and useful stones, quartz, chalk. Legend said that centuries ago a monster had died there and, in its agony, battered a mountain into that compact rock. It was a landmark that brought in some profit, not for the Tlingit or the settled whites, but for the bandits. Their limitless greed wanted more and more ways of squeezing people

who were almost powerless against them. The timber felled along the shore interested them too, but it sold badly; minerals and building stone, even clay, dug out of that frozen ground with great effort, sold much better than wood or fish.

Hazen argued and insisted, swept away by a passion for justice and fairness, a sudden sense of duty towards the local people, a deeper shame, and the feeling of being a "big man." This man, who had lived ten years in sunny California, really was quick to answer other people's trouble. He woke his men in a fury (they were his subordinates first, before they were his hunting friends), explained the situation briefly, and pointed to the totem pole that crowned one of the village crossroads, more a symbol now than an object of worship, standing peaceably near the chapel and the cross. A crowd stood round them holding candles and crude torches that gave off a stinging smoke, which ate the eyes of friend and enemy alike: small men, but brave and proud warriors, trusting in Raven, the hero of their myths and legends, and in their honour, and in something else he could not understand in that second's glance. By the end of the nineteenth century most of the Tlingit had become Christians, many of them Orthodox, of the church that had come with the Magnolians; some say that the more conservative chose Orthodoxy to keep a little independence from the Anglo-Saxon civilisation of the Presbyterian missionaries. The empire that had shelled their forts had left them, in the end, the means to resist the next one.

The place where Hazen had met Aiya, nowhere near the centre of that wretched little town, became the rallying point, since it was screened from the rock by a tall barn or workshop, which, damn it, made good military sense, though Hazen and his friends only realised that later.

The voices of the people running from the rock came nearer, and when three loud shots rang out one after another and some saw the flashes from the same direction, the comfortable, pot-bellied "escorts" stirred and, without much enthusiasm, at the orders of the respected Odell, made ready to fight. Take away a man's motive and he is worth nothing; give him one, and he will do the work of ten. In the heads of the cleverer ones, who understood the brief orders of their chief, who had quickly put the promised hunt out of his mind in favour of a real battle with God knew whom, one thing became clear: these people had come for *them*. The shots did not frighten the policemen much. They had been through worse, and in their ignorance they treated it as a nuisance rather than a threat.

Twenty-four rifles and twenty-two gallant sons of the American fatherland went into the town, getting in the way of the women running for shelter in their second alarm in a day. The bell was abandoned after a stroke and a half, and everyone with strength and leadership in him ran to the edge of town, to the last two streets hidden from the shore behind a low bare rise. People who came running "into town" to the sound of the shooting said it was the bandits. They had meant to attack in the morning, hiding for the night, repeating their usual pattern and changing only the flank, and, not expecting anyone, had made a field camp behind the rock. But their plans had been thrown off by the townspeople meekly digging for stones on the slope. Something happened between them, and they began shooting at the unarmed. Maddened when someone panicked and ran, they gave chase. Of twenty people, only four got away, the youngest.

Yakutat stands on a point, guarded by the sea on the north and west, and on the side of the "white beauty" there is water too: a bay running twenty miles inland like a great fjord, into which flows a large river that links much of that country and leads into the Yukon, with little islands and channels among them. Among those islands the villains hid. Their cruel habits were bound up with sadism, greed and racial hatred. They were tired of simply taking tribute and feeling like feudal lords. Money they could not spend, and a merry past, wanted action, and there was always a pretext. Their failed attempt to burn the village a week before had been a defeat, and they did not like defeats; their pride was boundless, God knows why. That they preferred to sleep on those islands among the reeds and lonely stones and icy water rather than on dry land showed how unhealthy they were. Cold guns never get warm unless they are fired. Feeling that something was wrong, and eager for a fight, they set out along the coast in two "galleys."

That night the sea was wrapped in fog, much more than before. Strangely, the snow had still not fallen, and the fog bit into the shore and the houses nearest the rickety jetty, though it did not go beyond the strip of forest that divided the main village from the two little streets. While the defenders crowded about doing nothing, passing round the few rifles and every sort of instruction, comforting their children and their women, who were tired of hiding and suffering for no reason, the attackers crept up quietly in their boats, and their couple of shots from "that side" were taken by the locals for an echo.

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Tatyana and Panasevich were still in a bad way. The kind woman who looked after them had not left her post all day, not even to eat, since by the old belief still held by the Tlingit a healer might not do so. She was no medicine woman or shaman; she was small, frail, old, with a fierce face and warm, faded blue eyes, and she fought for their lives. Panasevich had been lucky a second time; he even tried to speak now and then, badly, for the shock had done something to his voice. The young woman was still burning, and her wounds still bled, and the endless changes of dressings, which were not sterile in any sense I care to mention, still came away bloody. But there was vodka on the table, or rather a tincture of herbs from the July meadows high on the mountains round about, where sheep had once grazed when Yakutat still had sheep, before the villains ate and stole them. It seemed that only there was there any light: a dim yellow spot coming through a little pane of glass. A splint had been lit for the last dressing before sleep. They used animal skin now, soaked in a thick mixture the colour of a rusty horse chestnut, which eased the pain of torn muscle. All other lights had been put out, though there was plenty of seal oil, almost the only thing left, used for everything in the face of the endless raids of these Alaskan nomads.

And then it began, suddenly and very strangely. Heat came to the cold ground, as if they were in a desert. The whole waterfront caught fire. Vessels of some explosive mixture struck the ground with tremendous force and burst, and more and more came flying onto the waterfront street out of the fog. A little later came shooting from the hill, a sea of lead. Firing back was pointless; the enemy could not be seen. But the policemen fired and fired. Soon the people's spiritual home, the church in the centre of the village, caught fire. Nobody knew how it had happened, and panic howled with horror. The bandits came on unhurriedly, preparing more surprises for the night. In a moment everyone scattered, some to the sea, in hope, some to the forest, perhaps from fear, and all confidence vanished.

"The earth is burning under our feet," was all Aiya said, and he ran on towards the bay, among the houses, and his guards ran after him. Only Hazen and his brothers stayed, their eyes enormous.

A specially fitted boat of the villains had used a new weapon, not the first of its kind. Lately they had turned to the element of the sun: simple arson, and

home-made grenades thrown one at a time. And now, apparently, an ancient device, known since the Greeks. Someone clever and bold was directing it, emptying their stores with monstrous coolness and throwing them, by some machine, a hundred metres.

Only one dog howled, hidden away from the anger of the vilest of men. The dogs, the old friends and helpers of these people, had all been slaughtered one spring morning because, for some reason, some sadist taking his tribute did not like them. This one had survived, no more than six months old, fluffy and white, and it howled with the voice of a fierce dog over its dead master. It stood for struggle and faith in victory. Left without dogs, with nothing but empty harness, the Tlingit had been cut off from the world. That was what had driven them to resist. But their resistance had ended in disaster, from which they had never recovered. They were left toothless, and dead, a dozen of them. Every boy was made to lose a finger, some their teeth, and some died of the pain while their fathers were at sea. That had happened the summer before.

The burning lamps set cloth alight, and the smoke caught the rotten huts. Those who came running were condemned to watch the end. Two hours later snow covered the smouldering ground and hid its shame. The evil of the night still flickered in their heads, not yet taken for what it was. Everyone who had shaken or moaned with horror through the night now helped to clean up and sweep away the traces of that unseen, broken-off battle between a defenceless town and the vessels lying broken in hollows and burnt places. It was plain that it was no punishment of God's but the work of human hands. The cruel truth came out slowly, under their feet; minds woke and numbness wore off. Hazen's force and the local men had done nothing; there had been no time for the body to make the chemistry of a fight. The one-sided attack ended above all in a moral defeat.

Now, without hypocrisy or endless talk, under a lone hemlock, almost the only tree left, sat the people most useful and most loyal to those who lived there every day. They had laid out, to the four points of the compass, little mats made from the useless dog harness, sewn with a strip of some animal's skin like fish scales, which kept off a little of the cold of the ground. But their thoughts were not in their bodies. The guards came back from the edges of the village, rewarded only by a soft tapping of three fingers on the bare earth. Their iron endurance was astonishing. In five hours of waiting for fire and stone and lead from the sky, the forest, the hills, they had not lost their strength, and they held their torches, burned out now, with the straight back of a noble stag. The deep

furrows in their faces spoke of courage and stubbornness. And yet something was missing, a wolf's snarl perhaps, or blood running from the mouth, to make them win.

The strange speech of the Tlingit made one sleepy. The wind from the north blew the first snowflakes, heralds of the storm. Aiya, smaller than ever, tormented by a quiet pain, was tearing at something on his poor cape, and trying to master himself, and failing. His sad eyes said everything and needed no translation. The words came slowly, waiting for revenge. It was agreed, and every cartridge and rifle there was was handed over, and they all went to their homes, burned or scorched. That night took three people, quietly, at a stroke. Facelessness belongs to both birth and death.

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Tatyana did not come to herself; the fever would not let her go. But Panasevich came round. On his torn, naked body, covered in gooseflesh in that unheated room, he felt a snowflake that had blown in through a crack between the grimy, weeping glass and the frame, and it startled him so that he found the strength to open his eyes, not in delirium, for the first time, and cried out in a voice that hissed like a snake. That first evening of November he spoke. His red coat would be taken off for good and thrown away, so that he need never again see the colour of blood, of which so much had been shed. In the night of the second he began to speak English, which he knew, though badly. He could not explain much, but he said that he was Magnolian.

The drying rag that hung between him and Tatyana, flapping in the draught that blew through the many holes of that half-sunken hut, did not hide for long the only kindred soul he had left in that cursed land. He tried to get up, and could not, and fell from the high bunk onto the clay floor and writhed in pain for several minutes, while Aiya's helper, leaving them for the first time, went to find Hazen and tell him. She had not gone out even in the night, though she knew something terrible was happening; her duty came before her fear. Odell, on his way back from the council, where they were now deciding, with words still, but backed by real help, to settle the bandit question for ever, met her, and they soon put an end to the poor fellow's torment. And then he managed to speak, a greeting at least. Weak and very pale, he remembered French, some words of German, but English would not come. In his head the wolves' teeth were still snapping.

He had been much luckier than Tatyana. His thick clothes had saved his life; the damage to his body was less than to his mind. She was a sight one could not look at: a dead shadow of a bright young woman, who had carried other people's bodies and had not saved her own.

That he was Magnolian, and had come on a ship, Hazen heard and understood from his hoarse voice. Nothing more. Hazen sighed, wished him something, and went out into the dark, scattering the wonderful, bright, childlike wet snow, which made Panasevich weep, and soon fall asleep.

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There were a few scouting trips by day, a short way out, but nobody believed the villains would come back that night. They did, without fire this time, but no less fiercely. The day's little blood had not satisfied their wish for revenge and destruction, and there was greed behind it too, as long talks on the fingers through the blizzard revealed. The enemy had done everything right: sown panic, reminded the town of his existence, raised the pressure, and tested what interested him even more than his sport: the boats that had come from Lituya, from Juneau. Those were worth taking, and from the land now, since they had grown cautious, and something had kept them from simply boarding those fair boats and everything in them in the night. If only the people of Yakutat had thought like that.

The tired day and the burned bodies of those killed in seconds made people long for sleep. But not everyone slept; some kept watch as a punishment for their own weakness and guilt.

Some of the bandits went over the pass, to get out of the blizzard that had reached even that cosy place, so as to circle round it and come in from the south, and meet those on the "fire ship," which had covered a fair distance unseen. It was on that ship that they made their final decision, to strike from behind, from the empty beach that ran a hundred miles south, the beach known to everyone who had survived the *Helvetia* and reached land; the same way Hazen's hunters had come. It was a dull, simple place, which inspired none of the dread of the hillsides, the water, the glacier across the bay.

About forty souls sold to the devil waited for a sunset nobody could see, and set out in three straggling, stooping files: bearded, filthy and therefore vicious, without gloves, since the weather had been mild until now, and constantly scraping off the snow that clung to their guns, the enemy of a steel trigger.

The shooting woke everyone, those who had not earned their sleep and those who had fallen into it with grief. This time the response was different, decided by the day's talk round a fire that did not exist; for fire had suddenly stopped being man's lovely friend, and lost through no fault of its own the trust of thousands of years. Every season of trouble in that friendship, strong but fragile as tellurium, has come from using it wrongly.

I will leave out a great many details. I will not show again, more juicily still, hearts and lungs torn open. I do not apologise. I am not trying to give the reader artistic "pleasure," to amuse and then sadden him, but to convey the meaning. I will not tell of the ranks of fighters, of shootings, of those who fell holding the line. An ordinary hold-up of a stagecoach would have been more beautiful, having a cleaner purpose.

The bandits did reach the village and got into its absurd "quarters," which were nothing but alleys and crossings leading to the sea. People did not fall; they hid, and the bullets found them in every position. Some were killed by flying glass, some kicked to death. The fight went on for seven long hours, and only at dawn, when both sides ran out of cartridges and the wet snow stopped at last and a frost struck, did the pinkish morning look at the battlefield. It was not frightening. It was ghastly. A street was burning down, and with it the wooden jetty, the village's pride, along which the main body of devils had tried to retreat. The snow, which was only beginning to melt, did nothing to smother the flames. The south-western side was worst hit: twelve houses or so had suffered at those sadists' hands. One could have gathered cartridge cases for days. And bodies.

A ledger in the library at Ketchikan holds the official account: "The bandits who attacked Yakutat on the night of 2 November 1922 intended to wipe it from the face of the earth, killing and burning all its inhabitants. Meeting at first no proper resistance, most of the inhabitants having taken the shots for another provocation such as had occurred before, they began to break into houses near the eastern landing, dragging the occupants out on the frozen ground and abusing them in various ways: six cases of the cutting off of ears and two of fingers are recorded. Return fire from small arms by local forces, consisting of fishermen and a self-organised council of elders, together with police officers temporarily resident and Deputy Sheriff Hazen Odell of Juneau, had a considerable effect upon the criminals. The attack, carried out by some thirty armed men, bogged down in an exchange of fire within the settlement. Only towards dawn were the raiders defeated; fewer than ten escaped. In

retreating they attempted to set fire to several buildings, more than half of which, struck by an unidentified incendiary mixture, burned out completely."

That dry little entry in a ledger which nearly went into the stove years later says nothing of the scale of that night. It stayed only in the memory of those who saw it, as a heavy sense of loss.

Odell got a small, clean wound through the shoulder from a revolver bullet. He left the bay two days later, after helping to put up wooden crosses for everyone killed there, and there were many. More died in the following week of their wounds, for want of any real medical help. When grief comes into every house, every shack, every hut, one cannot breathe.

If it had been a couple of degrees warmer, the bullets might not have got through the rain. But the snow, that bloody snow they would remember all their lives, was treacherous too. It came in waves, long and short, as if trying to throw its own pain onto the madness going on beneath it. It beat into their eyes, and sometimes ice fell and struck the brows of the lunatics shooting at one another, for nothing. Why such hatred? No one will ever say. The living ran away, and the dead are silent. Salt ice off the bay struck their beards: the tears of those who had fallen into the abyss two weeks before. The grey earth was weeping, trying to sanctify itself in white. That year was cursed by everyone, and that whole twentieth century. What will be, will be.

Odell lost three of his friends, and three more were wounded, himself among them. With not a cartridge left, at the risk of their lives if anything went wrong again, they stacked their useless rifles like firewood, defiled now. There was nothing to bind wounds with, and the Tlingit tore their own clothes, giving up the last they had, to dress the wounded. Instead of tourniquets they used the tails of some wild animal, fishing line, old worn ropes bought in the last century. The sea grieved, or did not; but that is how the living heard it.

"The heaviest, most agonising, most tragic thing in our life," Vernadsky once wrote, "is that our mind and our feeling cannot reconcile themselves to our own annihilation, to the absence of personal immortality." Many of the Tlingit, especially the old and wise, had not that weakness. They did not weep for their heroes. They rejoiced for them. Fifteen men were given to death, but not to oblivion, which was, for them, the absolute evil.

That first winter night eight or ten inches of snow fell. Later, when the sun came out of its white covers, it began to melt patches of drift, and with it came a vile smell from the bodies lying everywhere, each with its mortal wound. Hazen, who would accept only a bandage on his left shoulder, set to work at

once. "In such a situation I understood that one must not give in or let go," he wrote. "The horrible sight had to be cleared away as quickly as possible. We helped put out the houses, and then we turned to the worst thing, gathering the dead. There were many. I could not look at the faces of those swine, nor could many others; their mere presence there was a desecration."

The locals decided that the killers' bodies, being worth nothing, should not be buried. One of Hazen's oldest friends, Max Born, perhaps the best shot of that day, proposed taking them to Juneau, since they had no right to be buried either in that water or that earth. A strange idea, but it made sense in their profession. And as soon as it was light they found the boats the raiders had landed from: a small sailing vessel built for sealing or fishing, of a hundred tons at most, two low masts and, for some reason, only one sail, nimble and handy for boarding, a pirate's craft. She did not look like a ghost ship or a hearse, but that was the part she was given now. She had been the instrument of the men who were now loaded into her single hold, among boxes and kegs.

They dragged the killers to her in a strange way, out of fresh grief: with nooses made from the last of the ropes, face down, through every rut and hollow, as if letting the dead feel the earth they would never be allowed to lie in. The defilement of Tlingit land by strangers had to be ended quickly. The Tlingit were too bitter to respect these deaths. They came up and spat on their dead enemies, but went no further; a delicate spirit lived in them still, grown from a life lived in harmony with nature.

Yakutat smouldered for the last time. While some loaded the dead villains, and others helped the living and buried their own, others gathered the ash of the burned houses to scatter on the bay at sunset. It was an old charm, someone explained to Hazen, meaning that life could grow only from life, and not from the death of other things.

There were no coffins. As the bodies were stacked, some people noticed in those bluish, bearded faces something human, even something familiar. Hazen and his men were not at the landing then, smeared with thawed blood. But later, in Juneau, examining them carefully, he would recognise some of them, and that would let him find and catch the rest of those bastards and open a case that had gone unnoticed for a long time.

It was time to see the two whom the wolves had savaged. Neither had slept that night. Tatyana was very bad. When he looked into her sick, glittering eyes, barely open, and her mouth asking for water, he decided to leave Yakutat as soon as he could. She was burning, and raving, raving. She had come to herself

late the evening before, and not for long. Panasevich, too, was worse. The endless roar of the guns had shaken him badly. He lay as if on his deathbed, refusing food, in his second week of real starvation, trying to say something and only hissing like steam from a locomotive standing too long at a small station. He was greedy for air, and there was not enough. The woman who had stayed with them through the night had dragged them both onto the floor, afraid of the shooting, and it had cost the brave old woman dear: she had torn something in her back, and fell, and called for help, and help came only three hours later. Tatyana had felt something like it once, dragging her husband's body down the slopes of that plateau. Bones held together by sinews and the pitiful remains of muscle weigh a great deal, especially a man's.

They helped her, but the pain would not leave her. Everything was against them: the barriers of language and mind, hunger, deaths, deaths, sickness, a real war outside the window on the "peaceful continent."

The rusty chains made for the new boat were used as a towline. But when they tried the simplest manoeuvre, coming out of the little cove where the raiders' vessel had been hidden, the tow failed: the strain was too much. So the Juneau men's desperate attempt to avoid sailing a ship that carried nothing but corpses ended in a predictable fiasco. Hazen knew he had made a mistake. On the other hand he had done his duty to his country, at that price. He felt sick at all of it. And yet Odell had done, not alone, of course, the bravest thing of his difficult career. Without his guns and his men, Yakutat, which had no cartridges and nothing to fight with but knives and axes, would have burned to the ground. He came to the conclusion, talking with those who spoke his language, that his own little flotilla had been the bait in the bandits' trap. He felt no pride in it. What the bandits had wanted was not simply to steal; they could have taken the boats easily, with the weather and their numbers and their skill, and slipped off into the fog or the blizzard. There was no guard on the jetty. They looked like soldiers, rebels, and Hazen knew what he was talking about: his son had been born in Panama, a country already full of strange armed bands like the men he had glimpsed dragging themselves to the landing.

He shook his head when he saw how bad his two charges still were. But he took them with him, which meant a long sea voyage in his boats. He did not believe they would be alive when his ships reached Juneau. Odell, the son of Janey, was not a domineering man, despite his post; but he had to run the ball and hold off every trouble that had fallen on him in his holiday.

Some of the attackers had died in the pinewood, covering the retreat of the others at the edge of the forest as the late pale dawn came. Nobody had time for them. The village had to be cleared before dark, and the day was barely nine hours long. At least the shame would be hidden for a long night. But the work went on at night too. A hospital was set up by the little church. There was nothing to treat anyone with. The two Magnolian wretches had proved that.

But there was a little of the "hellish mixture" of spirit and local herbs. The wounds had to be cleaned, and Hazen helped with that, giving his instructions. Bullets were drawn with strange pincers made from fishing tackle. For disinfection, which the whites had to explain and the Tlingit had never heard of, the blessing of Dr Semmelweis, they used some tasteless, poisonous mixture that fizzed like acid on alkali, and sprinkled it with brushes of whalebone, like water from a wet besom, onto the cloths and, by accident, onto the patients, burning them, in the belief that it would save them from worse. Chalk was given to swallow for some purpose nobody understood, to heal broken bones perhaps; that was the Tlingit's own contribution.

Aiya had come through the night unhurt, and had killed two of the men who had defiled his land. He did not seem lost or anxious. On the contrary, he was calmer than before, as if sure that everything had been for the best. Only now and then, meeting the wounded, did he lose his composure and embrace them as if to give them a part of himself. He dug graves for the fallen alongside everyone; he was a Christian, so there was nothing strange in that for him. But the core he had drawn in with his mother's milk let him bear such an end much more lightly than the plain American boys who had settled there with their Christian faith in their hearts. The burials were put off till morning; the heroes were wrapped in cloaks taken from every house, for cloth was desperately short. The killers were wrapped in nothing and thrown into the hold. There were no wounded on the other side. Nobody dared go into the wood.

Because so many had fought, the battle had sounded from outside like a machine gun, though there was none. Nearly every window in the place was broken, and there were not many windows; glass was a ghost from a rich and marvellous past.

Aiya's helper was given help, but she had to take to her bed. On the last day before they left, Panasevich and Tatyana were looked after by one of Hazen's men, Mark, who was wounded himself, not seriously, in the leg, by a knife

thrown to kill him. They suffered all the time they lay in that cramped little room. The night had harmed them. Three rifle bullets and seven pistol bullets had hit the walls of the house, which terrified the young woman, who had only just come to herself. Nothing improved on the second day.

The farewell was very long, exhausting and moving. The people, lifting their heads at last, thanked those who had saved them from endless oppression with their lives and their health and their courage, though they were utter strangers. People still feared another attack, and with reason. But now they had a whole arsenal left by the bandits, with few cartridges, and could give a decisive answer to any villain wandering in the hills and forests. Hazen took some of the weapons, his own being spent, with a long voyage ahead carrying wolves' carcasses and dead bandits and dead soldiers.

They left sadly. People gave them a piece of their souls, knelt, and clapped and clapped; Aiya, standing with them on the hill above the shore, had told his people that the newcomers would take that sign well. Wooden crosses went up fast, and fires smouldered by every grave, as if saying goodbye to the world. Rifles were raised and fired in a salute, a new custom for the Tlingit and an old one for the English-speakers. Their tears had run out the day before, and the sun that lit the sky at noon dried them. Perhaps that last act was needed to settle the eternal argument: that violence never brings anything, ever.

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Odell knew that he would have to come back one day to *the place where canoes rest*, and that helped him to live. He had grown attached to those people without really knowing them. The fight had settled everything, when side by side, lying in the ruts and the muddy alleys, they had fought for their lives and won. The last place on land, before the jetty, was the little church. He stood by it a long time and, unable to hold back his tears, put his arms round that small building of bare logs, more a chapel than a church. The priest was wounded, and no one rang the bell.

A week later the flotilla reached the jetty at Juneau and let fall onto its planks everything that had been held in their hearts. On the way, almost forgetting, running before a fine wind, they had put in at Lituya Bay to tell the gentlemen waiting there in ignorance that the hunt was over and they should collect their horses and themselves. After that they reached their destination without incident. And then it began.

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Adam Smith had been released four days before from his unpleasant and irritating confinement. He was angry with everyone. His wife had nearly died of sweetness, and had come through only by mad luck and the help of a Dr Bauer. His patrons were displeased that he cleaned up after himself so clumsily and allowed discontent on the territory they controlled. The question of the "inspection" and the stray visitors had been settled; but money and power love silence, and he was told that this was a warning, and the last. The simple folk from Sitka had no clear complaints, and were to go home with nothing but the illusion that their wages and so on would be seen to and the guilty punished. Did they believe it? Hardly. After three days' detention and the drawing up of some absurd papers about conditions of life in Sitka, they bowed their heads and went down to their canoes to go home.

And at that very moment a motley flotilla of boats and ships, in quite orderly naval formation, came in to the shore: the little boat with the dead, the horses, all of it. The battle-hardened men began unloading brazenly, pushing aside the local fishing boats, and the first thing they unloaded, onto the plank walks of that pretty town lost among the fjords, in the morning, was bodies. Either Hazen had gone mad, or he had lost all sense of decency after street fighting in a seaside village. People who had never seen rotting corpses nearly fainted. Among the onlookers stood the men from Novo-Arkhangelsk, amazed, keeping their distance from the end of the pier.

And the living, the wounded? Bad. Tatyana had died the day before. Panasevich was still breathing. One soldier had died too; he had been doomed since Yakutat.

At the last moment, on the voyage, Hazen had studied the faces of the dead men and recognised two as robbers he knew, and asked his colleagues to look more carefully. It bore fruit. Five more were identified who were not bandits to the police at all, but old friends. Death's face could not be mistaken. At least three were former policemen who had left the force. Two bandits and three ordinary fellows, at the first look. Rumour and the town's open layout soon had every officer of the law on his feet. Unfortunately for them, none of the bandits had been taken alive; those who could, had run, and those who fought were rotting on the planks. A cart soon came and took them away somewhere far off. There was no morgue in Juneau then. There was not even a hospital in

that half-built village: a single-storey pharmacy and three doctors were all the riches of the capital of mighty Alaska.

The talk that began that afternoon went on all evening and all night. The men who had come by sea longed for their own beds, but nobody let them go. Within two days a force as large set out for Yakutat to see what had happened there. The police worked hard: piles of paper, telegrams. The chief of police, Joseph Wellington, was baffled, but trusted everything Hazen told him. They had come to Juneau on the same day, seven years before. This was the first serious incident they had faced, and in a place nobody would have expected. Yakutat had never interested anyone.

That day Adam, hemmed in by his high fence and his thoughts, went once more to visit his domain. His most precious "collection" was a living one, moaning and weeping in the pits of that place. A fine feeling, his invisible ring of power, especially now that it was in trouble. He had forgotten the four sailors; they no longer interested him. He had left town an hour before Hazen landed, and gone over the nearest rise to a kennel where he bred dogs, sold officially to ordinary people and in fact for fighting, a trade that was legal enough then. He played with them a long time and brought them treats. When he came back the next morning, everything had changed. His wife, who had gone out for air for the first time since her ordeal, told him first, and accurately. Within a couple of hours he knew everything and had seen everything. The policemen who served him were simple souls and told him details unknown even to his higher friends.

Adam was connected with those bandits. He ran them, though not alone; he shared them equally with a man named Dreiser, the "king of the far north," of everything in Alaska above the sixtieth parallel. A slow, outwardly unemotional man with hidden sadistic streaks, he fell into a stupor, briefly, and then began to act. The bandits had long brought him little, and had slipped their leashes; but they were close to him. He knew every one of them. More than forty fighters, quietly working in places beyond the reach of the feeble arm of government, had been a precious jewel, if an oddly behaved one. He was not glad of their deaths, though they had caused him pain. He knew the value of each. And he did not know what to do. He had plenty of small cards in town, but not one knave. The king was himself. He could not turn to his "friends"; they had nearly sunk him in the bog a few days before, with a kick from above.

The hunters and fishermen from Sitka changed their minds about going home. What they had seen under their noses that morning made them stay a

while. They had no money for lodgings, and who could house thirty heavy men? Somehow they tracked down Odell's house. He was a family man; he had brought his wife and three children with him to Juneau, leaving only his mother, who lived with his father and his brother, a winemaker, south of Portland. His "northern bungalow" was simply built, more like a barracks, with gaudy, fussy carving on the window frames, and there his family took off their boots and ate their quiet dinners and told each other about the day. Here the good gentlemen arrived, sweaty, muddy, unshaven. His wife had to open. They knew only his name and his job. He was out. After a long conversation they were let into the yard. Mrs Odell did not make a habit of taking in visitors who came for her husband, the house being small, but she never turned anyone away. So many men did not alarm her; it pleased her; murderers and robbers do not come in such numbers. What decided her was the speech of one fisherman, who told her in the plainest words what was happening, and went down on his knees, begging to wait for the master of the house, since there was no one else they could trust. She did not know why they had come to him. They knew very well. The little house could not shelter them all that cold evening. The yard could. And a rug would be summer warmth, and the starry sky a crystal night of crickets.

Hazen could stand the stuffy police office no longer. He and Wellington had to walk a quarter of an hour to some department in the half-built government quarter, a fine chance to breathe and talk alone. The talk was brisk; their steps were slow, putting off one more pointless meeting.

Adam, meanwhile, wandered the streets, trying to solve his problem with fresh air. He could not give himself up; the thread that bound them all was too fine. And the fact that his bandits had been beaten thoroughly but not finally troubled him. Perhaps wounded men had been hidden from him, and had already talked. He could not reach anyone. And what would it change? His guesses multiplied, and he came to no decision, from a temporary feeblemindedness or because nothing he did would change anything now. He went back to his secret yard. He had "forgotten" his three dear friends upstairs and turned all his attention to three other "friends," who had vanished from the world at his hands. He meant to toss coins to the blind. Blind? Thanks to him they had become the blind prisoners of that strange gaol: six years in pitch darkness, and then a blaze of light, and nothing more is needed. But that day he did not get to play his old medieval game.

As he came near the yard, he heard shots. Something was happening that could be called a mutiny. Twenty prisoners had tried to take their fate into their

own hands rather than die slowly, here in a wet rat pit, or somewhere in the wastes of Alaska, the Yukon or British Columbia. All of them were wanderers caught in the claws of a syndicate that dealt in slaves. Nobody ever looked for them. The "yard" stood on a site Adam had once chosen for a good deed: he had bought for nothing some old pipes from an ironworks and meant to give Juneau a water supply. It never happened. But a drainage system for a little factory, also never built, remained, and a steam pump to keep the pits from flooding in autumn and spring. That day someone mixed up the valves, and instead of pumping the water out the old machine began to pump the sea in. The prisoners screamed. And then the old, powerful engine, left running untended in a warm room, simply blew up, and the blast drowned every other sound in that corner of town. Only then did the prisoners, waist-deep in freezing water, try to break out, and there was shooting.

Smith came running, having felt the iron heart burst, and two policemen after him, and others. Such an explosion could not go unnoticed. If it had happened somewhere else, the secret of that yard might never have come out. If Smith had not been there, it might all have ended as usual, with an inquiry, and the necessary killing of vassals he no longer needed, and some mythical villain found. But chance does not come twice. And Hazen and the chief had just finished talking about that very man.

Juneau in early November 1922 could have been compared to New York, full of events and gangs and crowded life. Nobody expected one bang to solve so many problems at once. It was not like detective novels, and that was just as well.

Adam gave up quickly. On his birthday, over brandy, he wrote page after page laying out his whole empire, and took a great many people down to hell with him. Why did he fall? Not because of provincial policemen, whom yesterday he could have bought by the dozen, but because experts from higher up came quickly, men nobody could bargain with even at his level. And his feudal empire had failed also because a telegraphist whom his deputy Scherner had paid to cut the line when news came from Yakutat had simply taken the money and not done it, since tampering with the telegraph meant almost certain prison.

Smith's fall started a great redivision. Everyone wanted it. Did it make life better for ordinary mortals? Not really. His cronies "ruled" until the end of the Great Depression, and even they did not escape the rope in the end. "Adam was the weak link because he stopped feeling money and took up philosophy.

We laughed at him," his "brothers" would say of him ten years later. He had loaded himself with too many mortal sins. The trial of his nameless gang, or "the gang of Soapy Smith's Second Coming," lasted three years, before he was exposed in full and sentenced to death. There is no point listing his endless crimes. He had grown from an ordinary swindler and thief into real evil; but his surroundings made him so, according to his wife, who got a prison sentence for hiding his affairs and his real name. Among the bandits who attacked Yakutat were even members of Soapy Smith's old gang, whom he had got out of prison and away from the noose years before. His real name turned out to be Adam Parkinson.

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**

And all this had a great consequence for the case of those wrecked on the *Helvetia*. The sailors, who had spent a week in the pit, survived. And as the business of the false Smith began to die down, what concerns us came to light too, because Hazen had kept in his head the two strange incidents at the start of his "great hunt." Only through that were the facts learned from the only witnesses of that other tragedy.

They waited a long time for an interpreter, agonisingly long, until Odell's persistence found one, just before the New Year. By then Panasevich had recovered, and the boys had shaken off their hunger and their fear. Hazen, inclined to doubt, gave way again to what he was told, and was right again. And at the New Year, on that same empty beach, the sea gave up proof of the disaster; it could not hide for long what was in its power. But the winter was fierce, and there was hardly any search in December. Only with the spring thaw did the dreadful traces of what Panasevich had told them come out; the sailors knew none of it. A hundred and twenty-five sets of remains, of people who had died by violence or otherwise, were found in the mountains.

The living were found not by the Americans but by the Canadians.

Vladimir Obolensky-Kaspiysky's party, which lost seventeen people in the long winter, was found not far from Whitehorse. On that foggy November day where our story broke off, they had come upon one of the old abandoned roads leading north, and their real search for life began. At last they found an abandoned village, left long before by departing prospectors, by a rocky outcrop, and spent the whole winter there, close to a band of the Southern Tutchone who lived across a small river.

Towards the end of February and the beginning of March, the neighbourliness turned to bloodshed. Three Magnolians died strange, violent deaths. The Magnolians blamed their neighbours, and in revenge they killed three Tutchone men, who had done nothing. That crime was never fully investigated, and only the notebooks of Vasily Andreyevich Chertopolokhov and Genrikh Vyacheslavovich Brzezinski reveal something of those days. Both lived, like a few others of those who had been at the professor's on that warm evening at the end of August.

The strange series of murders was stopped when the "enemy" was found among their own. Semyon Semyonovich Bobrov, who had been a policeman before the revolution, as you will remember, helped to find him. The mad killer, the maniac, the idiot in the flesh, was the one who had survived against everything: his "partner" Neuter. The heresy in Semyon's head had been right. By October and November, with the death of their third "friend," Morozov, the man who no longer hid his real name, Serafim Stanislavovich, had begun to lose his mind. The worst came later, and turned him into a quiet killer, fed by the newly learned ideology of class struggle and by plain revenge. Three innocent souls took three Tutchone with them. Neuter, with his ironic false name of "Bogodukhov," the "God-spirited," so unsuited to him, was put to death. Only "Bashmachkin" recorded every detail of that horror. They burned him alive. The charred body of the murderer decided the fate of the survivors. But of that, a little later.

Rescue came in the shape of the Mounted Police of the Yukon. They would have passed by, if the people of the First Nations had not asked them for help against the "trouble" caused by strange "white dumb people." It is remarkable that almost all of it was set down on paper, in dry and objective form, which lit up the great white blanks of the affair. Rescue came on Easter Sunday, in April. There is a story, which people prefer to ignore, that the Holy Fire did not descend at the Holy Sepulchre at that sad Easter of 1923, a sign of the time of troubles that had come over the whole Orthodox world; Patriarch Tikhon had been removed from the government of the Magnolian Church. I have no right to connect that with what happened on the coast of Alaska and all that happened in the Land of Magnolias in those terrible days. But it seems that, taken together, they cast a dark shadow on the "spark of peace" that the Holy Fire is.

After a short time in the capital of the Yukon, the government of Canada, in agreement with the authorities of Alaska, placed all the survivors in the care of

the Magnolian émigré community of the Pacific coast. A great deal of money and effort went into the search on land and into their medical recovery, some of it from the pockets of individual "Whites," struck by the passengers' six-month stoic fight to live. The search went on until September 1923. Only five years later did the world learn of two more groups of Magnolians who had long since been given up for dead: twelve who had stayed in the mountains, choosing the life of hermits after everything, and eight who had stayed in the taiga.

The chief storyteller of what this book has described from August to the beginning of November 1922 lived to old age and died in 1969 in the little town of Olympia, in the state of Washington, which happened to be her namesake, as happens rarely in this world. There, sitting on the town's waterfront, Olympia Alexandrovna Feoktistova set down with a pen, when pens were already going out of fashion, the daily accounts her husband had given her in those months. His remains stayed for ever in a bog by that very rock. On that November day her husband, a writer by profession, too curious, noticed the stumps of long-felled trees in the clearing by "the white death," as she later called the rock, and walked into the veil of the unknown that hid a real bog, which swallowed him in a couple of minutes. She wrote down only what he had told her, and did not dare add a single line of her own. She was a fine stenographer, with a wonderful clear memory, which had won Grigory's heart in a single day. She was widowed young, had no son or daughter, and stayed faithful to him.

Of course, her pages were not the only ones in the book. The other people of that August evening put much into it too. Ulyana Konstantinovna Muravyova, the niece of Vladimir Obolensky-Kaspiysky, wrote a heart-breaking poem about everything that happened to them in those months, though not at once. They all began to write only decades later, once they had recovered from their wounds of the mind. Most of them settled close together on the edge of Seattle, and if you read all their testimonies and the letters they wrote one another, you find a far deeper, more personal web of feelings, and many different ways of seeing and setting down the same days. *Sunset of the Midnight Sun* is only a drop of blood, a gallon of air.

Semyon Semyonovich Bobrov, half his old weight, at last gave up smoking, renounced communism, and repented before everyone for his "subordinate." They forgave him. He never forgave himself, and went into the Church and took vows, as did several other men and women.

And the fate of the man under whose quiet, careful guidance *Sunset of the Midnight Sun* was written, or rather put together, deserves a word: Vladimir

Obolensky. According to a story that dates from the middle of the 1940s, after he lost his wife, who died early, her health broken, he went back to those places, travelling through Alaska. His last journey was on the White Pass and Yukon Railway, the narrow-gauge line between Whitehorse and Skagway. Somewhere along it he vanished. He jumped from the train, the story says, leaving on the table in his compartment an iron railway spike and a note:

> *I have gone into the woods. Not out of resentment at anything, nor because human malice has hurt me especially; but since the woods do not come to me, I go to them. That is all.*

For almost half a century the story made no sense. But it was confirmed in the end, and with great patience the meaning of his last message to the world was worked out. It lay not in the note, which was plain enough, but in the spike. The railway had been built in the years of the Klondike rush, to carry men and supplies over the White Pass, which had broken so many horses and men. The last spike was driven on the twenty-ninth of July 1900, when the gold rush was already dying. A golden spike had been made for the ceremony, but gold was too soft; it would not go into the sleeper, it only flattened. So they drove an ordinary iron one instead.

Many would envy such insight. How he knew that unremarkable fact, no one knows. But he did, and with it he said everything.

*Sunset of the Midnight Sun* is only the compressed first child of a far larger story, which could compete in size with *Gone with the Wind*. It did not end there, in April 1923. It was with them until their last breath. One day I will tell the feelings of all of them in full. You have not heard of the heroic deed of Mr Belyaev, one of those who lived through that winter in Alaska, who went back to the Land of Magnolias in secret when the war with Germany began, and died, quite literally frozen with hunger, in his house in Pushkin in December 1941. There is a great deal you do not know.

*The End*

# Author's Note



The novel is finished; one may rest. Now let me say a few words.

If you think this book is about one particular event, it is not. It is a story about everything, gathered from many places and invented, entirely, one fine day in June. It is a reflection in clear water of everything that happens to people. Is it a historical novel? Perhaps. There are no false places in it, and no false dates.

What is it about? Certainly not justice, or honour. It is about the things people do not want to dirty their hands with, the things they turn up their noses at or try to dilute with pink jelly. In this novel people die without ornament, quickly, always suddenly, always unjustly. Empires fall, and people remain. Nature is the hero here, and the weather is her director.

Look closely, listen, read it again. Do you notice how quietly and quickly the voices fall silent? Those are the people falling silent. How the "I" of the opening grows quiet and is replaced by a meek "they." How the story, begun in ordinary literary language, gives way to dry statement, backed by silence. There are no bright portraits of particular characters here; why should there be, when every one of them is the hero? How quickly the days fly by, and autumn kills thirst. The story breaks off at the moment the bough of the great tree of discord cracks. I did not want to go on describing that bacchanal until you began to take it for ordinary life. That would be vile.

The book is a token of gratitude and respect to Vladivostok, to Alaska, and to all decent people. I tried to make it close to life, full of the unexpected, of death and suffering. Look again at the Provenance at the start, and remember how fragile you all are. This story is a tribute to the memory of the tragedy of the revolution, and of the tragedy of the eleventh of September. I will say it again, and I will not be lying.

⁂

The little Greek Orthodox church of St Nicholas on Liberty Street in Manhattan stood across from the South Tower of the World Trade Center, and was the only building outside the complex to be destroyed on the eleventh of September 2001. There was no one inside. It was buried under the tower. In the ruins they found damaged icons of St Dionysios of Zakynthos and of the Mother of God, the Life-Giving Spring; the relics were lost. A small white church with a pointed roof had always stood in the shadow of the giant, a world of prayer at the foot of a world of money. When the giant fell it took the little church with it, as the people of this novel were taken down against the background of a great country.

*And I saw no temple therein.*

— Revelation 21:22

# Letters

Just above Svetlanskaya Street, in Post Office Lane, there stands a two-storey house with windows looking out over the Golden Horn. It is almost as old as the city. It once belonged to an American, Charles Henry Smith of Boston, who had made his money buying furs in Kamchatka in the 1850s and moved to Vladivostok in the 1860s, where he opened a shop on the ground floor selling good American goods of every kind: nuts and revolvers, razors and axes, gramophones and typewriters, tinned food and bicycles. It became one of the best-known shops in the city.

In June 1894 Smith came back from a visit home with two newly-weds: his wife's brother Frederick Pray, a jeweller by trade, who had signed on for five years as his assistant, and Frederick's wife, Eleanor Lord Pray, twenty-six years old, from Maine. For her, the journey to the Land of Magnolias' Pacific shore was a great adventure, and she was a born observer. Almost every day, sometimes several times a day, she wrote letters to her family and friends in America, in China and in Europe. In thirty-six years in Vladivostok she wrote more than two thousand letters, sixteen thousand pages: a novel in letters about the city, or, as we would say now, a blog.

Her letters follow the city through everything this book has touched on. The naval band playing the national hymn at sunset as the flag came down over the bay, in her first week. The vice-admirals and barons who called on the shy young woman from "down east," until she could, as she put it, swallow all that gold braid without blinking. The double windows stuffed with cotton wool against the Magnolian winter. The cabbage soup, fit for a king, she thought, whatever the foreign papers said about the Magnolian soldier's rations. Tennis in the long summer evenings, with two little Chinese boys paid three roubles a month to fetch the balls. The guns of the flagship on the night in February 1904 when the war with Japan began, and the cruisers going out one after another, and the women on the ice who fainted. The Japanese shelling of the city a month later, which killed one poor woman. An Easter service in the cathedral so crowded that the fastenings of her corset gave way one by one. A soldier's

wife weeping on a train in 1914, looking for her husband's regiment before it left for the front, and Eleanor weeping with her.

On the morning in March 1917 when news of the tsar's abdication reached Vladivostok, she wrote that everyone felt as if they were standing on their heads; that if the men making the revolution could live up to their words, a new dawn would rise over the Land of Magnolias; and that her heart ached for the emperor and empress, whose weakness, she thought, was their misfortune rather than their fault. In 1918 the city was full of the intervention's soldiers, Americans and British, Canadians, Czechs, Italians, French, and she found it, after Paris, the most interesting place in the world. In November 1919, after the rising against the Whites, she counted the bodies by the station and the quay under the wet snow and looked for the faces of cadets she had known. And on the twentieth of October 1922, the very day this book's chapter "Crossed Out" begins, she walked out to see the streets, and watched cart after cart go down Svetlanskaya loaded with trunks and boxes, with women and children on top, sometimes a little dog, all fleeing for the ships, out of the country where they had been born and which many of them would never see again. She wondered what it must be like for people who had given their whole lives to the Land of Magnolias to have to run for their lives.

She did not leave when her husband's contract ran out. She did not leave when Frederick died in 1923; she went to work as a bookkeeper at the great Kunst and Albers department store. She did not leave when the Reds came, and stayed through the arrests of the late 1920s, when hundreds of people with foreign connections were taken by the secret police for no reason anyone could name. She stayed until she had no means left at all, because she had fallen in love with the city. Only in 1930 did she write her last Vladivostok letter, from the ship, saying that every turn of the screw was carrying her further from the city she loved.

She took with her to China nearly a thousand photographs of Vladivostok, many of them unique, and kept them and her letters through the Japanese internment camps and her deportation, and brought them home to America. She died in 1954. Her archive was found and edited by the American scholar of Magnolian history Birgitta Ingemanson, and her letters were published, in part, in Magnolian and in English. On the fourth of July 2014 a statue of Eleanor Lord Pray was unveiled in Vladivostok, near the house where she lived for thirty-six years. She stands by the post office on Svetlanskaya Street, on the steps leading up to Post Office Lane, holding to her breast another letter from Vladivostok.

*A weary weave of half-glances,*
*half-tones, half-lit and half-said;*
*this world does not open its chances,*
*and is not, alas, new-made.*
*But one day it will rise to its feet,*
*and fall without sound on its face,*
*and then there will be no secret*
*in pages stuck down in their place.*

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